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Ammianus' Julian

Narrative and Genre in the *Res Gestae*

Alan J. Ross



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ALAN J. ROSS

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Preface

> But to anticipate those who might think that one's only source was the history of Ammianus Marcellinus (or even of Edward Gibbon), I have included at the end of the book a partial bibliography.[1]

This extract is taken from the preface to Gore Vidal's historical novel *Julian*. There are few such novels set in Late Antiquity, and the existence of one that takes as its protagonist an emperor who reigned for less than twenty months is testament to the continued fascination that the last ruling member of the house of Constantine, the last pagan emperor, and also the first emperor to be brought up a Christian, holds in today's world. At this point in his preface, Vidal offers a gentle correction to his earlier claim that he had not read as much in preparation of his *Julian* as Robert Graves had for *I, Claudius*. No doubt his declaration is designed to act as an elegant understatement, a *captatio* to his reader, and a mark of deference to another great author of historical novels, but the way in which he corrects himself neatly encapsulates the position that Ammianus holds for modern readers, historians, or novelists, as the author of the dominant ancient narrative of Julian's reign. To begin a study of Julian one turns first to Ammianus.

This is perhaps a curious phenomenon, considering that the short life and reign of Julian is one of the best attested of any Roman emperor.[2] Indeed no other emperor has left such a rich corpus of his writings, but their largely philosophical and rhetorical nature often requires modern readers to look elsewhere for, at the very least, a chronological framework of his military and political career. Other narrative accounts either have been lost or are now heavily fragmentary, leaving only Ammianus able to fulfil this role.[3]

[1] Vidal 1976, *A Note* (prior to p.1), an addition to the reprint of the first edition from 1964.

[2] Elm 2012b, 1, who also notes that modern studies of Julian often overlook or marginalize Julian's own writings.

[3] Chapter 1 discusses the relationship between Ammianus, Eunapius, and Zosimus.

Additionally, the other historical narrative mentioned by Vidal, that of Edward Gibbon, is largely responsible for ensuring Ammianus' dominance as *the* narrative source for the history of the second half of the fourth century and of Julian particularly. Gibbon's portrayal of Ammianus as an 'accurate and faithful guide' has helped ensure a position of precedence for the latter over other contemporary accounts of Julian, even those penned by the emperor himself. Narrative, particularly Ammianus' classicizing historiographical narrative, is more seductive as historical source material because it appears to offer what other accounts of Julian do not, a combination of completeness and cool detached authority in comparison to the openly partisan accounts of contemporaries; or as Gibbon put it, Ammianus was free from the 'prejudices and passions' of his peers.[4] The surviving eighteen books of Ammianus' *Res Gestae* offer an unmatched narrative of the quarter century from 353 to 378 in terms of detail, vividness of presentation, and geographical scope. Of course, there is far more in the *Res Gestae* than Julian, but as Julian's latest biographer remarked, Julian 'protrudes like a mountain' from Ammianus' narrative.[5]

Not all modern critics of Julian's reign adopt as mechanical a position as one recent historian, who introduces his study of Julian's Persian campaign of 363 by proclaiming 'like nearly all modern readers, I base my account on Ammianus and supplement it with Zosimus and Libanius, usually believing Ammianus in cases of disagreement',[6] but often historical biographies of Julian have gained greater praise and critical acceptance the more closely they adhere to Ammianus' version of the years 355–363. Thus Bidez in his *Vie de Julien* (for whom Ammianus is 'the most complete, the most detailed, the most picturesque and the most truthful' of contemporary writers on Julian),[7] Browning, who presents Ammianus as an unprejudiced, fair critic in his *The Emperor Julian*,[8] and more recently Rosen, in his

[4] Gibbon 1776–88, 1.1073. [5] Rosen 2006, 23.

[6] Lendon 2005, 439. He employs similar methodology for the battle of Strasbourg in 357, p.433.

[7] Bidez 1930, 337. Bidez regarded Ammianus as an accurate enough reader and reporter of Julian's works to include the letter to Constantius that appears at 20.8.5–10 within his Budé edition of Julian's letters (no. 17b, 1960, 23–6). There is no doubt that, at the very least, the words are Ammianus'.

[8] Browning 1975, 225.

Julian: Kaiser, Gott und Christenhasser[9] have generally fared better than Bowersock, who severely undervalued Ammianus, and Athanassiadi, who ignored him entirely, instead privileging Julian's own writings over any other source.[10] Nonetheless, all biographers of Julian, understandably, have the habit of sifting out details from the *Res Gestae* that they value above those offered by parallel accounts, often without studying Ammianus' depiction of Julian systematically.

Equally, discussions of Julian within wider studies of Ammianus have often focused on how well Ammianus' depiction stands up against comparable accounts (with varying conclusions[11]), or on individual aspects of Julian's reign, especially his religion. Julian plays an important role in Rike's explication of the religious system at play within the *Res Gestae*, particularly Julian's relation to cultic activity.[12] The only study devoted exclusively to Ammianus' Julian is a thirty-page chapter by one of the French contributors to the Budé edition, Jacques Fontaine, published in 1978 within a collection of essays devoted to the reception of Julian from the fourth through to the eighteenth century. He offers a commentary-like survey of Ammianus' representation of certain key moments in Julian's reign, beginning from the important proposition, often downplayed, that Ammianus wrote specifically for a western audience and as one who had spent most of his career in close proximity to Julian. I elaborate on the first point in Chapter 1, and take a rather more cautious

[9] Rosen has a somewhat schizophrenic relationship with Ammianus, sometimes following him closely, and at others disagreeing markedly, particularly, for example, in his central and contentious point that Julian converted to paganism only upon receiving the news of Constantius' death, *contra* Ammianus 22.5.1; 2006, 87.

[10] Bowersock demotes Ammianus' value as an independent witness to Julian by suggesting he was largely dependent on Eunapius, who, in Bowersock's view, is the most reliable source for Julian due to his access to Oribasius (Bowersock 1978, 6–8, cf. Tomlin's cutting review, 1980); Athanassiadi's methodology (1981) left her open to accusations of creating an overly sympathetic picture of Julian and downplaying the political and military context of the reign (see, e.g., den Boeft's comments, 1994, 412). She even describes herself openly as Julian's 'hagiographer' in the robust *apologia* to the second edition (1992, viii).

[11] Barnes (1998, 143–65) focuses on Ammianus' representation of three aspects of Julian's reign, his activities in Gaul, his relation to religion, and the Persian expedition. According to Barnes, Ammianus 'goes badly wrong', for example, in his interpretation of Julian's decision to burn his fleet at Ctesiphon, 1998, 164. Matthews displays a characteristically more positive assessment in his commentary-like survey of Books 15 to 25, Matthews 1989, 81–180. Cf. Blockley's earlier descriptive approach, Blockley 1975, 73–103.

[12] Rike 1987, Chapters 2 and 3, pp. 37–86.

approach to the biographical assumption of the second, especially regarding Ammianus' presentation of himself as a character within his text. Fontaine makes an important contribution to the study of Ammianus' Julian, but the space available to him allows only a cursory overview of the subject, and his work predates the advances made by the recent boom in Ammianean studies.

The almost four decades since the appearance of Fontaine's essay have seen a steady shift in attitudes towards Ammianus' text and the nature of its relationship both with the literary environment in which it was composed and the historical world that it purports to represent, steadily moving away from the Gibbonian view of faithfulness and accuracy. John Matthew's compendious *The Roman Empire of Ammianus* of 1989 offers an Ammianus who resembles Gibbon's closely;[13] a dependable and inquisitive investigator whose testimony is wholly based on his experiences during his military career and investigations among contemporaries, Ammianus can be relied on to illuminate the world he inhabited. Matthews' book was of necessary importance to rehabilitate Ammianus, particularly in the Anglophone world, from the views of the Marxist historian E. A. Thompson, whose book of half a century earlier had argued from the same biographical details for an Ammianus whose Antiochene curial status and class consciousness had deeply coloured his representation of several facets of his history, particularly the careers of Ursicinus and Gallus.[14] Matthews' book overall takes a positivist approach to Ammianus, but it altered scholarly consensus on several important issues, particularly the single composition of the work, and the Antiochene origins of its author.[15]

If Matthews revived an approach akin to Gibbon's, then nine years later Barnes, to some extent, revived Thompson's. Although Barnes does not deduce a single, strong ideological bent in Ammianus

[13] Matthews' *Roman Empire* may follow Gibbon in its attitude to Ammianus, but its form is modelled on Syme's *Tacitus* (1958) and *Sallust* (1964), providing an ample analytic retelling of Ammianus' narrative, followed by thematic chapters.

[14] Thompson 1947.

[15] The latter issue, particularly as related to the question of whether Ammianus was the recipient of Libanius' *Ep.* 1063, produced a flurry of debate in the subsequent decade (Bowersock 1990, 247–8; Fornara 1992a; Matthews' own restatement at greater length 1994), which died down by the end of the 1990s largely thanks to Barnes 1998, 54–64. Kelly subsequently has poured cold water on the importance of the identification, by noting that 'the information gleaned [from the letter] can be mostly . . . inferred from elsewhere' (Kelly 2008, 114).

comparable to Thompson's bourgeois historian, he does challenge the view of Ammianus the faithful guide, instead strongly arguing for a historian whose greatness rests on his ability to sculpt his own, even idiosyncratic, version of reality through a combination of careful structuring, emphasis, omission, and downright distortion. The book is full of brilliant observations, such as that Ammianus composed in a hexadic structure,[16] and that there must have been more lost books than the transmitted numbering allows.[17] One of its most important conclusions relates to religion, an issue that Matthews had largely left untouched (as indeed had Thompson). Barnes has little to add to Rike's description of the *Res Gestae*'s 'fundamentally consistent metaphysical scheme',[18] but he makes the essential and related point that Ammianus is polemically, if subtly, hostile to Christianity.[19] For all its merits, however, Barnes' book is largely negative in its methodology, revising or rejecting views of several modern scholars and pointing to Ammianus' partiality and even unsound judgement, despite claiming a positive conclusion: Ammianus is a great historian because 'his *Res Gestae* exhibit the creative and imaginative powers of a novelist'.[20] It is a rather unexpected conclusion to a book that begins with a preface in which Barnes asserts the continued strength of his 'conviction that Ammianus failed in his obligation as a historian to strive to transcend personal bias'.[21] The juxtaposition does reveal, however, that Barnes (indeed like Matthews) is fundamentally interested in whether Ammianus was 'correct' in his presentation of the world of the later fourth century, rather than the literary qualities of the world created within the text of the *Res Gestae* itself.

Barnes' and Matthews' studies are fundamentally historically orientated, even if Barnes had set out to offer a more literary study of Ammianus.[22] Contemporary trends in scholarship underpinned their decision to view the work of an ancient historian as primarily

[16] A feature which aligns Ammianus with Tacitus. For more on Ammianus' relationship with Tacitus, see Chapters 2.2 and 3.2.

[17] Cameron's adaptation of Barnes' theory (1998, 27–31), that there were in fact twenty-three lost books (a scribe corrupted the xxiiii of the first extant book to xiiii), misses Barnes' central point that Ammianus wrote in hexads. 2011, 750–1.

[18] Barnes 1998, 167.

[19] Barnes 1998, principally 79–94 but also 46–50 and 167–71.

[20] Barnes 1998, 198.

[21] Barnes 1998, viii.

[22] Barnes' incongruous description of Auerbach's 1946 work *Mimesis* as 'a classic of modern literary criticism' fully justifies Cameron's observation that 'Barnes is innocent of contemporary literary theory', 1999, 354.

the domain of his modern counterpart, rather than of literary specialists. It was only a year before the publication of Matthews' book that Tony Woodman's *Rhetoric in Classical Historiography* radically altered scholarly perception of ancient historiographical texts through his studies of Tacitus and Cicero. Woodman's call to study historiography in the same way as ancient poetry—based on the concept that whatever the rigour of the historian in investigating his material, the presentation of his past as text drew authority from the use of the conventions of ancient rhetoric[23]—invited the exploration of historiographical texts more firmly within a literary context and not purely with regard to questions of historical 'accuracy'.

It was a further generation before this movement fully reached Ammianean scholarship. In an Introduction to a book that warns against judging a text based upon the reconstructed biographical details of its author, Gavin Kelly is, nevertheless, revelatory about his own academic biography:[24] he is part of that generation brought up in the full awareness of rich allusive practices of Latin authors, including historians: 'The approaches of (for example) Tony Woodman to Tacitus, or Richard Thomas to Vergil, were part of my education, and it always seemed plain to me that Ammianus, striking both for his high-minded attitude to his historical calling and for the degree of his allusive engagement with earlier Latin and Greek texts, could benefit from similar scholarship.'[25] The book that follows skilfully questions the standard approach to Ammianus that had held sway ever since Gibbon, that the study of the *Res Gestae* must be founded on an interpretation of its author's biography. Noting that the only available sources for Ammianus' life come from his text itself, and that the writing of a literary history is 'a self-conscious act'[26], he argues that these internal 'clues' to Ammianus' biography should instead be seen as the construction of an authoritative persona rather than an exercise in biographical revelation. Moments of suggested autopsy, indeed, are often also moments of allusive engagement with earlier texts.

[23] Woodman draws on, amongst others, the work of Hayden White. Woodman 1988, 197; White 1984.

[24] Kelly's moment of biographical revelation, as his book goes on to argue for Ammianus', also alludes to a tradition: both Matthews and Barnes offered prefaces that detail the time and circumstances of their first encounters with Ammianus and Ammianean scholarship (Matthews 1989, ix; Barnes 1989, vii).

[25] Kelly 2008, 4. [26] Kelly 2008, 33.

In the latter portion of his book, Kelly demonstrates that the 'self-conscious' act of composition affects the very fabric of Ammianus' text. With example after example of meaningful allusion, he reveals an Ammianus steeped in Latin literature, and not just in the works of his historiographical forebears, but of poets of epic, comedy, and satire, and of novelists and orators. The allusions to these earlier texts are not just superficial decoration; a full appreciation and interpretation of the *Res Gestae* requires an awareness of how these allusions comment on their source texts. One of the most significant contributions that Kelly's book makes to Ammianean scholarship is to demonstrate Ammianus' greatness as an author of Latin prose. In the words of one reviewer, Kelly 'drops a bombshell into any post-Barnesian consensus over the Greekness of Ammianus'[27], especially since Barnes had vigorously revived earlier (negatively framed) remarks on the Greek influences on Ammianus' Latin.[28]

Like Kelly, I too was brought up to read historiographical texts as works of literature as much as sources for history, and to recognize that an understanding of the literary dynamics of an ancient historical text, in terms such as its internal structuring, the role of the narrator, intertextuality, and the use of generic topoi, must precede any attempt to draw historical conclusions from it. As a graduate student it was inspiring to read Kelly's work, first as an exemplary DPhil thesis in the Bodleian, then, in 2008, as a monograph. Taking some of Kelly's leads, this book sets out to evaluate Ammianus' presentation of Julian by considering the *Res Gestae* within three interrelated contexts; as a work of Latin historiography, which consciously sets itself within a classical and classicizing generic tradition; in the more immediate literary and political context as the final contribution by a member of an 'eyewitness' generation to a quarter century of intense debate over the interpretation of Julian by several authors who had lived through the reign and had been in varying degrees of proximity to Julian himself; and as a narrative text, in which narratorial authority is closely associated with the persona of the narrator both as an external narrating agent and an occasional participant in the events he relates.

[27] Kulikowski 2008, 66.

[28] Most famously by Wachsmuth who stated that Ammianus 'writes as he can, not as he wants', 1895, 677. Norden concluded that Ammianus 'thought in Greek' 1909, 648.

Quotations are drawn from the 1978 Teubner edition of the text, but I note where necessary the sources of additions and emendations that fill the numerous lacunae left by its cautious editor, Seyfarth, as well as any discussion of variant readings. In longer quotations, I have marked the breaks between the rhythmic cola with a solidus (/). Ammianus' system of clausulation is entirely regular, and, as Kelly remarks, 'because [clausulae] function within as well as at the end of sentences, they provide a guide to understanding quite as helpful as modern punctuation'.[29] Translations of the *Res Gestae* are taken, often adapted, from the only complete, modern translation of Ammianus into English by Rolfe in the Loeb series. All translations from modern languages are my own.

[29] Kelly 2008, 9. The most accessible guide to Ammianus' rhythmic system is given in Kelly 2013[2015], 72–7.

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List of Abbreviations

All journal abbreviations follow *L'Année Philologique*, with the conventional modifications made for English.

BNJ	*Brill's New Jacoby*, ed. I. Worthington (Leiden, 2006–)
CIL	*Corpus Inscriptionum Latinarum* (Berlin, 1862–)
FGrH	*Die Fragmente der griechischen Historiker*, ed. F. Jacoby (Berlin 1922–56)
FRHist	*The Fragments of the Roman Historians*, 3 vols, ed. T.J. Cornell (Oxford, 2013)
ILS	*Inscriptiones Latinae Selectae,* 3 vols, ed. H. Dessau (Berlin, 1892–1916)
PLRE	*Prosopography of the Later Roman Empire vol. I (AD 260–395)*, edd. A.H.M. Jones, J.R. Martindale, and J. Morris (Cambridge, 1971)

1

In Search of a Latin Julian

> Vtcumque potui ueritatem scrutari, / ea, quae uidere licuit per aetatem / uel perplexe interrogando uersatos in medio scire, / narrauimus ordine casuum exposito diuersorum; / residua, quae secuturus aperiet textus, / pro uirium captu limatius absoluemus / nihil obtrectatores longi, ut putant, operis formidantes. / tunc enim laudanda est breuitas, / cum moras rumpens intempestiuas / nihil subtrahit cognitioni gestorum. (15.1.1)
>
> So far as I could investigate the truth, I have, after putting the various events in clear order, related what I myself was allowed to witness in the course of my life, or to learn by meticulous questioning of those directly concerned. The rest, which the text to follow will disclose, we shall set forth to the best of our ability with still greater accuracy, feeling no fear of critics of the prolixity of our work, as they consider it; for conciseness is to be praised only when it breaks off ill-timed discursiveness, without detracting at all from an understanding of the course of events.

In this short methodological preface Ammianus openly alludes to the standard cognitive imperative of historiography set down by generations of historians before him—to provide a truthful narrative of the past—and to pursue that aim using the traditional tools of autopsy and inquiry.[1] The censorious reference to *breuitas* also allows Ammianus to engage subtly yet polemically with the recently popular genre of breviary history.[2] This preface is curious, however, in claiming to introduce no new methodological practice but merely to continue

[1] For interpretations of 15.1 see Fornara 1990; Barnes 1998, 66. On truth, autopsy, and inquiry, Schepens 1980; Marincola 1997, 63–94.

[2] Sabbah 2003, 62; Kelly 2008, 240.

applying what had been used before, now 'with greater accuracy'. Nonetheless, it serves an important structural function in marking the first book to contain narrative of Julian; just as the only other methodological preface in the extant books (26.1) marks the first complete book to carry the narrative forward after Julian's death.

The present book will explore how Ammianus combines his role as both the inheritor of a tradition of historiographical writing and as a participant in (and eyewitness to) several events connected to Julian's reign. In doing so, it will seek to justify the place of Ammianus within the study of ancient narrative texts generally, and within the genre of classical historiography specifically. The latter part of this chapter will set out techniques that will subsequently be employed towards these twin aims. Narratology will aid the examination of a narrator that appears occasionally as a character within the narrative itself as well as an authoritative narratorial presence throughout; and intertextuality the phenomenon that several of the major scenes which comprise the account of Julian's reign are of a type comparable to those that appear in, and are frequently definitive of, earlier works of large-scale historiography. First, however, I address the curious existence of a work of Latin historiography from the late fourth century that took as its major protagonist the emperor Julian. Against this background, Ammianus should be seen as striving to create an authoritative narrative of Julian distinct from other pre-existing accounts.

1.1 DISCOURSE ON JULIAN BEFORE AMMIANUS

There is scant evidence for Ammianus' impact upon his contemporaries. No author before Priscian in the early sixth century mentions him directly, and even then Priscian only names Ammianus to illustrate the past participle of *indulgeo*.[3] A few allusions may suggest that among Ammianus' more recent contemporaries, Jerome, the author of the *Historia Augusta*, and Claudian were familiar with his work.[4] If the search for actual readers returns few results, attempts to (re)construct an intended or implied readership have produced

[3] *Inst. Gram.* 9.51; Barnes 1998, 30.

[4] Maenchen-Helfen 1955; Cameron 2012, 351–5 (Jerome). Syme 1968, 69–71; Birley 1991 (*HA*), though see now Cameron's proposed dating of the *HA* to *c.* 380

several, often conflicting interpretations. No one has doubted that Ammianus composed his history in Rome. Rome is 'the home of empire and of every virtue' (16.10.13), and is a powerful ideal that resonates throughout the extant books of the *Res Gestae*.[5] Ammianus turns his readers' attention to Rome, for example, by fastidiously recording the tenure of nearly all the (relatively inconsequential) Urban Prefects during the period of his history.[6] Nevertheless, Anglophone scholarship has largely argued that Ammianus did not write for the Romans, particularly not for the aristocracy. Cameron detached Ammianus from a 'circle of Symmachus' and indeed from the whole senatorial class of Rome.[7] For Matthews, although Ammianus wrote in Rome, he did not address a Roman audience but Theodosius and his eastern court during their visit to Rome in 389 and subsequent stay in the West till 391.[8]

By following a trend of looking for an audience outside Rome (though without denying that Rome was the place of composition), Anglophone scholars dismissed the argument put forward by Seyfarth and Sabbah that Ammianus' literary sophistication presupposes a highly educated audience,[9] and that, combined with composition in Rome, that audience was specifically the Roman élite.[10] More recently Ammianus' literary sophistication has received even greater exposition by Kelly, who has revealed the complexity of Ammianus'

(2011, 743–82) which would make the *HA* antedate Ammianus; Cameron 1970, 333–4; Dewar 1996 374–6 (Claudian).

[5] Sabbah 2003, 52.

[6] Barnes 1998, 237–40. Ammianus pays 'anachronistic attention' to Rome, Rohrbacher 2002, 25.

[7] Cameron 1964.

[8] Matthews 1989, 8–9. Two years before Matthews, Rike had suggested a similar scenario, 1987, 135. Frakes (2000) rightly pointed out that Matthews identifies not an intended but an actual audience, whose existence Ammianus could not have predicted when he began to compose his lengthy history some years previously. Instead Frakes posited an intended readership of imperial bureaucrats on the basis of a prosopographical study, assuming (perhaps crudely) that Ammianus would mention proportionately more individuals from the group in society which he intended would read and sympathize with his work. Rohrbacher (2007, 471–2) also follows Frakes, suggesting that a military-bureaucratic audience would particularly have appreciated the way in which Ammianus lampoons the Roman senators in two famous digressions. I have argued that these lampoons are not to be read as serious attacks upon the Roman élite, but as the author's adoption of a satirizing *persona* with which he establishes himself as an insider-critic of Roman society and the continuator of the satiric traditions of Juvenal. Ross 2015a.

[9] Seyfarth 1969. [10] Sabbah 1978, 507–39.

allusivity, not just to authors who continued to make up school curricula, such as Virgil and Cicero, but also those, like Tacitus and Plautus, for whom there is much less evidence for their popularity or circulation in the fourth century. Rather than being rehabilitated with an élite Roman audience, Kelly's Ammianus instead appears almost too sophisticated for his surroundings. Identifying for the first time an allusion to Plautus (*quasi fundata cum mortuis pace nihil formidans* 18.7.7 ∼ *nihil ego formido, pax mihi est cum mortuis,* Plautus, *Mostellaria* 514), Kelly poses the question 'if as certain an allusion . . . went unrecognised or at any rate unremarked through three centuries of modern scholarship, was it likely to have impacted on many or any of Ammianus' original readers or hearers?'[11] Kelly's solution is to sidestep the issue of a contemporary audience (real or intended) altogether. Instead he calls into question the appropriateness of assessing the *Res Gestae* based upon the (re)construction of an intended readership:

> It is doubtless sometimes true that works of literature are written with a particular audience in mind, and it may even sometimes be the case that they are read by that singular, intended audience and it alone. This is perhaps particularly the case with technical or sectarian works, and those written in times and places when literacy is particularly limited and books are little copied and little travelled. But Ammianus wrote under the Roman Empire, not in the early Middle Ages. Other than that it required a certain degree of learning, I do not think that the notion of an intended audience for Ammianus' work is a particularly helpful one. In writing classical historiography, he was producing an eternal possession, and not an ephemeral performance, aiming to establish the *Res Gestae* as the canonical historical account for distant posterity as much for contemporaries.[12]

Ammianus certainly creates a narrator who keeps one eye on posterity. Can every aspect of Ammianus' work so easily be divorced from the contemporary culture of both its author and those who were likely to form the immediate readership, whether intended or actual? A comparable case is the poet Claudian, who, like Ammianus, was a Greek-speaking easterner writing in Rome. He delivered his first Latin poem, a panegyric-epic for the consulship of Olybrius and Probinus in 395, just four or five years after the publication of

[11] Kelly 2008, 179. [12] Kelly 2008, 181.

the *Res Gestae*. Like Ammianus, Claudian imbued his poetry with a sophisticated nexus of allusions to earlier Latin authors, Virgil, Ovid, and Lucan among others. Panegyric, even Claudian's panegyric-epic, presupposes an audience (its dedicatees) and even a precise time and place of delivery to that audience far more explicitly and precisely than a work of historiography. In a study of Claudian's allusive practices, which parallels Kelly's work on Ammianus, Ware similarly notes 'the sophistication of Claudian's allusive technique would discourage any immediate comprehension of his complete intertextuality'.[13] She goes on to acknowledge, however, that Claudian 'was writing for private study as well as public performance'. Panegyric, especially panegyric-epic such as Claudian's, more clearly demonstrates the twofold reception of sophisticated literary work containing overtly political content. Claudian's panegyric-epic presupposes performance (and reception by a specific audience) yet also sets itself within a Roman literary tradition.[14] Panegyric and historiography are not entirely dissimilar genres.[15] Historiography also had the capacity to carry a political or didactic message for the author's contemporary world, even if it conveyed that message in a more subtle way than panegyric.

In what follows, I observe Kelly's warnings about seeking to construct a single intended audience. Instead I situate Ammianus' *Res Gestae* within both the political and literary context of its place and time of composition, Rome in the late 380s. That context, as we shall see, was not one in which we might have expected a Greek easterner to have written a work of classicizing Latin historiography, let alone one which treated Julian as its major protagonist. From what we can gather, there had been few historical works written in the West, and Julian himself had not been a favourable subject for any western writer. It is inescapable that this context had an impact upon some fundamental choices for Ammianus' work, even if he composed as much for posterity and his place in a literary tradition as for a contemporary audience. What was the state of Ammianus' chosen genre, historiography, how does his subject matter fit within it, and what does his choice of genre tell us about his reaction to contemporary culture?

[13] Ware 2012, 8. [14] Ware 2012, *passim*.

[15] Rees 2010,107. Cf. Ross 2014 for Ammianus' relationship with Julian's panegyrics to Constantius.

Ammianus Marcellinus made two crucial choices when he decided to embark upon a history of the empire: to write in the city of Rome and in the Latin language. Neither was straightforward or necessary for a historian who was born in the East and whose first language was Greek.[16] In the preceding two centuries, the genre of historiography had suffered an unequal fate on either side of an empire that had seen a long-standing cultural divide between Greek and Latin reinforced by the coextensive political division into East and West. Unlike its Latin counterpart, Greek historiography had continued to flourish in the East throughout the third and early fourth centuries. Large-scale, universal histories with political and military subject matter were produced by authors such as Asinius Quadratus, whose *Roman Millennium* narrated events from the founding of Rome to the year 230.[17] Later in the third century, Dexippus' *Chronicle* provided a history from the foundation of Rome to within a few years of the work's date of composition in the 270s.[18] In the early fourth century, a Eusebius, possibly from Thessalonica, composed a history from Augustus to the death of Carus in 283.[19]

To stay in the East and write in Greek was perhaps a more natural option for an aspiring historian. This was certainly the path chosen by Eunapius of Sardis, whose relationship with Ammianus will be discussed further below in this section. At this point, suffice it to mention that Eunapius and Ammianus embarked on projects of similar scope and aims: these contemporary authors presented Julian's short reign as the principal event in their large-scale, 'classicising' histories. Both were defensive of Julian and relied on autoptic accounts of the reign, Ammianus upon his personal experience, and Eunapius on Julian's doctor and companion Oribasius.[20] Each historian's career path was decisively different, however. Eunapius spent the majority of his life in Sardis, whereas Ammianus had

[16] 31.16.9. Ammianus was of Syrian origin, and most probably from Antioch. Matthews 1994; see Barnes 1998, 54–64 for the more cautious suggestion of Syria or Phoenicia.

[17] *BNJ* 97. See Janiszewski 2006, 33–4 for the possible date of his work.

[18] *BNJ* 100, and a new fragment published in Grusková 2010. See also the new edition by Mecella 2013.

[19] Janiszewski 2006, 54–77; *BNJ* 101 fr. 1 & fr. 2, *contra* Sivan's (1992) suggestion of Eusebius of Nantes.

[20] Eun. *Hist.* fr. 15 (Blockley).

campaigned extensively in the East and had travelled widely throughout the empire.[21]

Writing in Latin was no less an innovation than foregoing Greek. There is no evidence that any other author attempted an historical work in Latin on the scale of Ammianus' *Res Gestae* after Tacitus concluded his *Annals* in the early second century. Latin historiography had contracted into the subgenre of epitomizing or breviary history, first at the hands of Florus in the second century, then only revived after a hiatus of two hundred years by the author of the *Kaisergeschichte* postulated by Enmann, swiftly to be followed and imitated by Aurelius Victor, Eutropius, and Festus. Breviary was a popular genre between the 350s and 380s,[22] and would continue to attract an audience even after the publication of Ammianus' *Res Gestae*, as the production of the anonymous *Epitome de Caesaribus* sometime after 395 makes clear.[23] To this list can also be added the elusive *Annales* of Nicomachus Flavianus, a work that is attested only in two dedicatory inscriptions on private monuments set up by Flavianus' family.[24] Of its scope or date we know nothing for certain; no further *testimonia* or fragments survive. This has not dissuaded a small scholarly industry from attributing to Flavianus the responsibility of transmitting to a later Greek historical tradition much of the detailed material for the late third and early fourth centuries that ultimately appears in the work of the twelfth-century Byzantine historian Zonaras.[25] These scholars assume that Flavianus' text, therefore, was significantly more detailed and greater in scope than the likes of Victor or Eutropius. In more than sixty pages of his recent *The Last Pagans of Rome*, to which I need neither add nor attempt to summarize *in extenso* here, Alan Cameron has indisputably

[21] Cameron 2011, 642–3. Eunapius was a generation younger than Ammianus and in his early teens when Julian died, fr. 15. Blockley 1981, 1.

[22] Lenski 2002, 187.

[23] The *Epitome* concludes with the death of Theodosius. It may have been composed in Constantinople, Cameron 2011, 669–70.

[24] One inscription by Flavianus' grandson notes that Flavianus had dedicated his *Annales* to Theodosius; another on a statue base from the early fifth century describes him as *historicus disertissimus*. Cameron 2011, 629.

[25] Best exemplified, in recent years, by Bleckmann 1992, Paschoud 1994, and Festy 1997, with successive contributions by both Bleckmann and Paschoud, most recently Baldini and Paschoud 2014. The theory was first advanced, however, by von Domaszewski in 1918 and developed by Hartke 1940. For other refutations see Barnes 1976, and Burgess 2005.

overturned the major claims of the pro-Flavian school.[26] Flavianus' text was likely produced within a three-year period, published in the late 380s, and was as brief as the other Latin breviary histories produced before and after it. In scope alone it could not have been the much sought-after source for Zonaras (if the *Annales* covered the empire at all, rather than the Republic), and, indeed, the likelihood of a Latin work being the candidate for the source of detailed information about the late third and early fourth centuries for a Greek text is minimal and overlooks the far more obvious possibility of Eunapius' *History*.

In comparison to the extant breviary histories, Ammianus' *Res Gestae* is a far more 'western' text and is more closely connected to the city of Rome. Although not much can be said about the *Kaisergeschichte*'s place of composition or potential audience, Aurelius Victor most likely brought his work to completion in 361 while in Sirmium,[27] before receiving promotion by Julian to the rank of Governor of Pannonia Secunda.[28] Eutropius, though he wrote in Latin, spent most of his life in the East. He almost certainly had enjoyed a long career in the service of Constantius. He seems to have retained his position under Julian and Jovian and rose to become a high-ranking member of the court by the time he composed his *Breviarium* and dedicated it to his latest (eastern) imperial master, Valens, in 369 or 370.[29] Within a few months, another member of the court, the *Magister Memoriae* Festus presented Valens in 370 with an even more concise history than Eutropius', which had the pragmatic objective of preparing Valens for his coming campaign against the Persians.[30] His *Breviarium*, therefore, focuses mainly on conflicts between Rome and Persia. It is clearly written for an eastern audience.[31] Although it carries one allusion to the joint reign of Valentinian in the West and Valens in the East, it otherwise addresses a

[26] Cameron 2011, 627–90.

[27] Dufraigne 1975, xv–xvi. Nixon 1991.

[28] Amm. 21.10.6. Penella 1980, Bird 1994, vii–xii. Not until twenty years after the publication of the *De Caesaribus*, would Victor become Urban Prefect at Rome, in 388–9.

[29] Bird 1993, ix–xiii. Rohrbacher 2002, 49–51. Eutropius was, however, not *Magister Memoriae*, Burgess 2001. Eutropius would visit Rome sometime after 372, where he most likely became acquainted with (and subsequently a correspondent of) Symmachus. Symmachus *Ep.* 3.50; Callu 1982, 229–30; Bird 1993, xv.

[30] Lenski 2002, 185–96. Rohrbacher 2002, 59–60.

[31] Rohrbacher 2002, 62.

single emperor (Valens) and downplays the role of Valentinian, for example by omitting to mention the latter's successes in Britain or on the Rhine.[32] Despite the use of Latin, Festus' *Breviarium* cannot in any way be considered a western text.[33]

Eutropius and Festus could have been in little doubt that their *Breviaria* would have been read primarily by easterners, albeit by proficient speakers of Latin.[34] Aurelius Victor, too, wrote not in Rome, but probably in Sirmium on the cusp of the geographical division between West and East, and when he came to complete his *De Caesaribus*, between Constantius and Julian as they prepared to engage in a civil war. The praise heaped on Constantius in Victor's text suggests that he intended Constantius rather than Julian to be his initial reader.[35] A short postscript, which attacks Constantius' officials, is perhaps a sign of Victor's quick adaptation of his completed text to the changed political situation as Julian arrived in Sirmium.[36] The positive representation of Constantius in the *De Caesaribus* suggests Aurelius Victor's later favourable treatment by Julian was more a result of a natural cordiality between two pagans with literary interests.[37]

In comparison to this contemporary trend, not just the language but the subject matter and scope of Ammianus' work appear all the more remarkable. Julian is the undoubted focus of the *Res Gestae*. The narrative of his reign is the most expansive of all the emperors treated in the extant books, slowing to a pace of two and a half months covered in Book 24, compared to five years in Book 27 under

[32] Kelly 2010, 83. [33] Lenski 2002, 188.

[34] Particularly the military élite and members of the court. Their Latin was likely more proficient than the likes of Libanius and Gregory Nazianzen who flaunted their supposed ignorance of Latin, Libanius *Or*. 12.92–4; Gregory Nazianzen *Ep*. 173. Liebeschuetz 1972, 247–9; Cribiore 2007, 208–9 suggests most inhabitants even of Antioch (which frequently hosted the imperial court) learned Latin only 'rather superficially'. Eutropius did gain a wider audience in the East by means of his translation into Greek, Matthews 1975, 107.

[35] The final chapter includes a list of Constantius' virtues in the present tense, 42.20–3. Cf. Nixon 1991, 123. Victor's suggestion that Julian should model himself on Tiberius and Galerius (42.19), 'both rulers who had been diligent subordinates before inheriting in their own right' (Kelly 2008, 285), further points to Victor's allegiance to Constantius.

[36] Nixon 1991, 124; Bird 1994, viii–ix.

[37] As Banchich suggests, the *De Caesaribus* ended up being 'a vehicle for career advancement', but not as Victor initially intended under Constantius. Banchich 2007, 308–9.

Valentinian and Valens. His reign shapes the fabric of the *Res Gestae*, calling for Ammianus to introduce a preface to the first complete book to deal with Julian's reign as Caesar (Book 15).[38] The events Ammianus describes almost resemble 'material for panegyric' (16.1.3). At his death, Julian alone of all the emperors in the extant part of the history is described as possessing the full set of cardinal virtues (25.3). Even after his death, Julian still permeates the latter books of the *Res Gestae,* acting as an *exemplum* by which Ammianus judges his successors.[39]

Contrary to the evidence provided by the *Res Gestae*, however, Julian's brief reign was not a sympathetic subject for a western audience in the late 380s. More than twenty-five years had passed since Julian's death, and even during his reign, he had had little contact with or shown much interest in Italy, let alone Rome. Julian was born in the New Rome, Constantinople, and spent his youth in the East.[40] He was twenty-two when he first set foot in the West in late 353, when he spent a few months with Constantius at Arles.[41] He was summoned again to Milan the following year, and once more in 355 this time to be installed as Caesar and despatched to provide an imperial figurehead for the campaigns against the Alamanni and other German tribes in Gaul. On none of these occasions did he come further south in Italy than Milan. Despite his attempts to assimilate to his surroundings in the West, particularly to the dominant use of Latin, Julian still felt out of place and resisted the new cultural environment in which he found himself, remarking in a letter to some fellow students from his time in Athens, 'if I can still so much as speak Greek it is surprising, such a barbarian have I become because of the places I have lived in'.[42]

[38] As noted at the beginning of this chapter, the only other preface appears at 26.1, the first book after Julian's death. Authorial prefaces thus frame the narrative of Julian.

[39] Kelly 2008, 306–17.

[40] *Pan. Lat.* III(2).2.3. For Julian's early life see Browning 1975, 31–66; Bowersock 1978, 21–32; Athanassiadi 1992, 13–52; Rosen 2006, 70–93.

[41] Evidence in Julian's *Ep. ad Them.* 359D and *Ep. ad Ath.* 272D suggests Julian had been in the West on two occasions before his appointment as Caesar in November 355, the first, Vanderspoel (2013) argues, coincided with Constantius' vicennalia in 353 (see Chapter 2 n.15). Barnes had previously suggested that Julian was present at Gallus' appointment as Caesar in Sirmium in 351, though his evidence rests on an imprecise allusion in a fragment of a speech by Himerius. 1987, 209.

[42] Jul. *Ep.* 8.441B–C. Translations from Julian are taken from Wright 1913–23. Whereas Julian probably was competent orally in Latin, especially the administrative Latin of the army, it is unlikely that he could write Latin, and certainly not highly wrought literary Latin. Rochette 2010. Cf. Ammianus' description of Julian's

Ammianus chose to reflect Julian's cultural dislocation, recording that the troops in the West did not agree with Julian's assessment of his integration. Instead in a moment of insubordination they deride him with the diminutive *Graeculus*, 'a Greekling', a term glossed by the narrator as a 'rebuke' (17.9.3).[43] It is also a sentiment that Constantius' ministers echoed at court, describing him as a *litterionem Graecum* (17.11.1), a remark attacking his Greek bookishness. On each occasion, Ammianus defends Julian against the underlying cause for these attacks (Constantius' refusal of funds, which prevented Julian from paying the troops, and the courtiers' envy of Julian's success) but the association between Julian's Greekness and its uncomfortable juxtaposition within a western context remains. It is hardly surprising that Julian was out of place in the Latin West, as his upbringing was exclusively Greek; his mother Basilina was Greek and his teacher Mardonius could not speak Latin.[44] When Julian mentions Rome in his extant writings, he depicts the city as civilized only because of its Greek origins.[45]

Julian did not ingratiate himself with the inhabitants of old Rome, nor did he receive the opportunity to do so. Although he won a superb victory against the Alamanni at Strasbourg in 357 he did not celebrate a triumph in the same way as Constantius had done in Rome only a few months earlier.[46] Ammianus does his utmost to

knowledge of Latin as 'sufficient for conversation', 16.5.7. Perhaps this is just censure from a Greek who had mastered the skill of writing literary Latin.

[43] Isaac 2004, 402.

[44] Sánchez-Ostiz 2007, 301 focuses on the Greek nature of Julian's upbringing before his appointment as Caesar. He suggests Julian became more culturally attune to Roman and Latin culture after he became emperor, but there is little evidence of this in Julian's own works (which are all heavily Hellenized). Any evidence for the 'Romanization' of Julian comes from Ammianus, and, it is argued below, is a peculiar feature of the *Res Gestae*.

[45] '[Helios] has civilized the greater part of the world by means of Greek colonies, and so made it easier for the world to be governed by the Romans. For the Romans themselves not only belong to the Greek race, but also the sacred ordinances and the pious belief in the gods which they have established and maintain are, from the beginning to end, Greek.' *Or*. 4.152D–153A. According to Julian, 'Rome is simply Hellenized'. Den Hengst 2010, 221 also notes that in the *Caesars* Julian 'lampoons his predecessors practically without exception, even Julius Caesar and Augustus. The only ones who come out of it well are Alexander the Great, whose presence in this company is rather a surprise, and the φιλόσοφος βασιλεύς Marcus Aurelius, who published his writings in Greek'.

[46] Klein 1979 argues that Ammianus obscures Constantius' attempts to placate the senators during his visit. The speech delivered in Rome by Themistius (as the official

deride Constantius for his victory over Roman blood (the usurper Magnentius) rather than a foreign enemy, and to contrast Constantius' empty triumph with Julian's real victory by juxtaposing the description of Strasbourg immediately after that of Constantius' *adventus* in Book 16.[47] Nevertheless, the contemporary Romans were happier to embrace the legitimacy of Constantius' victory; the City Prefect in 352–3, Naeratius Cerealis, had already set up an equestrian statue of the triumphant Constantius, which described him as the 'restorer (*restitutori*) of the city and world of Rome, and the destroyer of pestilent tyrants, our lord Flavius Iulius Constantius, victorious and triumphant, always Augustus'.[48] Cerealis' successors followed suit. Leontius in 355–6 set up another statue on a base with similar wording, 'to the victor throughout the whole world (*toto orbe victori*), our lord Constantius, the greatest, triumphant, forever Augustus'.[49] And in time for the imperial visit Orfitus set up a further three, all of which carried the similar sentiment, 'to the expander (*propagatori*) of the Roman empire, our lord Flavius Iulius Constantius, the greatest, victorious and triumphant in the whole world, forever Augustus'.[50] Orfitus did also set up a statue to Julian, but the wording of the inscription (even considering it was addressed to the junior member of the imperial partnership) is notably underwhelming when compared to the five other inscriptions to Constantius: 'to our lord Claudius Iulianus, most noble and powerful (*nobilissimo ac fortissimo*) Caesar'.[51]

representative of a Constantinopolitan embassy) omits any reference to Julian, even though Julian and Constantius had campaigned together in 356. *Or.* 3, Heather and Moncur 2001, 120.

[47] Blockley 1999, 6–8. Humphries 2003, 28. Ammianus' objection is anachronistic; victory celebrations in civil wars had become standard practice since Constantine's over Maxentius in 312: Wienand 2015, 182–7 and 188–9.

[48] *CIL* VI.1158. The statue was erected in the immediate aftermath of Constantius' victory. Humphries 2003, 38; McCormick 1986, 40–1.

[49] *CIL* VI.31397.

[50] *CIL* VI.1161, 1168, 31395. Ruck 2007, 48–9 and 253. Moser notes that the senators' guided tour of the forum for Constantius (for which see Symmachus *Rel.* 3.7) 'must have been cherished moments of intimacy with the otherwise distant emperor'. Moser 2013, 153. See the rest her chapter (pp.139–64) for arguments that Constantius acted in a conciliatory fashion towards the Roman senators during his visit in 357.

[51] *CIL* VI.1168. Conti 2004, 136–7 speculates this base may have stood near a larger statue of Constantius. Julian was honoured alongside Constantius again in 358 or 359, in which Constantius' victories over the Quadi and Sarmatians is acknowledged. *CIL*

To the Romans in 357, as they witnessed the Augustus processing, statue-like, through the streets, there could have been little doubt about the favour shown by Constantius to their city.[52] The *adventus* was the only visit of a reigning emperor to Rome between Constantine in 312 and Theodosius in 389.[53] Indeed, for Ammianus' first readers in the early 390s, the recent visit of Theodosius would have recalled that of Constantius thirty-two years earlier. Constantius must have come to Rome in a conciliatory mood, knowing it was in his interest to placate and pacify the West in the wake of Magentius' rebellion. Several of his actions in Rome testify to this. He made administrative appointments in person, and, according to Theodoret, even allowed the wives of officials to convince him to reinstate pope Liberius.[54] Although Constantius had ordered the removal of the altar of Victory from the Senate House,[55] he also fulfilled the role expected of the *Pontifex Maximus* and made several pontifical appointments.[56]

Julian, in contrast, had uneasy relations with the Roman senate. When advancing eastwards in 361, he sent a series of letters to major cities, mostly in the east, in support of his credentials as a legitimate emperor.[57] Of these only the *Letter to the Athenians* is fully extant.[58] It is full of praise for the city where Julian had spent his student days, and provides a condemnation of Constantius' treatment of him.[59] We do not know what the Athenians' reaction was to this piece of propaganda, but a corresponding letter to Rome, which contained a similar denunciation of Constantius according to Ammianus ('a sharp oration and full of invective', 21.10.7) elicited an angry response from the Senators, who demanded Julian should remain loyal to Constantius ('we demand reverence to your own creator'). At

VI.1164. There are three further possible surviving inscriptions in Rome to Julian when he was Augustus, *CIL* VI.31401, *CIL* VI.40792 I–II, *CIL* XIV.4408.

[52] Even if that favour was carefully designed to bring a city and senate, which 'had shown little reluctance in throwing in their lot with the usurper' back under his control. Humphries 2015, 164.

[53] Demandt 1989, 376 and n.7.

[54] Theod. *HE*.2.17.1–4. Curran 2000, 134–5; Cameron 2011, 166 and 187.

[55] Ambrose *Ep*. 73.32.

[56] Symm. *Rel*. 3.7. Cameron 2011, 33.

[57] Zosimus 3.10.4 also mentions letters to Sparta and Corinth; Libanius *Or*. 14.30 mentions the letter to Corinth. See Kaegi 1975, Bowersock 1978, 46–65, and Drinkwater 1983, 370–83 for the political situation.

[58] There is also a short fragment of the *Letter to the Corinthians* fr. 20 (Bidez–Cumont).

[59] Humphries 2012.

the same time the Senate also decided to express its loyalty directly to Constantius in Antioch via two envoys, Valerius Maximus and Avianius Symmachus.[60] On their return, these envoys chanced to meet with Julian on his march eastwards, and were nevertheless greeted, as Ammianus tells us, 'with full honours' (21.12.24). Julian evidently lost no time in ensuring his former opponents were induced to support his cause.[61]

This hostility extended elsewhere within Italy: the only major stronghold that resisted Julian after his proclamation as Augustus in 360 was Aquileia in northern Italy. Julian had sent troops to hold the strategically important city. These soldiers had only recently come over to his side at Sirmium, and swiftly decided to defect back to Constantius and hold Aquileia against Julian, though they did so also with the active support of the Aquileians themselves. Ammianus explains that the inhabitants' opposition to Julian was the result of the 'dread (*horrore*) which was even then connected with the name of Constantius' (21.11.3), and thus he neatly condemns Constantius as a ruler who terrified his people. He also suggests, however, neighbouring Italians joined the Aquileians in support of Constantius. The ease with which these troops defected back to Constantius as soon as they reached Italian soil, the complicity of the population, and the duration of the ensuing siege, which was broken only by news of Constantius' death, suggest that support for Julian's cause was not strong in the West outside the region where he had been active with his army in the years leading up to his proclamation.[62]

Julian, conversely, received far more positive attention in the East. Themistius had written a panegyric to him in 363.[63] That panegyric is now lost, but earlier Themistius had presented Julian as a child of Constantinople, who consequently loved the new Capital.[64] Libanius

[60] Sogno 2006, 3–4. Libanius describes the visit in a letter to Avianius Symmachus' son, *Ep*. 1004.

[61] Julian received a later delegation from Rome in 363 and appointed them to a series of official positions, Apronianus Urban Prefect; Octavianus proconsular governor of Africa; Venustus *vicarius* of Spain; Rufinus Aradius Count of the Orient (23.1.4). Den Boeft et al. 1998, 11–14 for historical notes on each recipient.

[62] See Sotinel 2005, 55–9 for a description of the political situation.

[63] Vanderspoel 1995, 130–1. Libanius asked for a copy of it in spring 363 (*Ep*. 818.3), and subsequently praised it after Julian's death (*Ep*. 1430).

[64] *Or*. 4.59a, Themistius' *Philopolis* written, probably in celebration of Constantius and Julian's second joint consulship in 357, Leppin and Portmann 1998, 80–3.

sought to defend Julian posthumously in not one but three published speeches.[65] A small industry appears swiftly to have grown up after Julian's death offering accounts of the Persian expedition. None of these texts are fully extant, but we have sufficient clues about their authors and content to demonstrate the contemporary interest in Julian's military record.[66] Most of these accounts seem to have been historical prose, but both Libanius and Socrates of Constantinople mention an epic poem that took the Persian campaign as its subject. Libanius identifies the author as Callistion, the *assessor* to the Praetorian Prefect of the East, whereas Socrates names him Callistius, but they are undoubtedly the same individual.[67] The poem, according to Socrates, blamed Julian's death on a demon rather than his rashness or the actions of an enemy (in other words, the poem absolved Julian of personal responsibility), which has led Janiszewski to suggest 'Callistius' was largely sympathetic to the poem's protagonist.

Likewise another eyewitness to the reign was Oribasius, Julian's doctor who had accompanied Julian since his time in Gaul.[68] Eunapius describes a memoir, *hypomnema*, of Julian's deeds, which Oribasius put at his disposal for Eunapius' history. Eunapius does not suggest that the 'deeds' upon which the memoir was based were confined solely to the Persian expedition, and thus they may also have included Julian's earlier campaigns in Gaul.

Julian himself was his own historian, writing what Eunapius describes as a *biblidion* about his victories in Gaul.[69] Although its subject matter was a western campaign, the *biblidion* must have been written in Greek, especially since the only *testimonium* comes from a Greek author. It may not be the only Greek account of Julian's wars in the West; Eunapius refers to a letter from Julian to a Cyllenius, whom Julian upbraids for misrepresenting his achievements in Cyllenius' account of Julian's expedition *κατὰ Ναρδινῶν*.[70] There

[65] Firstly in *Orr*. 17 and 18, dated to spring 364 (Wiemer 1995, 251–5) and mid-365 (Elm 2012a, 439) respectively, and latterly in *Or*. 24 in 379. Swain 2004, 399; Malosse 2014, 83–7.

[66] The identification and significance of Philagrius, Seleucus, Magnus of Carrhae and Eutychianus are discussed in more depth in Chapter 5.

[67] Libanius *Ep*. 1233; Soc. *HE* 3.21. Janiszewksi 2006, 390–3; *BNJ* 223.

[68] Janiszewski 2006, 382–90; BNJ 221.

[69] Fr. 17 (Blockley). It is probably the text referred to by Libanius *Ep*. 38.6. Cf. Janiszewski 2006, 114–16.

[70] Eun. *Exc. de Sent*. 79.12; BNJ 222; Janiszewski 2006, 116–21.

has been some debate over the identification of Julian's enemy[71] but most plausible is Blockley's suggestion of *Dardani,* and hence that Cyllenius' work narrated Julian's swift advance down the Danube in 361.[72] The rest of the *testimonium* describes how Julian corrected Cyllenius' account by producing 'a high-spirited and brilliant encomium of himself',[73] which would better fit the situation of open hostility towards Constantius in 361, rather than Julian's campaigns of the late 350s.

Julian's reign, particularly the Persian expedition, received extensive attention at the hands of Greek writers in the years immediately following his death. Even allowing for the two posthumous denunciations of Julian by Gregory Nazianzen, other accounts were largely positive: Cyllenius, as already mentioned, set Julian as a hero within an epic; Oribasius' and Seleucus' association with Julian would have prompted a positive portrayal of their hero. Libanius' defence of Julian may represent the prevailing trend among the Julian-literature of the East, which was produced after his death, even despite the seriousness of Julian's spat with the Antiochenes before his departure for Persia.[74] We should not forget that Julian's corpus of panegyrics, philosophical treatises, war monographs, and letters marks him out as the most literary-minded emperor of Late Antiquity. There was an extensive corpus of literature focused on Julian in circulation by the late 360s.

To return again to Eunapius, his now-fragmentary *History after Dexippus* provides a parallel model for an attempt to resurrect the grand style of history.[75] We know that the work, which began where Dexippus' *Chronicon* ended in 270, was published in two instalments. The first is referred to within and was therefore published before his *Lives of the Sophists*,[76] itself written sometime after Alaric's invasion

[71] Emendations of 'Narsici' and 'Chnodomarius' have been suggested by Müller 1851, 20 and Thompson 1943 respectively.

[72] Blockley 1983, 32–3 and n.44.

[73] Eun. *Exc. de Sent*. 16. Trans. Blockley 1983, 35.

[74] See Van Hoof and Van Nuffelen 2011 for the inherent seriousness of Julian's anger and Libanius' attempts to act as an intermediary between populace and emperor. As late as 390 Libanius was still presenting Julian's Persian campaign as a success. *Epp*. 901, 929, 947. 'As time went by, the problematical aspects of Julian's character or reign retreated for Libanius and his merits could be idealized along with other good things from the past.' Swain 2004, 399.

[75] Blockley 1981, 10–15.

[76] E.g. 7.3.1; 8.3.4.

of Greece in 395.[77] The cross-references to clearly dateable events all refer to the period before 380 and therefore the likely terminus was (as in Ammianus) the battle of Hadrianople in 378.[78] Like Ammianus, Eunapius was primarily concerned with narrating near-contemporary history. His first book offered a brief history covering eighty-five years between 270 and 355[79] and the remaining books thus covered 355–378, a tantalizingly similar scope as the extant portion of the *Res Gestae*. Furthermore, Eunapius' organizing principle was evidently the career of Julian; his appointment as Caesar in 355 provided the terminus of the first book, and Julian is the primary focus for much of Eunapius' history: 'henceforth [from book 2 onwards] my narrative centres upon the one who was its object from the beginning, and, feeling the love that I do for him, I am compelled to turn my attention to his achievements' (fr. 15).[80] If Eunapius, as Liebeschuetz suggests, 'gave Ammianus the idea of writing an imperial history with a pagan bias',[81] particularly in its depiction of Julian, then Ammianus radically broke from Eunapius' practice of embedding himself within an eastern and Julianic milieu. Eunapius frequently makes reference to Julian's works, even in the case of Julian's lost *biblidion* on his campaign against the Alamanni in 357, refusing to narrate the battle of Strasbourg in detail precisely because he did not want to compete with Julian's version.[82] Eunapius' text presupposes knowledge of Julian's

[77] A terminal date of 378 for the first instalment was first argued by Barnes 1976. The bibliography on the issue of the date and nature of Eunapius' text is massive. The best evaluation and synthesis of existing arguments, particularly as it relates to Flavianus' lost *Annales*, is to be found in Cameron (2011, 668–78). One should maintain a distinction between two 'editions' mentioned by Photius (*Bibliotheca* 77) and two instalments; Photius' second 'edition' was in fact a text bowdlerized for anti-Christian content, for which not Eunapius but a later editor was responsible (Baker 1988). The first 'original' edition was accessible to Ammianus (for which, see Cameron 2011, 677).

[78] See Barnes 1978, 115–17 for good arguments against reading two cross-references to events in the reign of Theodosius; Liebeschuetz 2003, 182–4 for an endorsement of Barnes and additional reasons. Banchich 1986 argues that Jerome had used Eunapius' *History* for details of events through to 378.

[79] As implied by fr.15 (Blockley), the preface to the second book. Blockley 1981, 7; Liebeschuetz 2003, 187. *Contra* Paschoud 1975, 176.

[80] The preface to the whole work describes Julian's reign as its high point, fr.1 (line 96 in Blockley's edition). Translations from Eunapius are taken from Blockley 1983.

[81] Liebeschuetz 2003: 190. See also Bowersock 1978: 8–9.

[82] Fr. 17, discussed in more depth in Chapter 4.1. He provides the *testimonium* for Julian's 'high-spirited and brilliant encomium of himself' (fr. 23.2) discussed above, as well as his speeches against the Cynics (fr. 23.3) and letters (fr. 28.5).

oeuvre and defers to it. Other contemporary, eastern authors were mentioned and discussed, including Libanius (fr. 26) and Oribasius, who is not just cited as Eunapius' source (fr. 15) but appears as a character within the narrative (fr. 28.2). Eunapius needed to connect his work to other Julianic texts because, as he himself admits, 'I never saw [Julian] or personally knew him; for when he was Emperor, the writer of this history was just a child' (fr. 15). Autopsy, nevertheless, is appropriated via Oribasius, 'the most intimate of Julian's companions' who had provided Eunapius with a *hypomnema* for the composition of history. The positioning of Eunapius' text firmly within an eastern context is perhaps not surprising; there is little evidence that its author travelled outside the eastern Mediterranean, indeed, he spent most of his life in Sardis.[83] As we shall see, in comparison Ammianus removes himself from that Julianic milieu. He does not name any contemporary author other than Julian himself, and even then, Ammianus presents these works in a way that does not place the *Res Gestae* in competition with Julian's texts.

When Ammianus began writing his history, there were few Latin accounts of Julian that could compare to the richness of material available to Greek speakers in the East, let alone that could attempt to rehabilitate Julian in the estimation of the Romans after his death. The three *Breviaria* are necessarily brief, bare accounts that deal with Julian within a few short paragraphs. Aurelius Victor's *Breviarium* was certainly known by Ammianus.[84] Victor would later become *Praefectus Urbi* and it is tempting to imagine a Roman audience taking an interest in the earlier publication by its new prefect. However, they would find little relating to Julian. As noted above, composing his work towards the end of Constantius' reign, he gives an account of Julian in two sentences, in which his success at Strasbourg is credited to Constantius' *fortuna* and *consilium*.[85] Eutropius is the

[83] 'A public notary pure and simple', Liebeschuetz 2003, 177.

[84] 'There [Naissus in 361] he [Julian] made Victor, the writer of history (*scriptorem historicum*) whom he had seen at Sirmium and had bidden to come from there, consular governor of Pannonia Secunda, and honoured him with a statue of bronze, a man who was a model of temperance, and long afterwards prefect of the City.' 21.10.6. In 374 Jerome requested a copy of the *De Caesaribus* from Paul of Concordia *Ep.* 10.3. Concordia is to the west of Aquileia, whereas Jerome at this point was at Trier. J. Kelly 1975, 33. The *De Caesaribus* was certainly, therefore, in circulation in the West.

[85] Aur. Vict. 42.18, a judgement that Nixon suggests would have been 'particularly galling to Julian'. Nixon 1991, 124.

most positive of the three authors of Breviaria. Banchich plausibly imagines Eutropius using the prominent positions he held in the 370s and 380s 'to disseminate copies in various key locations in the empire or for those anxious to please him to request the same'.[86] He would have an opportunity to do so in Rome when he visited in the late 370s.[87] Julian receives attention for only two major events in the reign. His victory at Strasbourg is held up as a significant achievement, without any reference to Constantius (10.14.1), and even the Persian expedition is presented as a success, during which Julian 'accepted the surrender or forcibly seized several of their towns and fortresses, devastated Assyria, and for a time established a permanent camp at Ctesiphon' (10.16.1). Julian is presented as victorious right up until the moment of his death, which is explained as a moment of personal rashness rather than as the result of strategic failing that threatened the safety of the entire army. Jovian, instead, bears the brunt of responsibility for the 'shameful (*ignobilem*) peace' subsequently concluded with Sapor (10.17.1). Eutropius had been asked to prepare his *Breviarium* by an emperor who was himself intending to embark upon a campaign against Persia. To conclude his work with the description of a disastrous and ill-conceived defeat, which was the result of the shortcomings of the emperor, may have seemed impolitic to Eutropius; [88] or perhaps he felt some residual loyalty to Julian, who had kept him in position during his reign, and whom Eutropius had accompanied on that disastrous campaign. In any case, Eutropius does not give any space to Julian's personal shortcomings.

Festus' account is more balanced. Although Julian's march down the Euphrates is presented as a success in the same sort of terms as Eutropius (many towns and fortresses were captured), there is more detail about the army's activities once they reach Ctesiphon. Unlike Eutropius, Festus draws his reader's attention to Julian's failure to capture the city. Ctesiphon could have been taken had it not been for the troops' wish to halt and plunder (28.5–6); subsequently Julian ignores the advice of his colleagues, follows that of a defector and burns his fleet (28.9–10). His death, as in Eutropius, is the result of personal rashness (28.12). Festus had been requested by Valens to prepare his *Breviarium* only a few months after the completion of Eutropius', and within the same context of preparation for renewed

[86] Banchich 2007, 309. [87] Symmachus *Ep.* 3.50.
[88] Cf. Kelly 2010, 85 for a similar judgement regarding Festus.

war with Persia.[89] The greater space and detail afforded to Julian's campaign in a work which otherwise is more concise than Eutropius' perhaps suggests that either Festus or Valens himself judged Eutropius' account of this, the most recent Persian campaign by a Roman emperor, to be too positive or unrealistic. It was, after all, the shame of the losses in 363 that Valens sought to avenge. To the eyes of a western audience in the 380s,[90] however, Festus' *Breviarium* provides a more limited picture of Julian than Eutropius', focusing solely on the Persian campaign on 363 to the exclusion of any other event in the reign, and shows a great ambivalence about Julian's merits as a leader.

Claudius Mamertinus produced a panegyric for Julian in 362. Though written in Latin, it was delivered in Constantinople. Naturally, given its place of delivery, Mamertinus emphasizes Julian's links with the new Rome, 'this city, newly named but of ancient nobility, is your birthplace, here you were first brought forth, here you arose like a kind of star beneficial to the human race' (*Pan. Lat.* III(11).2.3).[91] As a piece of propaganda, it skirts swiftly over Julian's activities in Gaul, confining his main success to the victory at Strasbourg (4–5) before narrating Julian's recent advance down the Danube towards Constantinople in comparatively greater detail (6–7).[92] Otherwise it offers a positive gloss on the new reign, alluding to but rarely detailing Julian's administrative reforms. It is another Julianic text written in Latin but produced in and for an eastern context.

Beyond these few 'secular' texts, the Latin reader before 390 could glean some information about Julian from passing references in works written by Christians, which openly show their hostility towards the Apostate. Jerome mentions Julian three times in his *Chronicle* composed in the 380s in Constantinople, at his appointment as Caesar

[89] For the date of Eutropius' *Breviarium* see n.29. Festus completed his work in early 370. Lenski 2002, 186.

[90] Ammianus certainly knew of Festus, but does not mention him in his capacity as an historian (29.2.22). He did, however, allude to the *Breviarium* in several of the geographical digressions, Amm. 14.8.4 ~ Festus 12.1, 14.8.12 ~ 14.2, 14.8.15 ~ 13.1, 22.16.24 ~ 13.2, 24.4.4, 10, 11 ~ 9.1, 2, 4, as identified by Mommsen 1881, 605–9 and elaborated by Kelly 2010, 85–8.

[91] Translations of the *Panegyrici Latini* are taken from Nixon and Rodgers 1994.

[92] The lack of detail about the Gallic campaigns is explained by Blockley as Mamertinus' attempt to avoid arousing the jealousy of the eastern army. Blockley 1972, 449–50. The connection is dismissed as 'tenuous' by Rogers in Nixon and Rodgers 1994, 390.

(240a), the moment of his 'apostasy' which led to 'mild' persecution of Christians (242c), and finally the Persian campaign:

> For when Julian set out against the Persians he had sworn that he would offer our blood to the gods after his victory. He was conducted to the desert by a certain man playing the part of a deserter, when the same apostate had ruined his army with hunger and thirst. Then when he very ill-advisedly strayed from the ranks of his own soldiers, he by chance encountered an enemy cavalryman who pierced his side with a spear. He died in his thirty-second year of age. (243b).[93]

Not only does Jerome imagine that Julian, contrary to the picture of calculated toleration provided by Ammianus, would unleash a wave of persecution against the Christians upon his successful return from Persia, but he firmly casts Julian as the cause for the army's defeat.

Other Christian writers refer to Julian only in passing and in a derogatory fashion. 'Ambrosiaster', the anonymous author of a commentary to the letters of Paul written in Rome between 366 and 384,[94] openly refers to Julian as the successor of Nero and Diocletian as the persecutor of Christians:

> The unspeakable wickedness [persecution] began with Nero, who fired with zeal for idols, killed apostles at the instigation of his father the Devil, and went as far as Diocletian and most recently Julian, yet he, having launched persecution with a particular craftiness and subtlety, was unable to consummate it because this was not conceded by [God] above. For Satan used these men as ministers, in order to seduce men under the guise of a crowd of gods; he mocks the manifestation of the one true god as long as the Roman Empire stands.[95]

Ambrosiaster was a shadowy figure even in his own day: Jerome and Augustine knew only parts of his work, and Jerome, who was active in Rome at the same time seemed not even to know his identity.[96] Yet, in their assessment of Julian, Jerome and Ambrosiaster are quite similar: both viewed Julian as an eager but thwarted persecutor, whose death provided a fortuitous escape for the Christian population of the empire. They no doubt reflect the final assessment of Julian by Christians in Rome during the 370s and 380s.

[93] Translations of Jerome's *Chronicon* are taken from Donalson 1996.
[94] Vessey 2004, 308. Lunn-Rockliffe 2007, 12–17.
[95] Ambrosiaster, *Comm. II Thess.* 2.7. Translation in Lunn-Rockliffe 2007, 169.
[96] Lunn-Rockliffe 2007, 11 and 175–6.

Further corroboration of this prevailing Christian interpretation comes from the correspondence of Ambrose. In his carefully orchestrated and very public intervention in the request by the then Urban Prefect of Rome, Symmachus, for the return of the altar of Victory to the Senate house in 384, Ambrose uses Julian's ban on Christian teachers to deny Symmachus' plea for financial privileges to be restored to pagan priesthoods (*Ep*. 72.4). In his second letter on the subject, he explicitly refers to the Persian campaign as an example of the folly of the pagan religion:

> As for Julian, what need I say? He destroyed his own means of retreat, because he had unwisely trusted the responses of soothsayers. So all men are liable to disaster, but not all because of the same failing. Nobody for instance has ever been misled by promises of ours. (*Ep*. 73.38)[97]

Once again, failure in Persia is the linchpin of Christian interpretation of Julian, to the exclusion of most other episodes in his reign.[98]

In comparison to the eastern tradition, by the late 380s there was a substantial deficiency in discourse on Julian within Latin literature. Other than passing, negative comments on individual moments of Julian's reign in the works of contemporary Christians, the only positive or at best neutral narrative accounts were to be found in texts which were in abbreviated histories or (one) panegyric. These works had been composed by officials closely associated with Julian, produced during his lifetime or within a few years of his death, and, most importantly, primarily for an eastern audience. Ammianus, by contrast, strives to demonstrate that he is a Greek writing for a western audience, and as a part of a Latin tradition of historiography. The most blatant statement of this attitude is the authorial *sphragis,* which closes the work:

> These events, beginning from the principate of Nerva Caesar up to the death of Valens, I, a former soldier and a Greek (*ut miles quondam et Graecus*), have unrolled to the best of my strength. (31.16.9).

The chronological frame of the work, beginning where Tacitus' *Histories* concluded, establishes the *Res Gestae* within a continuum

[97] Trans. Liebeschuetz 2005, 93.

[98] Ambrose also refers to Julian's failure to rebuild the temple at Jerusalem in his letter to Theodosius on the destruction of the synagogue at Callinicum, written in 388 or 389. *Ep*. 74.12, cf. Liebeschuetz 2005, 95–6.

of large-scale Latin historiography, contrary to (and ignoring) the newly fashionable subgenre of Breviaria.[99] Furthermore, Ammianus' status as a Greek writing in Latin neatly reverses the orientation of Mamertinus, Eutropius, and Festus as Latin-speakers writing for easterners.

His self-definition as *Graecus* is important for understanding his historiographical project. This brief and seemingly straightforward phrase has attracted much scholarly comment. Matthews has argued that its tone is apologetic, excusing the presumption of a 'native-born Greek to have written in the Latin language'.[100] There is little that is apologetic in the text that precedes the *sphragis,* however. Greeks, when they are mentioned, are usually praised for their learning.[101] An alternative and more attractive suggestion is that it should be better understood as a declaration of Ammianus' historical skills 'in the noble tradition of Thucydides and Polybius'.[102] I tend to agree with the latter interpretation, at least in the sense that Ammianus is proud of his Greek credentials. However, Kelly has recently shown that, despite the Greek elements of Ammianus' composition (the use of lengthy, Herodotean *excursus,* for example) Ammianus is steeped in literary Latin, and well able to deploy meaningful allusion to a wide range of classical Latin authors of prose and verse, and so, again, the text which precedes does not quite match up to Barnes' interpretation of the *sphragis*. Furthermore, *Graecus* can imply a specifically Roman perspective. Earlier Latin authors had used the term for a Roman who was particularly 'acculturated' to Greek literature. Cicero praises Atticus by calling him a *Graecus,* and 'in Martial . . . *Graecus es* refers to an educated Roman versed in Greek literature, as distinct from *rusticus*, which denoted an uneducated local'.[103] Paradoxically,

[99] Marincola 1997, 237–8 for the phenomenon of praising one's predecessor and establishing one's own work in a tradition by beginning where that predecessor left off. For Ammianus' other allusive attacks on Breviaria, see Sabbah 2003, 62 and Kelly 2008, 240. Kelly 2009a, 350–3 rightly points out some of the stylistic difference between Tacitus and Ammianus.

[100] Matthews 1989, 461.

[101] See Appendix for Ammianus' discourse on Greek.

[102] Barnes 1998, 66. Similarly Blockley 1998, 306. Stoian 1967 plausibly equates *Graecus* to *Hellēn,* and thus reads the phrase as a statement of Ammianus' paganism. Stoian's interpretation does not preclude the one I present here, however.

[103] Biville 2002, 90, with examples from Cic. *Att*. 1.20.6 and Martial 14.58. For the ambivalent use of the term in Latin panegyric, see Gómez Santamaría 2010.

therefore, there is something distinctively Roman in his self-definition as a *Graecus*.[104]

Reading the phrase back onto his account of Julian, which though the narrative of Julian's reign had ceased in Book 25 nevertheless is the climax of the work, *Graecus* acts as a statement of Ammianus' authority in another sense. As fellow Greek, and one writing in the West and in Latin, Ammianus presents himself as a prime interpreter of Julian's reign to a western audience, and an audience that has not had an account of Julian written specifically for it before. It is notable that the other half of this statement of authority, *miles quondam*, refers to a period roughly contemporaneous with Julian's imperial career: Ammianus first allows himself a role as a soldier within the narrative in 354 and effectively disappears at the end of the Persian expedition in 363, when the army under Jovian reaches Antioch.[105] *Graecus* can similarly be read as a statement about his contemporary expertise as an easterner who is able to access and interpret the reign of Julian, the most Greek of Roman emperors since Marcus Aurelius, for a Latin-speaking audience.

But this was no longer the age of Atticus, the cultured Roman *Graecus*. The status of a *Graecus* writing for a western, Latin-speaking audience afforded Ammianus a highly specialized position in the 380s. His immediate audience in Rome were, by the late fourth century, becoming increasingly monolingual and thus lacked the skills to read the likes of Themistius, Gregory Nazianzen, and Libanius. Alan Cameron has recently sketched a picture of late fourth-century Rome in which there was little opportunity or even need to learn Greek. There are no Greek *grammatici* known at Rome

[104] Biville also notes 'the Roman practice of imitating the Greeks, which involved adopting their language and their values, gave rise to a specific vocabulary of acculturation, which allowed Romans to become, depending on their level of assimilation, either Greeks (*Graeci*), or half-Greeks (*semigraeci*), or pseudo-Greeks (*Graeculi*),' 2002, 90. There is a trace of this hierarchy still visible in Ammianus' record of the Western troops' insult of Julian as a *Graeculus* at 17.9.3.

[105] Ammianus first appears at the trials in Antioch under Gallus in the military retinue of Ursicinus, *magister equitum per orientem,* 14.9.1. The last use of the first person after the Persian invasion occurs when the army arrives back at Antioch, 25.10.1. Ammianus uses the first person a further three times in the later books, however he does not narrate his own (or collective) deeds but rather uses his presence to construct authority via autopsy (26.10.19, the aftermath of the tsunami; 29.1.24 and 29.2.4, the fear created by Valens' treason trials). There is no suggestion that he was serving as a soldier after 363.

in the fourth century, and so there was no opportunity to learn Greek within the city.[106] Evidence from Symmachus suggests he had learned Greek only at school and had become rusty in later life.[107] Indeed his correspondence to easterners such as Libanius was in Latin, and Libanius in turn required a translator before he could read Symmachus' letters.[108] It may have been easy enough, if somewhat troublesome, to await the skills of a translator when dealing with individual, short letters, but the inability to read long texts in Greek was a major impediment that closed off knowledge of the literature of the East.

Julius Valerius' Latin adaptation of the *Res Gestae Alexandri* from the first half of the fourth century is indicative of a wider movement of translating Greek works for a western audience.[109] It is notable that by the later fourth century, it was predominately Christians who understood the problems of monolingualism and acted to overcome them by translating texts on a large scale. Jerome's translation of the Bible, begun at the behest of Pope Damasus in 384, is perhaps the most significant example,[110] but Augustine had read a Latin translation of the *Life of Antony*,[111] two translations of which were in circulation by 375; Rufinus translated works by Eusebius, Origen, Gregory Nazianzen, and Basil the Great and thus 'made a great part of Greek [Christian] literature accessible to Latin readers' according to Gennadius.[112] Gennadius' comment (albeit from the late fifth century) is telling that the skills of the few remaining bilinguals were now deployed to serve the need of the many monolinguals, who, otherwise, were cut off from Greek literature by their linguistic inabilities. Furthermore, Cameron has successfully quashed the suggestions that a parallel translation project was undertaken by pagans such as Nichomachus Flavianus to offer a Latin translation of Philostratus' *Life of Apollonius of Tyana*.[113] The exception to this general

[106] Cameron 2011, 529.
[107] Cameron 2011, 535–6. Cf. Salzman in Salzman and Roberts 2011, xxii.
[108] Libanius *Ep.*1004.4 (Foerster).
[109] Stoneman 1999, 147–50.
[110] He also translated Eusebius' *Chronicle* to which he added subsequent entries down to 378. Donalson 1996, 1–3.
[111] *Conf.* 8.6.15.
[112] Gennadius *Vir. Ill.* 17; Vessey 2004, 322; Cameron 2011, 546. The two orations against Julian (4 and 5) were not among Gregory's works translated by Rufinus, however.
[113] Cameron 2011, 546–54.

monopoly on translation by Christians is Marius Victorinus, whose translations of Aristotle were possibly read by Augustine in the 370s.[114] Translation into Latin also carried with it the responsibility to make a text more accessible to a western audience, as Jerome mentions in the preface to his translation and continuation of Eusebius' *Chronicon*:[115]

> I have added some things which seemed to me to have been omitted, in Roman history especially, of which Eusebius, the originator of this book, seems to me, not to have been thus ignorant, for he was most learned, but since he was writing in Greek, to have skipped over those things less necessary to his countrymen.

In Jerome's case, this updating seems to have been a simple task of adding in western events that Eusebius had omitted.[116] It should be noted that even though Jerome most likely composed his *Chronicle* in Constantinople, his choice of Latin presupposed a western audience.[117]

When Ammianus embarked upon the first work of large-scale, classicizing Latin historiography for two hundred and fifty years, Julian's legacy was perhaps the most 'sectarian' historical subject he could have treated, yet, as far as we can tell, it was one which had not before received an extensive narrative treatment in the Latin tradition of the West. Although one can never rule out the existence of another large-scale Latin history that covered the same period, the chances are very small. We have several examples of lost texts from this period that, nonetheless, have left traces, even breviary histories such as the *Kaisergeschichte* and Flavianus' *Annales*, though the scope and nature of the latter may be more difficult to recover. Indeed even if all Ammianus' text had been lost, not just the first thirteen books, provided it happened after the early sixth century we would still know his name, have a title for his work, and an indication that there were at least fourteen books, thanks to Priscian.[118] The genre that Ammianus resurrected in order to provide a narrative of Julian's reign was innately tied to Rome. Sallust, Livy, and Tacitus all created Roma-centric works, which presupposed a Roman audience. Sallust's extant monographs

[114] Cameron 2011, 566.
[115] Trans. Pearse 2005.
[116] Burgess and Kulikowski 2013, 40.
[117] For Constantinople as the place of composition see Donalson 1996, 4–6. 'With Jerome, for the first time, western readers had not only a history that placed Rome in her Mediterranean context, but also a history of Christianity, one that put Rome into a Christian context.' Burgess and Kulikowski 2013, 128.
[118] See n.3.

both offer (negative) critiques of Roman society, explicitly in the internecine material of the *Bellum Catilinum* but also through the study of how war with a foreign enemy could illustrate the decline of political life at Rome in the *Bellum Iugurthinum*. Livy tracks the expansion of Rome from its foundation to the domination of the Mediterranean world. For Tacitus the city represents the focal point for his imperial narratives, to the extent that the revelation that in 68AD an emperor could be made elsewhere than at Rome was novel and shocking (*Hist*. 1.4). Given these traditions of the genre, and the literary and historical environment in which Ammianus brought it back to life more than two hundred years after Tacitus, this book is concerned with what type of Julian Ammianus creates within the revived genre of a Roma-centric Latin historiography. How does the genre accommodate him, or how is his presentation altered or constrained by it in comparison with the other presentations of Julian that were in circulation by the 380s?

One feature of Ammianus' narrative style is immediately striking to a reader who is familiar with earlier examples of historiography, whether Latin or Greek: Ammianus is frequently 'present' as a character, a feature to which he draws the reader's attention by the use of first-person narration. Several historians had previously been characters in their own texts: Xenophon (in the *Anabasis*) and Caesar are prominent examples, but neither so explicitly drew a connection between the author and the character. Caesar used the third person to separate narrator and character, whereas Xenophon published pseudonymously.[119] Furthermore, Caesar and Xenophon were principal characters in their works, both being in command of their respective campaigns. Ammianus was a staff officer, peripheral to the main events in the narrative.

Ammianus' frequent appearances within his narrative have been used by modern scholarship as a tool for biographical assessment of his text.[120] This positivist approach has rightly come under attack in recent years. In his study of Ammianus' participation in the Persian campaign Ivić notes the fundamental flaw in this approach:

> To narrate his own experience through his own eyes for at least a part of the campaign was also a literary choice, and naive insistence on

[119] Marincola 1997, 186.

[120] The pattern was set for Anglophone scholarship by Thompson whose Ammianus 'welcomes an opportunity of becoming autobiographical', 1947, 1.

> [a biographical reading] obscures the fact that even descriptions of the events witnessed in person (*uisa*) are verbal/textual fictions generating a historical truth (or truth effect).[121]

Ivić goes on to illustrate how the first person appearances often lend persuasiveness to a narrative that admits of several contradictions. Four years later, Kelly more thoroughly exposed the 'limits of biography', by showing how Ammianus carefully controls the presentation of himself as a participant throughout his work.[122] The activities of the participant serve three main purposes, all related to the construction of the historian's authority: 'by relating his experiences in absorbing detail (including some which do not reflect well on himself, such as the deception of Silvanus or his escape from Amida), Ammianus leaves it open to readers to think they are getting a detailed and honest account; by showing himself in solitude and peril, amidst the death of others, he can give the impression of being a unique witness or a sole survivor. And (I have suggested) other interventions serve to emphasize his greater authority in comparison to other sources.'[123] More recently still Weisweiler has argued for an unreliable narrator, whose moments of stated autopsy may even be designed to draw attention to the fabrication of 'eyewitness' episodes.[124]

The participant is clearly and closely associated with the identity of the narrator. This book will consider how, additionally, the participant may act as an interpretative guide for the primary narratee, and by extension also for his readers.[125] As has been noted above, the period of Ammianus' active career (so far as Ammianus allows us to learn about it from references in his text), coincides with the reign of Julian: Ammianus first appears as a participant in 354, during Gallus's reign as Caesar. Gallus' fall from favour was the event that precipitated Julian's elevation. Equally Ammianus disappears from the narrative after the Persian campaign, becoming the *quondam* soldier.[126] Ammianus'

[121] Ivić 2004, 323. [122] Kelly 2008, 31–158. [123] Kelly 2008, 102.

[124] Weisweiler 2015. E.g. Ammianus' viewing of the Persian army in Corduene so clearly invokes Herodotus' account of Xerxes' crossing to Greece that 'the dramatic allusion is broken, the traces of the historian's *inuentio* are all too visible', 2015, 121.

[125] The narratee is not identical to the actual reader, but 'narratees, both primary and secondary, are a powerful instrument for influencing the reception of a text, in that they provide the readers with figures to identify with or distance themselves from'. De Jong 2014, 6.

[126] Mary 2008, 226–7.

authoritative statement in the *sphragis* applies particularly to, and is indeed largely limited to the period of Julian's reign.

The *Res Gestae* is a complex narrative text precisely because of the close (though not direct) interplay of Ammianus as a character and of Julian, and the construction of authority through the identity of the narrator as a *Graecus* writing Latin historiography. In order to evaluate Ammianus' construction of Julian within the context of Latin historiographical narrative this book will utilize two theories which are not new to Classics, but which are relatively new to the study of classical historiography. Narratology will be used to evaluate how Ammianus' narrator presents Julian to the primary narratee, and how that process is complicated by the presence of Ammianus as a character within the text. As such it can reveal the interpretative dynamics that are internal to the *Res Gestae* as they are applied to Julian. Intertextuality, by contrast, necessarily looks at a text's external relationships. It will evaluate how Julian is accommodated within the genre of historiography by providing a framework to compare Ammianus' text with earlier examples of the genre as well as with presentations of Julian in contemporary texts of different genres. Both these theoretical approaches require qualifications when applied to a genre such as historiography, which purports to record 'real' events, especially in considering the degree to which an author may manipulate the presentation of historical events within a literary text. In the second half of this chapter I outline how both narratology and intertextuality will be used within the subsequent chapters, and confront some of these theoretical concerns as they apply to historiography.

1.2 NARRATOLOGY AND HISTORIOGRAPHY

> It should cause no surprise if at times we use our proper name in speaking of ourselves and elsewhere use general expressions such as 'after I had said this' or again 'and when we agreed to this'. For we were personally much involved in the events which are about to be chronicled, it is necessary to change the phrases when alluding to ourself, so that we may neither offend by the frequent repetition of our name, nor again by constantly saying

> 'when I' or 'for me' fall unintentionally into a wearisome habit of speech. (Polybius 36.12).[127]

Polybius, like Ammianus, was a participant in the events he narrated and in a role that was not central to the action of his narrative. Unlike Ammianus, Polybius offered this methodological statement concerning how he would refer to himself in the narrative. His choice to use the first person was a departure from the practice of earlier historians, who had referred to themselves exclusively in the third person, as it is assumed, to maintain a sense of objectivity.[128] Polybius' change of policy required an explanation, which is presented here as the rhetorical need to avoid wearying his readership by referring to himself too often as 'I' or 'Polybius'.[129] The statement leaves his reader in no doubt, however, that the 'I' of the narrative is to be associated with the primary narrator. The presence of this methodological statement is also evidence of ancient historians' awareness of the importance of their narrator's relationship to their narrative in order to create a credible story line, or in other words, to create authority, particularly if a character within the narrative is explicitly linked to the narrator.

Ammianus has left us with no such methodological statement, but modern narratological theory presents us with a set of critical tools that can better illuminate the ways in which his narrative creates authority generally, and how indeed it shapes the presentation of a single character such as Julian. Here I introduce some terminology which will be employed in subsequent chapters, and offer an illustration of how Ammianus' narrative is particularly complex for a work of historiography in terms of the relationship between Ammianus as primary narrator and Ammianus as a character.

Narratology offers 'a refined, precise set of tools with which to analyze the role of the narrator and narratee, and aspects of time, setting, description and characterisation'.[130] Description and characterization will be of importance to this book, but here I offer some preliminary remarks about the principal narratorial feature

[127] Translation adapted from Paton 1927.

[128] Thucydides is the best example. For Polybius, see Marincola 1997, 189–92. Rood (2004, 153–5) points to the difficulty in assessing Polybius' self-presentation because those portions of his work in which he appears as a character survive only as excerpts.

[129] Miltsios 2013, 133.

[130] De Jong 2006, 86.

of narrative text, the narrator.[131] Simply put, 'a narrative text is a text in which a narrative agent tells a story'.[132] That narrative agent we call the narrator. Narrators themselves can be internal (a character within the narrative text, whether or not that narrator uses first-person narration) or external to the narrative. As we have already seen, Ammianus oscillates between both positions. Throughout most of the *Res Gestae* he is an external narrator (this is almost exclusively the case after Book 25). In the earlier portion of the extant narrative, however, he regularly appears as internal narrator, albeit with varying degrees of frequency and duration. The most pervasive is found in Book 18, where Ammianus narrates his spying expedition to Corduene and subsequent flight to Amida in the first person singular.

Narrative may also contain various levels of narration. 'The narrator who recounts the main story and whose voice is usually the first we hear when the story begins, is the primary narrator. This primary narrator may hand over the presentation of events to a character who recounts a story in direct speech, in which case we speak of a secondary narrator. When this character in turn embeds another narrative in his own narrative, we are dealing with a tertiary narrator, and so on.'[133] There are few occasions when Ammianus relinquishes his role as primary narrator to a secondary narrator. The typical locations in which one might expect to find secondary narration are absent from Ammianus—speeches are rare, and when they occur do not often contain narrative.[134] Equally, there are relatively few instances in which news is reported by a character. Where reports occur, they are never delivered in extensive *oratio obliqua,* and rarely contain any developed focalization or reaction from a secondary narratee. The announcement of Aquileia's surrender to Julian is typical of the role given to messengers and announcements in the *Res Gestae* (22.8.49):

> Another thing was added (*accesserat*) to crown the present joys, something long hoped for, but postponed by many complicating delays. For it was announced (*nuntiatum est*) by Agilo and Jovius, who was later quaestor, that the defenders of Aquileia, through weariness of the long siege and having learned of the death of Constantius, had opened their gates, come out and surrendered the instigators of the revolt.

[131] I follow here terminology set out in de Jong 2004a.
[132] Bal 2009, 15. [133] De Jong 2004a, 2.
[134] O'Brien 2002, 3. Most speeches are military *adlocutiones*.

There is nothing here that suggests a particular focalization of the messengers Agilo or Jovius. Julian's reaction to the news is recorded, albeit impersonally (*accesserat*) but before the news itself is reported.

De Jong further distinguishes between a 'covert' and 'overt' narrator. The best example of the former in classical literature is Homer, who presents the events of his narrative without any direct comment from the voice of the narrator. An overt narrator, by contrast, 'clearly manifests himself throughout the text', either by appearing as a character himself, passing comment on the events he narrates or on his narratorial procedure itself.[135] Perhaps the best example of an overt narrator from historiography is Herodotus.[136] Ammianus' narrator lies somewhere between the two extremes. Of course Ammianus often appears within the text as a character, and in those sections the character often focalizes the action. One of the best examples is his solitary, hurried flight from a group of Persian horsemen during the Persian invasion of 359 (18.6.13–14):

> Having through the fleetness of my mount outstripped (*praegressus*) [the Persians] and come to Amudis, a weak fortress, I found (*uenissem*) our men lying about at their ease, while their horses had been turned out to graze. Extending my arm far forward and gathering up my cloak and waving it on high, I showed (*demonstrabam*) by the usual sign that the enemy were near, and joining my horse with them I was hurried along (*ferebar*) at their pace, although my horse was now growing tired. But the full moon terrified us (*terrebat . . . nos*) as well as the flatness of the country around, which was devoid of trees and bushes and covered only by short grass, so that if were harder pressed we should have nowhere to hide.

The action here is clearly focalized through Ammianus the participant. We follow Ammianus in his moment of isolation as he flees from the Persians. Through him we perceive the soldiers in their state of un-readiness. The signal of the cloak is focalized through Ammianus' gesture (*demonstrabam*) rather than the troops' perception of it. The reader is not privy to Ammianus' personal emotions, however. These are reserved for the collective group: *terrebat autem nos*.

There is far less narratorial involvement when the narrator resumes his external narration. There is nothing that resembles the frequent comments by, for example, Polybius' or Xenophon's narrators, who commonly introduce judgements on characters or events

[135] De Jong 2004a, 2. [136] De Jong 2004b, 102–6.

within the narrative.[137] Direct authorial comments by Ammianus' narrator are confined to prefaces and methodological statements (e.g. 15.1).[138] Within the narrative itself, narratorial interventions are confined to organizational markers, such as 'cross-references' to earlier parts of the work (often in the form *ut supra* or *ante . . . rettulimus*, *monstrauimus* or *docuimus*),[139] or forwards to later sections (*ut narrabimus postea* or *ut docebimus*).[140] Otherwise they mark the beginning or end of a digression (e.g. *nunc ad textum propositum reuertamur* 14.4.7),[141] or a move in the geographical focus of narrative, for example from Gaul to North Africa in the middle of Book 28, 'from there, moving to almost another part of the world, let us come (*ueniamus*) to the sorrow of the African province of Tripolis' (28.6.1). These interventions help create the impression of a narrator who controls and organizes his narrative.

Evaluations of characters are often expressed in an impersonal form. For example, Julian is criticized for his indecorous greeting of

[137] Polybius' narrator is 'a highly intrusive explicator' according to Marincola 1997, 10. Cf. Rood 2004, 150; Miltsios 2013, 115–46. Xenophon often intervenes to offer praise or blame, for example of Teleutias: 'by Zeus, it seems to me that it is well worth a man's while to consider what sort of conduct it was that enabled Teleutias to inspire the men he commanded with such a feeling toward himself. For to attain to this is indeed the achievement of a true man, more noteworthy than the expenditure of much money and the encountering of many dangers' (*Hell.* 5.1.4). Marincola (1997, 174) had suggested that after Thucydides, Greek historians included praise or blame mainly in digressions, i.e. outside the main narrative. However, as Grey points out, Xenophon's praise of Teleutias here is within his narrative, as is that of Iphicrates (*Hell.* 6.2.32) and Epaminondas (*Hell.* 7.5.19). Grey 2003, 111–12 n.5.

[138] There is a single exception. The surrender of Nisibis by Jovian in 363 in the wake of Julian's failed Persian expedition is condemned directly by the narrator via an historical comparison: 'for never, I think (*ut arbitror*), since the founding of our city can it be found by a reader of history that any part of our territory has been yielded to an enemy by an emperor or consul.' (25.9.9). It is little surprise that this is a crucial moment for Ammianus' interpretation of Julian's campaign: Julian is absolved of blame, which instead is transferred to Jovian. See Chapter 1.1 for a similar sentiment in Eutropius, and Chapter 5 for Ammianus' presentation of Julian in Persia. The change in narratorial procedure here (the rare interjection of the narrator to pass comment on an event) draws attention to the interpretative importance of the surrender of Nisibis. See Belcher 2013 for a similar interpretation.

[139] Some examples: 14.1.8, 14.7.7, 16.6.2, 20.1.1, 21.8.1, 23.6.50, 29.6.1.

[140] Often there will be a reference to narrating an event in its proper place: *ut congruo docebimus loco* (28.6.30). Further examples: 14.9.2, 15.9.2, 19.5.3, 28.6.30, 30.7.4. Forward references can often be expressed impersonally, e.g. *residua quae secuturus aperiet textus* (15.1.1), similarly 18.4.7, 19.13.1, 26.4.3.

[141] Further examples: 14.4.26, 23.6.1. See Emmett 1981, 22 for other formulae used in concluding digressions.

the philosopher Maximus in the Senate House at Constantinople, during which he jumped up from his seat, kissed Maximus, and brought him back into the Senate chamber (22.7.3):

> This unseemly ostentation made him appear to be an excessive seeker for empty fame (*nimius captator inanis gloriae uisus*).

The criticism is couched in the passive *uisus* without any indication of *to whom* Julian's behaviour seemed so outrageous. The scene implies an internal audience (the rest of the senators) and indeed Julian performs a very visual action, but does the censure belong to the internal audience or the narrator or both? It is in fact an example of 'double focalization', a phenomenon identified by Bal, whereby focalization is carried out by both the external narrator and an internal focalizing character, in this case the senators.[142]

The primary narrator, despite his role as a character within the narrative, nonetheless has a high degree of narratorial privilege. De Jong defines the degree of such privilege according to whether the narrator 'know[s] and reveal[s] the outcome of his story . . . [has] access to the inner thoughts of his characters, and can . . . move freely and rapidly to and from all the locations of his story'.[143] Two examples illustrate the typical nature of Ammianus' narratorial privilege. The first records Julian's reaction to the news that Constantius has died and with his last words had named Julian as his heir (22.2.2):

> On learning this, and now delivered from a sea of troubles and the turmoil of anxieties associated with war, he was elated beyond measure. He now put faith in the predictions he had received, and, knowing from experience that speed had often contributed to his success, he ordered an advance into Thrace.

The narrator knows and describes Julian's intimate emotions, and even uses them to explain his decision-making without any reference to the narrator's surmise, the judgement of other characters in the text, or any other source of information.

[142] 'The external EF [External focalizer] can also watch along with a person, without leaving focalization entirely to a CF [Character focalizer]. This happens when an object (which a character can perceive) is focalized, but nothing clearly indicates whether it is actually perceived' Bal 2009, 162. A good example from ancient historiography is provided by Herodotus in his description of what Darius saw as he viewed the Bosphorus (4.85).

[143] De Jong 2004a, 3.

The second example displays how the external primary narrator can supply additional information to supplement the narrative of the internal narrator. During the siege of Amida in 359, Ammianus alludes to his presence amongst the defenders by frequent use of the first person plural. One morning, the defenders spy a group of prisoners below the walls (19.6.1):

> But at the arrival of the following dawn we saw from the citadel a countless throng (*innumeram cernimus plebem*), which after the capture of the fortress of Ziata was being taken to the enemy's camp.

The way in which these prisoners are first introduced, describing their number (*innumeram . . . plebem*), reflects the focalization of the defenders.[144] The explanation of their origins in the subsequent relative clause can only be the addition of the external narrator.[145] Matthews wishes to read this episode as an example of Ammianus' compositional technique, 'he is unlikely to have known positively when he actually saw them that the columns of prisoners were from Ziatha . . . He discovered these details later or could safely infer them, and inserted them where they belonged'.[146] Whether this is so is pure speculation; what is notable about this passage is the willingness of the narrator to retain the perspective of both the internal and external narrator. Commenting on a similar phenomenon in Caesar, Pelling notes that eyewitness and historian 'are melded together as constructors of the narrative'.[147] In the episode in Ammianus, this melding also demonstrates, however, the dominance of the external narrator, who exercises a position of omniscience at the expense of retaining the focalization of the internal narrator.

[144] Focalization may be defined as the 'selection or restriction of narrative information in relation to the experience and knowledge of the narrator, the characters or other, more hypothetical entities in the storyworld' (Niederhoff 2009, 115).

[145] Some scholars have argued that narrators cannot be focalizers (e.g. Chatman 1990 and Prince 2001, cf. Niederhoff 2009, 120–2). A text such as Ammianus' where the primary narrator alternates between (and, as here, combines) internal and external narration offers a good test-case for this issue: and the passage cited here offers evidence that an internal narrator (at least) may be a focalizer.

[146] Matthews 1989, 61. Cf. Kelly 2008, 54–5.

[147] The example is an incident at Avaricum (Caes. *BG* 7.25.1) 'which happened as we watched: we have taken the view that it was memorable and should not be passed over in silence'. The first 'we' refers to the eyewitnesses, the second to the historian. Pelling 2013, 54.

For the most part Ammianus' narrator enjoys a high degree of privilege, but he occasionally notes his uncertainty. Often these occasions are specifically concerned with character motivation, and it is notable that the characters about whom doubt is expressed are not the imperial protagonists who occupy the central focus of the narrative but more peripheral figures. Ammianus claims not to know the reason for a change of plan amongst the Alamanni (17.1.3) or the Goths for their decision to execute some Roman prisoners ('it is unknown why . . . ' 31.15.4). Often however, the claim not to know something (especially a character's motivation) is not so absolute, but is accompanied by two possible alternatives. Constantius' wife Eusebia (an imperial figure, but as an empress, not central to the narrative) suggests Julian should replace the executed Gallus as Caesar, rather than have Constantius return immediately to the East, 'whether she dreaded journeying to a far country or with her native intelligence took counsel for the common good' (15.8.3).[148] Julian's *Magister Peditum* in Gaul sabotages supplies, 'whether he did this like an empty-headed fool (*uanus*) or he brazenly perpetrated many abominable acts at the emperor's [Constantius'] bidding, has remained obscure (*latuit*) up to this time' (16.11.12). The Tripolitanians are compelled to make charges against their envoy Jovinus, 'whether by bribes or deceit is uncertain' (28.6.21). In all three occasions the narrator compensates for uncertainty by narrowing the potential (if unknown) causation to two alternatives, though he does so in an impersonal construction, which distances the judgement somewhat from the voice of the primary narrator. We may detect the well-documented Tacitean technique of innuendo or insinuation, making a suggestion of causation without openly endorsing it.[149] In the case of Barbatio, the *Magister Peditum,* it fits Ammianus' wider detraction of Constantius by insinuating the latter's involvement in undermining Julian; the authorial uncertainty here may be designed to reflect on the clandestine methods employed by Constantius. Overall, the distribution of these admissions also suggests

[148] This episode is examined in more depth in Chapter 3.2.

[149] For Tacitean innuendo see Ryberg 1942. Ammianus' narrator mentions his uncertainty at several points in the narrative of the Persian campaign of 363 (23.1.6, 24.1.11, and most crucially surrounding the identity of the person who killed Julian 25.3.6). The presence of the 'participant' during this episode may affect these displays of narratorial uncertainty.

that Ammianus' narrator retains a sharper narratorial certainty about the figures who are central to the narrative, above all Julian.

The foregoing discussion has been based on the terms set out in de Jong's collection of essays on *Greek* literature for the simple reason that there is no comparable, systematic study of narrative in Latin literature, and certainly not in historiography.[150] This is not to suggest that the terms of reference for the application of narratology to historiographical texts are radically different to genres that have traditionally been considered as more 'fictive'. Classical or classicizing historiography is essentially a narrative genre. Although it may purport to narrate events that took place in the real world, the process of connecting and explaining those events through the attribution of causation is a fictive process.[151] Some narratologists, even those who have worked on ancient texts, have appealed to an extra 'referential level', which should be taken into account in the composition of historiographical narrative, specifically the 'extra-textual level of the words and deeds of real people'.[152] This level is beyond the scope of narratological study, however. As de Jong has noted it 'is no narrative (yet): it is the historiographer who turns historical events into a narrative'.[153] Ammianus is ultimately responsible for his choices of narrative presentation.

Furthermore, although the narratological work carried out on Caesar, Livy, and Tacitus has focused largely on close readings of individual episodes or certain aspects of each historian's narrative, it has shed important light on each author's construction of authority

[150] Only four of the twenty-three essays in Grethlein and Rengakos' collection *Narrative and Interpretation: the Content of Narrative Form in Ancient Literature* deal with Latin authors. Grethlein and Rengakos 2009. The study of narrative in Greek literature carries on apace, with the recent collection of essays, *Defining Greek Narrative* (Cairns & Scodel 2014) and the preparation of a fourth volume in de Jong's series *Studies in Ancient Greek Narrative* on characterization. There are as yet no signs of as thorough a treatment of Latin literature. Wittchow's study of Ammianus examines the structural recurrence of certain narrative patterns (relating to *exempla* and what Wittchow calls 'anecdotes'), and is less concerned with questions of narratorial identity, narratees, and focalization. Wittchow 2001.

[151] White 1978, 42, and a central point of White 1987.

[152] Rood 1998, 10.

[153] De Jong 2004a, 9. See de Jong 2014, 168–72 for a response to Cohn 1999's argument that one should consider a 'historiographic narratology' separate from 'fictional narratology'. Ancient historiography, *proxima poetis* in Quintilian's words (10.1.31), is far more fictive than its modern counterparts, which are the subject of Cohen's argument.

and shaping of the interpretation of certain events.[154] Caesar has been a popular author for this kind of study because he is also a participant in his narrative, albeit the narrator and character are kept formally separate by the primary narrator's use of third-person narration for the character Caesar. Such studies of Caesar have shown how the narrator exploits this phenomenon, focalizing the action through the third-person participant, and thus conveying to the primary narrator that 'this is Caesar's story in every sense, acted out by him, perceived by him, with extra details discovered by him, then finally told by him'.[155] Narratological studies of Caesar, particularly, have shown the potential for a historian to use the relationship between his narrator and a character, especially via focalization, to convey a broader message about or interpretation of his work.[156]

In broad terms, we may define Ammianus' narrator as mostly external, moderately overt, and almost exclusively primary, though this is not universally the case. Ammianus appears to vary his narratorial voice depending on type of episode or character concerned. Although the following chapters do not offer a systematic narratological study of the *Res Gestae*, they will examine how Ammianus uses his narratorial position to characterize Julian, specifically how Julian is focalized, and how the primary external narrator and the internal 'participant' narrator work together to shape the presentation of Julian.

1.3 INTERTEXTUALITY AND HISTORIOGRAPHY

Narratology is principally concerned with the internal dynamics of a text: particularly how the narrator presents the story, constructs authority, and guides the narratees' interpretation. Intertextuality investigates relationships between texts, and will thus help assess

[154] E.g. Kraus 2007 studies Caesar's focalization and narrative arrangement in his description of the battle of Masillia in the *Bellum Civile*; Tsitsiou-Chelidoni 2009 examines internal focalization in a number of passages of Livy; Pelling 2009 studies Tacitus' 'personal voice'.

[155] Pelling 2013, 55. In other words, Caesar's is 'only a *sort-of* third-person narrative, a first-person-masquerading-as-third-person', 2013, 51.

[156] Caesar's is, perhaps, a special case, as his chosen historiographical subgenre, the *commentarius,* 'implies a relationship between author and events which is autoptic and more intimate than that implied by most historiographical narrative'. Kraus 2007, 373. Though one could say the same of the sections of Ammianus containing first-person narration.

how Ammianus related his portrayal of Julian to the generic conventions of historiography, particularly though his engagement with standard historiographical 'topoi' that had been employed by his predecessors. Here I outline the ways in which Ammianus' intertextuality has previously been studied, and develop an intertextual framework that will be deployed in the subsequent chapters.

Some attempts have previously been made to assess Ammianus' relationship with earlier Latin historians. Fornara convincingly argues for Ammianus' closer relation to Latin rather than Greek literature,[157] and indeed for his knowledge not just of the phraseology of Sallust, Livy, and Tacitus, but also of the context from which the allusions are drawn.[158] Such examples argue persuasively for the intimate intertextuality between one paragraph, or as little as one sentence in Ammianus and those of his predecessor. Attempts to gauge Ammianus' wider indebtedness to Latin historiography as a genre have rarely been made, and when they have, they have often floundered because the nature of the comparisons often does not, and cannot, rely on the level of detailed, lexical allusions used by the likes of Fornara.[159] Hence Blockley and Matthews argue for merely a superficial Tacitean sheen to Ammianus' work,[160] and Barnes' attempts to find parallels involving historiographical method (for example, the use of rumour to insinuate guilt without corroborating this view by a direct authorial comment[161]), rather than language, have met methodological opposition.[162]

The lexical allusions to Tacitus identified by Fornara on the one hand, and Barnes' attempts to identify similar historiographical techniques on the other are both types of intertextuality. In a recent study the polarizing terminology of 'conservative' and 'radical' has

[157] Fornara 1992b, 424. [158] Fornara 1992b, 430–8.

[159] Fornara compiles a list of allusions between Ammianus and Tacitus at 1992b, 433–4. For example, on the trustworthiness of barbarians: Amm. 18.2.18 *ut sunt fluxioris fidei barbari* ~ Tac. *Hist.* 3.48 *fluxa, ut est barbaris, fide*.

[160] Blockley 1973, 64–5; Matthews 1989, 32 'touches of stylistic colouring'.

[161] 'Ammianus chose to include the story [that it was rumoured the bishop of Bezabde betrayed the city to its Persian attackers] because he had learned from Tacitus how to use rumors to suggest disreputable conduct or a dishonest motive while taking no authorial responsibility for the dubious information thus conveyed.' 1998, 88. For examples of the technique in Tacitus, see Martin 1989, 46, Martin and Woodman 1989, 124–5, and Gibson 1998.

[162] 'Confirmation of this intuition is difficult, and further examples, though helpful, would not constitute proof.' Kelly 2008, 178.

been applied to Fornara's and Barnes' types of intertextuality respectively.[163]

Kelly has undertaken a form of 'conservative' intertextual study of Ammianus in which he vigorously argues that we should not read the *Res Gestae* from the starting point of a (highly contentious) (re) constructed biography,[164] but in the realization that Ammianus was engaging in an allusive literary project which sought to unite an account of contemporary history with the literary traditions of predominately Latin classical authors, in order to create a narrative rich in historical *exempla* to serve future generations, whilst simultaneously establishing itself as the continuation of that earlier tradition.

His argument is based on a thorough evaluation of close parallels of individual words and phrases in Ammianus, what I call here lexical allusions. One of the first intertextual identifications in Kelly's book is between Ammianus and Tacitus. In the aftermath of the battle of *Ad Salices* in Book 31, Ammianus describes the remains of the dead on the battlefield in a conscious allusion to both Tacitus and Virgil:[165]

> ut indicant **nunc usque albentes ossibus campi**. (Amm. 31.7.16)
> as the **plains, even now white with bones**, show.
>
> . . . **adhuc campique ingentes ossibus albent** (Virgil *Aen.* 12.36)
> and the boundless **plains are still white with bones**
>
> **medio campi albentia ossa** (Tacitus *Ann.* 1.61.2)
> in the **plain** between **were whitening bones**

Kelly argues that this is a 'window allusion'; Ammianus is conscious that Tacitus, in his description of the aftermath of Varus' disaster, alludes to Latinus' lament in the *Aeneid* about the result of the fighting between Italians and Trojans. Ammianus alludes to both texts, rather than one or the other. The version in Book 31 is one letter away from being a complete clausula of hexameter, and the *nunc* mirrors the *adhuc* suggesting the allusion to Virgil. Additionally, 'the echo of

[163] Levene 2010, 82. Levene places his own study within the 'conservative' camp. He is 'primarily interested in allusive effects which can plausibly be attributed to Livy's own intentions' and therefore chooses to rely on lexical allusions to demonstrate Livy's reliance upon and adaptation of earlier historians (including Greek texts, such as Polybius). Levene 2010, 82–163.

[164] 'To rest theories about his work on what we know of his life is to build a house on the sands.' Kelly 2008, 107.

[165] Kelly 2008, 19–21.

Tacitus is more obviously interpretable than the Vergilian one. It implies a comparison of the two great Roman disasters, those of Varus and Valens, at barbarian hands. In both cases, bones are left unburied and unhallowed many years on, whereas Vergil's Latinus speaks in the immediate aftermath of the battle.'[166]

Context (the similar nature of the scene—both in content and presentation) as well as the lexical similarity justifies the strength of the identification of this intertext. Kelly is emphatic about the primacy of the latter; similarity of content or context (subject matter) is merely 'a device of signalling allusion within the text'.[167] Nevertheless, it is conceivable that one could invert this proposition, and argue that it is the lexical allusion that is merely the clue to engagement with a wider intertextual nexus.

Indeed, the example of the *Ad Salices* passage is more complex than Kelly suggests. Kelly's reasons for identifying the allusions to Virgil and Tacitus are strong (a similar combination of words, metrics, and content). Yet the central combination of *ossa* and *albere* appears in relatively few situations in extant Latin literature, several of which share a similar context:

> **testes estote**, Philippi, | et quorum sparsis **ossibus albet humus**.
> (Ovid *Fasti* 3.707–8)
>
> **witness** Philippi and they whose scattered **bones whiten the ground**.

> **nunc** licet Esquiliis habitare salubribus atque
> aggere in aprico spatiari, qui **modo** tristes
> **albis** informem **spectabant ossibus agrum**
> (Horace. *Serm*. 1.8.14–16)
>
> **Now** one may live on a wholesome Esquiline, and stroll on the sunny rampart where **once** one sadly **looked out on ground** ghastly **with whitening bones**.

In the first example, Ovid refers to the aftermath of Octavian and Antony's victory over Brutus at Philippi in the *Fasti,* his poetic catalogue of Roman historical events and religious practices. Here, Ovid approves of Octavian's revenge taken against the conspirators who murdered Caesar and who 'lie low in death, the death they merited' (*Fasti* 3.707). The aftermath scene of Philippi is invoked as a testament to this. For Ovid, the ground whitening with bones (here

[166] Kelly 2008, 21. [167] Kelly 2008, 21.

ager rather than *campi* in Ammianus, Virgil, and Tacitus) is the signal that this is an incident of battle-aftermath. Ovid has inverted the convention of visual perception so that we do not behold Philippi, but rather Philippi acts as a witness to Octavian's revenge (*testes estote*).[168] This playful technique is familiar from Ovid's adaptation of generic conventions of epic in his *Metamorphoses*.[169]

The second example, from Horace, contains the same elements—visual perception (*spectabant*), the ground (here, *humus*) marred with white bones. Like the passages in Virgil and Ammianus, a comparison is made between the present (*nunc*) and the past, when once (*modo*) the Esquiline could be seen covered in bones. The scene is not the aftermath of a battle, but an area which had been used as a burial ground for slaves. It had recently undergone renovation by Maecenas and is now a 'sunswept mound'.[170] Again, outside the genre of serious history, there may be an element of playfulness in applying this description to the actions of Maecenas, who had been a general for much of his career and served on Octavian's side at Philippi, but had become chief administrator in Rome and Horace's patron.[171] Whatever his purpose for including this scene, Horace identifies the same defining elements that are present in Ovid and Virgil—'then' versus 'now', the ground covered with whitening bones, and visual perception.

Indeed, the combination of *ossa* and *albere* proliferates between Virgil and Tacitus. In Seneca's eponymous tragedy, Oedipus describes the ground around the Sphinx's perch as ***albens ossibus*** *sparsis* ***solum***.[172] Statius (perhaps picking up on Ovid's lead) describes Philippi again as ***albos ossibus*** *Italis Philippos*.[173] The connection between conflict-aftermath and the ground covered with white bones is evident in both examples.

[168] 'Viewing' is a key element of the 'battle aftermath scene'. See the discussion of Pagán 2000 in Chapter 1.3.1.

[169] For example, the mostly unheroic actions of the great heroes of the Calydonian boar hunt, who cannot aim their javelins properly (8.345–6) and leap into trees for safety (8.368).

[170] Brown 1993, 171.

[171] The contrast between the bones of slain soldiers (which the general is accustomed to seeing) and the decaying corpses of domestic slaves is a startling turnaround. Evidence for Maecenas' military career is found in Propertius 2.1.25–30.

[172] 'the ground whitening with scattered bones' *Oed.* 94. It may not be the aftermath of a specific battle but these bones are the evidence of several earlier conflicts between individuals and the Sphinx.

[173] 'Philippi white with Italian bones' *Silvae* 2.7.65.

Where does this leave Kelly's neat intertextual relationship? Does it matter that not all the manifestations of these lexical *comparanda* pertain to the aftermath specifically of battles? Could Ammianus be alluding to Horace or Ovid or Seneca as well as Tacitus and Virgil? In Seneca's case, there are other corroborating points of comparison: in the previous clause Ammianus had stated *reliqua peremptorum corpora **dirae uolucres** consumpserunt*.[174] What better example could there be of a *dira uolucer* feeding on the flesh of humans than the sphinx herself?

The Virgilian prototype clearly establishes the idea of the ground whitening with bones as a small-scale topos,[175] which as a single phrase has the power to invoke a wider topos of 'battle aftermath'. In the hands of Ovid and Horace, it can be applied to different contexts for playful effects. Indeed, these manifestations can then feed back into the genre of 'true' historiography. Earlier in the *Fasti*, Ovid applies the 'whitening bones' topos as the evidence of Cacus' victims outside his cave:

> **ora super postes adfixa**que **bracchia** pendent
> squalidaque humanis **ossibus albet humus**.
> (Ovid *Fasti* 1.557–8)

> **Above the doorway skulls** and **arms** of men were **fastened**, while the ground bristled and **whitened** with human **bones**.[176]

As Seneca was later to do with the sphinx, Ovid applies the topos to mark out the fate of earlier victims of a human-eating monster, while setting the scene for that monster's demise (this time at the hands of Hercules).[177] It can be argued that this passage of Ovid provides a source text for Tacitus' description of the Varus-disaster:

> medio **campi albentia ossa**, ut fugerant, ut restiterant, disiecta vel aggerata. adiacebant fragmina telorum equorumque artus, simul **truncis** arborum **antefixa ora**. (*Ann*. 1.61.2)

[174] 'the bodies of the rest of the slain were devoured by foul birds' 31.7.16.

[175] *Pace* Kelly 2002, 11: 'the whitened and unburied bones on the battlefield are less of a topos than the Rhine flowing with blood at Strasbourg or the rivers warm with blood in the *Aeneid*'.

[176] Trans. Frazer 1931.

[177] The Virgilian version of the Cacus scene contains the heads nailed to the doors but not the whitening bones (*semperque recenti | caede tepebat humus, foribusque adfixa superbis | ora virum tristi pendebant pallida tabo*. *Aen*. 8.195–7).

> In the **plain** between were **bleaching bones**, scattered or in little heaps, as the men had fallen, fleeing or standing fast. Hard by lay splintered spears and limbs of horses, while **human skulls** were **nailed prominently** on **the trunks** of trees.[178]

We find not just the whitening bones, but the combination of *os* and a compound participle form of *fingo*. The tree trunks are a comparable fixing-post to Cacus' door-frame. The whole scene is applicable to Germanicus' return to the Teutoburg forest—the description is set within a flashback in which the primeval threat to early Roman society (Cacus) is directly comparable to the menacing presence of the contemporary Germans to the first-century Romans. Germanicus (as close as it comes to a Tacitean hero), by seeking out this former battlefield, is cast as a new Hercules pursuing Cacus.[179] A small-scale topos (whitening bones) can signal an engagement with a larger topos (battle aftermath). Lexical allusion is the key determining factor for the former, whereas comparability of context and meaning is essential to the latter.[180]

Ultimately, I believe that Kelly is correct to identify Ammianus' direct intertextual engagement with only Virgil and Tacitus.[181] There is little intertextual evidence to suggest that Ammianus was aware of the more developed nexus surrounding 'whitening bones', whereas certainly Tacitus seems to have alluded to Virgil and Ovid. One also requires meaningfulness to establish these sorts of relationships between texts, and it seems difficult to establish what Ammianus gained by a possible allusion to Seneca's *Oedipus* beyond rhetorical *color*.

[178] Translations of Tacitus are taken from Moore and Jackson's Loeb editions unless otherwise stated.

[179] The situation could be more complicated still—in the Virgilian original (quoted in the previous footnote) those *dirae volucres* also appear within this intertextual web. They make their home on the crag above Cacus' cave: ***dirarum*** *nidis domus opportuna* ***volucrum*** (*Aen*. 8.235). This could be another window allusion; Ammianus is signalling that he knew the Virgilian version which underlies Ovid's.

[180] Kelly (2008, 62) anticipates this in his conclusion to his discussion of the 'bones on the battlefield': 'Further comparison of Ammianus and Tacitus shows aesthetic similarities, worthy of note whether or not they are the product of conscious imitation . . . in a more developed form than Ammianus, Tacitus deploys a device which might be called archaeological reconstruction, in which the battle or its aftermath is seen through its remains.' He does not pursue it any further, however.

[181] He does not mention or discuss any of these other intertextualities in either his 2008 monograph or the 2002 thesis on which it was based.

Yet we also find other examples of 'battle aftermath' elsewhere in the extant portions of *Res Gestae*.[182] In the next section we will investigate in a case study how earlier authors establish other conventions of the 'battle aftermath scene' (beyond 'whitening bones') and how Ammianus meaningfully engages with and redeploys these conventions in his *Res Gestae*.

1.3.1 *Miseranda civitas*: Constantius and the Aftermath of Amida

Unlike the soldier Ammianus, the emperor Constantius was not present at the siege of Amida in 359. However, he did visit the site six months after the loss of the city to Sapor's army, as Ammianus narrates in 20.4–5 at an interval of several chapters after the completion of the siege in the previous book at 19.9.[183] Within the *Res Gestae,* the scope and aims of Ammianus' narrative of Constantius' military failures in the Persian wars of 359 and 360 contrast with Julian's successes in Germany.[184] Constantius' visit to Amida plays a part in this project.

The 'battle aftermath scene', of which the 'whitening bones' were a part, does not only exist in Tacitus. Tacitus himself adopted and adapted a large-scale topos of Latin literature. In a seminal study which investigates the deployment of this type of scene in Statius, Pagán charts the formulaic elements of a 'battle aftermath' scene from a corpus of texts consisting of Sallust *BC* 61.1 (the aftermath of Catiline's defeat), Livy 22.51.5–9 (Hannibal at Cannae), Tacitus *Annals* 1.61–2 (Germanicus at Varus' defeat in the Teutoburg forest) and *Histories* 2.70 (Vitellius at Bedriacum),[185] Lucan 7.787–801

[182] 14.7.3 and 20.11.4–5.

[183] This may be the aftermath of a siege, rather than a pitched battle, but the capture of a city is as militaristic a scene as a battle, and the casualties perhaps even more pathos-invoking because they could also include civilians. Quintilian (8.3.67–70) details exactly how an orator should treat the topos in oratory. Woodman argues that Quintilian's conventions also pass into historiography (1972, 155–6).

[184] Elsewhere I have examined Ammianus' negative presentation of Constantius at Amida as the historian's attempt to redress Julian's more positive presentation of the same emperor at another Mesopotamian siege, Nisibis, found in Julian's two panegyrics to Constantius. Ross 2014.

[185] The passage in the *Annals* alludes directly to that in the *Histories*. Woodman 1979.

(Caesar at Pharsalus), and Silius Italicus 10.449–53 (Hannibal at Cannae). All are historiographical works, but Pagán does not extend her study to include Ammianus. It is instructive to quote at length Pagán's summary of the common features:

'(1) Each aftermath scene is set apart from the rest of the narrative temporally: *sed confecto proelio* (Sall. 61.1); *postero die ubi primum inluxit* (Liv. 22.51.5); *sextum post cladis annum* (Tac. *Ann*. 1.62.1); *intra quadragensimum pugnae diem* (Tac. *Hist*. 2.70.1); *postquam clara dies* (Luc. 7.787); *postera cum thalamis Aurora rubebit apertis* (Sil. 10.525).

(2) Four examples state the purpose of the return to the battlefield, and three use a gerund or gerundive to do so: *visundi aut spoliandi gratia* (Sall. 61.8); *ad spolia legenda foedamque etiam hostibus spectandam stragem* (Liv. 22.51.5); *cupido . . . solvendi suprema* (Tac. *Ann*. 1.61.1); *lustrare oculis concupivit* (Tac. *Hist*. 2.70.1).

(3) All contain verbs of discovery or visual perception: *cerneres, repertus est, reperiebant* (Sall.); *spectandam, invenerunt, apparebat* (Liv.); *scrutaretur, invenerit* (Tac. *Ann*.); *spectato, recognoscere, intueri, mirari* (Tac. *Hist*.); *cernit, agnoscat* (Luc.); *visu, spectacula, agnovit* (Silius).

(4) Three authors use the verb *lustrare*, conferring a sense of ritual to the scenes: *lustrare oculis* (Tac. *Hist*. and Luc. 7.795); *lustrabat* (Sil. 10.450).

(5) Four examples mention the role of fate or chance in the battle: *fors* (Liv. 22.51.6); *sortem hominum* (Tac. *Ann*. 1.61.1); *sors rerum* (Tac. *Hist*. 2.70.3); *fortunam . . . cernit* (Luc. 7.796).

(6) In three of the descriptions, Livy and Tacitus join pairs of nouns or adjectives with either coordinating or disjunctive conjunctions, asserting a sort of rhetorical control over the chaotic scene: *pedites passim equitesque; aut pugna aut fuga* (Liv. 22.51.6); *disiecta vel aggerata; fragmina telorum equorumque artus* (Tac. *Ann*. 1.61.3–4); *alienas reliquias an suorum* (Tac. *Ann*. 1.62.1); *putres virorum equorumque formae* (Tac. *Hist*. 2.70.1).

(7) In some instances innumerable bodies are seen lying about: *disiecerat* (Sall. 61.3); *iacebant tot Romanorum milia* (Liv. 22.51.6); *adiacebant* (Tac. *Ann*. 1.61.4); *tot milia insepultorum*

civium (Tac. *Hist*. 2.70.3); *numerat populos* (Luc. 7.792); *facta recensebat* (Sil. 10.451).

(8) In three cases, the return to the battlefield serves to unite the surviving soldiers in purpose: *per omnem exercitum* (Sall. 61.9); *omni exercitu* (Tac. *Ann*. 1.61.1); *volgus militum* (Tac. *Hist*. 2.70.3).'[186]

Pagán's examples are taken from a range of authors with whom Ammianus shows familiarity. Kelly has demonstrated that Ammianus knew all of these authors in sufficient detail to deploy meaningful, lexical allusions to these source texts elsewhere within the *Res Gestae*.[187] My contention is that Ammianus was sufficiently familiar with all of these conventions to be capable of using them in his description of Constantius' visit to Amida in order to condemn the emperor for the loss of this strategically important city. Ammianus' description of Constantius' visit to Amida is brief (little over one section at the beginning of the final chapter of Book 20).[188]

> diu moratus **post aequinoctium** egreditur **autumnale** / Amidam petens. / cuius, cum prope uenisset, / moenia **fauillis** oppleta **collustrans** / flebat cum gemitu / reputans, quales **miseranda ciuitas** pertulerat clades. / ibi tunc **forte** Ursulus praesens, / qui aerarium tuebatur, / dolore percitus exclamauit: / 'en quibus animis urbes a milite defenduntur, / cui ut abundare stipendium possit, / imperii opes iam fatiscunt!' / quod dictum ita amarum / **militaris multitudo** postea apud Calchedona recordata / ad eius exitium consurrexit. (20.11.4–5)
>
> Delaying for a long time, **after the autumnal equinox** he set out on his way to Amida. When he had approached, **inspecting** the walls reduced to a heap **of ashes**, he wept and groaned aloud as he thought of the calamities the **pitiable city** had endured. And Ursulus, the state-treasurer, who **chanced** to be there at the time, was filled with sorrow and cried: 'behold with what courage the cities are defended by our soldiers, for whose abundance of pay the wealth of the empire is already becoming insufficient'. And this bitter remark the **throng of soldiers** recalled later at Chalcedon and conspired for his destruction.

[186] Pagán 2000, 433–4.

[187] Kelly's catalogue and set of examples of 'seven types of allusion' (2008, 198–214) demonstrates Ammianus' use of Tacitus, Sallust, Livy, and Silius Italicus. For Ammianus' allusions to Lucan, see Kelly 2008, 169.

[188] The brevity itself may be seen as part of Ammianus' programme of denigration against Constantius.

At least six of Pagán's eight features are present, if somewhat transmuted, in the Ammianean context. (1) Constantius' visit is marked off by a temporal indicator, *post aequinoctium,* but the interval is far greater than what one finds in earlier historians, who normally posit the visit to the battle scene within a few days of the end of the conflict.[189] (2) Constantius' visit is almost incidental (his ultimate destination is Bezabde), yet there is a hint of causation in the gerundive *miseranda*.[190] Instead of wanting to intervene in the scene, either for stripping spoils or burying the dead, Constantius merely wishes to pity the place and leave it as he found it.[191] His lack of active intervention is more akin to Vitellius' tyrannical viewing of the aftermath of Bedriacum (*lustrare oculis concupivit,* Tac. *Hist*. 2.70.1).[192] Vitellius does not intervene to bury the dead, and instead views the scene for his own twisted enjoyment. Ammianus' presentation of Constantius is not as blatantly negative as Tacitus' of Vitellius, but pity is not enough to make Constantius' presence at Amida seem positive.

(3) and (4) Ammianus combines the verb of perceiving with a hint at the purification found in Tacitus, Lucan, and Silius by employing the participle *collustrans*. The verb does not just imply viewing,[193] but the root meaning of *lustrare* meaning to purify is tied up in the semantics of the compound. The choice of this verb of perceiving reinforces the idea that Constantius mistakenly thinks that his passive viewing of the scene is suitable, and no further action is needed.

(5) The idea of fate or chance is transposed from those who fought in the battle to the (ill-fated) presence of Ursulus (*forte*), who assumes the formulaic role of guide. Instead of pointing out features of the

[189] Though Tacitus still applies the conventions of a battle aftermath scene to Germanicus' arrival in the Teutoburg forest six years after the Varus disaster. Tac. *Ann*. 1.62.1.

[190] *Miseratio* for the victims is a key element in rhetorically elaborated scenes of the *urbs capta* (Quintilian *Inst*. 8.3.67). Tacitus uses it when he maps the conventions of the *urbs capta* topos onto the collapse of an amphitheatre at Fidenae and thus casts Tiberius as an external foe (*miserandi magis, Ann*. 4.62.3). Woodman 1972 and Keitel 2010, 340. Tacitus also notes that the whole army were moved to pity (*ad miserationem*) at Teutoburg, *Ann*. 1.62.1.

[191] It was eventually rebuilt by Valens. Lenski 2002, 378 and 2007, 220.

[192] For Vitellius' 'cruel voyeurism' as part of his tyrannical representation, see Keitel 2007, 443.

[193] 'The verb is used [in Tacitus and Vergil] when a person surveys a wide space or a large quantity of things, as is also the case in the other instances in Amm.: 16.10.14, 24.5.3, and 27.10.10.' Den Boeft et al. 1987, 251.

scene as Valens and Caecina do to Vitellius at Bedriacum,[194] he attacks the Roman troops who defended the city, alienating him from them, as Ammianus records in a prolepsis by referring to his future indictment at the Chalcedon trials. Pagán notes that 'an aftermath narrative affords an author the opportunity to explore the intertwining nexus of past, present, and future'.[195] Here this exchange and the subsequent forward-reference forces the reading of this aftermath narrative firmly towards the future (Ursulus' fate in the trial is recorded at 22.3.7–8), and by extension to Constantius' coming military failure at Bezabde and his final demise.

(6) The one feature that is absent from Ammianus' aftermath scene is the pairing of nouns or adjectives connected by coordinating or disjunctive conjunctions. The examples that Pagán cites are drawn from the scene of the battle (not, for example, related to those viewing). Ammianus' aftermath scene is notably devoid of a detailed description of Amida, other than the *moenia fauillis oppleta* (this takes the place of the enumeration and description of the slain (7)). Again this stresses the time scale involved (the inhabitants, presumably, have deserted the place and despoiled or buried the dead and so there is no scope for Constantius to take on this formulaic role).

(8) The return to Amida does indeed serve to unite the surviving soldiers in a common purpose, but here that purpose is turned against Constantius' official, Ursulus: *quod dictum ita amarum* ***militaris multitudo*** *postea apud Chalcedona recordata*.

In this short scene, we find Ammianus carefully redeploying an emotive topos of classical historiography to raise questions about Constantius and to show that this brief visit to Amida is part of his journey towards his failure at Bezabde and subsequent demise as Augustus. Importantly for this study of Ammianus' historiography, it clearly demonstrates that Ammianus was fully capable of engaging with the classical tradition of historiography in a way that goes beyond the lexical allusions that Kelly has identified. The battle-aftermath topos relies on similarity of context and presentation. These large-scale topoi are themselves a form of intertextuality, but of a kind more complex than the largely linear relationships of lexical allusions, whereby Ammianus alludes to one or maybe two source

[194] Vitellius' generals act 'as tour guides'. Manolaraki 2005, 249.
[195] Pagán 2000, 425.

texts at a time.[196] Topoi construct their formulaic elements across a wide spectrum of texts, each one in turn codifying the rules of the tradition by adherence to or overt mutation of those rules.

1.4 OVERVIEW

The chapters that follow are necessarily episodic; they do not offer an analysis of each and every of Julian's actions within the *Res Gestae* but focus on select events from Books 14 to 25. This approach nonetheless reflects the nature of Ammianus' text, which oscillates between the actions of imperial protagonists, interspersed with excursus and events elsewhere in the empire; each section is, then, bounded as a distinct narrative unit.[197] At the expense of a comprehensive study of every moment of Julian's career as it is represented by Ammianus, the selective nature of the following chapters allows for a detailed analysis of how Ammianus' narrator creates a depiction of Julian that simultaneously engages with and stands apart from existing (predominately Greek) traditions, whilst melding this new interpretation into distinctive and defining topoi of classical historiography. Such an analysis is both diachronic and synchronic, intratextual and intertextual, and thus repays the detailed scope I give it here. The episodes have not been chosen randomly. They are the principal episodes of Julian's reign, and had been established as such because they are those which Eutropius had chosen to include in his *Breviarium* (the fullest account of Julian's reign in Latin to appear before Ammianus'). These events are the background to Julian's elevation, namely Constantius' treatment of Gallus and Silvanus (Eutr. 10.13); Julian's appointment as Caesar (10.14.1); his subsequent victory at Strasbourg and elevation to Augustus (10.14.1–.15.1); and finally his campaign and death in Persia (10.16.1–2).[198]

[196] The exception to this is 'window allusion' whereby one author alludes to the text of another author who in turn alludes to a third author. The original allusion of the first to the second text does not preclude also the meaningful allusion of the first text to the third (through the medium of the second). Ammianus engaged in this sort of allusive practice: Kelly 2008, 209–11.

[197] Barnes 1998, 34–9.

[198] 10.15.2 contains Constantius' death and obituary.

The choice of material also reflects the alternating pattern of presence and absence of Ammianus as a protagonist. Chapter 2 analyses two characters who in different ways prefigure Julian in the narrative in their roles as appointees, rivals, and finally victims of Constantius—the Caesar Gallus and the usurper Silvanus. Significantly Ammianus appears as a character in both episodes and it will be argued that he establishes his presence as a means of effecting a significant shift in the presentation of each of Constantius' rivals.

Chapters 3 and 4 provide an analysis of Julian when he first enters the narrative as a relatively unknown and inexperienced character before going on to accrue legitimacy and experience via his military exploits in Gaul. Significantly these episodes provide a sustained commentary on the development of Julian's suitability to be sole emperor in the lead up to his proclamation as Augustus. Ammianus' use of recognizable topoi such as speech-scenes and battle-scenes allow him to rework and critique the existing debate about Julian's growing qualifications.

The final chapter deals with an event which more than any other has received detailed discussion by recent and contemporary authors, Julian's Persian campaign of 363. It is only here that Ammianus appears as a participant during the same event as Julian. The chapter considers the uses to which Ammianus puts the participant in negotiating his text's relationship with contemporary discussions of Roman failure in Persia and equally how he seeks to explain Julian's failure while offering a final assessment within a particularly Roman and historiographical framework.

Ammianus composed his work as the last of the generation of authors who wrote about Julian's reign and had lived through it themselves. The subsequent historians Rufinus, Orosius, Philostorgius, Socrates, and Sozomen had to rely on what they found in their predecessors. It is the contention of the following chapters that Ammianus is aware of his position at this watershed in the tradition of Julianic discourse. His choice to write in Latin adds to the sense of definitiveness of his account. In writing for a Latin-speaking and increasingly monolingual audience, he did not ignore the Greek and Eastern tradition; rather he absorbed it, engaged with it, and reworked it into a text that drew its authority and sense of definiteness from the very fact that it was written in Latin and thus stood outside the intense 'Julianic debate' of the late 360s.

2

The Narrator and the Participant

Gallus and Silvanus in Preparation for Julian

Ammianus' narrative of Julian begins in earnest only with Julian's elevation to the position of Caesar halfway through Book 15, but much of the material that precedes this event appears to be closely linked, thematically and in terms of the role of the narrator, to the later Julianic material. This chapter, then, explores two episodes—the brief careers of Gallus Caesar and the usurper Silvanus, during both of which Ammianus appears as a participant within the narrative—from a series of interconnected perspectives. Namely, it will consider the related questions of how Ammianus uses broad structural arrangements to link the two episodes as a critique of Constantius in preparation for the arrival of Julian; what role the primary narrator plays in shaping the presentation of Gallus and Silvanus, particularly in light of the (brief) insertion of an internal narrator part of the way through each section; and how these figures are linked interpretatively to Julian.

Julian is mentioned only once in the extant books before his elevation scene in 15.8 as 'the future famous emperor' (15.2.7) in a fleeting note as he defends himself against attacks made by Constantius' courtiers who allege that he met and colluded with his half-brother Gallus in Constantinople. The placement and content of these two episodes in Book 15 thus link Julian to two other characters, who in varying ways foreshadow the arrival of Julian within the *Res Gestae*—Gallus, the latter part of whose reign as Caesar in Antioch is narrated in Book 14, and Silvanus, Constantius' *Magister Peditum* in Gaul, who is cast as an unwilling usurper against Constantius in the fifth chapter of Book 15. There are broad, yet obvious parallels with

Julian's situation later in the *Res Gestae*; Julian will be elevated to the Caesarship as Gallus has in Book 14, and then usurp (20.4–5) in the same part of the empire, and, as Ammianus presents it, in a similarly unwilling way to Silvanus at 15.5. However, direct parallels between these three episodes are complicated when the details of each are examined closely. Gallus is presented as a cruel and tyrannical figure during his brief tenure as Constantius' Caesar in the East, driven by his wife to commit a string of injustices against the inhabitants of the eastern half of the empire, particularly in Antioch. Constantius is kept well informed of Gallus' behaviour, however, and pretending still to be well disposed to him, recalls him to Italy but arranges his execution en route. Ammianus had the scope, therefore, to present Gallus also as victim of Constantius' machinations at court. Similarly Silvanus is both victim and villain. Ammianus initially outlines the complex details of a plot against him by several of Constantius' officials, who forge documents suggesting Silvanus planned to revolt; the discovery of this plot prompts Silvanus into actual rebellion. It is a more complex tale told in a more compact form than the Gallus episode, during which the narrator has to present each side's relative level of understanding of the other's knowledge and motivations in order to explain the development of the plot.

From this brief overview, it is already clear that the episodes have various elements in common. Both are illustrations of Constantius' removal of a rival, who in turn is presented in an ambiguous fashion as tyrant/rebel or victim. The elucidation of both episodes, and the characterization of Gallus and Silvanus rely largely on the explanation of the understanding (or lack thereof) on one side of the intentions and motivations of the other. These episodes are further drawn into parallel by a narratorial phenomenon—the appearance of Ammianus as a participant within the narrative. In each case Ammianus introduces himself using the first person roughly halfway through each episode (14.9.1 and 15.5.22). Both times Ammianus is in the company of his commanding officer, the general Ursicinus. Largely because of these statements of participation, both episodes have received a great deal of scholarly attention, though individually and never as a pair, and often as a way to demonstrate Ammianus' distortion of events apropos of a modern reconstruction of what might actually have been afoot on each occasion.[1]

[1] For such approaches to Gallus, see Blockley 1972 (though he explores the literary qualities of Ammianus' Gallus in the first chapter of Blockley 1975), Barceló 2004, 107–10; and Nutt 1973 and Drinkwater 1983 for Silvanus.

Such approaches have merit for addressing purely historical questions of imperial politics during Constantius' reign—especially of his attempts and failures to manage the entire empire single-handedly in face of potential usurpers and external threats during the 350s—but after offering their versions of what might have actually happened, recent scholars rarely return to Ammianus' account and its 'distortions' other than to suggest that Ammianus has introduced them out of loyalty to defend his old boss Ursicinus.[2] Such studies, which reach conclusions about Ammianus' personal loyalty to Ursicinus, often fail to see how Gallus and Silvanus are deployed as a pair within the wider narrative of the *Res Gestae*, despite the obvious part they play in preparing the way in the narrative for Julian.[3]

2.1 STRUCTURE, SELECTION OF MATERIAL, AND INTERPRETATION

Later in this chapter we will turn to look in detail at the internal arrangement, themes, and narratorial roles within each episode, but first it is worth considering how they are set within the *Res Gestae* as a whole and particularly how they relate to the Julianic narrative that begins towards the end of Book 15. It could be argued that Books 14 and 15 only appear to offer preparatory material before the arrival of Julian at 15.8 because they are the first extant books of the *Res Gestae,* but this may not just be an accident of survival. Indeed Book 14 is likely to have been the first book to survive precisely because it represents a change of narrative gear, moving away from a rapid and cursory format of the lost books which covered AD 96–353 to a more extensive narrative, which took eighteen books to cover only twenty-five years.[4] In a period replete with breviaries and epitomes

[2] Den Boer 1960; Nutt 1973; Drinkwater 1994; Hunt 1999, 58. For a recent exception in the analysis of the Silvanus, see Weisweiler 2015, discussed in more depth below.

[3] An exception is provided by Guzmán-Armario 2002, who sketches out briefly the multiple uses to which Silvanus is put within the narrative—among them, an attack on Constantius, a negative critique of 'barbarian' commanders within the Roman army, a defence of Ursicinus, and the preparation for Julian's rebellion. He does not draw any comparisons with the Gallus episode, however.

[4] Schanz 1914, 95.

(such as those of the *Kaisergeschichte*, Victor, Eutropius, and Festus), the unexceptional format of Ammianus' early books ensured they were swiftly lost.[5] Gallus, therefore, provides the introduction to this newly expansive section, confirmed also by the neat hexadic structure into which the extant books fall, 14–19, 20–25 and 26–31.[6] Book 14, albeit lacking an authorial preface, unlike Books 15 and 26,[7] introduces the first of the two most important hexads in the work, those that narrate the reign of Julian.[8] Barnes, attaching much significance to the idea of this regular, hexadic structure and noting that the preceding thirteen lost books cannot so neatly fall into groups of six, made the radical suggestion that there were in fact thirty-six (not thirty-one) books: a scribal error following the loss of the first eighteen books (as he would have it) elided a 'V' from the original numbering, turning, for example, book XXV to XX with a knock-on effect for the rest of the numerals.[9] If Barnes' suggestion that there

[5] Vessey obliquely suggests that the early books of Ammianus' work were lost because they could not compete with other, contemporary breviary histories, 2010, 286. The problem may have been that they were not brief enough, averaging *c.* twenty years per book of a length, if the same as the extant books, of roughly thirty Teubner pages each (a problem compounded if one accepts there were a further five lost books, as suggested by Barnes 1998). They would have sat somewhere awkwardly between the level of detail typical of true breviary, but far short of the expansive classicizing scope of the extant books. Eutropius' books, by contrast, are no more than eight Teubner pages in length, and, with the exception of the very brief fifth book, cover no less than thirty-five years in a single book.

[6] A noticeably Tacitean rather than Livian format, cf. Barnes 1998, 24.

[7] Cf. Fornara 1990 for the argument that Ammianus' preface in Book 15 is not designed to mark a change in the expansiveness of his narrative. The prefaces also frame the Julianic books.

[8] Rees has recently made the radical suggestion that the missing books never existed, and that 'the *Res Gestae* masqueraded as fragmentary' (Rees 2014). One of the main tenets of his argument is that Book 14 contains much material that seems to be introductory (particularly digressions that, in Rees' view, would better have been posited earlier in a missing book if it had existed and seem to be disconnected from the surrounding narrative in Book 14) and thus they are ill-suited to the fourteenth book of work that purports to contain thirty-one. I argue here, however, that Gallus (and Silvanus after him) are intended to be read as preparatory for the arrival of Julian and thus it is little surprise that Book 14 is introductory in character, even if thirteen books preceded it. Below I consider how some of these digressions are not as irrelevant within the context of Book 14 as Rees makes out.

[9] Barnes 1998, 29. Cameron's revised suggestion (2011, 749–50) that there were originally forty-one books fails to take account of Barnes' central point that Ammianus composed in a hexadic structure. Cf. Rees 2014, 132. Rees raises the important caveat, however, that 'it is harder to imagine that the copyist would have depended on his erroneous intertitle XIIII rather than his source text (which would have read XX) when scribing the subsequent intertitle (XIIIII or XV)'. 2014, 132.

were thirty-six books is correct, and his case is an attractive one, then Book 14 (in Barnes' theory, the original XIX) is not just the beginning of a new hexad, but the beginning of the second half of the work, the nineteenth out of thirty-six books. Our first (extant) book was originally placed at a structurally significant point, which invited its reading as the beginning of a new stage in Ammianus' text.

Even if Barnes' hypothesis were incorrect, the first half of the hexad formed by Books 14–19 nonetheless forms a distinct unit, a triad of Books 14–16 links Gallus, Silvanus, and Julian together as a succession of imperial figures who become implicated in some way with the machinations of Constantius' court.[10] The series begins with the reign and downfall of Gallus in Book 14, transitions in Book 15 via the rebellion of Silvanus in Chapter 5 to the elevation of Julian in Chapter 8, then culminates with Julian's victory against the Alamanni at Strasbourg at the end of Book 16.[11] The Gallus and Silvanus episodes stand out from the other events of this triad because they involve the participation of Ammianus as a character; the narrative thus switches (albeit very briefly in the case of Gallus) from external narration to internal narration. The use of the first person to represent the historian as a character within the narrative was a rare phenomenon in historiography generally, but particularly so in Latin historiography, where the only other extant historians who refer to themselves using the first person are Velleius and Eutropius.[12] That alteration is a rare enough event within the *Res Gestae,* and that the first two instances happen in two similar episodes, and half-way through each, prompt a comparison of the two.[13]

Gallus and Silvanus are structurally marked as important case studies for the interaction of Constantius with a rival imperial figure.

[10] Hexads also split neatly into triads in terms of content throughout the rest of the *Res Gestae*: 17–19 'Julian's continuing success in Gaul contrasted with Constantius' failure in Mesopotamia'; 20–2 'the proclamation of Julian as Augustus, his conflict with Constantius, and his rule as sole emperor until the end of 362'; 23–5 'Julian's Persian expedition and its immediate consequences'. Barnes 1998, 25.

[11] See Barnes 1998, 34, for the observation that Ammianus 'organized his material in compositional blocks' within each book; Barnes outlines the structure of Books 14 and 15 on pp. 34–5.

[12] Eutropius' single use of the first person in relation to Ammianus is discussed in Chapter 5.1. See also Marincola 1997, 79 and 179 for rarity of first person narration.

[13] Kelly 2008, 38–40 offers a catalogue of the nine instances, in his count, in which Ammianus uses first person narration. By far the longest is his description of the Persian war of 359, 18.4.7–19.8.12.

But more than that it appears that Ammianus has gone to lengths to keep the narratives of Gallus, Silvanus, and Julian distinct from one another so that the former two may better fulfil this purpose. Ammianus presents the Silvanus affair as a self-contained episode; the details of the origin of the plot against him, its revelation to both sides, and the mission to remove him are all narrated without any other material breaking into this sequence. But this was not the only option open to Ammianus. He could have interwoven part of Julian's narrative with Silvanus'. Julian appears in Milan briefly in 15.2.7–8 but is sent off to Athens on the advice of the empress Eusebia, well before the Silvanus episode begins (15.5). Julian himself, however, suggests in the *Letter to the Athenians* that he was first summoned to Milan as soon as Constantius learned of Silvanus' attempt to rebel ('in the utmost alarm and terror he forthwith sent for me', 273D) though Constantius then sent him back to Athens and recalled him again only after Silvanus had been killed (274C).[14] If we believe Julian's version of events, Ammianus had the opportunity to connect Julian directly with Silvanus' rebellion. Like Julian, he could have used the sequence to suggest Constantius' surprise at Silvanus' rebellion and subsequent knee-jerk planning. By keeping these two figures separate, Ammianus can offer a more focused critique of the relationship between Constantius and Silvanus without bringing in a third imperial character. The presence of the participant seems also to condition this decision. As will be elaborated below and in the final chapter of this book, Ammianus is unwilling to present himself in close 'proximity' with Julian, even when both are on the Persian campaign in 363.

A similar wish to keep Julian and Gallus separate may have influenced Ammianus' decisions about the material he includes in Book 14. Vanderspoel raises the intriguing point that Julian may have spent more time with Constantius in North Italy and Gaul in the winter of 353/4, and may even have accompanied him on campaign across the Rhine against the Alamanni in 354.[15] If so, Julian was with

[14] Cf. Athanassiadi 1992, 52.

[15] Vanderspoel bases his thesis on a section of the *Letter to Themistius*, in which Julian seems to suggest that he had spent two periods of study in Athens: 'finally, before my return to Greece took place and I was still at headquarters running what people would call the highest risks (*κινδυνεύων ἐγὼ τῷ στρατοπέδῳ παρέμενον*), remind yourself now what kind of letters I was writing you—not full of complaints, not containing anything trivial or poor or vulgar. Leaving again (*πάλιν*) for Greece, when everyone thought I was going into exile did I not praise my fortune as if I were at

Constantius precisely during the time that Constantius was plotting against Gallus.[16] Julian is certainly not mentioned at any point during Ammianus' account of Constantius' celebration of his *tricennalia* at 14.5, and it seems that, if Vanderspoel's reconstruction is correct, then Ammianus has, again, sought to keep these protagonists separate in his narrative.

In comparison to the shorter, more compact narrative of Silvanus, which is perhaps easier to appreciate as a single narrative event, the account of Gallus is spread throughout Book 14. However, there is reason to believe the latter too was constructed to be read as a single, if more complex, narrative unit, and thus may be seen as an important 'building block' of the triad of books that introduces Julian. This is specifically the case because it appears that the description of Gallus' reign was largely confined to Book 14. There is a significant risk that any attempt to assess Ammianus' depiction of Gallus is hindered by the loss of the early books of the *Res Gestae*. Gallus had been appointed Caesar in 351, whereas the extant narrative picks up at the beginning of Book 14 in 353. As Thompson originally pointed out, the first chapter of Book 14 offers a retrospective overview of the appointment of the new Caesar 'who had been carried from the utmost depths of misery, in the first moments of his adulthood, to the peak of power through an unhoped-for leap'. (14.1.1).[17] Even if this is not new information, it suggests a new evaluation of the career of the Caesar thus far.[18] A further sense that this is the beginning of a new episode is created by the description of Gallus' marriage to Constantius' sister, Constantina, in a way that suggests she is a new figure within the *Res Gestae*: 'to his cruelty his wife was besides a

a major festival?' *Ep. ad Them.* 259D. Vanderspoel suggests that this second period in Athens was that alluded to by Amm. 15.2.8, and that Julian had earlier been sent to Athens from the West, probably having been summoned to Arles to celebrate Constantius' *tricennalia* in 353. Thus the references in the *Ep. ad Ath.* 272D to Constantius' release of Julian to Athens 'after dragging me hither and thither for seven whole months' is to the first visit to Athens and the campaign of 354 respectively.

[16] See Barnes 1989 for the chronology of Book 14, particularly the re-dating of Gallus' departure from Antioch in September 354 (*contra* Seeck 1906, 494–9). Vanderspoel 2013, 332 even suggests that Constantius invited Julian to the tricennalia in 353 because of his growing distrust of Gallus.

[17] Thompson 1947, 56.

[18] Blockley is no doubt right to point out that, at the very least, Ammianus would have described Gallus' elevation to the Caesarship, as he does for every other imperial figure in the extant portion of the text. 1972, 439. Cf. Sabbah 1978, 457.

serious incentive, a woman beyond measure presumptuous because of her kinship to the emperor, and previously joined in marriage by her father Constantine with his brother's son, King Hannibalianus' (14.1.2). The inclusion of the details of her previous marriage to Hannibalianus gives the impression that Ammianus is mentioning Constantina in her new role as Gallus' wife here for the first time, even though their marriage seems to have occurred at the moment of his appointment in 351 (Zos. 2.45.1), presumably as Constantius' method of ensuring the loyalty of the new Caesar, in the same way that the senior emperor gave his other sister, Helena, to Julian at the moment of his elevation in 355 (15.5.18). The summary here at least provides the impression that this is the beginning of a self-contained episode dedicated to Gallus, even if he had already been mentioned in some form earlier in a lost book.

The structure of Book 14 itself further suggests that its primary purpose is to provide a critique specifically of Gallus' reign. To illustrate this phenomenon, I give a brief overview of each chapter that deals with Gallus and the material that comes between, both to demonstrate the way in which Gallus dominates the whole of Book 14, and to provide an outline of the material that will be discussed later when we turn to look in detail at the characterization of Gallus and the role of the narrator. Of the eleven chapters, the first, seventh, ninth, and eleventh of Book 14 deal with Gallus' rule in Antioch. Each provides a development in Gallus' career and charts a steady movement towards his downfall. Although the chapter divisions are the product of the seventeenth-century editor, Adrien de Valois, in Book 14 they reflect a clear division of material within the book, with the contents of the intervening sections focused on geographically distinct areas and the activities of other protagonists.[19] The first chapter, as has already been noted, introduces the two main protagonists in Antioch, Gallus and Constantina, and sketches out their relationship: Gallus may be naturally cruel but Constantina is the driving force behind him. The remainder of the chapter illustrates the effects of their cruel reign; for example Clematius, an Alexandrian

[19] See Kelly 2009b for the editorial history of the chapter divisions and the epitomes which are regularly printed as chapter headings in modern editions. Adrien de Valois introduced the chapter-epitomes to his revised edition of 1681 of his brother Henri's earlier text.

noble, is denounced to Constantina and is subsequently sentenced to death (14.1.3). Such activities ignite a reign of suspicion, in which Gallus employs spies to gather information on the Antiochenes, and even takes to the streets himself in disguise in order to interrogate the inhabitants about their thoughts of him. The final event in this chapter sees the introduction of another character who plays a similar role to Constantina: Thalassius, the praetorian prefect at court, incites Gallus further, but also inaugurates the chain of events which will eventually lead to Gallus' execution by reporting his activities to Constantius.

Gallus' cruelty towards the Antiochenes and specifically members of the senate is elaborated in Chapter 7. Constantius' involvement via his agents becomes greater. Domitianus, Constantius' replacement for the praetorian prefect Thalassius, who had died in office, first refuses to meet Gallus then orders him out of Antioch. Gallus reacts by trying to have his troops arrest Domitianus, but is thwarted by his *Quaestor* Montius, who believes such an action would be tantamount to rebellion against Constantius. Gallus incites the troops to lynch both men, before executing yet more individuals on trumped-up charges.

After this general accumulation of details that set out Gallus' cruelty, Chapter 9 seems to mark a change not least because the first sentence marks the arrival of Ammianus in Antioch along with his master Ursicinus, 'to whom an imperial order had joined me (*nos*) in attendance' (14.9.1); however, Ammianus does not elaborate on his role alongside Ursicinus. In fact, he does not refer directly to his presence again until he departs Antioch with Ursicinus at 14.11.5, 'we hastened (*properauimus*) at full speed to Milan'. The chapter details the outcome of the trials for the two cases that had been first mentioned in Chapter 7: that of Epigonus and Eusebius (who had been falsely implicated by Montius), and an inquiry into the weaving of a purple robe in Tyre. The two defendants in the former are both executed, as are the only two people who could in some way be connected to the purple robe.

Only in Chapter 11 does the carefully crafted narrative come to a head and we are presented with the downfall of Gallus. It is dominated by a series of westward movements, first Ursicinus' recall to Constantius' court (along with Ammianus), then Constantina's return to placate her brother (she dies on route), then finally Gallus, who is executed in Histria. The structure of the chapter (which begins

with Constantius' plotting to recall the Caesar) also represents a change in focalization: the action is driven by Constantius' western court, which is able to orchestrate these three departures from Antioch, reflecting Gallus' loss of power.

Several of the intervening chapters also have a role to play in creating the impression that Book 14 is designed primarily to be a study of Gallus, even though he features directly in only four chapters. Ammianus depicts the hostile activity of the Isaurians, narrated in Chapter 2, as a threat equal to that of Gallus. The chapter is introduced with a reference to Gallus as 'not the only calamity afflicting the East with various disasters'. Gallus is equated to Rome's actual enemies in terms of the threat he poses to the East. The opportunity for Ammianus to describe Constantius' punishment of Magnentius' supporters in 14.5 also serves to remind the reader of Constantius' reputation for success in civil conflicts, especially when confronting usurpers.[20] It proleptically suggests that Gallus will himself suffer the same fate. The chapter also makes a subtle attack on Constantius by portraying him in a similar way as Gallus has been in the surrounding narrative. Constantius suffers from *asperitas* (14.5.5, a quality also applied to Gallus at 14.1.1) and interferes in the proper operation of justice, suspending re-trials 'which even the most inexorable emperors commonly allowed' (14.5.5). He also gives a set of theatrical and circus shows 'on ambitious scale' (14.5.1); Gallus' staging of equestrian games in Constantinople is the last straw that drives Constantius to rage against his Caesar (14.11.12). Both the digression on the Eastern provinces (14.8) and the brief description of the failed Persian attack on Roman Mesopotamia (14.3) opens up the narrative's narrow focus on Antioch throughout the chapters that concentrate on Gallus, to remind the reader of the area of the empire that Gallus should be protecting and the continued threat posed to it by the Persians in the East.

The Gallus narrative is more complex than that of Silvanus, but it too is self-contained within Book 14. Each chapter marks a stage in the development of Gallus' characterization, and the other material among which they are interspersed comments on Gallus too, through a process of careful structuring, and comparisons particularly with Constantius.

[20] Sabbah 1978, 461.

2.2 GALLUS—A FAMILIAR TYRANT

Modern critics have long recognized that Ammianus presents Gallus as a negative, even tyrannical figure.[21] In this section we will discover that Ammianus may have drawn upon a more specific model for Gallus' behaviour than has previously been noticed, and that he achieves this through complex intertextual engagement with earlier Roman historiography. The complexity and uniqueness of Ammianus' depiction of Gallus is all the more apparent, however, if we first consider other depictions in circulation before 390.

The Latin breviarists deal with Gallus succinctly and draw attention to cruelty as his defining trait.[22] According to Victor, Gallus died 'because of his cruelty and violent disposition' (42.12), and for Eutropius 'he was a naturally cruel man (*vir natura ferus*) and excessively inclined to usurpation (*ad tyrannidem*)' (10.19).[23] Constantius' actions in killing him appear fully justified. Curiously, Jerome in his Chronicle represents the reverse position, explaining that 'Gallus had come under [Constantius'] suspicion for his extraordinary talent (*ob egregiam indolem*). He was killed in Histria' (239c). Although Jerome mentions that Gallus had killed some nobles in Antioch, his portrayal is the direct opposite of that of Victor and Eutropius, and thus castigates Constantius for his jealousy.

In the Greek tradition, Julian, Libanius, and even Gregory Nazianzen all skirt over Gallus' cruelty in order to compare him positively to either Julian or Constantius. For Julian and Libanius, Gallus was

[21] Thompson initiated modern studies of Gallus by arguing that Ammianus' negative portrayal (created by downplaying Gallus' military record and the justifiability of the execution of certain prominent Antiochenes) was a result of the latter's curial bias and sympathy towards Gallus' victims, 1947, 56–71. Blockley by contrast views Ammianus' Gallus as an exercise in the creation of a rhetorical tyrant, an extreme figure in direct contrast to Julian, and a moral yard-stick for other characters in the *Res Gestae*: 'he is important to Ammianus as the incarnation of arbitrary cruelty, an evil against which the historian vigorously protests; he forms the lower end of the moral spectrum, serving as a foil for and introduction to Julian.' 1975, 28. In Blockley's view Gallus is a negative figure pure and simple, but Barnes and Leppin have argued for Ammianus' more ambiguous portrait of Gallus, particularly since both Gallus and Julian are victims of Constantius. Barnes 1998, 130; Leppin 2011, 190. Barnes, however, does not elaborate on how Ammianus accommodates these two opposing attitudes to Gallus within his narrative.

[22] For details of the authors discussed in this section, see Chapter 1.1.

[23] Translations of Victor are taken from Bird 1994 and of Eutropius from Bird 1993.

primarily a victim of Constantius who was killed, 'in defiance of the laws' (παρὰ τοὺς νόμους, *Ep. ad Ath.* 271A), 'a victim of calumny . . . and he was condemned to death unheard' (*Or.* 18.24),[24] whereas Gregory attempts to exculpate Gallus in order to use him as a positive point of comparison for Julian.[25] Gregory goes on to admonish Gallus and Constantius simultaneously for their actions towards each other, but consciously omits any of the details or examples of this cruelty we find in Ammianus 'the intervening events [which led to Constantius' recall and execution of Gallus] I shall pass over in silence (σιωπήσομαι), from a wish to spare both the maker and the sufferer, of both of whom I respect the piety, though I approve not of their rashness' (*Or.* 4.33).[26] There is an underlying assumption that the events that led to Gallus' recall were well known in an eastern context, and had to be alluded to, if only to excuse their omission. Their inclusion would have been difficult to reconcile with Gregory's use of Gallus as a positive foil for Julian.

Ammianus depicts Gallus' cruelty more explicitly and in greater detail than any other extant text. Those other authors who had focused on his cruelty had done so only briefly, and those who had dealt with Gallus in more detail tended to downplay his cruelty in order to use him as a positive *exemplum*. In the genre of classicizing historiography, Ammianus had the scope to offer a more complex picture than his predecessors in either breviary history or the various forms of epideictic writings discussed above. Earlier scholars were

[24] Libanius had expressed a similar sentiment in 363, *Or.* 12.35. Libanius is not unaware of Gallus' cruelty, however. A decade after composing his posthumous defence of Julian, he would criticize Gallus for the Caesar's harsh treatment ('murderous anger') of him and his fellow Antiochenes (*Or.* 1.96–98). On this occasion Libanius seeks to defend himself before his fellow Antiochenes, especially for composing a panegyric to Gallus. The comparison between the two texts demonstrates how Libanius was willing to treat Gallus positively for the sake of promoting Julian, but when that constraint was removed would eagerly criticize Gallus' cruelty. Translations of Libanius' *Orations* are taken from Norman 1987.

[25] Gallus 'although too hasty in his temper (τὴν φύσιν θερμότερος), nevertheless was genuine in his piety (εὐσέβειαν)' whereas Julian 'hid his evil disposition in a false appearance of goodness' (*Or.* 4.24). This may have also been Eunapius' approach; Zosimus depicts Gallus as an unsuspecting victim of the palace clique, 2.55.1–3 (though see Paschoud 1971, 262–3 for the possibility that Zosimus has merged some details of the Gallus and Silvanus episodes. Zosimus does not mention the latter).

[26] Gregory here 'speaks allusively of the Caesar's planned revolt against the emperor' (Kurmann 1988, 120).

certainly right to suggest that Ammianus' Gallus is a kind of rhetorical tyrant, but what kind?[27] There had been plenty of bad emperors described in Roman historical writing before Ammianus.

Ammianus certainly had earlier exemplary figures and the works of certain Latin authors in mind when he composed his Gallus narrative. Ammianus demonizes Constantina by using an allusion to liken her to Virgil's Scylla when she pops her head out from behind a curtain during the trials run by Ursicinus in Chapter 9:[28]

> stimulis reginae **exsertantis ora** subinde per aulaeum (14.9.3)
>
> whipped on by the queen, who repeatedly **thrust her jaws** forth through the curtain
>
> at Scyllam caecis cohibet spelunca latebris
> **ora exsertantem** et navis in saxa trahentem. (*Aen.*3.424f.)
>
> but Scylla a cave hides in an unseen lair,
> **thrusting forth her jaws** and dragging ships to the rocks.

The combination of *os* and *exsertare* is suitably rare to corroborate the intertextuality. Indeed, Statius also alluded to this same passage of Virgil in his description of another watery creature, the god Ismenos.[29] By calling to mind Scylla, Ammianus adds to the list of mythical creatures to which he compares Constantina. At the beginning of the book she is directly equated with Megaera (14.1.2).

This is a neat addition to Ammianus' characterization. But we can approach this passage on a different level, not contemplating a lexical allusion (a correspondence between the deployment of the same or similar word forms—here, *exsertare* and *os*) but an intertextuality of scene: something that is more akin to a topos such as that of the battle aftermath discussed in the Introduction, which 'invokes its intertextual tradition as a collectivity, to which the individual contexts and connotations of individual prior instances are firmly subordinate'.[30]

Constantina's action of eavesdropping in an environment where she should not be present, and trying to influence decision-making, is

[27] Blockley points to some *comparanda* for Ammianus' tyrannical depiction of Gallus in Valerius Maximus, Eutropius, and Dio Chrysostom, 1975, 21–2.

[28] Wieber-Scariot 1999, 143; Kelly 2008, 288.

[29] *illum [Ismenos] per ripas annoso scrupea limo | **ora exertantem** silvae fluviique minores | mirantur.* Along the banks the woods and lesser rivers marvel at him [Ismenos] as he thrusts forth his face encrusted with age-long mire; *Theb.* 9.412. Trans. Mozley 1928.

[30] Hinds 1998, 34. Cf. Chapter 1.3.

strongly reminiscent of Tacitus' description of Agrippina stationing herself behind a curtain in order to hear the deliberations of the senate in Tacitus *Annals* 13.5.1:[31]

> quod quidem aduersante Agrippina, tamquam acta Claudii subuerterentur, obtinuere patres, qui in palatium ob id uocabantur, ut adstaret additis a tergo foribus uelo discreta, quod uisum arceret, auditus non adimeret.
>
> The latter point, though opposed by Agrippina as a subversion of the acts of Claudius, was carried by the Fathers, whose meetings were specially convened in the Palatium, so that she could station herself at a newly-added door in their rear, shut off by a curtain thick enough to conceal her from view but not to debar her from hearing.

In both cases we find the presence of the female power behind the throne attempting to influence the decision-making of a legitimizing body. The vocabulary may not overlap (even the curtains are described differently: *aulaeum* in Ammianus and *velum* in Tacitus), but the intensely visual nature of both scenes and the concentration on the same object to hide the female eavesdroppers together with the same intentions, and elements of staging, make this an intertextuality. The comparison also works because we may extend it to encompass the men related to each of these women, and so equate Gallus with the archetypal Roman tyrant, Nero. One could dismiss this comparison between Constantina–Agrippina and Gallus–Nero as coincidence, were it not for a number of similarities between Nero and Gallus' depictions as tyrants. It must be admitted that there is no single, definitive Nero-narrative. However, Ammianus certainly had read Tacitus and Suetonius, as the range of lexical allusions to both authors collected by Kelly and others have made clear.[32] In his one explicit reference to Nero, Ammianus defines his reign as a period of tyrannical government, suffering from the characteristic failing of unjust rule: in Book 15 Constantius' courtiers plot to have Ursicinus killed, 'just as in days gone by it is said that Domitius Corbulo was murdered, a man who had been a loyal and prudent defender of the provinces amid the notorious corruption of Nero's time

[31] See Wieber-Scariot 1999, 125–6 for Ammianus probable knowledge of this passage of Tacitus, though she does not identify the wider intertextuality with Nero.

[32] Kelly 2008, 177 for the relationship with Tacitus; and e.g. 22.4.3 ~ Suet. *Nero* 30.2 (Kelly 2008, 204).

(*in colluuione illa Neroniani saeculi*)'.[33] *Colluuio* is a particularly colourful term, more commonly employed in the *Res Gestae* to refer to religious pollution or some sort of excess.[34] And it is one that Tacitus himself uses to describe the moral debauchery of Nero and his court.[35] Furthermore, Ammianus' choice of phrase suggests that he believed Nero manifested the same sort of vices as Seager has noted are those typical of Ammianus' other tyrannical figures.[36] Moderation and *temperantia* on the other hand are particularly associated with Julian.

Gallus' attempt to spy on his own people by roaming the streets of Antioch in disguise is a similarly theatrical episode to Constantina's spying behind the curtain. It is interesting because it comes with its own 'heavily marked'[37] *exemplum* of Gallienus who, we are told, had done the same thing at Rome:

> Gallus also ventured to commit the atrocious crime which, to his utter disgrace, Gallienus is said to have once hazarded at Rome. Taking with him a few attendants with concealed weapons, he used to roam at evening about the inns and street-corners, inquiring of everyone in Greek (*quaeritando Graeco sermone*), of which he had remarkable command, what he thought of the Caesar . . . and all this conduct of his caused very deep sorrow to many (*multis gementibus* ***agebantur***). (14.1.9).

Ammianus is the only source of this information. Aurelius Victor states that Gallienus spent time among 'taverns and eating houses',[38] but there is no suggestion that he disguised himself or attempted to assault his citizens. One might have expected to find this sort of detail in the *Historia Augusta,* but, despite the *scriptor*'s concentration on Gallienus' appearances in Rome, this story in absent.[39] It seems

[33] 15.2.5. Cf. Schubert 1999, 353 n.2. Domitius Corbulo seems to be a favourite example of the virtuous victim of Nero's reign, cf. 29.5.4.

[34] Pollution 21.14.5, which can be specifically sexual: 31.9.5. Excess in eating: 25.10.13; speech: 27.4.14.

[35] 'Hence outrages and infamy swelled, and nothing made a greater contribution of lust to the long-standing corruption of behaviour than did that cesspit (*illa conluvies*)' *Ann.* 14.15.3 (trans. Woodman 2004). The combination here with *illa* suggests Ammianus may have drawn specifically on Tacitus.

[36] See Seager 1986, 1–13 for excess as Ammianus' premier vice.

[37] Kelly defines such an *exemplum* as 'an *exemplum* called an *exemplum* and transmitted through a character' often in *oratio recta* or *obliqua*. 2008, 286.

[38] *popinas ganeasque,* 33.6.

[39] *Gallieni* 16 and 17. The *Vita Gallienorum* otherwise casts Gallienus as a tyrannical ruler, and a hostile threat to the Roman people (Grey 2010).

unlikely, too, that Ammianus is being self-referential here (referring to a lost book). The *exemplum* is couched in the distancing formula *dicitur Gallienus.* Elsewhere Ammianus certainly seems to have treated Gallienus' reign as a military failure and he also refers to him as an unjust judge (21.16.9), but there is no suggestion that he has already reported this story.[40]

Yet an equally applicable *exemplum* would be Nero, who according to Tacitus roamed the streets assaulting his own people (*Ann.*13.25.1–2):[41]

> There were disgraceful excesses at home where Nero—his identity dissembled under the dress of a slave—ranged the streets, the brothels, and the wine-shops of the capital . . . others availing themselves of the licence once accorded, began with impunity, under the name of Nero, to perpetrate the same excesses with their own gangs; and night passed as it might in a captured town (*in modum captivitatis nox* ***agebatur***).

Both are discovered and the only divergence in the tale is that the Antiochenes are shocked, whereas the Romans use Nero's actions as a licence to indulge in the same activity. Both revert to the same notion of the ruler 'alienising' his city, Tacitus by describing Rome *in modum captivitatis* and Ammianus by employing a scene typical of the *urbs capta*: *multis gementibus agebantur*[42] (both of which are introduced by passive third person forms of *agere*). Woodman has noted that Tacitus' Nero 'alienises' Rome in Book 15 of the *Annals*: thwarted in his attempt to visit Greece, Nero holds a banquet on Agrippa's lake.[43] The description contains a series of natural reversals, commonly found in Roman descriptions of foreign practices. In the description

[40] 18.6.3, 23.5.3, 28.8.8; unjust judge 21.16.9.

[41] Suetonius (*Nero* 26.1) has the same episode but differs somewhat in its presentation. Suetonius suggests that Nero was in real danger during these escapades, being almost beaten to death at one stage. Suetonius suggests that these nighttime forays involved some perverse valour on behalf of Nero. For Tacitus' Nero, like Ammianus' Gallus, it was a far less risky activity—it involved merely the loss of face at being discovered. Tacitus' castigation of Nero here seems likely to be built on a comparison with his description of Germanicus earlier in the *Annals.* At *Ann.* 2.12 Germanicus goes out into his camp in disguise to test his reputation amongst his men. Needless to say, he discovers he is well regarded, and the troops praise his *nobilitatem . . . decorem . . . patientiam . . . comitatem.*

[42] The motif of the *urbs capta* was sufficiently well established in historiographical literature that the mere mention of a captured city was enough to incite *misericordia*: Paul 1982, 151, with examples from Caesar and Tacitus.

[43] Woodman 1992.

of the fire of Rome, Nero too is cast as a foreign aggressor.[44] And after the death of Agrippina, Nero returns in triumph to Rome, 'victor over the national servility' (*Ann.* 14.13.2), described by Tacitus as a staged event (tiered seating even lined the route) in a way that unites the themes of hostile theatricality and subverted militarism with which he characterizes Nero's reign. Ammianus similarly denigrates Gallus by presenting him as an outsider, and a hostile outsider at that.[45] Linguistically Gallus is different from the Antiochenes: he is not a native Greek speaker, and his skills in the language, rather than being a positive attribute, are in fact part of the threat to the Antiochenes. Furthermore, at the opening of the book, his activities are described as storms which fall upon the *rebus . . . communibus* (14.1.1). These are *tempestates* ***alias,*** the latest in a series after the usurpation of Magnentius. Similarly the damaging nature of the attacks by the Isaurians, who are categorized by Ammianus as typical barbarians via the application of feral imagery,[46] is equated with Gallus' mismanagement: 'and indeed this was not the only calamity to afflict the Orient with various disasters. For the Isaurians too . . . broke out into a serious war' (14.2.1). Ammianus seeks to stress the similarities by using torrential imagery of both Caesar and barbarians: both share ideas of unstoppable speed and destructive force, Gallus 'rushed on with uncontrollable impetuosity, like swift torrent to overthrow whatever opposed him (*ad uertenda opposita/* ***instar rapidi fluminis*** *irreuocabili impetu ferebatur*, 14.1.10), whereas the Isaurians 'thus all swooping like a whirlwind down from their steep and rugged mountains, made for the districts near the sea' (*ita omnes* ***instar turbinis*** *degressi montibus impeditis et arduis / loca petiuere mari confinia*, 14.2.2).

There are other points of similarity between Nero and Gallus, for example the ineffectual handling of grain shortages.[47] These two rulers' response to their own deeds also has something in common. Both succumb to feelings of guilt, and are actively haunted by them, both in the form of dreams. In his sleep Gallus is frightened 'by the

[44] For example, Tacitus has Calpurnius Piso state that Nero 'built his house from the spoils (*spoliis*) of the citizens', *Ann.* 15.52.1. Woodman 1992, 185.

[45] Ammianus may be capitalizing on his name ('the Gaul') which is geographically out of place considering his main location in Antioch during the course of Ammianus' narrative, as well as having barbarian connotations.

[46] Wiedemann 1986, 196. [47] Tac. *Ann.* 15.39; Amm. 14.7.2.

terror of spectres' (of those he has killed).[48] Similarly Suetonius' Nero, following the murder of Agrippina, 'was terrified . . . by manifest portents from dreams'.[49]

To concentrate again on Tacitus' presentation of Nero, recent critics have noted the sustained theatricality with which Tacitus presents his material.[50] Nero was infamously keen to appear on the stage himself. It is one of the charges that has stuck through the centuries. Woodman has assessed the theatricality surrounding the failed Pisonian conspiracy at the end of Book 15.[51] The narrative of Agrippina's murder at Baiae is suffused with theatricality, even down to the use of the technical language of stage contraptions for the booby-trapped barge.[52] The Nero of Suetonius and Dio indulges in stage-like activities at key moments, such as the inspection of Agrippina's corpse.[53] Nero in a sense is an actor within his own set.

There is a recurrent theme of theatricality surrounding Ammianus' Gallus too. The tragic bent of the narrative has been noted, for example by Blockley, who nevertheless offers the caveat that Book 14 is 'hardly tragic in the Aristotelian sense (Gallus is too much a monster to evoke the necessary response)'.[54] Julian had already remarked that his brother's fate resembled a Greek tragedy, quoting from Euripides' *Orestes* to introduce his account of Gallus' demise, 'but why should I "recount" as though from some tragedy, "all these unspeakable horrors?"'[55] If Julian's brief remark was Ammianus' inspiration, the historian has elaborated on it and woven it into the fabric of his narrative. Blockley notes 'in a number of passages [throughout the *Res Gestae*] to introduce or sum up a description he uses the simile of the theatre curtain hiding or revealing a scene

[48] 14.11.17. Ammianus appends a note to describe how these guilty dreams come about. In this instance (*contra* Weber 2000, 470) the dream is a hint at Gallus' imminent downfall. Den Boeft 2006, 50.

[49] Suet. *Nero* 46.1. Though Tacitus does not include Nero's dreams, he widely reports dreams, secret thoughts, or rumour as a method of corroborating a character's guilt that has already been insinuated in the narrative. Blockley 1973, 68.

[50] Bartsch 1994, 1–35; Santoro L'Hoir 2006, 15–70.

[51] Woodman 1993.

[52] Bartsch 1994, 20–1. Agrippina herself likens the collapsing to a *terrestre machinamentum* (*Ann.*14.6.1); cf. Furneaux 1907, 240. The theme is developed by Dio 62.12.2.

[53] Baldwin 1979, cf. Suetonius *Nero* 34.4 and Dio 61.14.2.

[54] Blockley 1975, 23–4.

[55] Julian *Ep. ad Ath.* 270D. The quotation comes from Euripides, *Orestes* 14.

with dramatic suddenness'.[56] In Book 14, however, Ammianus' use of the theatrical goes beyond simile. The structure of the Gallus tale is ultimately one of descent into punishment, following a series of hubristic actions. The tragic undercurrent is introduced within the first paragraph by the comparison of Constantina to the avenging fury Megaera. Additionally, the framing of many of these events is suggestive of staging. In particular Ammianus makes use of stage directions. The palace (*palatium*) is ever present in Book 14 and is akin to a *scaena.*[57] It is Gallus' main abode, and gaining access to it is the only way to have any dialogue with the Caesar. Hence the mother-in-law of Clematius convinces Gallus via Constantina to execute her son-in-law 'having been led in through a secret door (*pseudothyrum*)'.[58] We find a structurally similar incident at 14.7.4 where a woman is admitted to the palace to see Constantina, informs against a secret plot against Gallus and is publically sent out of the palace on a carriage to act as an incentive for others to betray similar plans.[59] There is a noticeable concentration on the difference between the private entry and the public exit to the palace. Exiting through the *ianua* rather than the *pseudothyrum* is a highly visible action. Constantius' agent Domitianus is unsuccessful in carrying out the emperor's orders to recall Gallus during Chapter 7 precisely because he does not gain entry, 'passing by the gates of the palace . . . he neither entered the palace nor appeared in public (*praestrictis palatii ianuis / . . . nec regiam introit / nec processit in publicum* 14.7.10)'.[60]

[56] E.g. 16.6.3; 16.12.57; 28.6.29 (1975, 25).

[57] Cf. Ammianus' awareness of the dramatic potential of the *scaena* elsewhere, 26.6.15.

[58] 14.1.3. *pseudothyrum* is used only here by Ammianus. It is uncommon in Latin generally, and Ammianus seems to have adopted it from Cicero *post red.* 14, where it is used to describe the method of entry of personified Lustfulness to Catiline's house. It is therefore not inappropriate in this context.

[59] Several scholars have drawn a connection between this plot and Zonaras' more elaborate description of a similar plot against Gallus orchestrated by Magnentius (Zon. 13.8.24–8). Tränkle 1976, 178; DiMaio 1980, 171–2; Bleckmann 1992, 336. Barnes 1989 and Frakes 1997 have raised some objections on grounds of chronology (Magnentius had died in 353). However, it is possible to see why Ammianus both wanted to include this plot (it was a good illustration of Gallus' extreme and tyrannical reactions to threats against him), yet also did not want to include the details of Magnentius. Ammianus' Gallus is the victim of only Constantius and his subordinates. To describe Magnentius' role in detail would have detracted from this characterization.

[60] Both terms appear throughout Book 14 referring to the palace. It is a constant topographical feature of the book. *regia:* 1.6; 7.4; 7.10; 8.9; *palatium* 1.3; 7.4; 7.11.

His later command to Gallus is clear: 'get out! (*profiscere*)'. It is only when Gallus leaves the palace (14.11.16) that his fate is sealed. Theatricality extends through Book 14 on several different levels. This technique is yet another feature shared with the Neronian narrative found in Tacitus.[61]

Casting Gallus' tyranny within a Neronian frame at once vilifies and magnifies the Caesar. Nero is one of few *principes* who continued to exercise a strong influence upon the Roman psyche for centuries after his death, specifically as a tyrannical figure given over to outrageous excesses.[62] The breviary historians, for example, all concentrate on his burning of Rome and his tyrannical activities (harming his people and indulging in excesses of behaviour).[63] The comparison neatly allows Ammianus both to criticize Gallus' behaviour, yet elevate him not just to an example of bad rule, but almost the greatest example of bad rule. Gallus was, after all, just a Caesar, not an emperor like Nero. If, as Blockley noted, Gallus 'forms the lower end of the moral spectrum, serving as a foil for and introduction to Julian',[64] that scale is particularly Roman, judged in terms of exemplary emperors, not of morality in the abstract, or even the Hellenizing terms suggested by Julian himself, who had assessed Gallus, as noted above, as acting 'in least kingly fashion (ἥκιστα βασιλικῶς)' (272C). Furthermore, the theatricality of Gallus' reign in Antioch is also a reminder that his power is, ultimately, a charade. He is dutifully acting the part set out for him by Constantius. It is the Augustus who is in ultimate control, as becomes increasingly apparent over the course of Book 14.

2.3 GALLUS' DOWNFALL AND SYMPATHY

This broad intertextual criticism of Gallus the tyrant is undercut and eventually replaced in the latter part of his narrative in Book 14 by a more sympathetic portrayal. Narratologically, Gallus is treated

[61] Santoro L'Hoir 2006, 15–70. [62] Champlin 2003, 235.

[63] Aurelius Victor notes the unjust treatment of citizens in court (2.1). Eutropius includes a selection of incidents, probably derived from Suetonius, and concentrates on Nero as an unmilitary emperor (*in re militari nihil omnino ausus*), 7.14–15. Festus defines Nero as the 'worst emperor' Rome has ever suffered (20.1).

[64] Blockley 1975, 28.

differently in the final chapter of Book 14 than in those which precede it. (The distinction is one that receives fuller elaboration in the Silvanus episode, as the later part of this chapter will demonstrate.) In the earlier chapters of Book 14 Gallus is portrayed as a tyrannical and therefore unsympathetic character, and in doing so the primary narrator avoids detailed description of the Caesar's inner thoughts and instead ascribes his motivation to his negative emotions.[65] For example, from the outset Constantina is presented as the main stimulus for these emotions and as 'a constant inciter of his savagery' (14.1.2). Although Gallus' regime is the main focus of Chapters 1, 7, and 9, the Caesar is not presented as personally involved in very many of the crimes which are ascribed to his name. Instead Gallus' actions are either vague (he 'harassed all parts of the East' (14.7.1)) or left without any indication of their motivation (he merely 'ventured to commit a crime' (14.1.9), or acts purely out of emotion: 'enraged' he orders the execution of chief senators of Antioch (14.7.2)). The narrator refrains from displaying narratorial privilege, and revealing the thoughts of the Caesar.

In Chapter 9 it is implied that Gallus orchestrated the outcome of the trials at Antioch even though Ursicinus nominally presided.[66] Even here, however, there is only one moment in which Gallus becomes involved, and then the narrator allows his interpretation of events to stand in marked opposition to those of the defendant (14.9.5–6):

> Eusebius on the contrary, courageously denied the charges, and although he was put upon the rack, he remained firm in the same degree of constancy, crying out that it was the act of brigands (*latrocinium*) and not of a court of justice (*iudicium*). And when, being acquainted with the law, he persistently called for his accuser and the usual formalities, Caesar, being informed of his demand and regarding his freedom of speech as arrogance (*libertatemque superbiam ratus*), ordered that he be tortured as a reckless slanderer.

Eusebius had already been presented as an innocent victim, who had been wrongly implicated by the dying Montius (14.7.18). The juxtaposition of these two interpretations of the situation structurally helps

[65] See Chapter 1.2 for narratorial privilege.

[66] See section 2.2 above for Constantina's controlling presence behind the curtain of the courtroom.

to create a negative portrayal of Gallus: Eusebius has been set up as the correct interpreter of events (the narrator had already established his innocence), so by narrating Gallus' thought-processes here and contrasting them to the version which has been endorsed through the 'correct' interpretation of the more sympathetic character, Eusebius, the narrator condemns Gallus.

It is this process that is reversed in Chapter 11. We now learn more about Gallus' thoughts and here he is portrayed as a correct interpreter of Constantius' reputation (14.11.7):

> For in the midst of his embarrassments and troubles his anxious mind dwelt on this one thought, that Constantius, who measured everything by the standard of his own opinion, was not one to accept any excuse or pardon mistakes; but being especially inclined to the ruin of his kin, would secretly set a snare for him and punish him with death, if he caught him off his guard.

The opening of this chapter, as has been noted above, portrays Constantius as planning to 'uproot (*conuellere*)' Gallus, whom he considers 'his most difficult knot and stumbling-block' (14.11.1). It has in fact been revealed that Constantius plans to lure Gallus to Italy by a show of clemency. Gallus' interpretation of Constantius coheres with that presented in the wider narrative. Whereas previously he had been unaware of his actions or driven into them by Constantina or his other advisers, he becomes fully aware of his own position in this last chapter, 'cursing (*imprecatus*) from time to time at the rashness which had reduced him, now mean and abject, to submit to the will of the lowest (*infirmorum*) of mankind' (14.11.16). Gallus' awareness of his passivity is a theme that is developed throughout the chapter. Instead of acting according to anger or rage as he did earlier in the book, he is now troubled and fearful, 'his anxious (*sollicitam*) mind dwelt on one thought' (14.11.7); and he feared (*uerebatur*) treachery (14.11.8).[67]

Gallus' new role is corroborated by authorial comments and intra-texts with later portions of the *Res Gestae*. Gallus' fate is now defined as 'most sad' (*tristissima*, 14.11.19). The scene describing his execution is

[67] It is at this stage that he also suffers from guilty nightmares about those he has killed (14.11.17). Though this last point does not necessarily indicate remorse, it does suggest that Gallus is at least aware of the criminal nature of his actions, which had not been suggested previously.

particularly vivid, dwelling on the removal of his royal robes, and forcing him into an ordinary soldier's cloak in a reversal of the typical elevation scene, where the newly created Caesar or Augustus (whether legitimate or not) is clothed in suitable attire.[68] It is a clear visual reversal of his fortunes and the change of costume provides a neat conclusion to the end of performance as Caesar. Finally, he is killed 'in the fashion of some guilty robber' (14.11.23).

In his death notice (a recurring topos in historiography generally, but especially in Ammianus)[69] we are still induced to recognize his wasted potential.[70] His death is 'premature (*immaturo*)' (14.11.27) and his physical appearance is described in positive terms. There is generally a correlation in Ammianus' death notices between a good character and a good physique.[71] Julian is broad shouldered, well-proportioned, and strong (25.4.22), whereas Constantius is bow-legged and ill-proportioned (21.16.19). Gallus is 'conspicuous for his handsome person, being well proportioned, with well-knit limbs' and has golden hair (14.11.28). After his death his body is treated with a pathos-invoking Virgilian echo: 'the man who a little while before had been a terror to cities and provinces was left a disfigured corpse'.[72]

The death notices of other imperial figures in the *Res Gestae* regularly contain two lists, one of virtues, the other of vices, but Ammianus omits this feature altogether for Gallus. Instead Ammianus avoids passing a definite moralizing judgement on Gallus by instead including a list of *exempla* of those who have also suffered the vicissitudes of fortune.[73] The list itself is hardly exclusively

[68] It is a means by which Ammianus can denigrate Procopius by mentioning how ill-suited he was to his outfit (26.6.15–16). Cf. the discussion of Julian's elevation in secton 3.2.

[69] Pomeroy 1991, 243–7.

[70] Pity, as Blockley noted, may be too strong a reaction to this clearly tyrannical figure, 1975, 24. A sense of wasted potential is commonly associated with cruel or tyrannical leaders, especially for example Sallust's Catiline whose body is found far ahead of his ranks, still bearing the grim determination that he exhibited in life (*BC* 61).

[71] Sabbah 1978, 424–9; Den Boeft et al. 1991, 274.

[72] *cadauer est relictum informe, / paulo ante urbibus et prouinciis formidatum.* 14.11.23. cf. *tot quondam populis terrisque superbum | regnatorem Asiae. iacet ingens litore truncus | avulsumque umeris caput et sine nomine corpus*, *Aen.* 2.556–8 (the reference is to Priam's disfigured corpse after the fall of Troy). Hagendahl 1921, 3–4; De Jonge 1935, *ad loc.*; Blockley 1975, 24; Kelly 2008, 288.

[73] Pomeroy laments Ammianus' habit of including lists of 'virtues and vices [that] happily coexist in sublime disharmony and where final judgement is not of this world'

comprised of historical villains. We find included Pompey, who 'after he had gained the surname Great by his glorious deeds, was butchered in Egypt to give the eunuchs pleasure' (14.11.32). Furthermore, Pompey has just been indirectly invoked as the object of pity by the use of Ammianus' allusion to Virgil's Priam, as that former 'terror to cities and provinces' now 'a disfigured corpse'. Ammianus' contemporary Servius had already noted the reference to Pompey, and the appearance of the explicit *exemplum* of Pompey so soon after the allusion to Virgil suggests Ammianus did too.[74]

This rehabilitation extends beyond the end of Book 14. Gallus has a relatively positive narrative 'afterlife' in the later books of the *Res Gestae.* This afterlife links Julian closely with his dead brother and continues some of the themes that we first encounter in Book 14. At 17.1.4 Julian's detractors believe he fought bravely at Strasbourg only because he would rather die fighting than face the same fate as Gallus. Thus Gallus was not justly executed, but was killed because of Constantius' envy.[75] Julian himself is not unaware of the model of failure set down by Gallus. Pondering whether to attack Constantius (just as Gallus had done, while considering that Constantius was 'always victor in civil conflicts'[76]), Julian considers the example of Gallus: 'in particular his mind was made anxious and uncertain by the example of his brother Gallus whom his own negligence and the combined deceit and perjury of certain men had betrayed' (21.1.2). Negligence, *inertia*, is not a positive trait for a leader, but it is far from the original charges made against Gallus by the narrator in Book 14 of cruelty and rage. Indeed, there is a move towards equating Gallus more closely with Julian after the former's demise. Whereas in Gallus' death notice he 'differed as much from the disciplined character of his brother Julian as did Domitian . . . from his brother Titus', (14.11.28) things change by the time Julian arrives in Antioch and faces a similar situation of food shortages, when he 'resembled his brother Gallus, though without his cruelty' (22.14.2). The terms of reference may be slightly different, but the reconciliation of Gallus is clear. Barring the

(1991, 247) and indeed condemns Gallus' death notice as 'moralizing overkill, rather than historical explanation'. (1991, 245). The relative length of each list, however, alludes to a final judgement, even if it is not expressed openly.

[74] Servius ad. *Aen.* 2.557. Kelly 2008, 288.

[75] A situation very akin to Jerome's otherwise lone opinion that Gallus was killed *ob egregiam indolem* (*Chron.* 239).

[76] *in aerumnis civilibus saepe uictorem,* 21.1.2; cf. 14.11.8.

excesses of Gallus, it is now suitable to compare the two brothers in terms of their conduct. It is important to note that Gallus does not die at the end of Book 14: he has an exemplary role, which has not been noticed by many critics who concentrate solely on the narrative of his reign in Book 14.

Thus, despite the strong characterization of Gallus as a cruel and tyrannical ruler throughout the majority of Book 14, Ammianus does appear to rehabilitate the Caesar at the moment of his death and beyond. The reason for this lies in the subsequent events narrated in the *Res Gestae.* In Book 15 Julian is raised to the Caesarship, and Constantius takes over the role of foil for Ammianus' ideal emperor. The redemption of Gallus is therefore a method for blackening Constantius. Although we have concentrated on Gallus' activities in Book 14, Constantius is active in Chapter 5 overseeing the torture and execution of the remaining adherents of the failed usurper Magnentius, whose defeat was (presumably) narrated in the preceding (lost) book. There Constantius is cast in a similar vein to Gallus, 'accepting every false or doubtful charge as evident and proven' (14.5.1). Constantius is presented in this chapter as overly concerned with his own safety, and lacking *cura salutis alienae,* just as Gallus did (14.1.10). Instead he easily believes the courtiers who flatter him by suggesting instead that 'the condition of the whole world depended on his safety (*salutis suae*)' (14.5.2).

Constantius is established in this book as a different type of bad ruler. Ammianus casts him as both cruel and unjust, yet he is far more aware of what a good ruler ought to be, and knows how to deploy this on a rhetorical level. We observe this both in his speeches and the reports of his messengers. The contrast between narrative and speech, which is such a useful characterizing tool for a historian like Tacitus, has its place in Ammianus also. Constantius is a more developed character than Gallus' stock tyrant who is entirely unaware of his own actions until the last moment.

2.4 INTERNAL NARRATION—THE PARTICIPANT AS GUIDE

The Gallus episode, as we have seen, is clearly divided into four distinct sections, which modern editions have defined as Chapters

1, 7, 9, and 11. Ammianus uses the first three to depict Gallus as a tyrannical figure, and the change to a more sympathetic depiction of Gallus the victim (such as had been expounded by Julian and Libanius) comes at the beginning of the fourth. The point of change in Gallus' character coincides with the entrance of Ammianus as a protagonist. In a narrative that is largely external, the sudden if short change to internal narration (if even with a couple of first person verbs), marks out that section as notably distinct from those around it. As discussed in the Introduction, first-person narration can also mean that the narrative is focalized through the participant. This certainly seems to be the case in the Silvanus episode, which is discussed below, but here we investigate the effect and use of two brief intimations of Ammianus' involvement in Antioch in order to assess what if any interpretative role they may perform.

Ammianus took particular care when choosing at which points to allude to his presence within his narrative. There are only nine distinct occasions in the extant portion of the *Res Gestae* when he refers to his presence within the narrative with first person verbs. As Kelly has noted, taking the entire narrative of the Persian War of 359 as one episode (18.4.7–19.8.12), only three of those nine occurrences are more than one sentence in length.[77] Notable also are the portions of the narrative where Ammianus chooses not to include himself. Uses of the first person in Books 15 and 16 suggest he remained in the West between 355 and 357 during the time both of Julian's command in Gaul and Constantius' visit to Rome,[78] though he chooses not to refer to his personal involvement in any of the events of this period, when the two imperial protagonists and the author were all in close proximity.[79] Participant narrative has been shown to serve a number of purposes. Primarily it is a statement of authority via autopsy: 'it emphasises [Ammianus'] particular knowledge and superior expertise'.[80] But in Ammianus' case he presents himself in situations primarily of solitude or peril (the latter is the more prevalent in the

[77] Kelly 2008, 38–40.

[78] Ammianus notes his presence on Ursicinus' mission to suppress Silvanus' revolt in Cologne in 355 (15.5.31) and then states that he was dispatched with Ursicinus back to the East in 357 (16.10.21). In the intervening narrative, Julian had been dispatched to Gaul (15.8.18) and Constantius visited Rome (16.10).

[79] It is likely that Ammianus, like Ursicinus, was with Julian in Reims in 357 (16.2.8). The episode, however, 'does not prompt the first person' (Kelly 2008, 70).

[80] Kelly 2008, 65.

Gallus and Silvanus episodes).[81] This choice, as Kelly has suggested, has historiographical implications: 'the literal loneliness of Ammianus acts as a metaphor for his loneliness in the field of history. By showing himself alone, he suggests his historical testimony is unique. And by giving prominence to the perils that he faced and to the chances that permitted his survival, he emphasises that the survival of his literary work had hung (to reuse Ammianus' own metaphor of the sword of Damocles) by a horse hair.'[82]

The episode in Antioch in Book 14 certainly places Ammianus in a risky situation (though his personal fear and trepidation are not elaborated upon as they will be on his mission to depose Silvanus in Book 15), but more perversely, it was one for which it was hardly favourable for the author to admit his involvement, not least because Gallus' regime is portrayed so negatively in the Chapters 1 and 7, before Ammianus arrives on the scene. From what the reader is allowed to glean from the events of Chapter 9, Ammianus was in Antioch as a member of Ursicinus' staff. He arrives with Ursicinus 'to whom an imperial order had joined me (*nos*) in attendance' (14.9.1) and departs again ('we hastened (*properauimus*) at full speed to Milan'. 14.11.5). One may wonder why Ammianus chose to include his presence at this point at all, given that he is obviously circumspect about his personal role, providing no further details of his actions when in Antioch, unlike, for example, his comparatively detailed involvement in the equally shady events of the suppression of Silvanus' revolt, where he uses a number of first-person plural verbs to draw the reader's attention repeatedly to his presence as a participant (*mirabamur*, *festinamus*, *inuenimus*, *scrutabamus*, 15.5.22–30). Ammianus goes out of his way to portray the Gallus affair as a murky episode, and one could imagine that it would have been easier for the author to omit reference to his own part in it, however small, altogether. It is worth, therefore, considering, what Ammianus gains from the inclusion of himself as a participant, and how his role may guide the interpretation of the complex figure of Gallus.

This brief intrusion of an authorial 'I' as an actor represents a strong truth-claim. The note of his presence without any further elaboration on his actions sets Ammianus up as an observer of events, even though his observations are not articulated using any further

[81] Kelly 2008, 70–2. [82] Kelly 2008, 72.

first-person verbs.[83] When Ammianus wrote his account of Gallus' reign, he had to deal with a competing source tradition which had been composed prominently by two authors, Julian and Libanius, who enjoyed a particularly close association with Gallus' activities in Antioch; Julian through his blood ties to Gallus, and Libanius as an inhabitant of Antioch. The note of Ammianus' presence is as brief as it could possibly be, but nonetheless serves the purpose of establishing the author's credentials as an eyewitness, the strongest claim to authority available to the ancient historian.[84] Ammianus particularly required this support for his authority because his Gallus embraces both aspects of the Caesar's portrayal that had been developed by earlier authors: Ammianus' Gallus is both tyrant and victim. These two interpretative paradigms (kept separate, as we have seen, by other authors) are necessarily oppositional, and so Ammianus required a strong claim to authority in bringing them together.

The choice to insert himself into the narrative brought risks as well as advantages. By noting his presence however, Ammianus necessarily had to involve Ursicinus, who is otherwise absent from the parallel accounts, even from Philostorgius', who is the only other author to narrate Gallus' reign in comparable detail to Ammianus. This in itself was a mixed blessing for Ammianus, for on the one hand he has to exculpate Ursicinus from charges of complicity in Gallus' unjust trials. Ursicinus is excused by being described as both unwilling and unskilled in legal matters (14.9.1), and Ammianus strives to make clear that it was both Constantina and Gallus who were pulling the strings, even if they were not themselves present in the courtroom (14.9.3).[85] On the other hand, Ursicinus and Ammianus' second and final appearance serves an interpretative purpose for the final act in the narrative of Gallus, at that crucial point when his portrayal moves from the tyrannical to something more sympathetic. As noted in the outline of the Gallus-narrative above,[86] Ursicinus' and Ammianus' journey to Milan at the opening of Chapter 11 is the first in a series of westward journeys narrated within the chapter that will culminate in the execution of Gallus. Ammianus draws out a number of parallels between Gallus and Ursicinus, which associates both Ursicinus and

[83] See Bal 2009, 21 for the heightened 'narrative rhetoric of "truth"' associated with an internal narrator (what Bal calls 'character-bound' narration).

[84] Marincola 1997, 63–86.

[85] Discussed in section 2.2.

[86] Section 2.4.

Ammianus with Gallus, and thus enforces the sympathy for the Caesar, because Gallus in turn is aligned with the views and focalization of the strongest interpretive guide in any narrative text, the primary narrator. Like Gallus, Ursicinus is made the victim of the plots of Constantius' courtiers, who imagine that if Gallus were removed from Antioch but Ursicinus remained, the latter would step into the power vacuum and become a new Gallus (14.11.2); just as he plans to do with Gallus, Constantius summons Ursicinus with feigned friendliness: 'in the most complimentary terms (*summo cum honore*) he directed Ursicinus to come to him' (14.11.4); Constantius plans to lure Gallus back with 'courteous (*mollioribus*) letters' (14.11.1). Structurally we find the same recurring narrative pattern, with Constantina, wife and ally of Gallus, providing the second of the three westward journeys. Likewise, Constantius entices her 'with many feigned endearments (*multis fictisque blanditiis*)' (14.11.6) in order to make Gallus less suspicious about his reasons for later summoning him.[87] The repetitive structure not only suggests the ineluctable nature of Gallus' demise engineered by Constantius, but also adds to the more pitiable version of Gallus who emerges in this final chapter, as we have discussed above. Ursicinus is presented as a sympathetic figure who is himself a victim of Constantius; the structure of this chapter not only places him in alignment with Gallus, but presents him as the first and illustrative model of Constantius' plotting, which will eventually see the execution of Gallus. The author's presence on that critical return (*properauimus*) briefly makes this internal narration and serves to highlight the interpretative importance of this moment.

2.5 PLOTTING AGAINST SILVANUS—THE OMNISCIENT NARRATOR

In the Gallus episode, the appearance of the participant marked a change in the narrative's interpretative stance. The depictions of

[87] This is a major difference with Philostorgius' version, which instead has Constantina sent ahead by Gallus 'in order to soften Constantius' (4.1a [*AP* 14]) without any invitation from Constantius. Philostorgius' source for this episode remains unclear, though the comparison shows that Ammianus represents a unique interpretation of Constantia's role.

Gallus as both tyrant and victim were largely determined through focalization—the presentation of Gallus' reasoning and decision-making within the narrative were restricted when he was presented as a tyrant, whereas as a victim both his decision-making and wider place in the narrative cohered with paradigms that presented Constantius in a negative light. Some of these interpretative practices receive greater elaboration in the Silvanus episode.

Modern scholarship on Silvanus has increasingly recognized the complex, often conflicting, depiction provided by the *Res Gestae*, though explanations for this phenomenon have often fallen back on biographical readings based on Ammianus' participation. Moving away from older, more positivist approaches, which took Ammianus' stated participation as a guarantee of the text's historical accuracy,[88] Drinkwater suggested that Ammianus' participation instead caused him to distort his account in order to exonerate Ursicinus from killing Silvanus 'out of self-interest'; indeed, according to Drinkwater, Silvanus may not have rebelled at all.[89] Hunt teases out three competing 'vantage points' from which Ammianus presents the narrative—'the conventional critic of the tyrannical regime of Constantius, the close observer of court and consistory reacting to unfolding events, and the unquestioning servant of the government's bidding'.[90] There is much merit in Hunt's identification of a multifaceted representation of Silvanus, but like his predecessors Hunt relies on a biographical reading: Ammianus' presence in Milan and Cologne provides the basis for the second and third of Hunt's vantage points and the biased depictions created by them.[91] More recently still, Weisweiler has argued that the episode is deliberately constructed in order to provide a commentary for Ammianus' reader on how to read the *Res Gestae* itself: 'we, the "external" readers of the *Res Gestae*, are continuously given the opportunity to observe how the protagonists in the *Res Gestae*, the "internal" readers, grapple with texts . . . In the Silvanus episode, the experiences of the protagonists teach us how to

[88] Balducci 1947; Den Boer 1960; Nutt 1973; Austin 1983, 57–8; Matthews 1989, 37–8.

[89] Drinkwater 1994, 575. Drinkwater's major contention that Silvanus issued no coinage, suggesting he did not assume imperial office (cf. Barnes 1998, 18–19), is challenged by Hunt 1999, 52.

[90] Hunt 1999, 61.

[91] Hunt suggests the last of these is provided by a narrativized version of an official account made by Ursicinus to Constantius.

read.'[92] Particularly, Weisweiler argues Ammianus has created a narrative that entirely depends on the correct understanding of forged texts. In 15.5 there is a clear narratorial judgement that Silvanus was the victim of the forgery plot, but his innocence is later undermined by the note that Silvanus' former cryptographer found her way into the service of Barbatio (18.3.2). If Silvanus possessed a cryptographer, then perhaps he was not so innocent after all.[93] By consciously positing conflicting depictions of Silvanus, Ammianus leaves it to the reader to decide which to believe. There is much of value in Weisweiler's call for a narratological reading of the Silvanus campaign (I offer my own more extensive reading below), but his depiction of the agnostic narrator does not fit with the Ammianus that I have sketched out in the first chapter. Ammianus' narrative has the air of definitiveness about it, not least because of its use of Latin and its distancing of itself from earlier, eastern accounts of the decade, at least, from 353–63. Nor indeed is the Silvanus episode such a self-contained study on the reading of texts, though this narratological aspect certainly is of importance for its wider role in the critique of Constantius. The Silvanus episode creates the situation in which Julian can become the saviour of Gaul.[94]

The description of the usurpation of Silvanus is devoid of the rich exemplification of the Gallus episode. As noted above, the first half provides a description of the plot against Silvanus, interpretation of which (especially the motivation of the characters) is largely based on the understanding of who knew what and when. In this context, the external primary narrator plays a particularly important role in shaping the interpretation of Silvanus and Constantius before the entry of the participant at 15.5.22, where there is a marked change in the presentation of the principal characters. The plot involves a series of clandestine actions, which are revealed to different groups at different times, the reactions to which in turn become the subject of

[92] Weisweiler 2015, 112–13. He suggests that Ammianus may have invented the detail of the forged letters, which is absent from parallel sources, 2015, 111–12.

[93] 'If Silvanus was innocent, an unwilling usurper, to what purpose did he acquire a cryptographer?' Weisweiler 2015, 114. This piece of information certainly casts Silvanus in a negative light, but why would he have needed a cryptographer to forge letters that were supposedly to have been signed by him in the first place? And do we need to interpret *notarum perita* as a 'cryptographer' rather than someone merely skilled in shorthand?

[94] 15.8.21. Hunt 1999, 60; Guzmán-Armario 2002, 753.

report. I provide a brief, but I hope clear, summary of the intrigue, which will receive more detailed analysis below: Dynamius, an *actuarius*, procures a letter from Silvanus. He erases the original text from this letter (though retaining the signature) and re-writes it so it now suggests that Silvanus is planning to rebel and implicates several others at court (15.5.1–4). The forgery is then delivered to Constantius by the praetorian prefect Lampadius. Constantius orders the arrest of all those named in the letter and dispatches one Apodemius with a letter to recall Silvanus, though Apodemius fails to deliver this second letter. In the meantime, Dynamius forges another letter, this time sent to the tribune of the Cremona arms factory, in which the tribune 'was admonished to prepare everything with speed' (15.5.9). The tribune is perplexed by this obscure request and the letter finds its way to Constantius via another Frank at court, Malarichus, who notices the letter is a forgery and exposes the plot (15.5.11). Constantius launches an investigation that fails to convict Dynamius or his accomplices (15.5.14). Ammianus then moves the focus of the narrative to Cologne, where Silvanus has heard of Apodemius' attempts to undermine him and decides that his safest option lies in actually rebelling (15.5.15–17). The narrative returns to Milan, where an 'unexpected messenger' relays the news about Silvanus and the court subsequently plan to send Ursicinus to depose Silvanus. It is at this point that Constantius decides to send Ursicinus, accompanied by Ammianus, to Cologne (15.5.21).

Before passing any further comment on the details of this episode, it should be noted that before the arrival of the participant within the narrative, the external narrator maintains a position of almost total omniscience. He switches the focus of the narrative back and forth from Cologne to Milan with ease and only once admits a degree of authorial uncertainty, when he lists Dynamius' accomplices: 'he had as abettors and fellow conspirators, as uncertain rumours declared, Lampadius, the praetorian prefect, and Eusebius, former keeper of the privy purse, who had been nicknamed Mattyocopus, and Aedesius, late master of the rolls' (15.5.4). Any doubt raised initially here is not repeated later in the episode, where Lampadius plays a further role in the delivery of the forgeries to Constantius without any doubt expressed by the narrator. There is little, however, in the way of direct narratorial comment on the actions of the characters, other than in the introductory sentence: 'now there arises in this afflicted state of affairs a storm of new disasters, with no less ill for the provinces'

(15.5.1), which is generalizing and imprecise (who caused these disasters and what was so terrible for the provinces?). Instead interpretation is mediated through narratorial control of this complex web of information, particularly as that control relates to the degree to which Constantius and Silvanus know about the other's actions and plans. Silvanus is initially described as outside this nexus of observation and plotting, 'suspecting nothing' (15.5.3), though he will soon be drawn into it, whereas Constantius is a specialist in gathering information, especially if it relates to plots against him: Lampadius delivers the forged letters to an emperor 'accustomed to investigate these and similar charges eagerly' (15.5.5).

In terms of the plot itself, the primary narratee is made aware from the outset that both letters are forgeries, again thanks to the omniscience of the primary narrator, who discloses Dynamius' plans in chronological order before any response to the forged letters is described (15.5.3). The same applies to the second forgery at 15.5.9, where the letter to the tribune at Cremona is also explained in advance of its receipt. Thus the primary narratee is presented with two structurally similar scenes:

> This packet of letters, thus forged at his pleasure to assail the life of an innocent man, the prefect received from Dynamius, and coming into the emperor's private room at an opportune time and finding him alone, secretly handed it to him, accustomed as he was eagerly to investigate these and similar charges. Thereby the prefect hoped that he would be rewarded by the emperor, as a most watchful and careful guardian of his safety. And when these letters, patched together with cunning craft, were read to the consistory, orders were given that those tribunes whose names were mentioned in the letters should be imprisoned, and that the private individuals should be brought to the capital from the provinces. (15.5.5)

> Dynamius made up a letter tallying with the one which he had presented to the emperor through the prefect, and sent it to the tribune of the Cremona armory, in the name of Silvanus and Malarichus; in this letter the tribune, as one privy to their secret designs, was admonished to prepare everything with speed. When the tribune had read this, hesitating for a long time and puzzling as to what in the world it meant (for he did not remember that the man whose letter he had received had ever talked with him about any confidential business), he sent the identical letter back to Malarichus by the carrier who had brought it, and with him a soldier, begging Malarichus to explain openly (*doceret aperte*) what he wanted, and not so enigmatically (*perplexe*).

> For he declared that, being a somewhat rude and plain man (*subagrestem et simplicem*), he had not understood what had been obscurely (*obscurius*) intimated. (15.5.9–10)

In the first instance Constantius accepts the letter as genuine, despite the fact that the narratee knows it had been written 'in obscure terms' (15.5.4), and based upon Constantius' credulous interpretation of the contents he subsequently and wrongly orders the arrest of those named within the letter. However, the second elicits suspicion in the initial recipient, who recognizes the obscurity of the text. The tribune at Cremona is perplexed and attributes his confusion to his lack of erudition based upon his lowly status. There is a wry comment about Constantius' inability to recognize the suspiciously obscure language as the sign of a forgery in comparison to this self-professed rustic's keen interpretative skills.

Worse than this, Constantius and the court are depicted as attempting to use false information (not unlike Dynamius at the beginning of the episode) to engineer a situation where the extent of their knowledge exceeds Silvanus', thus their plan to bring down Silvanus involves making the latter believe 'the emperor had no knowledge of his actions' (*gesta etiam tum imperatorem ignorare existimaret*, 15.5.21). This is the last description of events at court before the narrative switches to Ursicinus' mission, but earlier Constantius' plans have been implicitly undermined by the presentation of Silvanus as someone who has a better understanding of Constantius than vice versa. Silvanus, 'knowing the pliant mind of the fickle emperor (*sciens* ***animum tenerum*** *uersabilis pricipis*)' (15.5.15), is prompted into rebellion. It is an interpretation which has previously received corroboration in the voice of the primary narrator, who had sketched out the danger of Constantius' disposition in relation to the punishment of Magnentius' adherents in the previous book, 'his narrow and pliant mind (***animus*** *eius angustus et* ***tener***), thinking that every sound indicated something done or planned at the expense of his safety (*ad salutis suae dispendium existimans*), made his victory [over Magnentius] lamentable through the murder of innocent men (*insontium*)' (14.5.2).[95] The other point articulated in this passage from Book 14, that Constantius is obsessed with his own safety, again is deployed in the Silvanus episode by Lampadius who 'hoped that he

[95] Cf. Silvanus' description as an *insons* at 15.5.5.

would be rewarded by the emperor, as a most watchful and careful guardian of his safety (*peruigilem salutis custodem et cautum*)' (15.5.5). Both Silvanus and Lampadius use their knowledge of Constantius as motivations for action. From a narratological perspective, their knowledge is established as correct (and therefore their actions at least understandable if not justifiable) because their interpretations are corroborated by information expressed by the primary narrator elsewhere. Ammianus uses the same narrative technique as he had done for Gallus when the latter was portrayed as a more sympathetic character because his interpretations cohere with those of the primary narrator.

A similar phenomenon of narratorial corroboration is evident in the role given in 15.5.6–8 to Malarichus, who protests against Constantius' decision to imprison all those named in the first forged letter. It is worth quoting this paragraph in full:

> 6. But Malarichus, commander of the gentiles, was at once struck (*percitus*) with the unfairness of the procedure, and summoning his colleagues, vigorously protested, exclaiming that men devoted to the empire (*homines dicatos imperio*) ought not to be made victims of cliques and wiles. And he asked that he himself—leaving as hostages his relatives and having Mallobaudes, tribune of the heavy-armed guard, as surety for his return—might be commissioned to go quickly and fetch Silvanus, who was not entering upon any such attempt as those most bitter plotters (*insidiatores*) had trumped up (*concitarunt*). Or as an alternative, he asked that he might make a like promise and that Mallobaudes be allowed to hurry there and perform what he himself had promised to do. 7. For he declared that he knew beyond question that (*testabatur enim id se procul dubio scire*), if any outsider should be sent, Silvanus, being by nature apprehensive, even when there was nothing alarming, would be likely to upset the peace (*turbabit*). 8. But although his advice was expedient and necessary (*utilia . . . et necessaria*), yet he was talking vainly to the winds. For by Arbetio's advice Apodemius, an inveterate and bitter enemy of every patriot, was sent with a letter to recall Silvanus.

With the description of Dynamius' plot placed only a few sentences previously, Malarichus is clearly correct in his interpretation: Silvanus and his men are not traitors, but devoted to the empire; the accusations are the invention of plotters (*insidiatores*). Again here we find a character, Malarichus, presented as the purveyor of correct

knowledge (*procul dubio scire*). Therefore, his assessment of Silvanus' probable reaction to Constantius' plans (that he will cause real trouble, *turbabit*) also acts as a credible prolepsis. Indeed the plotline subsequently confirms that Silvanus will indeed act as Malarichus predicts. Malarichus' role as a correct interpreter of the events is subsequently confirmed by the narrator's comment that his advice is *utile* and *necessarium*, and by ignoring it, Constantius is cast as outside the correct procedures of interpretation, though he himself, as has been established earlier, has pretensions to have a stake in this battle of knowledge. Indeed, despite this warning, when Constantius later receives news that Silvanus has in fact rebelled, the messenger and the news he carries is described (focalized through Constantius) as 'unexpected (*insperabilis*)' (15.5.17). Constantius has been unable to countenance the correct interpretation provided earlier by Malarichus.

This assessment of the series of events, which led Constantius to remove Silvanus, illuminates a feature of Ammianus' narrative that will repay further investigation in his portrayal of other imperial figures. Ammianus' narrator can often promote a character by aligning that character's interpretation of the events with either the primary narrator's assessment, or with an interpretation that has already been proved correct in some other way. In the Silvanus episode, simply put, Silvanus and his supporters are more sympathetically portrayed than Constantius. But what happens when the participant enters the narrative?

Ammianus accompanies Ursicinus to Cologne on Constantius' orders. The episode is narrated with first person verbs, which necessarily focalize the action through this group (presented collectively in the first-person plural). The extent of the participant narration, however, is brief. In all there are only five first-person plural verbs, two of which record the group's trepidation before setting out.[96] Otherwise 'we hurried (*festinamus*)' (15.5.24) to Cologne, 'we found (*inuenimus*) everything beyond our reach' (15.5.24) and 'we were searching around (*scrutabamus*)' for a plan to remove Silvanus

[96] Ammianus introduces himself with a first-person singular, which notes his presence among Ursicinus' retinue: *inter quos ego quoque eram* (15.5.22). An initial use of the singular followed by a set of plurals is a pattern that Ammianus repeats during the siege of Amida; see Kelly 2008, 42. See Section 5.1 for the argument that Ammianus also alludes here to Eutropius' intimation of his presence on Julian's Persian campaign.

(15.5.30).[97] Despite relatively few appearances of the participant, Ammianus makes it clear that Ursicinus' retinue is merely acting on its orders, thus the participant repeats some of the court's pejorative terminology, for example the one and only time Silvanus' regime is labelled as a *tyrannis* is as part of the focalized participant narrative: 'accordingly, we hurried (*festinamus*) by forced marches, since the commander-in-chief of the army, in his zeal, wished to appear in the suspected districts before any report of the usurpation (*de tyrannide*) had made its way into Italy. But for all our running haste, Rumour had flown before us (*nos*)' (15.5.24).[98] Earlier in the episode the court had primarily aimed 'to destroy Silvanus as very strong rebel (*fortissimum perduellem*)'. By repeating the official line, Ammianus is keen to stress that Ursicinus and his men were acting, as he declares elsewhere, 'to assist the needs of the state' (15.5.22), and therefore, may be less culpable of bringing down an innocent man.[99]

Nevertheless, the overall frame of internal narration allows a very different presentation of Silvanus, even though, in common with the Gallus episode and other points of first-person narration in Ammianus, 'we' never perceive or interact directly with the main object of the mission, in this case Silvanus (as the list of first-person verbs above makes clear).[100] The effect of this limited internal narration is to undermine the presentation of Silvanus that had been set out in the first half of the chapter. Earlier, as we have seen, Silvanus was a skilled interpreter of the events around him, able to perceive and react in advance to Constantius' plans. Now, the presence of the focalizing participant removes the opportunity for him to play that role within the narrative, indeed in that role he has been supplanted by the participant-narrator. Silvanus is unaware of what Ursicinus and his

[97] There are three uses of *nos* in the accusative: rumour of the group's arrival outstrips 'us' to Cologne (15.5.24); the punishment of death might await 'us' if they fail (15.5.26); and Silvanus' angry soldiers terrify 'us' (15.5.29).

[98] The term *tyrannis* aggrandizes Silvanus' rebellion, as it was regularly 'imposed retrospectively on an individual who had held imperial power but had then been disposed', Humphries 2008, 86. The terminology, then, coheres with Ammianus' depiction of Silvanus as a credible threat.

[99] Hunt suggests the use of this terminology 'derive[s] from the official communiqué submitted to the emperor in Milan' by Ursicinus (1999, 58). Even if this is the case, Ammianus made a choice to preserve this terminology within his narrative.

[100] Guzmán-Armario 2002, 751 suggests the change in presentation happens when Ursicinus enters the narrative; I would suggest it is the participant, rather than Ursicinus himself, that correlates with the change.

men are planning; 'we were searching around (*scrutabamus*) in secret investigation for some plan likely to have results'. Ultimately, however, Ammianus distances the participant from that plan (to bribe some barbarian troops to kill Silvanus) by reporting it impersonally 'the matter was arranged' (*firmato itaque negotio*, 15.5.31). From that point on, the primary narrator becomes external once more although Silvanus does not again receive a privileged place in the narrative as a character whose interpretations cohere with the primary narrator's. He is overcome by a 'sudden group of armed men' (15.5.31) and thus he has been outsmarted in this final action. Indeed, once again Silvanus has become the victim of falsification, Ursicinus had used 'various pretences of flattery' (*uariis assentandi figmentis*) (15.5.25) to gain his confidence and enter his court, but this time he has been successfully duped. Ursicinus is received (incorrectly as the primary narratee knows) by Silvanus as a 'distinguished and intimate friend' (15.5.27), whom Silvanus even consults on important affairs. Ursicinus puts into practice the deceptive techniques perfected by the court. This intimacy between Silvanus and Ursicinus allows the opportunity for Silvanus' opinions to be presented for one last time (during which there are no first-person verbs alluding to the presence of the participant) (15.5.28):

> Silvanus was aggrieved that while unworthy men were raised to the consulship and to high positions, he and Ursicinus alone, after having toiled through such heavy and repeated tasks for the government, had been so scorned that he himself had been cruelly harassed in an unworthy controversy through the examination of friends of his, and summoned to trial for treason, while Ursicinus, haled back from the East, was delivered over to the hatred of his enemies; and these continual complaints he made both covertly and openly.

Silvanus' interpretation is fundamentally correct in that it tallies with the primary narrator's description of Ursicinus' fate earlier in the book, where Ursicinus had been slandered at court in a way not dissimilar to Silvanus.[101] Although he is right about Ursicinus, his fault here is to underestimate Ursicinus' willingness to fulfil his orders. It is also notable that the participant is absent from this tête-à-tête. Instead,

[101] Ursicinus 'was attacked with the blandishments of counterfeit courtesy by Arbitio, who kept openly calling him his colleague and a brave man, but who was exceedingly shrewd in devising deadly snares for a straightforward character and was at that time altogether too powerful' (15.2.4).

the participant reappears in the next sentence to outline that the object of their observation is not Silvanus but his troops, who 'terrify us' by their willingness to invade Italy. Although Silvanus' fate is sealed, there is still the recurring suggestion (via his discussion with Ursicinus) that his rebellion has been forced upon him, whereas the real danger which Constantius should be afraid of comes from his troops.

The use not just of Ammianus the participant but also of more extensive participant-narration than in the Gallus episode allows the narrator to justify the sudden change in the characterization of Silvanus as he had of Gallus. Previously Silvanus had been cast in a sympathetic light because his intentions and motivations were presented by the omniscient, external narrator in an understandable way: they cohered with the wider interpretation of events. However, even if Ammianus was naturally sympathetic to Silvanus, he nevertheless had to explain his demise. Silvanus died not as moral or political punishment for his rebellion per se, but because he finally succumbed in the battle of deception with Constantius by underestimating Constantius' agent, Ursicinus. The internal narrative plays a major role in corroborating that point by depicting Silvanus, in the end, as an incorrect interpreter of events.

2.6 THE PARTICIPANT, URSICINUS, AND THE TRADITION

Between these two episodes, we have observed how Ammianus uses the participant to mark a change in the interpretation of each character. In the Gallus episode, the participant's role was heavily circumscribed, amounting to nothing more than Ammianus' arrival and departure in Antioch. However, the rare appearance of the first person to present the actions of the historian within his own work, even if those actions are merely of travel, is enough to arouse the especial interest of the primary narratee. It was precisely because of the oddity of participation and the unusual use of the first person that Polybius had felt the need to include a methodological statement so late in his work, as we saw in Chapter 1.[102] The correlation between

[102] Cf. Marincola 1997, 189–92 and Rood 2004, 153–4. See section 1.2.

the appearance of the participant and a change of presentation of Gallus could be dismissed as coincidence if it were not for the same pattern occurring in the Silvanus episode. Gallus had started out as a cruel figure, with limited rationalization of his actions by the primary narrator and instead marked with tyrannical exemplarity. The appearance of Ammianus the participant not only coincides with Gallus' change to a more sympathetic figure who becomes aware both of his own faults but also of how Constantius is likely to treat him, but the manner of his departure, with Ursicinus recalled by a suspicious court, sets the narrative pattern for Gallus. The participant himself is deployed by the primary narrator as an interpretative tool for the primary narratee. So also in the Silvanus episode, the innocent Silvanus, who is portrayed sympathetically as shrewder than his opponents and a better judge of the situation, loses these attributes once Ammianus the participant appears. The participant-focalized narrative helps explain the change in Silvanus to the primary narratee.

In terms of the longer traditions of Latin historiography, this use of the participant adds a further dimension to our understanding of why Ammianus chose to present his involvement in the events he narrates, and also why, in these two episodes, he chose to use the first person in a far more extensive way than his predecessors. The appearance of internal narration and Ammianus-as-participant implicitly questions, however, the charges raised by those source-based historians who have studied Gallus and Silvanus and detected charges of bias within each episode in favour of Ursicinus.[103] Ursicinus is a curious character for Ammianus to wish to defend in the 380s. Of course he no doubt had a great admiration for his former commander, but it is unclear against whom or what Ammianus needed to defend him. The only other Greek or Latin author to show any knowledge of him is Zonaras, who mentions him only in relation to Silvanus: Ursicinus 'was sent there [Cologne], corrupted some of [Silvanus'] soldiers with wealth, and through them killed him and quashed the rebellion'.[104] Zonaras' depiction of Ursicinus is not

[103] Den Boer 1960, Nutt 1973, Drinkwater 1994, Hunt 1999.

[104] Zon. 13.9.47 (translations from Zonaras are taken from Banchich and Lane 2009). Cf. Kelly 2008, 45 n.45, who points out that earlier claims that Ursicinus is entirely absent from the historical record other than in Ammianus and Zonaras are not correct (e.g. Valesius *ad* 15.5.31 and *PLRE* 1 s.v. Vrsicinus 2). Ursicinus is mentioned in the Palestinian Talmud, a set of Rabinnic notes on Jewish sacred texts

overtly hostile, and even if Zonaras' source was more so, the temporal gap of thirty years or more between the fall of Gallus and Silvanus and Ammianus' time of composition lessens, or at least makes more rarefied, Ammianus' defence against any contemporary gossip which may have been directed against Ursicinus' conduct. Those who argue for Ammianus' partisanship have often noted that it is Ammianus' presence alongside Ursicinus in Books 14–19 that has been the key to identifying his bias. However, it is possible to invert this observation. The participant, at least in these two episodes, serves a highly interpretative role. Ammianus needs Ursicinus in order to justify his own participation. His presence as a mere *protector domesticus* could not be justified without his attachment to a senior general, even if it meant presenting Ursicinus' actions (particularly in the Silvanus episode) in a questionable light. The defence of Ursicinus was a consequence of participant narration, not its cause.

Participation and autopsy certainly serve an important related purpose in creating authority, for although Ammianus' accounts of both Gallus and Silvanus are probably the most detailed of those in circulation up to the time he wrote, he did not adhere to standard interpretations. As we have seen above, Gallus was either treated as a simple brute, or exonerated, but never the combination of the two within the same text.[105] Similarly Silvanus had been treated either as a rebel or a victim, but not both, as a brief survey will show.

Julian repeatedly presents Silvanus as guilty of rebellion against Constantius, not just in his panegyrics to Constantius in the late 350s (*Or.* 1.48C and *Or.* 3.98C–D), where the unambiguous depiction of a traitor would be expected, but also in his self-apologetic *Letter to the Athenians,* in which he fails to exonerate Silvanus as victim of Constantius' plotting, an interpretative approach which would have equated Silvanus with Gallus (273D). The presentation of Silvanus the traitor was soon echoed by Mamertinus in his panegyric of Julian in 361 (*Pan. Lat.* (III)11.13.3), and Libanius in *Oration* 18, who alludes to Silvanus' rebellion as the cause for Julian's dispatch to

compiled in the second half of the fourth century. Geiger 1979 offers a list of the sections of the Talmud where Ursicinus appears. Zonaras' source for Ursicinus could have been Eunapius, but Zosimus' omission of the Silvanus episode makes this difficult to judge.

[105] Libanius does of course reverse his positive view of Gallus when he wrote the *Autobiography* (*Or.* 1, 96). The separation of the two versions of Gallus highlights the difficulty in combining the two within one text.

Gaul, where 'the commanders sent to that theatre of war aspired to something higher than their lawful station' (*Or.* 18.31).[106] It is understandable that Julian, at the moment when he sought to justify his usurpation against Constantius on the grounds that he was unwillingly forced into it by Constantius' suspicion of hostility towards him, did not want openly to share that motivation (and therefore equate himself) with Silvanus, who, willing or not, had failed in his usurpation five years previously.[107] Libanius' repetition of Julian's hostile interpretation of Silvanus suggests one way of promoting Julian after his death—by reiterating Julian's point of view.

Equally, there is a disagreement between the Latin breviarists.[108] Eutropius simply describes Silvanus as a usurper (*res nouas molitus*), though by the late 360s, it was easier to equate Gallus and Silvanus as a joint phenomenon that unsettled Constantius' reign between the defeat of Magnentius and the rise of Julian, 'Silvanus too (*quoque*) rebelled in Gaul and was killed before his thirtieth day' (10.13). The previous sentence contains the brief description of Gallus' death.[109] Writing for Valens a few years after the revolt of Procopius, it was also more politic for Eutropius to keep the presentation of usurpers free from any exculpating details, such as the threatening role of the Augustus. Before Ammianus, only Victor creates a more complex picture of Silvanus (42.13–16):

> Thus after a long interval of almost seventy years the care of the state was returned to one man. Its newly acquired respite from civil turmoil again began to be disturbed when Silvanus was forced (*Siluano . . . coacto*) to assume the imperial power . . . when he had climbed still higher from that rank through fear or madness (*per metum seu dementiam*), he was slaughtered on about the twenty-eighth day during a mutiny of the legions from which he had hoped for protection.

[106] Kelly suggests that to Mamertinus 'Silvanus seems little more than a name' (2008, 45 n.43); however, both Mamertinus and Libanius seem to know that Silvanus should be understood as part of the rise of Julian.

[107] For an assessment of Julian's self-presentation in the *Letter to the Athenians,* see Humphries 2012, 81–6.

[108] Again, Kelly suggests the breviarists 'know or tell little' about Silvanus (2008, 45 n.43), but their subtly different accounts suggest an attempt to individualize Silvanus within their texts (even if they had been able to rely on the *Kaisergeschichte* for Silvanus, a scenario made possible if one accepts the dating of the *KG* put forward by Burgess 2005).

[109] Jerome derives his entry on Silvanus (*Chronicon* 239d) from Eutropius.

Victor's Silvanus is forced to rebel, though Victor shows the same caution as elsewhere in his descriptions of recent events by refusing to explain the precise cause for Silvanus' action. He merely hints that fear of Constantius drove Silvanus, and also leaves open the possibility for madness, a far more palatable option for Constantius if he were ever to read Victor's work. Nonetheless, Victor's willingness to suggest (if not actually confirm) that Constantius pushed Silvanus into rebellion could well have been provoked by the thought that such an interpretation would be more pleasing to the other Gallic commander who had recently rebelled against Constantius.[110]

Ammianus again blends two competing interpretative approaches, and whereas in the case of Gallus the division had fallen neatly between Greek and Latin authors, in the case of Silvanus there were conflicting accounts also within the Latin breviary tradition. Ammianus' more extensive first-person narration in the Silvanus episode may be an attempt to create an authoritative interpretation of Silvanus, who was already the object of more interest than Gallus to a western, Latin-speaking audience in Rome. Ammianus suggests that the Roman public was attune to the fate of Silvanus before even Constantius learned of his rebellion: there had been a prophecy about Silvanus circulating in Rome.[111] Gallus, by comparison, was a far more distant and less well understood character.

These two episodes, which previous scholars have shown are set up as introductory studies in Constantius' reaction to other imperial

[110] Orosius would later echo this interpretation, presenting Silvanus as Constantius' victim. His Silvanus did not get a chance to rebel, though he was 'desiring (*inhiantem*) revolution', because Constantius 'took care quickly to encircle and suppress (*circumueniendum opprimendumque*) him', 7.29.14. The *Epitome*, written soon after 395, is also favourable to Silvanus. It avoids any language of rebellion, instead mentioning that Silvanus simply had been made emperor (*imperator effectus*), and describing his character positively as *blandissimus,* and caring for the Roman state, 42.10–11. It is tempting to see this reassessment (which is far more positive than Victor's) as the result of the anonymous Epitomator's reliance on Ammianus (Barnes 1976, 266 n.24 has also suggested verbal similarities between *Epitome* 45.6 and Ammianus 30.9.4).

[111] 'Now it had happened that before anything of the kind was set on foot in Gaul, the people at Rome in the Great Circus (whether excited by some story or by some presentiment is uncertain) cried out with a loud voice: "Silvanus is vanquished."' 15.5.34. Ammianus places this prophecy at the end of Silvanus' death notice, outside the description of the exchange of information at the beginning of the chapter. To have included such a proleptic note earlier would have greatly complicated Ammianus' depiction of the relative knowledge of Silvanus and Constantius.

characters deemed by him to be a threat, also act as preparatory studies in Ammianus' narrative technique for dealing with such figures and such themes. The participant and participant-narrative, when in the company of an imperial figure, serves an interpretive purpose, particularly if that imperial figure undergoes a change of presentation. Ammianus does not appear again in proximity to an imperial figure until Julian's Persian campaign of 363, although, as already has been discussed, he might well have been with Julian in Reims in 356.[112] This structure creates a hiatus in participant-criticism of the imperial figures in which Julian enters the narrative fully, is appointed Caesar, secures his greatest military victory at Strasbourg, is proclaimed Augustus, and moves against Constantius. We will return to the role of participant narration in the final chapter of this book, but in the intervening chapters I offer a survey of how Ammianus tracks Julian's development as an imperial character and the trajectory of his career towards his death in Persia. We will be concerned with the same questions as have been outlined in the foregoing analysis of Gallus and Silvanus: how does Ammianus' primary narrator explain Julian to the primary narratee, does Ammianus invoke any comparison with earlier works of Latin historiography, and how does his newly minted version of Julian compare with versions in circulation before 390?

[112] See Chapter 2.4.

3

Julian's Elevation

Tradition and Innovation in Speech and Narrative

3.1 IMPERIAL ELEVATIONS IN LATE ANTIQUITY AND AMMIANUS' SPEECH SCENES

The politician and philosopher Themistius viewed the news of Julian's elevation to the Caesarship in 355 as an important opportunity to impart some advice on the nature of kingship to a young and inexperienced student.[1] The letter he received in reply must have surprised and shocked him. Far from being an innocent youth in need of advice from a trusted imperial adviser, Julian reveals himself to be a confident intellectual who already possesses well-formed ideas on the relationship between politics and philosophy.[2] The exchange, or what we have left of it, between these two figures not only demonstrates the degree of thought that Julian had given the prospect of his appointment to an imperial position but that his elevation in Milan was empire-wide news, even though Julian himself was immediately dispatched further westwards and Constantius did not return to the East for a further four years.

Julian's elevation in 355 was the first step in a political and military career which would see him proclaimed Augustus four-and-a-half

[1] See Swain 2013, 54–7 for convincing arguments that Julian's *Letter to Themistius* is a response to a letter received from Themistius at the moment of Julian's elevation to the Caesarship, rather than to the position of Augustus in 361. Swain also argues that a later, reconciliatory letter from Themistius' to Julian is preserved in Arabic translation (see also Watt 2012).

[2] Julian, *Letter to Themistius*. See Watt 2013 for Julian's rejection of 'Themistius' grand conception of kingship'.

years later, then become sole emperor after Constantius' death in 361, before his own death less than two years after that. Julian was the last of the Neo-Flavian emperors, the last of the House of Constantius I. Within the context of the fourth century however, such an elevation may not seem an overly special event. Constantine had made all four of his sons Caesar; Crispus and Constantine II in 317, Constantius II in 324, and Constans in 333, as well as two of his half-nephews, Licinius junior in 317 and Dalmatius in 335. Constantius would go on to appoint Gallus as Caesar, as we have seen, in 351. Julian, however, was the last Caesar of the fourth century, his successors preferring to elevate their relatives to the position of co-Augustus, even if they were young children as in the case of Gratian.[3]

The frequency of elevations and successions of junior emperors compelled successive regimes to seek methods to justify the choice of new individuals for imperial positions, whether Caesar or Augustus. Increasingly this took a fixed form of ceremonial, which demonstrated the legitimacy of an imperial candidate before a certain audience. Sabine MacCormack's seminal study of this feature of Late Antique culture and politics has deftly traced the development from the Tetrarchy through the fourth century and into early Byzantium.[4] In a pioneering approach for its time, MacCormack analysed the art of Late Antiquity alongside literary sources, particularly panegyric, to uncover the developing form and objectives of accession theory. Her work provides important contextualization for Ammianus' depiction of Julian's elevation within historiographical discourse. Under the Tetrarchy, panegyrics may have stressed divine approval for the new imperial figure as well as his *virtus* (to the exclusion of the consent of senate, people, or army);[5] however, only under Constantine did a ceremony of accession develop, which favoured the idea of election by both the army and the people, accompanied by physical manifestations of the elevation including the donning of purple clothing, and the appearance before the palace.[6] With the sons of Constantine, the concept of dynastic legitimacy became a more potent force, and the ceremony, which could so obviously provide a physical manifestation of dynastic ties, became a legitimizing event in itself:

> In the early fourth century, this reflection of two succeeding emperors upon each other was for the first time expressed in a set of ceremonial

[3] See McEvoy 2013, 3–6.
[4] MacCormack 1981, 161–266.
[5] MacCormack 1981, 168–77.
[6] MacCormack 1981, 177–85.

> actions . . . with that a further avenue of claiming legitimacy became established, and this was a ceremonial of accession carried out to rules which were in the course of becoming established at this period.[7]

We might have expected panegyrics to dwell heavily on this new means of expressing legitimacy under the sons of Constantine, but they make few explicit references to the moment of elevation or any accompanying ceremonial.[8] In order to reconstruct the ceremonial elements of imperial accession, MacCormack had to piece together occasional references in panegyrics. For example, the anonymous panegyric to Constantine of 310 refers to the moment of Constantius I's death when the soldiers acclaimed Constantine in York, 'the whole army agreed on you, and the minds and eyes of all marked you out . . . and as soon as your appearance gave them an opportunity, straightway the soldiers threw the purple over you despite your tears' (*Pan.Lat.* VI(7).8.2–3). This is certainly a form of narrative, but it is selective and focuses only on certain actions, which, as MacCormack correctly argues, are those that had particular contemporary resonance for the conceptualization of legitimacy. This selectivity is understandable when viewed in terms of the function that narrative sought to perform within panegyric. Events narrated in panegyric were often those of the recent past, which were familiar to the audience and therefore did not require detailed exposition. Instead they could be narrated, as here, selectively for celebratory or evidentiary purposes.[9] The scene was not included in order to inform the audience about the details of the events themselves.

Ammianus creates a scene at 15.8 in which many of the legitimizing themes familiar from panegyric—divine approval, dynastic connections, personal virtue, and ceremony—play a role. By including a detailed scene in which Constantius elevates Julian before an audience

[7] MacCormack 1981, 184.

[8] Neither the panegyrist of 313 nor Nazarius in 321 (who marked Constantine's quindecennalia and Crispus and Constantine II's quinquennalia as Caesars) 'mentioned the actual moment when, or ceremony whereby, Constantine's sons became Caesars. Narazius, however, referred to the commemoration of this occasion, the *vota,* in some detail' (MacCormack 1981, 186). Dynastic concerns are mentioned by Eusebius *VC* 4.40; Libanius *Or.* 59.10–11 and *Or.* 22.27–28; Julian *Or.* 1.18C; Them. *Or.* 3.44A–B. For the emergence of the concept of dynastic legitimacy under Constantine, see now Börm 2015.

[9] See Rees 2010 for the primacy of 'celebratory' and 'evidentiary' functions of narrative within panegyric, over a 'cognitive' function.

and delivers a speech, however, Ammianus is the only surviving author from the fourth century to describe this imperial elevation within the format of extensive historical narrative.[10]

In doing so, Ammianus gave prominence to an event that few other writers paid detailed attention to. Not only that, it was also a challenging event to accommodate within a narrative of Julian, as a survey of how it was treated by other writers before Ammianus shows. Julian himself was unwilling to dwell on a moment that so obviously placed him in a position of subservience to Constantius and that cast the latter as his benefactor. Julian's first panegyric to Constantius is curious for the absence of any reference to the elevation, especially since it was likely composed shortly after the event.[11] He addresses the circumstances of his elevation only in this *Speech of Thanks to Eusebia*, where he stresses his unwillingness to take on the position, though he knew he could not refuse, 'for when those who have the power to exact by force what they wish condescend to entreat, naturally they put one out of countenance and there is nothing left but to obey' (*Or* 2.121C). Julian refers to the need to alter his clothing, but there is no direct description of the ceremonial at the actual elevation (121D). He prefers to stress his unwillingness to take up the office of Caesar. His later depiction of the moment in the *Letter to the Athenians*, Julian continues the theme of his unwillingness, but again avoids a direct description of the moment of his adoption.

[10] As such, some of MacCormack's conclusions about the role of ceremonial under Julian (that the ceremony itself was a sign of legitimacy, 1981, 194) may be more Ammianus' creation rather than representative of a wider view. It is not clear how Eunapius treated the elevation; it was the culminating event in his first book, but that book itself was more breviary in nature than those which followed (see Chapter 1.1). Zosimus merely states 'Constantius declared [Julian] Caesar, married his sister, Helena, to him and sent him to the provinces beyond the Alps' (3.2.1) (translations from Zosimus are taken from Ridley 1982), although he devotes some space to the machinations at court which led to the decision to call upon Julian, particularly the advice given by the Empress Eusebia who is given a rare instance of direct speech, 3.1.3, see Paschoud 1979, 61. Symmachus' panegyric to Valentinian I (*Or.* 1.9–10) gives more information about an accession ceremony than many other extant fourth-century panegyrics; even though Symmachus gives details of an assembly of troops and Valentinian's unwillingness to take up the position of Augustus, the purpose of this section of his speech is clearly not to offer a detailed narrative of the scene.

[11] Julian does, as we have seen, allude to Silvanus' rebellion (*Or.* 1.48C), and thus the speech at the earliest dates to late 355. Even if, as some have suggested, it dates to 356, the elevation would have been an opportunity for Julian to express his thanks to his senior emperor. See Tougher 2012, 20–2 for an overview of the debated options for the date. There is no reference to the elevation in his second panegyric either.

Instead, he includes a long debate with himself on the necessity to accept Constantius' offer, which opens (275D):

> 'Now,' I said to myself, 'I am planning to oppose the gods, and I have imagined that I can devise wiser schemes for myself than those who know all things . . . '

Julian cleverly deprives Constantius of the opportunity to define his legitimacy for him by placing the reference to the will of the gods (which in the end, of course, Julian decides not to oppose) in this dialogue with himself rather than the mouth of the senior emperor. Otherwise, the only reference to the ceremonial is Julian's investment with 'the title and robe of Caesar' (277A).[12]

Julian's own panegyrist Mamertinus decided to stay clear of the elevation altogether, perhaps knowing that it was a tricky subject,[13] while Libanius dwells on the particular circumstances which led to the elevation (the overrunning of Gaul) but not on the elevation itself.[14] The generic restraints of breviary did not allow Victor or Eutropius to describe the scene, although they explain the event in terms of Constantius' need to send an imperial representative to stabilize Gaul.[15]

The parallel tradition surrounding the elevation of Julian in 355, other than in Julian's own works, is largely concerned with Constantius' pragmatic justification for electing Julian rather than offering any detailed defence of Julian's legitimacy based on a description or analysis of the moment of elevation itself. Even Julian, although making claims to legitimacy openly via divine approval and more covertly via dynastic links to Constantius, avoids dwelling on the act itself.

It was of course Ammianus' choice of genre that allowed him to bring several of these factors together—Constantius' pragmatic reasons

[12] Cf. Elm 2012a, 77, for Julian's 'high-wire act at the heart of the letter, namely to claim dynastic legitimacy whilst seeking to destroy the most exalted member of that dynasty in every way possible'. He explicitly refers to a dynastic claim to legitimacy only when his position was more secure, *Caes.* 334D. Börm 2015, 256.

[13] MacCormack 1981, 193.

[14] Libanius, following Julian, emphasizes Julian's reluctance, 'Julian smote his breast, bade himself bear no malice and prepared loyally to play his part in the task.' (*Or.* 12.41, composed in 363). Cf. *Or.* 18.31, where Julian was aware he was walking into a trap.

[15] Victor specifies Silvanus' usurpation as a cause for the unrest in Gaul (42.17), whereas Eutropius, although not mentioning the usurpation, is far more sensationalist, 'the Roman empire was already tottering to certain disaster' (10.14.1), no doubt to aggrandize Julian's later achievement in stabilizing the situation.

for elevating Julian, wider contemporary concepts of legitimacy, and the role of ceremonial in establishing a new ruler—by narrating the elevation within a scene that contains a mixture of narrative and speech. Ammianus devotes four Teubner pages to a compact set-piece scene in which Constantius deliberates on raising Julian to the Caesarship (15.8.1–3), summons an audience of the troops (15.8.4), and makes a speech recommending Julian to the audience (15.8.5–10). Julian is robed in a purple cloak (15.8.11) before Constantius delivers a further speech to Julian directly (15.8.12–14). A description of the reaction of both troops and Julian concludes the scene (15.8.15–17), though Ammianus mentions the events immediately afterwards, including Julian's marriage to Helena and departure for Gaul (15.8.18–22).

The combination and interaction of speech and narrative is a hallmark of historiography, and one which was denied to the other contemporary literary genres that had dealt with this type of event (an imperial elevation).[16] Speech scenes are too lengthy for breviary, and panegyric is essentially the inverse of historiography, the former being a genre that has an outer structure of speech with occasional moments of narrative, whereas the latter is predominantly narrative with the occasional moments of speech. Indeed, a reference to the impossibility of embedding a speech within a panegyric is made by Libanius when describing Julian's preparations for the battle of Strasbourg (*Or.* 18.53):

> Then remembering the speeches of exhortation that he had heard given by the generals of old in history books, and well aware that such an address at the start of an action sends the men cheerfully into battle, he delivered a speech which I would gladly have inserted here in my own, but since that is forbidden by the tradition (*τοῦ νόμου*) in such matters, I will limit my remarks to this . . .

The presence of a speech within a speech is therefore not generically permissible according to Libanius. The motivations ascribed to Julian for making his speech at Strasbourg, however, are also telling of the nature of oratory in Late Antiquity. Libanius of course picks up the motif of Julian's self-confessed unpreparedness for the military challenge that he faced as Caesar by emphasizing his bookishness. But the comment also draws attention to the fact that the greatest number of

[16] See Fornara 1983, 142–68 on the use of speeches within ancient historiography.

extant speeches related to the role of the emperor in late antiquity, especially the military role, were encomia such as Libanius himself was writing.[17] Speeches such as battle exhortation were no longer common elements of literary prose. He also recognizes that such speeches by generals, or for that matter emperors, on the battlefield, or indeed in the case of 15.8 at the moment of imperial elevations, were not preserved and published in their own right. Instead, they were traditionally to be found embedded within historiographical narrative.

Speeches in historiography serve a number of purposes. Often a comparison between speech and narrative can aid the historian's characterization of the actors within his text.[18] They can reveal the speaker's understanding or reaction to the events of the surrounding narrative or indeed the judgement and views of the primary narrator.[19] Even if they do not reflect the contents of speeches delivered in the 'real world', their form often adheres to that of actual oratory. The majority of speeches in historiography tend to fall into the category of 'symbouleutic', the speech of advice or deliberation, such indeed as Libanius mentions in *Or.* 18,[20] particularly when speeches of opposing sides are paired in an apparent expression of free debate. Again, this is a point of contrast with the dominant variety of imperial oratory in Late Antiquity, which circulated in published form, namely encomium. Speeches within historiography can also serve as points of intertextuality. For example, the pair of speeches between Caesar and Cato in Sallust's *Bellum Catilinae* (51–52) appears to be modelled on Thucydides' version of the Mytilenean Debate (3.37–48).[21] Speeches

[17] See Chapter 1.1 for the classification of Libanius *Or.* 18 as a quasi-panegyric, and O'Brien 2002, 2–4 for the changed role of oratory in late antique society in comparison to earlier periods, particularly the late Republic.

[18] Marincola 2007, 119–20.

[19] For example, Ash 2010 examines Tacitus' construction of a 'powerful and convincing piece of oratory' placed in the mouth of Dillius Vocula at *Histories* 4.58 to dramatize wider issues in the text, particularly, in Tacitus' *Histories,* the impact and aftermath of civil war. Such uses of speeches go back to the establishment of the genre by Herodotus, who, for example, can use different styles of interaction of speech and narrative to characterize the Greeks ethnographically in opposition to the Persians. See Pelling 2006.

[20] Particularly 'since these speeches [in historiography] occur in relationship to actions taken by individuals or groups' Marincola 2007, 127. Cf. Ullmann 1927, 9.

[21] Marincola 2007, 130. He also notes that 'the Campanians' request for Roman assistance at Livy 7.30–31 is modelled on Thucydides' Corcyrean debate (1.24–45) . . . and Tacitus' account of the debate on governors' wives accompanying husbands to their

are not just traditional markers of the genre of historiography, but can closely connect one historian with a specific predecessor; in doing so the later historian can pass comment of the repetitive nature of historical events or causations, or set his work within a tradition.[22]

Ammianus clearly observes many of the practices of his predecessors in this regard. He may be far more sparing in his use of speeches,[23] but their distribution carries a certain meaning: only imperial characters are allowed to speak in lengthy *oratio recta,* and of those only Constantius (14.10.10–16; 15.8.1–17; 17.13.24–34; 21.13.10–15); Julian (16.12.9–13; 20.5.3–7; 21.5.2–8; 23.5.15–25; 24.3.3–9; 25.3.15–20) and Valentinian (26.2.6–10; 27.6.1–16) are given lengthy speeches in staged surroundings.[24] A staged speech, then, is not only a marker of an emperor, but the denial of a speech from certain emperors, notably Jovian and Valens, contributes to Ammianus' wider condemnation of these figures as inadequate holders of the imperial office.[25] These twelve speeches share a number of formulaic elements. With the exception of Julian's deathbed speech in Book 25, all are symbouleutic, and of these two are speeches of elevation (15.8 and 27.6), two of accession (20.5 and 26.2), and the rest military *adlocutiones* by the emperor in a military role before his troops.[26] On most occasions

provinces imaginatively recasts some of the same issues that Livy explored in his debate on the repeal of the Oppian Law'. Cf. Keitel 2006, 224 for Sallust and Thucydides.

[22] Marincola 2010 explores this phenomenon in terms of the use of *exempla* within historiographic speeches.

[23] Miller 1975 calculates that direct speech makes up 16 per cent of Sallust's *Iug.* and 26 per cent of *Cat.*; 27 per cent of Livy; though only 9 per cent of Tacitus. Although Caesar's works outwardly profess to conform to the historiographic subgenre of *commentarii,* they are remarkable for containing any speech at all, although most of it is *obliqua,* Miller 1975, 49. She does not include Ammianus in her study. From this rather crude statistical comparison, which says little about the use of speeches by each historian, it is notable that, again, we find Ammianus in closest alignment with Tacitus' practice.

[24] There are a further eleven instances of direct speech, which, however, are notably shorter (usually no more than a couple of sentences) and which are not set within a formulaic speech-scene, such as Gallus' brief exhortation to his troops to attack Montius (14.7.14). See Pighi 1936, 30–1, for a complete list. Barnes notes that Ammianus avoids the practice of 'paired speeches' in battle exhortation, where the speech of one general appears to answer the rhetoric of the other.

[25] See Barnes 1998, 138–42, Lenski 2000, and Kelly 2008, 242–50 for Ammianus' negative treatment of Jovian, and Leppin 2007, 59 for Valens. Cf. O'Brien 2013b, 226.

[26] They often give the appearance of being truly deliberative. For example Constantius puts forward his reasons to his troops for not attacking the Alammani in 354

Ammianus establishes the speech as a distinct topos, which is marked off from the surrounding narrative by a set of formulaic elements.[27] The troops who form the audience are gathered together, the emperor processes to a tribunal or platform accompanied by a retinue,[28] and often the narrator dwells on the speaker's physical appearance or actions.[29] After the speech, Ammianus notes the audience's reaction, typically, in the case of the soldiery, the sort of noise they make. As the author usefully explains in the case of Julian's elevation: 'all the soldiers with fearful din struck their shields against their knees (this is a sign of complete approval; for when, on the contrary, they smite their shields with their spears it is an indication of anger and resentment)' (15.8.15).[30]

In this chapter I will examine how Ammianus reworks contemporary discourse on the motivations behind Julian's elevation and on imperial legitimacy more generally to fit within the historiographic convention of speeches embedded within historical narrative. Drawing on the idea that speeches themselves can serve as points of intertextuality between historians, I will compare Ammianus' use of speech at 15.8 with two speeches from Sallust and Tacitus, which share strong thematic and structural similarities. A comparative analysis

at 14.10.11–15, in which he concludes 'in summation, I await your decision as arbiters'. For an example of a deliberative speech which is rejected by the troops, see the discussion of Julian's speech before the battle of Strasbourg below in Chapter 4.3.

[27] In an unpublished doctoral thesis, O'Brien (2002) examines the formulaic nature of the twelve-speech scenes in the *Res Gestae* by type (military *adlucutiones* and imperial adoption speeches) and the intratextual relationships between them. Although his analysis successfully reveals the intricate way in which the scenes respond to each other, it does not take fully into account the narratological aspects of each speech-scene's interaction with the wider narrative, how Ammianus' use of speeches compares to that of earlier Roman historians, or, in the case of the elevation scenes, how Ammianus may have been influenced by (or sought to reinterpret) the existing tradition as recorded in other genres.

[28] 14.10.10; 15.8.4; 16.12.8; 17.13.25; 20.5.1; 21.5.1; 21.13.9; 23.5.15; 24.3.3; 26.2.2; 27.6.5. A tabulated overview of these formulaic elements can now be found in O'Brien 2013b, 254–6.

[29] Constantius and Valentinian hold the right hand of Julian and Gratian respectively (15.8.4, 27.6.5), whereas in the military *adlocutiones* the narrator notes, for example, Julian's confidence and clear tone (21.5.1) or calmness (23.5.15), and likewise, Valentinian's confidence as the new emperor (26.2.5).

[30] Other examples of noise raised by striking shields: 16.12.13; 20.5.8 (where clashing spears of shields appears to be a positive sign of endorsement of the speech); 21.5.9–10; 21.13.16; 24.3.8.

of these three speech scenes will illuminate more clearly Ammianus' procedure in characterizing both Constantius and Julian at 15.8.

3.2 A FAILED ADOPTION

We have already explored how Ammianus engaged with certain aspects of Tacitus' historiography, particularly in his relation to the depiction of a tyrannical figure,[31] but Sallust too was a major influence on certain sections of Ammianus' work.[32] In a pair of recent articles, Seager and Drijvers have pointed to a number of thematic parallels between Ammianus' description of the North African revolt of Firmus in 373 (29.5) and Sallust's *Bellum Iugurthinum*. Importantly, these have not been on the level of close lexical allusions, but on broader thematic grounds, especially in terms of:[33]

> the avarice and corruptibility of the Romans, the desertion of Roman soldiers to the opponent's side, and the Roman military strategy—capturing of cities and strongholds and confronting the enemy in open battle. The parallels between Iugurtha and Firmus are striking. Both are of similar descent: Iugurtha being the son of a concubine of Micipsa and Firmus having brothers by concubines of his father. Both rebels had done military service in the Roman army. Both exploit the terrain: Iugurtha by retreating to country fortified by nature, to the deserted and difficult regions, Firmus by going to inhospitable—for Roman soldiers impassable—mountain regions. An interesting analogy is also that both men were driven by fear and desperation but also demonstrated courage. They also showed humility toward the Romans

[31] Chapter 2.2.

[32] Hertz 1874, 15 and Wirz 1877, 629–32 collect a list of possible allusions to the *Bellum Iugurthinum*. Wirz terms them either 'intentional borrowings' or 'unintentional imitations' of Sallust. Though not all are fully compelling, the several that stand up to modern definitions and concepts of allusion confirm the importance of Sallust to Ammianus. Cf. Matthews' remark, 'it is to Sallust, if indeed to any single author, that we must look in considering the broader issue of Ammianus' conception of the "dignity and character" of Roman history' (1989, 32).

[33] See Fletcher 1937, 382 for a potential allusion between Julian's elevation (*noxarum conscientia* 15.8.2) and Sall. *Hist.* 2.87 *conscientia noxarum.* Sallust is mentioned by name in a digression (15.9.6). Ammianus' indebtedness both to Sallust's moralizing style and his language has been noted by Kelly 2008, 206 and 211–12. For Sallust's continued popularity from Late Antiquity to the Carolingian period, see McKitterick 1994, 101 and O'Gorman 2007, 379.

> and sent envoys to come to an understanding. Both Iugurtha and Firmus attempted to shake the loyalty of the Roman troops: Iugurtha by shouting at the Roman soldiers that they were fighting for nothing, as a consequence of which many soldiers became terrified and were on the verge of fleeing; Firmus did the same by urging the Roman soldiers to leave Theodosius. Remarkable also is the resemblance between the Mauretanian king Bocchus and the Mauretanian chieftain Igmazen. Both were supporters of respectively Iugurtha and Firmus, but betrayed them and handed them—the one alive, the other dead—over to the Romans.[34]

Seager and Drijvers have shown that Ammianus uses intertextual engagement with Sallust in a similar way to the form of intertextuality discussed in the Introduction.[35] The Firmus episode was not widely reported by contemporaries, and, as in the elevation of Julian, Ammianus provides the only extensive extant narrative account. Ammianus has shaped his telling of an under-reported event 'to connect his own work to the writings of Sallust and Tacitus, and to place himself in the tradition of these great historians of Rome'.[36]

Sallust and Tacitus also supply the only existing examples of a scene-type that we also find in 15.8. Although thus far we have discussed the scene at 15.8 in terms of an imperial elevation, when compared to the sort of occasions in which speeches had occurred in earlier examples of Latin historiography we may also view Constantius' elevation of Julian as a 'failed adoption'.[37] From Constantius' perspective, the elevation of Julian has disastrous consequences; Julian will ultimately rebel against Constantius and accept a proclamation as

[34] Drijvers 2007, 149. 'The grounds for a comparison between Ammianus' narrative of the rising of Firmus and Sallust's account of the Jugurthine War lie primarily not in the existence of close verbal parallels but rather in the basic similarity between the two situations and thematic correspondences which are perhaps too numerous and too exact to be dismissed as sheer coincidence' (Seager 1997b, 7).

[35] While Seager dwells on the Sallustian comparisons, Drijvers also points to some parallels with Tacitus' description of the North African revolt of Tacfarinas in *Annals* 2.52; 3.20–1, 73–4; 4.23–6 (2007, 149–50): both relied on the help of tribes and guerilla warfare; Tacfarinas' and Firmus' brothers were taken prisoner; both authors concentrate on the harsh punishment of deserters; and both protagonists sought death when they knew they would be defeated.

[36] Drijvers 2007, 150.

[37] Baglivi touches on the elevation scene briefly in a book which argues that Ammianus largely reproduces Julianic propaganda, especially that Constantius represents the last stage in the decline of the house of Constantine (1995, 119–21). I argue below that, whereas notable aspects of Julian's interpretation of his elevation are brought into play, they are treated in a distinct way and are not taken over wholesale by Ammianus.

Augustus, contrary to the limited intentions that Constantius sets out for Julian within his speech. Two similar cases are found in Sallust and Tacitus. One of the earliest events in Sallust's *Bellum Iugurthinum* is the adoption of the eponymous anti-hero and enemy of Rome by the Numidian king (*Iug.* 9–10). Micipsa is an enfeebled monarch, who attempts to secure his position by appointing his nephew Jugurtha as his successor because the latter has proved himself by fighting for the Romans under the command of Scipio, and Micipsa thinks his own sons are too young to take power alone. The adoption takes place as a speech scene during which Micipsa speaks in *oratio recta* before Jugurtha and other members of their family.[38] After Micipsa's death, Jugurtha will go on to slay Micipsa's natural sons (with whom he was supposed to share the kingdom) and take Numidia into war with Rome.[39]

The second is Galba's adoption of Piso in the first book of Tacitus' *Histories*. Galba, the successor to Nero, is engaged in trying to shore up his position and legitimacy as the first emperor not to belong to the Julio-Claudian dynasty. Throughout Book 1 Galba is presented by Tacitus as an infirm and outdated emperor, whose republican *severitas* was unpopular among the army and inhabitants of Rome alike.[40] Galba adopts Piso as his heir in an attempt to put an end to the populace's perception of him as an aged ruler (*Hist.* 1.14–17). Tacitus presents Galba's adoption of Piso within a speech scene not unlike that of Ammianus, which contains two speeches, one addressed to the assembled audience and the second directly to the adoptee. Although Piso technically is being adopted rather than promoted to an immediate share in the empire, it is also clear that Galba attempts to use the adoption as a means to shore up his position by associating himself with a younger partner.[41] Piso, like Jugurtha, turns out to be the wrong choice, and proves to be just as unpopular as Galba. Otho will soon have himself proclaimed emperor and both Piso and Galba will be assassinated (*Hist.* 1.40).

[38] The event must also have been covered by Livy, but the periochae do not indicate how he treated this episode in his lost Book 61.

[39] *Iug.* 30ff. Paul 1984, 91.

[40] Tac. *Hist.* 1.5.2. Damon 2003, 105–6. The structure of *Histories* 1, which starts its narrative on 1 January 69, not at the death of Nero and Galba's accession the previous year, 'emphasises Galba's identity as an elderly and outmoded disciplinarian rather than as a liberator' (Ash 1999, 75).

[41] Galba states 'we have long reached such a pass that my old age cannot give more to the Roman people than a good successor, or your youth more than a good emperor' (1.16.1).

The set of thematic parallels between these three texts allows us to evaluate to what degree Ammianus makes use of a dramatized speech scene in a similar way to his predecessors, especially since, given Ammianus' familiarity with the work of both these authors, and his efforts elsewhere to draw thematic comparisons between his work and theirs, these speeches may have provided a template for Ammianus to apply a topos found in earlier Latin historians to the *Res Gestae*. The adopters (Micipsa, Galba, and Constantius) are all negative figures, yet the adoptees Iugurtha and Piso are also in some senses negative; Jugurtha is an *exemplum* of the corrupting effect of Rome and Piso is a non-entity, very much the wrong choice. Julian turns out to be the hero of the *Res Gestae*. Nevertheless, for all the adopters their choice will result in failure as the adoptees will not fulfil the role set out for them in the course of the elevation speech. This provides a complex situation for the narrator: there is an opportunity to place a set of ideals in the mouth of the adopter which reflect each character's conception of an appropriate and legitimate ruler and how he perceives them to be applicable to his chosen adoptee. The contrast between speech and narrative can help corroborate or undermine those views. Similarly the author can choose how to set the adoptee within this nexus of definitions of legitimacy. The depiction of the whole scene can be affected by the narrator's use of forward reference (prolepsis) to the (negative) outcome of the adoption. Furthermore, the audience before whom the speech is delivered can play a role in its interpretation, either simply in terms of their identity (are they the 'right' audience?) or in their reaction.

Before turning to Ammianus, I offer a survey of how Sallust and Tacitus construct their respective scenes, and use the dramatic setting to critique the act of adoption and characterize both adopter and adoptee.

3.2.1 Failed Adoptions in Sallust (*Iug.* 9–10) and Tacitus (*Hist.* 1.12–17)

The overall setting for each speech within both narratives contributes importantly to the interpretation of its content. Particularly, both Sallust and Tacitus use the choice of audience to critique the judgement and argument of the main speaker. Micipsa speaks 'in the presence of his friends and kinsfolk including his sons Adherbal

and Hiempsal' (*Iug.* 9.4).[42] Sallust's inclusion of Micipsa's two sons chimes with the sentiments of family concord in Micipsa's speech (a sentiment which Jugurtha will swiftly dispense with).[43] Galba spoke in front of a group of intimates including the consul designate and the urban prefect, 'a kind of imperial *comitia*, which he regarded as his only remedy' (*Hist.* 1.14.1), whereas the later narrative makes clear that the group who are actually able to corroborate or legitimize such a decision are the soldiers in the Praetorian camp, who will soon appoint Otho (*Hist.* 1.26.1). Galba does go on to make an announcement of the adoption in the camp, but instead of including another *oratio recta* Tacitus reduces it to a brief note, reflecting Galba's dismissive attitude towards the military: 'before a crowded gathering of the soldiers, with the brevity that became an emperor, he announced that he was adopting Piso after the precedent set by the deified Augustus' (*Hist.* 1.18.2). Tacitus has deliberately chosen to place Galba's speech in this enclosed environment, contrary to parallel sources which mentions the speech before Senate and praetorians.[44] Both authors use the audience to create dramatic tension and foreshadow the outcome of the adoption.

Each author also creates a contrast between the circumstances for the adoption and the reasons articulated in the speeches, and uses the contrast to critique the speakers. In Sallust, the events that led to Micipsa's adoption of Jugurtha were a long time in the making, stretching over several years. However, Sallust compresses the timeframe within these three sections (9–11) to use the juxtaposition of an earlier description of Jugurtha's character to undercut the arguments in Micipsa's speech. Sallust's Micipsa is aware of his approaching death, and, Sallust tells us, had earlier received favourable reports about Jugurtha from the Romans. Sallust provides this information immediately before Micipsa's speech (9.3), and the content of the Roman commander Scipio's letter itself is included at 9.2:

> 'Your Jugurtha displayed a virtue beyond all others (*longe maxuma virtus*) in the Numantine war, which I am sure will give you pleasure.

[42] All translations of Sallust are taken from Rolfe 1931.

[43] 'When you were a small boy, Jugurtha, an orphan without prospects or means, I took you into the royal household, believing that because of my kindness you would love me as if you were my own child' (10.1). 'Who is more bound by ties of friendship than brother to brother?' (10.5).

[44] Keitel 2006, 221.

> His services have made him dear to us, and we shall do all we can to make the Roman Senate and People share our opinion of him. As your friend I congratulate you; you have in him a man worthy of yourself (*habes virum dignum te*) and of his grandfather Masinissa.'

Micipsa immediately adopted Jugurtha (*statimque eum adoptavit*), but his speech of endorsement, which validates and explains his decision, and which names Jugurtha as the primary heir to Micipsa, is delayed until some years later (*paucos post annos,* 9.4), although it is the next event to be reported within the narrative.[45] Sallust thus juxtaposes two chronologically distinct events, and this juxtaposition has a direct effect upon the interpretation of Micipsa's actions. Indeed, Scipio's letter reads more like a displaced adoption speech. In it, he outlines three reasons for Micipsa to give Jugurtha a more prominent role in Numidia: Jugurtha's virtues, institutional support by the Senate and People, and reference to a hereditary connection (Masinissa was also Micipsa's father) (9.2).

Micipsa's rhetoric is therefore undermined before he even makes his speech (this is a feature we will find too in Ammianus). Any reference to Jugurtha's virtues now are made to appear like mere repetition of Scipio's judgements, rather than Micipsa's own conclusions. In the speech itself, Micipsa echoes Scipio's praise for Jugurtha, but turns it round to reflect upon himself and suggests his self-interest in his adoption of Jugurtha, 'you covered me and my realm with glory' (*Iug.* 10.2). As noted above, Micipsa's speech makes much of the family ties that Jugurtha will subsequently overturn: 'do not seek to form unions with strangers in preference to keeping your blood relatives close to you' (*Iug.* 10.2). After endorsing a restricted view of Jugurtha's virtues that had been set out by Micipsa, the latter part of the speech provides advice for the future (*Iug.* 10.6):

> 'The throne I bequeath to you and your brothers will stand firm if you conduct yourselves well, but will totter should you behave badly.'

[45] Micipsa died fourteen years after Jugurtha returned from the expedition in Numantia (118 BC, Livy *Per.* 62). Comber and Balmaceda 2009, 196 attribute this startling collapse of the timeframe to 'chronological vagueness', but the opportunity to juxtapose speech and letter appear to be the motivating factor. Micipsa's speech also tries to cover up the delay: Jugurtha has 'lately returned' (*novissime rediens*) from Numantia, which is incongruous even in light of the narrator's *paucos post annos* at 9.4.

This conditional sentence throws down an immediate interpretative crux for the subsequent narrative: it sets out the ramifications of what will happen if Jugurtha chooses to disobey Micipsa's advice. In some ways Micipsa has already been established as a credible interpreter of the events in the narrative: he recognizes, if selectively, Jugurtha's virtues that had been set out by Scipio and he may therefore be viewed as possessing some degree of authority. This then imbues the conditional sentence with the status of a prolepsis of the likely outcome of the adoption in the subsequent narrative.

As in Sallust, Tacitus presents many of Galba's sentiments in his speech as at odds with the surrounding narrative, thus casting them as out of touch or ill-conceived. Galba had come to power by rebelling against Nero, an act that had been recognized and legitimized by the Senate after the latter's death. Tacitus paints a picture of a world still in turmoil at the beginning of the *Histories,*[46] and of Piso as a man too outdated for the current situation: 'his look and manner were those of the ancient school (*moris antiqui*)' (*Hist.* 1.14.2). Galba is also presented as an old-fashioned and enfeebled ruler (*invalidum senem, Hist.* 1.1.6) at variance with the requirements of the time, which is reflected in the choice of epithets with which he labels Piso. They are strangely out of place: 'I have been moved by your high character and patriotism to offer you a man of peace (*quiescenti,* 1.15.1) the principate for which our forefathers fought.' Galba ignores the current need for a martial leader (a role Otho will try to assume).

Galba's speech, however, introduces several potential reasons for elevating Piso. He initially mentions (if only to dismiss it) the personal importance to both Galba and Piso of a union between their families, 'it would have been an honour to me (*mihi egregium erat*) to bring into my house a descendent of Gnaeus Pompey and Marcus Crassus, and a distinction for you to add the glories of the Sulpician and Lutatian houses to your own high rank' (1.15.1). He goes on to maintain that he has been prompted instead 'by your high character and patriotism' (1.15.1). Yet the reference to personal ties so early in the speech insinuates that the thought of personal gain is in fact important to Galba and thus prevents the speech from fulfilling a wider legitimizing role by seeking the consensus of the internal

[46] Especially in the survey of the empire 1.8–11 which precedes the adoption scene.

audience.[47] Galba's choice of figures to associate with Piso (Pompey and Crassus) also reflects his lack of understanding of the situation around him. Equally he advances the concepts of *libertas, aestimatio*, and *consensus* in 1.16.1–2, but there has been no consensus, no request in the senate nor before the troops.[48] Both Sallust and Tacitus, then, undermine the credibility of the adopter by contrasting the content of his speech with the surrounding narrative.

Both Sallust and Tacitus make the adopter the main focus of their scene, particularly by affording direct speech to each. In contrast, neither author allows the adoptee the opportunity to reply with a speech of his own. This removes the opportunity to create a rhetorically paired set of speeches, but each narrator finds other ways to comment on the reaction of the adoptee. In the case of Jugurtha, the narrator undercuts Micipsa's sentiments by instead recording Jugurtha's inner thoughts: 'although Jugurtha knew that the king spoke insincerely (*regem ficta locutum intellegebat*) and though he had very different designs in his own mind, yet he returned a gracious answer, suited to the occasion' (*Iug.* 11.1). We find the adoptee suspicious of the motivations of his adopter (as we shall in Ammianus too). Jugurtha's recorded thought forces the reader to reinterpret the speech and therefore undermines the sincerity of Micipsa's sentiments, and it also points towards the negative outcome of Micipsa's prediction, that the throne will indeed 'totter'.

Tacitus employs a similar method, though with a different resulting characterization for the adoptee. Piso (like Jugurtha) is also denied any direct speech, though he did make a reply (*Hist.* 1.17.1):

> People report (*ferunt*) that Piso gave no sign of anxiety or exaltation, either before those who were looking on at the time or afterward when the eyes of all were upon him. He answered with the reverence due to a father and an emperor; he spoke modestly about himself. There was no change in his look or dress; he seemed like one who had the ability rather than the desire to be emperor.

[47] Which, as has already been mentioned, is restricted to a group of five men, described by Tacitus as a *comitia* in 'a distortion of the constitutional language of the Republic' (Damon 2003, 134).

[48] Galba states that he himself has been appointed emperor *deorum hominumque consensu* (1.15.1), a statement which 'rings hollow after the survey of the growing dissent in ch. 4–11' (Damon 2003, 137). Keitel also observes that 'Tacitus repeatedly alludes to *fides, amicitia, adulatio* and self-interest in the narrative of 1.12–49 and shows the breakdown of traditional values among all groups involved in the struggle for power at Rome' (Keitel 2006, 223).

Tacitus emphasizes the passivity of Piso both by granting only indirect speech, and also by the focalization of the audience who detect no change in him. Jugurtha and Piso are very different adoptees. Jugurtha directly disobeys Micipsa's command to reign alongside his adopted brothers; Piso accepts Galba's adoption if unwillingly. Yet both authors use their response to help reinforce this respective characterization.

This comparison of Sallust and Tacitus reveals the degree to which the dramatization of an elevation or adoption scene may be used to critique the terms under which a new regal or imperial figure is adopted, foreshadow an outcome in the narrative that is quite different from the one which the adopter initially intends, and to characterize both the adopter and the adoptee. Once again, these functions are brought about through the contrast of speech and narrative, and indeed narratorial control over who is allowed to speak. The analysis that follows investigates how (and indeed, whether) Ammianus uses these same techniques to set Julian's elevation scene within the wider narrative, despite the formulaic elements which seem to mark it off from the surrounding text. It focuses on the same features that were of importance to Sallust and Tacitus, namely the setting and context of the speech scene within the wider narrative; how the reasons for Julian's adoption are articulated by the adopter, Constantius, particularly in view with those expressed elsewhere in the scene; and finally how the reaction of both Julian and the assembled audience may comment upon the ideals of legitimacy expressed elsewhere in the scene.

3.2.2 Julian's Adoption—Setting

Ammianus uses a short introductory scene (as both Sallust and Tacitus had done) set within the palace at Milan to introduce the motivation behind Constantius' planned elevation of Julian (15.8.1–4). Two principal concerns are articulated here, that Constantius could not manage the situation in Gaul alone, and that subsequently he should 'adopt [Julian] into the partnership of the empire'. Ammianus had previously offered several descriptions of the mechanism for decision-making at court, which followed a regular pattern whereby Constantius' decisions are heavily influenced by his advisers, as had been the case with the choice to bring down Gallus

and Silvanus.[49] However, here, the pattern is varied. Ammianus begins by presenting the choice as Constantius' decision and allowing a high degree of narratorial privilege to his thoughts. This allows Ammianus to cast Constantius' motivations as self-serving, and an attempt to keep himself from danger ('he thought it risky to thrust himself into a far-distant region', 15.8.1), and so it was better to send Julian instead. During this process of internal deliberation, Constantius' decision to promote Julian is, however, described as *consilium rectum*. The focalization here is ambiguous: the reader is not initially sure whether the definition of this decision as 'right' is merely Constantius' interpretation, or whether this is the endorsement of the narrator.[50] Why this is the 'right' decision is not elaborated by Constantius at this time. Instead the arguments for and against are put by the other members of the court. The palace clique react with formulaic flattery, but also point to the example of Gallus in an attempt to dissuade Constantius: 'several, since the consciousness of their offences pricked them on, added that the title of Caesar ought henceforth to be avoided, rehearsing what had happened under Gallus'. Their sinister role is confirmed by their reinterpretation of Gallus as negative figure, after he had latterly been portrayed as a victim by the primary narrator towards the end of Book 14. The courtiers misuse, or rather misconstrue, the role of Gallus within the narrative.[51] Constantius' choice is endorsed on the other hand by the empress Eusebia (15.8.3):

> To them in their obstinate resistance the queen alone opposed herself, whether she dreaded journeying to a far country or with her native intelligence took counsel for the common good (*consulens in commune*), and she declared that a kinsman (*propinquum*) ought to be preferred to everyone else.

[49] 'There having laid aside the burden of other cares, Constantius began to consider, as his most difficult knot and stumbling-block, how to uproot the Caesar by a mighty effort. And as he deliberated with his closest friends, in secret conference and by night . . . ' (14.11.1); 'Constantius, struck down by the weight of this unexpected mischance [the news of Silvanus' plot] as by a thunderbolt of Fate, called a council at about midnight, and all the chief officials hastened to the palace. And when no one's mind or tongue was equal to showing what ought to be done, mention in subdued tones was made of Ursicinus, as a man conspicuous for his sagacity in the art of war, and one who had been without reason provoked by serious injustice' (15.5.18).

[50] See Chapter 1.2 for 'double focalization'.

[51] Cf. Chapter 2.3 for the positive portrayal of Gallus in Book 14, and Kelly 2008, 287.

This is one of the few moments when Ammianus' narrator admits uncertainty.[52] The narrator claims not to know Eusebia's motivations for certain, though he does limit them to either a self-serving reason akin to her husband's or a more altruistic one.[53] Her two motivations, then, are presented as the interpretation of the narrator as much as they are Eusebia's actual thoughts. The hypothetical reasons neatly allow the narrator to endorse the choice to elevate Julian but at the same time criticize those who make the decision to do so. Constantius is motivated by his personal anxieties about the military situation, but does not recognize (or at least articulate) the parallels with Gallus or indeed what the particular merits of Julian are. The former point is instead mentioned by a group who are systematically characterized as negative forces within the palace, whereas Eusebia's endorsement of Julian is ultimately corroborated as a good choice for the empire as a whole, and she introduces the concept of Julian's appropriateness on dynastic grounds (Julian is a *propinquus*). Her choice, but not necessarily her motivation, is approved of by the narrator.[54]

3.2.3 Reasons for Julian's Adoption—Speech vs. Narrative

Before Constantius delivers his speech, he has already decided to elevate Julian. The speech, then, provides the opportunity to gather a consensus with a wider group of people, in this case the army, whose assent Constantius claims to seek (15.8.8).[55] The opportunity, therefore, allows the reader to compare how he has interpreted the debate between Eusebia and the palace clique when he comes to offer his justification for promoting Julian more publically. Constantius

[52] See Chapter 1.2 for narratorial doubt.

[53] Zosimus' Eusebia is far less ambivalent (and far more sinister): for her Julian's inexperience is a prime qualification and any subsequent success he may have in Gaul could be ascribed to Constantius, whereas his likely death would remove a potential successor (3.1.3).

[54] Ammianus attributes an ambiguous role to Eusebia. On the one hand she had been kind towards Julian at 15.2.8, when she endorsed Julian's wishes to study in Athens. However, she goes on to ensure that Julian does not have children by sabotaging Helena's pregnancies (16.10.19). See further Tougher 2000 and García Ruiz 2008, 54–6 for Ammianus' contradictory depiction of Eusebia, and Wieber-Scariot 1999, 197–285.

[55] Assent of the troops perhaps reflects more long-standing ideals of legitimacy based on *consensus universorum*. For the popularity of *consensus* as a political slogan at the end of the Julio–Claudian dynasty, see Damon 2003, 137.

reiterates his concerns about the barbarian incursions (§7) but elaborates upon this point by claiming that they came about after the 'death of those rebellious tyrants' (15.8.6). Exactly which rebel tyrants Constantius was referring to is not made clear. De Jonge presumed that it must be Maxentius and Magnentius.[56] Sabbah suggests Magnentius and Decentius (the latter the brother or possibly cousin of Magnentius, who was raised to the Caesarship once the former had usurped).[57] All are of course possibilities, though Maxentius is not mentioned by name anywhere in the extant portion of the *Res Gestae*.[58] For the reader of Book 15, the other obvious candidate is Silvanus, who had been branded by the Constantian camp as a *perduellis* (15.5.19) and whose regime Ammianus himself as a participant calls a 'usurpation' (*tyrannis*) (15.5.24).[59] If so, Constantius continues his pejorative reinterpretation of Silvanus' motivations, attributing them to 'madness and fury' (15.8.6), whereas Ammianus has made it clear that Silvanus rebelled only because of fear and a wish for self-preservation. Constantius' reference to Silvanus also complements the direct reference made to Gallus by the courtiers in the first part of the scene. Between the two, Constantius' motivations may be called into question by the reader and the audience alike.

Nevertheless, Constantius presents Julian as the solution to his problems in Gaul, though his terms of commendation are distinctly out of place. Despite the military nature of Julian's new role, there can be no way of recommending the new Caesar for his military achievements thus far; he is still *palliatus* (15.8.1).[60] Instead, in this public section of the speech, Constantius attaches two virtues to Julian: *uerecundia* and *industria* (§8). *Verecundia* is not a commonly used term. The far more canonical ways of referring to modesty are *moderatio, modestia*, or *modus*.[61] *Verecundia* (and its adjectival and

[56] De Jonge 1953, 32; Maxentius (who was killed in 312) is an implausible suggestion.

[57] Galletier and Fontaine 1968, 256. For Decentius, see Bleckmann 1999.

[58] Constantine's propaganda had indeed denounced him as a tyrant (*Pan. Lat.* XII (9).4.4; XII(9).14,5; IV(10).8.3; IV(10).9.4).

[59] Cf. Baglivi 1995, 118 for Constantius' growing sense of tyrannical absolutism up to this point in the narrative.

[60] As Julian himself finds a source of amusement in the *Ep. ad Ath.* as noted above. Cf. Vanderspoel 2013 (discussed in Chapter 1.1) that Julian may have spent more time in 'training' with Constantius than he makes out in the *Ep. ad Ath.*; by extension Ammianus too repeats this Julianic propaganda.

[61] Seager 1986, 2–4.

adverbial forms), by contrast, are used in relation to Constantius; they are part of his vocabulary, not that of the primary narrator, and Ammianus sets up a clear distinction between the two. Constantius applies the term to himself in a speech at 17.13.26, yet the narrator undermines this claim later when he maintains Constantius was 'unlike that revered prince (*principis uerecundi*) Marcus'.[62] *Verecundia* is not a suitable qualification for a military task. *Industria* is a neutral term; it may be applied to morally good or questionable actions.[63] In the second part of the speech, after a brief interruption by the audience, Constantius continues this mislabelling of Julian with two further ill-chosen epithets: 'a young man of quiet strength (*uigoris tranquilli*) whose temperate behaviour (*temperati mores*) is rather to be imitated than proclaimed' (15.8.10). Ammianus had noted in Gallus' death-notice that Julian differed from his brother in *temperatis moribus* as much as Titus did from Domitian (14.11.28), though Constantius and his court were thinking more of the parallels between the two. *Tranquillus* seems a strange attribute with which to commend a new general who, it is hoped, should quell the barbarian uprisings in Gaul.[64] Indeed, Constantius had recently described himself in the only other speech he has given thus far in the extant portion of the text as a *princeps tranquillus* (14.10.15) in order to persuade his troops of his decision *not* to attack up the Alamanni. Later Julian will explicitly define *tranquillitas* and *moderatio* (a kindred virtue to *temperantia*)[65] as virtues fitting for an emperor during times of peace, not war: 'I have seemed in time of peace a mild and self-controlled leader (*moderatus visus sum et tranquillus*).'[66] Constantius is setting Julian up to be the sort of Caesar he initially wished Gallus to be: compliant and obedient. He does not concentrate upon the task that he maintains is the main reason for Julian's elevation.

Furthermore, Constantius promotes the family connections between himself and Julian, reiterating the reasons presented to him by Eusebia; he praises Julian's *uerecundia* 'through which he is as dear to us as through ties of blood (*necessitudine*)' (15.8.8). There is a

[62] 21.16.11. Ammianus observes in Jovian's death notice that *uerecundia* might, had he lived, have corrected the emperor's excessive drinking (25.10.15).

[63] Cf. e.g. 14.7.18 (of those who frame Eusebius and Epigonus) and 16.7.3 (of Julian).

[64] Cf. Tacitus *Hist.* 1.15.1 where Galba uses similar terminology of Piso: *quiescenti*.

[65] Seager 1986, 18.

[66] 21.5.5, Julian's speech on being proclaimed Augustus by his troops.

degree of semantic ambiguity in Constantius' use of this term (Eusebia had simply referred to Julian as a *propinquus*), which picks up on his earlier justification for promoting Julian, the fear that he would 'succumb before so many crises (*necessitatibus*)' (15.8.2). Constantius, then, initially concentrates on Julian's virtues, which have yet to be proved in the narrative, and family ties, which essentially equate to a dynastic policy. The latter point in particular rings somewhat hollow for the primary narratee, who knows that Constantius merely repeats the argument that Eusebia has provided for him (in much the same way as Micipsa reused Scipio's praises of Jugurtha).

Constantius invokes a reaction from the troops in the middle of his speech, at a carefully crafted point in his argument, in which he asks the soldiers for their endorsement (15.8.9).[67] The interruption appears staged, but the soldiery do more than simply shout their assent.[68] They state (in indirect speech) that they believe Julian's elevation is the 'will of the supreme divinity (*arbitrium summi numinis*) rather than of any human mind'.[69] The suggestion contributes a further legitimizing reason for Julian's elevation, and one that chimes with earlier definitions of imperial legitimacy, particularly, as we saw above, during the Tetrarchy.[70] However, the troops' interruption adds a new dimension to Julian's ascendancy, which has not been articulated by any of the protagonists within the narrative, and therefore not by anyone associated with the court. The army at this

[67] Constantius asks whether his suggestion 'may be confirmed also by your assent'. (15.8.8). O'Brien 2002, 265, notes that the interruption here and in Valentinian's speech adopting Gratian 'are made at points in the speeches following complete periods and well-rounded arguments'. Each occasion, and that at 14.10.15 (for which see n.26), allows these speeches to seem deliberative.

[68] The interruption assumes a formulaic role when it is repeated at the elevation of Gratian at 27.6.10–11. There, however, the soldiers merely agree with Valentinian.

[69] Rike 1987, 31 argues that the '*numen* can only have been intended by Ammianus to represent a genuine deity'. Whether or not Ammianus believed in the 'deity' it certainly performs a useful narratological purpose: some characters can discern it whereas others have more difficulty in doing so. O'Brien notes that there is an intertext here with Virgil. The troops interrupt 'as if with foreknowledge of the future (*uelut praescia uenturi*)'; Aeneas addresses the Sybil as *O sanctissima vates, praescia venturi* (*Aen.* 6.65). O'Brien 2006, 284 concludes that Ammianus 'objectifies the legitimacy of Julian's Caesareate by underscoring its predestination and divine sanction'.

[70] MacCormack 1981, 169. Galba alludes, incorrectly, to his own position as the result of the consensus of gods and men. See n.48.

stage is an anonymous group, without any strong characterization,[71] yet the point is taken up by Constantius who works the new divine element into the conclusion of his speech: 'therefore with the immediate favour of the God of Heaven (*praesente nutu dei caelestis*) I will invest him with the imperial robes' (15.8.10).

Constantius concludes the public scene by addressing a speech directly to Julian, in which he makes grandiose claims about their future cooperation, and in which Constantius returns to the theme of dynastic appropriateness and downplays the role of the gods, now that he does not address the army (15.8.12, 14):

> You have received in your prime the glorious flower of your origin (*originis tuae splendidum florem*); with increase of my own glory (*aucta gloria mea*), I admit, since I seem to myself more truly great in bestowing almost equal power on a noble prince who is my kinsman (*nobilitati mihi propinquae*), than through that power itself . . . together we shall rule over a pacified world, provided only God grants our prayers (*deus modo uelit, quod oramus*), with equal moderation and conscientiousness (*pari moderatione pietateque*).

Constantius' speech, then, follows a similar pattern to both Micipsa's and Galba's. Like Micipsa and Galba, Constantius also dwells on his personal benefit and glory brought by the adoption,[72] and then goes on to make predictions about the future. Of course, no reader in the 390s could be unaware that Julian would go on to rebel, undermining Constantius' sentiments of cooperation, but the series of parallels with the other examples of the 'failed adoption' topos reinforce the point and may also suggest that Constantius, like Micipsa, 'spoke falsely'. The divine element has been reinterpreted by Constantius so that Julian's elevation is no longer the certain decree of the *supremum numen* but far more conditionally dependent on the potential help of a *deus*. Julian's future breaking of these terms perhaps has been given a divine sanction here at the moment of his elevation; Constantius' and Julian's joint rule was not what the god wanted.[73]

[71] O'Brien (2013b, 236) believes that 'Ammianus uses the voice of the crowd to validate his own belief in Julian's divine favor'. But such a judgement ignores the sequence of the narrative, in which the primary narrator has not yet expressed any such belief.

[72] Cf. *meque regnumque meum gloria honoravisti* (*Iug.* 10.2); *mihi egregium erat* (*Hist.* 1.15.1).

[73] The last event in the chapter offers a final neat prolepsis of Julian's divine endorsement in a form different from that imagined by Constantius: an old woman

3.2.4 The Role of the Adoptee and the Response of the Audience

Throughout the scene, Julian has repeatedly been cast as a passive figure. His first mention, in the introductory section, is focalized through Constantius' view of his cousin as 'still wearing his student's cloak (*etiamtum palliatus*)' (15.8.1), a term that seems ill-suited for a future ruler.[74] The use of this item of clothing to denote his position at this stage in the narrative also serves to underline the incongruity of his subsequent enrobing in a purple cloak by Constantius at the end of Constantius' public address (15.8.10), where Julian is *submaestus* in direct contrast to the joy expressed by the army. Julian's only action at the conclusion of Constantius' speech is to utter one line, and that not of his own composition but a quotation from the *Iliad* with which Julian expresses his unwillingness via another reference to the imperial office in terms of the cloak he now wears, 'by purple death I'm seized and fate supreme (ἔλλαβϵ πορφύρϵος θάνατος καὶ μοῖρα κραταιή)' (15.8.17).[75] Julian's allusive quotation and his countenance are suggestive of the practice of *recusatio imperii,* which Julian himself had articulated in the *Letter to the Athenians,* and had been echoed by Libanius. The 'staged' refusal had been a mainstay of imperial politics from Augustus onwards.[76] However, whereas earlier authors often set the refusal in a dramatic context, allowing the adoptee to state his refusal openly often to test the enthusiasm of the audience,[77] here Ammianus alludes to the practice but removes its dramatic potential.[78] Only the primary narratee is aware of his unwillingness. Furthermore, *recusatio* in the fourth through to the fifth centuries was often deployed by emperors who lacked dynastic

in Vienne spontaneously 'cried out that [Julian] would repair the temples of the Gods (*deorum templa*)' (15.8.22).

[74] Though useful for Julianic propaganda, Vanderspoel 2013, 327.

[75] *Iliad* 5.33. Galletier and Fontaine 1968, 258. The only other ancient author who mentions Julian's quotation is John of Antioch, fr. 176 (Mariev), fr. 263 (Roberto). He adds an explanation that Julian thought specifically of Gallus' fate here, whereas Ammianus, in comparison, leaves Julian's objection in the abstract.

[76] Huttner 2004, 160–295. It also appears in panegyric, e.g. *Pan. Lat.* II (12).11.1–12.2, VII(4).8.36 and VI(7).11.1–6, and Symm. *Or.* 1.10.

[77] E.g. Tiberius in Velleius 2.124.2, Maximinus in Herodian 6.8.6, and numerous times in the *HA*. Béranger 1953, 139–40 provides a complete list of public *recusationes* in the literary sources from the imperial period.

[78] It is therefore not such a neat fit with the 'tropic conventions of Roman *recusatio*' as O'Brien 2013b, 237 presumes.

claims to power.[79] By alluding to the practice of *recusatio*, Ammianus' Julian may also be counteracting the dynastic argument being put forward by Constantius, but in the setting of this scene, again, only the primary narratee, and not Constantius or the army, is allowed to witness Julian's resistance to Constantius' arguments.

Julian's position stands in direct contrast with the army, who eagerly support Constantius' decision and whose joy counteracts Julian's gloominess. Ammianus uses their focalization to force a reassessment of the downcast adoptee (15.8.16):

> Gazing long and earnestly on his eyes, at once terrible and full of charm, and on his face attractive in its unusual animation, they divined what manner of man he would be, as if they had perused those ancient books (*uelut scrutatis ueteribus libris*), the reading of which discloses from bodily signs the inward qualities of the soul. And that he might be regarded with the greater respect, they neither praised him beyond measure nor less than was fitting, and therefore their words were esteemed as those of censors (*censores*), not of soldiers.

This passage is remarkable for the style of criticism it presents. The physical description of an imperial figure is the usual preserve of the primary narrator, and frequently not within the narrative proper, but within the regular and formulaic death notices assigned to each imperial character.[80] On those occasions, Ammianus observes the theory expounded here by 'those ancient books' that good looks cohere with a morally good character, as we had seen in the example of Gallus at the end of Book 14, and will do again at the deaths of the subsequent emperors in the *Res Gestae*.[81] The image that is now applied to these previously rowdy soldiers, of dutiful scholars, who have researched the theory of moral physiognomy, is rather incongruous, and indeed helps align them further with the portrayal of the primary narrator.[82] Thus the primary narratee can trust their proleptic judgement of Julian's future character. That we should view their

[79] Dovere 1996.

[80] Pomeroy 1991, 243 notes that Ammianus' death notices exhibit a 'strong interest in physiognomy' in contrast to those of earlier historians.

[81] See Chapter 2.3.

[82] In the subsequent chapter Timagenes will be praised during the digression on Gaul (a typical place for the narrator to show off his reading and knowledge of earlier authors) as a true Greek on account of his scholarship: 'he collected out of various books (*collegit ex multiplicibus libris*) these facts that had been long forgotten', an activity not unlike that contained in this simile (15.9.12).

role more as skilled judges rather than crude soldiers is confirmed by the final (and again, incongruous) comparison of them to ancient censors (an office that had disappeared in Domitian's day).[83] Between the references to 'ancient books' and the censors, the critique of Julian is noticeably archaizing. If the ceremonial and the definitions of legitimacy advanced in the speech were reflective of the late antique practices, the concluding frame places Julian in a far longer continuum of imperial rule.

3.3 LEGITIMIZING JULIAN

Of the legitimizing elements advanced in this scene, the dynastic argument, that Julian deserved to be emperor because of his relationship to Constantius and the family he represents, is presented by two figures, Eusebia and Constantius, whose motivations are shown to be questionable.[84] The other, far more potent reason, that Julian has been elevated through the choice of the *supremum numen* is advanced by the far more neutral body of the soldiery. Yet the primary narrator subtly endorses and promotes their interpretation towards the end of the scene by the use of focalization (the troops assess Julian in the same way as the primary narrator elsewhere) and through their characterization as skilled judges rather than boisterous troops.

It is only by the dramatization of the scene and the use of *oratio recta* that Ammianus allows these several different legitimizing factors to enter into discussion, then to be promoted or undermined by the wider presentation of the character who articulates them. Like Micipsa, Constantius' motivations are undercut because they are not his own, rather they have been previously suggested by other characters and adopted only second-hand by him; like Galba, the terminology that Constantius uses to promote Julian is inconsonant with the situation around him. As in both Sallust and Tacitus, Ammianus'

[83] Den Boeft et al. 2005, 130, *contra* O'Brien 2013b, 234, n.42.

[84] O'Brien is not right to note that after the preliminary scene in which Eusebia suggests Julian on account of his family relations with Constantius, 'the dynastic recommendation for Julian's elevation is not stressed' (2013b, 233); it is raised again in Constantius' address directly to Julian (15.8.12).

speech scene makes references to the potential break-down of the terms under which the junior figure is promoted by the senior. In representing Julian's elevation in this historiographical format, Ammianus reworks existing expressions of Julian's legitimacy into a distinct hierarchy. Ammianus chooses not to avoid the dynastic element, but discredits it by placing it solely in the mouth of Constantius and the palace party, and by making the latter introduce the (misinterpreted) example of Gallus.[85] Ammianus adds the concept of divine endorsement, which had been absent from the other accounts, even from Libanius'. On the one hand, this form of legitimacy chimed with earlier concepts of sanctioned elevation, but it also allowed Ammianus to downplay Julian's dependence on Constantius for his position, and makes the whole scene, therefore, look forward to the moment that Julian is proclaimed Augustus in Book 20. It can be no accident that Ammianus allows the army to articulate this divine endorsement here. As has been noted above, it is not just that they provide another reason to support Julian's elevation, but they themselves have been established as a more credible interpreter of Julian's legitimacy than Constantius himself (who merely responds to the suggestions of others). The elevation scene, then, paves the way for the far more important event in Book 20 when the army alone, without the presence (and against the will) of Constantius, unilaterally declare Julian Augustus.[86]

These acclamations and claims to legitimacy swirl round the figure of Julian. Other than the brief quotation of Homer, he remains disengaged from the events surrounding him. Yet his use of the quotation does more than merely reflect the tradition of *recusatio imperii*.[87] As Julian's first act within the narrative of the *Res Gestae*, it sets him up as noticeably Greek. He does not even speak the same language as those around him. Not only is Julian's first act to speak in Greek, his choice of quotation corroborates his presentation in this chapter as a *palliatus,* well-versed in Greek literature, but not yet the

[85] As we saw earlier (Section 3.1), Julian had downplayed the dynastic argument in the *Letter to the Athenians.* Ammianus goes further in discrediting it by associating it with Constantius as he will do elsewhere by presenting it as Procopius' principal claim to the throne (26.6.18). O'Brien 2013b, 236.

[86] A point discussed in more depth at the end of Chapter 4.

[87] Huttner 2004, 266 rightly notes that if Ammianus had granted Julian a full and openly expressed *recusatio,* it would have undermined the credibility of Julian's Caesarship.

ways of war.[88] The quotation, however, is a Homeric formula applied to the death of heroes in battle.[89] Julian thus proleptically hints at his coming martial role, and indeed, to his death, fighting with his army in Persia. His entrance into the text is teleologically linked with his exit, and from the outset we are invited to track his progress between the two in light of literary precedents (in a ring composition with the adoption scene, Julian's Persian invasion is perfused with epicizing motifs).[90] Ammianus swiftly overlays this quotation, however, with one of his own, declaring in the voice of the primary narrator 'as the lofty bard of Mantua said of old "a greater work I undertake, a greater train of events arises before me"'.[91] The quotation is used to close the elevation scene and introduce a lengthy excursus on Gaul. The presentation of Julian here and the pair of quotations reveal the nature of Ammianus' project: to explain the career of a figure who was Greek by education and upbringing within a Roman literary framework. Ammianus does not deny or downplay Julian's Greek heritage, but it is notable that this most blatant exposition of his 'Greekness' in terms of his learning is utilized to demonstrate his lack

[88] And thus Julian may seem to acquiesce to Constantius' command to be *tranquillus*. O'Brien 2006, 280.

[89] The formula is used to describe the death of Hypsenor (*Il.* 5.83), Cleobulus (*Il.* 16.334), and Echeclus (*Il.* 20.477). This may even be a form of window-allusion: Diogenes Laertius reports that Diogenes the Cynic quoted this line upon spotting a man stealing a purple robe (*VS* 6.57) and Athenaeus reports the story of a Chian philosopher called Theocritus who quotes the same line when he finds out that the Chians have been commissioned to produce a purple fabric for Alexander the Great (*Deipnosophists* 12.540a). The ability to quote this line when confronted with purple clothing seems to be the mark of a philosopher, and therefore may also be a reference to Julian's philosophical training in Athens. Given the widespread use of this quotation, it cannot be concluded that Eunapius 'undoubtedly knew the story' of Julian uttering the line (Cameron 2011, 677) when he makes Ablabius allude to 'purple death' at his execution on the orders of Constantius (*VS.* 6.3.13).

[90] Though O'Brien does not propose this interpretation of the quotation directly, he does state that Julian 'has become an exile of fate, genuinely unsure what the future holds for him' 2006, 281. Ammianus hints at what that future is, however. For epic allusions in the Persian expedition, see Smith 1999, 81–5, yet for Ammianus' Romanization of Julian on that campaign, see Chapter 5.

[91] 15.9.1 *ut Mantuanus uates praedixit excelsus /opus moueo maius/maiorque mihi rerum nascitur ordo*, cf. Virgil *Aeneid* 7.44–5 *maior rerum mihi nascitur ordo | maius opus moueo.* Matthews 1989, 468 notes the appropriateness of the application of an allusion to Aeneas' arrival in Italy to Julian's arrival in Gaul, though mainly as a structural marker, an 'introduction to the heroic military exploits upon which Julian, and Ammianus, are about to embark' than a comment on the evolution of Julian. Cf. MacCormack 1998, 21 n.66.

of preparation for his new position as Caesar. Legitimacy and suitability are constructed on different grounds, and articulated through a far more Roman type-scene, which had been established within earlier examples of Latin historiography.

Ammianus uses a recognizable feature of historiography, the staged speech scene, to combine different existing interpretations of Julian's accession and present his own definition of Julian's legitimacy to rule. He also sets in place an interpretative programme for a subsequent important moment in Julian's career, his proclamation as Augustus. This scene has been focused on establishing Julian's potential to rule. In the subsequent books that potential is realized, and once again it is realized through Ammianus' deployment of some of the typical elements of historiography.

4

Strasbourg

Legitimizing Julian

At the beginning of Book 17, in the aftermath of the battle of Strasbourg during which Julian's army defeated a huge force of Alamanni in 357, Julian buries the Roman dead (17.1.1):

> He took care to keep birds of prey from devouring the bodies of the slain and he gave orders that they should all be buried without distinction.

Julian has changed dramatically from the hesitant *palliatus* of two books earlier. By burying the dead, Julian here fulfils a historiographical topos of the exemplary general, perhaps best illustrated by Germanicus' mission in the aftermath of the Varus disaster, narrated by Tacitus in *Annals* 1.[1] Furthermore, in Book 17 Ammianus corroborates the view of Julian as a 'good' general, by referring to Julian as a 'young warrior' (*Martius iuvenis*, 17.1.1). During the battle itself, however, Julian acts in a far from exemplary way. A pre-battle speech to his troops fails to convince them to do what he wants. This chapter will examine how Ammianus allows Julian to reach this point at the beginning of Book 17 so soon after his appointment as Caesar and in spite of the curious role allotted to Julian during the battle in Book 16.

[1] Tacitus *Ann.* 1.61.1 and 62.1 (discussed in Chapter 1.3). Vitellius is condemned at Cremona for failing to do the morally appropriate act (Woodman 1979, 147). Instead he 'never turned away his eyes or showed horror at the sight of so many citizens deprived of the right of burial' (*tot milia insepultorum civium*) *Hist.* 2.70. Ash notes that 'even Hannibal at Cannae buried the Roman dead' (Livy 22.52.6, Sil. It. *Pun.* 10.558–75) (2007, 275) but not before despoiling them (he is therefore a good, but not morally impervious general); cf. Pagán 1999, 307.

It will also argue that Strasbourg is important for Ammianus' assessment of Julian's developing character at this stage in the narrative, and particularly that aspects of the episode establish a framework for justifying his acclamation as Augustus in Book 20.

4.1 BETWEEN CONTEMPORARY SOURCES AND CLASSICAL TRADITION

In the year that followed Julian's elevation, both Caesar and Augustus campaigned simultaneously against German tribes along the Rhine and Danube. The rebellions of Magnentius and Silvanus had left the Gallic provinces in disarray, a situation that the German tribes, particularly the Alamanni, exploited to make incursions into Roman territory along the Rhine border. Julian retook Cologne in 356, then in the following season moved southward towards Strasbourg, where his army met and defeated a much larger force of Alamanni as it crossed the Rhine (16.11–12). It was an important but not decisive victory, as the narrative of subsequent battles against the Alamanni in 358 confirms (17.1–3, 8–10). Constantius in the meantime was further to the East in Raetia. Ammianus does not present his reader with a balanced account of a Roman strategy that must have been designed to rely upon Julian's cooperation with Constantius. As Barnes has noted, Ammianus neglects to mention Constantius' Raetian campaign in 356 in its proper place, instead referring to it only retrospectively within the narrative of Strasbourg (16.12.15–16).[2] Indeed, Ammianus' choice of which episodes to concentrate on and which to downplay extends also to the presentation of Julian. The recapture of Cologne involved Julian remaining there 'until he had overawed the Frankish kings and lessened their pugnacity' (16.3.2), but the whole event is narrated in a single sentence. The literary set-piece is reserved for Strasbourg.

Unlike Julian's elevation, which we have examined in the previous chapter, the battle of Strasbourg had already received detailed narrative treatment and held a particularly strong position in discourse on Julian by the 380s. Significantly, the first narrative account was

[2] Barnes 1998, 151.

penned by Julian himself. Although his text is now lost, its existence caused something of a dilemma for later authors, and prompted a methodological statement from Eunapius (fr. 17 (Blockley)):

> This expedition (τῆς δὲ στρατείας) [Julian's war against the Alamanni] was more violent and famous than the earlier ones. Although I am including an account of it in this work, I shall not be persuaded to act like those who hold up torches in the middle of the day to find something hidden. And since Julian, who was most royal even in eloquence, devoted the whole of a short work (βιβλίδιον ὅλον) to this battle (τῇ μάχῃ) and narrated the events perfectly well and with esteem for his own noble actions, I shall not set next to his work and publish another account that covers the same ground. Rather, I shall urge those who want to behold the greatness (τὸ μέγεθος) of his words and deeds <to read> his own book about these events and to turn to the splendour (τὴν ἀκτῖνα) of what he himself wrote. That splendour proceeded from the actual deeds he performed at the time, and it then shone upon his forceful narrative. I myself shall discuss the events in question briefly, adding what follows to them; for I am constructing and shaping my account, not in youthful and sophistic rivalry (ἅμιλλαν), but with a view to historical accuracy.

Eunapius addresses a problem he faced in writing an account of the same episode to which Julian himself had dedicated a monograph, yet at the same time deftly manages to praise Julian for both his military and literary capabilities. Eunapius draws attention to the historiographical convention that to narrate the same event as an earlier historian was to engage in an exercise of *aemulatio,* and thereby make a claim to improve in some way the predecessor's version.[3] By openly drawing attention to the existence of the *biblidion* and this historiographical problem, Eunapius instead manages to defer to the quality of Julian's writing and recognizes (and praises) his historical accuracy. In doing so, however, Eunapius also demonstrates the special status that Julian's work held in relation to his *History*. Elsewhere Eunapius is generally open about his sources in a way that Ammianus is not; for instance, he had earlier acknowledged his reliance upon a specially written account by Julian's doctor,

[3] Often the later historian claimed to write in an unbiased fashion or to contribute more accurate information than his predecessor. Marincola 1997, 115–16, with examples: Pol. 1.14.1–9; Arr. *Anab. proem.* 2; Jos. *BJ* 1.2; Tac. *Ann.* 1.1.2.

Oribasius, at the opening of his narrative of Julian's reign.[4] Referring to Oribasius' eyewitness testimony allowed Eunapius to construct authority for his own account.[5] Julian's *biblidion* could have provided a similar source: a text by an eyewitness, which Eunapius could have incorporated into his *History*. Oribasius, of course, was not the central focus of this portion of his work, unlike Julian, whose reign Eunapius introduces as an 'age of sweetness and gold' (fr. 15).[6] The ways in which Eunapius refers to the works of both Oribasius and Julian make claims about their availability and the narratee's familiarity with them, but the works of Julian, the hero of Eunapius' history, called for special treatment: even if Oribasius' work was written as a resource for other historians as well as Eunapius, it was suitable nonetheless to be taken over and worked into the latter's *History,* whereas Julian's *biblidion* was at the very least accessible, if not in wide circulation, and perhaps already known to his narratee.[7] Eunapius openly creates and draws attention to a lacuna in his *History,* which he demonstrates can only be filled by Julian's *biblidion,* and thus he reduces this section of his narrative to a paratext to Julian's work, commenting on it, praising it, but not over-writing it.[8]

Eunapius' approach was not adopted by Ammianus. Instead, Ammianus narrates the battle of Strasbourg on a scale that marks the episode out as a set-piece without any reference to a parallel

[4] This fragment of Eunapius (fr. 15 (Blockley)) is the only testimonium to Oribasius' work on Julian. Eunapius' phraseology does not make it clear whether Oribasius' *ὑπόμνημα* was written exclusively for Eunapius' use: 'he composed a very accurate memoir of [Julian's] deeds for use in writing (*πρὸς τὴν γραφήν*), he knew about all those deeds since he was present when they were done'. However, Eunapius certainly emphasizes that he wrote about Julian at Oribasius' behest. See Penella's commentary in *BNJ* 221, *contra* Fornara 1991, 3.

[5] By maintaining that he writes his history at the request of a friend, Eunapius also fulfils another topos of historiography, Marincola 1997, 52.

[6] Although Oribasius seems to have appeared also as a character, fr. 28.2.

[7] Paschoud's suggestion (1971, l) that Ammianus too saw Oribasius' *ὑπόμνημα* is not as outrageous as some have made out (e.g. Cameron 2011, 677 n.111), but how important an influence it could have had on Ammianus' far more expansive (and, as I argue throughout this book, idiosyncratic) narrative is more difficult to discern.

[8] Libanius had earlier demonstrated a similar attitude to the *biblidion*, using it in 362 to praise Julian as both general and author and deferring to its existence to justify not talking in detail about Julian's Gallic campaign (*Or.* 13.25–6). He would later describe the battle of Strasbourg in detail in his *Epitaphius* to Julian (*Or.* 18.31–69), though he makes no reference to the *biblidion,* which some, nevertheless, have supposed was his source, Blockley 1977, 223; Rosen 2006, 148. For the concept of the paratext, see Genette 1997.

tradition. He is willing to praise Julian elsewhere for the 'undefiled elegance and dignity of his speeches and letters (*orationum epistularumque*)' (16.5.7), but it is notable that neither *oratio* or *epistula* could correctly define the *biblidion*.[9] Otherwise, Ammianus does disclose his direct knowledge of some of Julian's works, naming the *Misopogon* (22.14.2)[10] and the (now lost) *Letter to the Romans* (21.10.7),[11] but these are notable for not providing the same sort of historical narrative that could stand in parallel to that of the *Res Gestae*.[12] Ammianus maintains a sense of independence and detachment from Julian's textual record. Indeed, the only textual account of Strasbourg that Ammianus openly engages with was composed, according to Ammianus, by the suspicious and hostile Constantius (16.12.70):

> In short, there are extant statements filed among the public records (*in tabulariis publicis*) of this emperor, <in which ostentatious>[13] reports are given of his boasting and exalting himself to the sky. When this battle was fought near Strasbourg, although he was distant forty days' march, in his description of the fight he falsely asserts that he arranged the order of battle, and stood among the standard-bearers, and drove the barbarians headlong, and that Chnodomarius was brought to him, saying nothing (oh, shameful indignity!) of the glorious deeds (*gloriosis*

[9] The most appropriate Latin term for Julian's work may have been *Commentarii*.

[10] Though perhaps not fully understanding the circumstances of its composition (or choosing to misrepresent them), but suggesting the *Misopogon* provoked the Antiochenes' attacks upon Julian, rather than being a response to them (22.14.2). Den Boeft et al. 1995, 241; Van Hoof and Van Nuffelen 2011, 178; Célérier 2013, 109 has identified a single allusion to the *Misopogon* in the *Res Gestae*.

[11] For which, see Chapter 1.3.

[12] Ammianus, then, certainly knew more of Julian's works than those he names directly: he also makes allusions to the panegyric to Eusebia (15.8.14∼*Or*. 3.123B. Pighi 1936, 60), the first panegyric to Constantius (16.10.8∼*Or*. 1.37C. first noted by Lindenbrog 1609 *ad loc*.; cf. Sabbah 1978, 306–8), and the *Caesares* (23.5.17∼*Caes*. 313B, Kelly 2008, 213). It is notable that Ammianus does not include any direct reference to the works where Julian openly praises Constantius or his family; any such reference to the panegyrics would have compromised Ammianus' presentation of Julian as an innocent and unwilling member of the Constantian dynasty. Célérier has recently suggested that Ammianus rarely referred to Julian's works, and when he did, he did so indirectly; though Célérier's suggestion that Ammianus was writing for two audiences, one Christian and Latin, who would not understand the allusions, and another, Hellenophone and Pagan, who would, presumes too clear-cut a distinction between the linguistic abilities of pagans and Christians in the West. Célérier 2013, 105–204.

[13] *in quibus ambitiose* is Valesius' addition (and not the erroneous *ambitione* printed in the apparatus of Seyfarth's Teubner edition). See Galletier and Fontaine 1968, 188.

> *actibus*) of Julian, which he would have buried in oblivion, had not fame (*fama*) been unable to suppress his splendid exploits (*res maximas*), however much many people would have obscured them.

The situation is a neat reversal of what we found in Eunapius. Ammianus does engage in *aemulatio,* and he does so formulaically by suggesting that he improves on the interpretation of an earlier account. However, that earlier tradition is not connected with Julian. Indeed, the final sentence particularly excludes the entire Greek tradition, not just the *biblidion* but also Libanius' lengthy description of the battle in *Or.* 18. It leaves Ammianus' version standing defiantly in opposition to only one hostile textual tradition situated in Rome and, because it was an administrative document, written in Latin.[14]

By choosing to write about Strasbourg at length, in Latin, and without any reference to contemporary narrative accounts, Ammianus once again fits a major episode of the discourse on Julian into a notably Latin historiographical form.[15] Military content is a factor common to all Roman historians, but the use of military narrative often contributes to the wider structuring of individual works.[16] For the authors of *Commentarii* and monographs such as Caesar and Sallust, war itself was the determining factor in the arrangement of their material. In Caesar's case particularly, military success is the

[14] The *tabularii publici* presumably are documents held in the Tabularium in the Forum Romanum. The Tabularium was built in the first century BC to house administrative documents and was in continuous use till the late empire (Posner 1972, 172–80; Mura Sommella 1999, 17–20). For Ammianus' possible use of imperial documents, see Sabbah 1978, 184–7. Brodka 2009, 54 suggests there may be a veiled critique of Aurelius Victor here, who attributes Julian's victory to Constantius' *fortuna* and *consilium* (42.18). If this is so, Ammianus exaggerates Victor's interpretation, which otherwise recognizes Julian's role as commander at Strasbourg.

[15] Both Eutropius and Jerome also refer to Strasbourg and show an awareness that the battle played a key role in establishing Julian's career. Eutropius notes that Julian 'with only a modest force, destroyed vast numbers of Alamanni' (*ingentes Alamannorum copiae extinctae sunt*, 10.14.1), whereas Jerome appears to adapt Eutropius' version and downplay Julian's achievement: 'A great hoard of the Alamanni (*magnae Alamannorum copiae*) was overwhelmed (*oppressae*) by the Caesar Julian at the Gallic town of Strasbourg' (240g). The German forces are now merely *oppressae* rather than Eutropius' *extinctae*, and the comparatively small amount of Roman casualties is not mentioned. Ratti suggests that 'It is possible that Jerome has sought to minimize the merits of a pagan emperor' (1997, 484).

[16] In contrast to the stance of other contemporary historigraphical genres, particularly ecclesiastical historiography, that feel the need to offer an apologia for the inclusion of political and military actions. Sozomen *HE* 5 pref. 1–3 cf. Leppin 2003, 238ff.

primary virtue of his self-representation. Within the genre of historiography proper, warfare could still be used to determine organization of material. For Livy, battles and wars themselves became the dominant factor in the arrangement of the early books of the *Ab Urbe Condita* into pentads and decades.[17] The duration and outcome of the war, not the biographical aspects of the general, are what determine the structure of Livy's narrative. Suetonius, by contrast, bemoans the pervasive role of militarism in early Rome, and even blames it for the late development of the study of grammar (*de Gramm.* 1.1). He sets war up as the antithesis of textual study, a position to be reversed by historians, who reduce war to text.

Mommsen famously described Tacitus as the 'most unmilitary of all authors'.[18] By the early imperial period, military activity on the borders of the empire had not decreased, but emperors tended to reside in Rome and claim the credit for the victories of their generals.[19] Tacitus exploited these changed military conventions to suggest that the emperors 'were no longer running the Empire according to the canon of military glory'.[20] Despite Mommsen's criticisms, Tacitus in the *Annals* made use of battles and campaigns to punctuate the reigns of his emperors, such as the activities of the generals Germanicus in Germany in *Annals* 1 and 2 and Corbulo in Mesopotamia in 13–15.[21] Tacitus exploits the ideal established in Sallust and Livy that military activity was a morally appropriate thing for the consul/ruler to undertake; by drawing attention to the successful campaigns of the emperor's generals on the periphery of the empire, he criticizes the unmilitary nature of several of his imperial characters. He even goes as far as to suggest that the narration of war is easy, even essential material for good historiography, contrasting the 'mighty wars, stormings of cities, routed and captured kings' of 'the writings of those who compiled the affairs of the Roman people of old' with his own work, which 'is confined and inglorious: peace was immovable or only modestly challenged, affairs of the city

[17] Stadter 2009, 94–6. [18] Mommsen 1919, 5.165 n.1.

[19] Mattern (1999, 10–12) notes that the ultimate responsibility for going to war still resided with the emperor and that, under Vespasian, Caesennius Paetus in 72 wrote to the emperor asking permission to invade the kingdom of Commagene. Not asking permission still constituted an offence punishable by death. Cf. Campbell 2002, 9, and Josephus *BJ* 7.220–5.

[20] Levene 2009, 231. [21] Levene 2009, 226.

were sorrowful, and the princeps indifferent to extending the empire' (*Ann.* 4.32).[22] Bad emperors, in Tacitus' view, are those who do not pursue wars.[23]

Unlike the emperors of Tacitus' period, the fourth-century *Augusti* were primarily military commanders, personally responsible for maintaining the *limes* of the empire. Since the Tetrarchy in the late third century, the *Augusti* and *Caesares* had forsaken the ancient capital of Rome for centres of command closer to the flashpoints of external threats, whether from across the Rhine or Danube, or from Persia in the East. The renewed convergence of the role of political leader and military commander in the form of the late Roman emperor (more akin to the figures described by Sallust, Caesar, and Livy than Tacitus) did not prompt Ammianus to promote warfare as his prime organizational unit. Instead, the *Res Gestae* often oscillates between warfare and the emperor as the prime structuring factor. Gallus, as we have seen, determines the structure of the first extant book, whereas the Battle of Hadrianople does so for the final.[24] The two combine most completely in the triad of Books 23–25 (the second half of a hexad on Julian's reign 20–25), which is both a monograph-like narrative of the Persian campaign of 363, yet also the culminating portion of Julian's reign.[25]

The syncopation of these two organizational principles serves to underline the role that performance on the battlefield holds as a core method of judging any given emperor. Constantius, for example, as already noted, is constantly criticized by several characters or groups within the narrative for being the wrong sort of successful general:

[22] Trans. Woodman 2004. Tacitus, in essence, comments that a 'kind of stagnation which the Principate induced affected the subject matter of history', Clarke 2002, 93. Tacitus here also plays with some of the conventions of historiographic prefaces, which should see the historian claim superiority over his predecessors, Martin and Woodman 1989, 169.

[23] Nevertheless, Tacitus also problematizes war and imperial expansion, perhaps most famously in the speech allotted to Calgacus in the *Agricola* (30). In the same text he also presents the abandonment of warfare as a key stage in the subjugation of 'barbarian' societies *Agr.* 21. Sailor 2012, 31.

[24] Kulikowski 2012 argues that Ammianus originally wrote a monograph in Greek on the Battle of Hadrianople, which he subsequently incorporated as the final book into the Latin *Res Gestae*. His theory would suggest an author who started his literary career by viewing warfare, rather than the emperor, as his main organizational principle.

[25] Barnes 1998, 34–9 for the detailed composition of these books.

successful in civil rather than external conflict.[26] This is in contrast to Constantius' self-presentation as shown by the numismatic record where he is often presented in image and text as the pious protector of the Roman state.[27]

At Julian's elevation in Book 15, Ammianus emphasizes Julian's lack of military experience and unpreparedness for his role as Caesar. Book 16 is our introduction to Julian as a successful military commander against foreign enemies, which, therefore, sets him up as antithesis to Constantius. Structurally, the book builds up to the lengthy description of Julian's greatest success as his time as Caesar or Augustus, the defeat of the Alamanni at Strasbourg in 357. As most commentators have noted, Ammianus' description of Strasbourg structurally stands in contrast with two other major 'purple patches' in the *Res Gestae*. The first, Constantius' *adventus* in Rome, appears earlier in Book 16. The Augustus celebrates his victories over Magnentius, as Ammianus wryly puts it, a victory 'over Roman blood' (*ex sanguine Romano*).[28] Julian's successes in Book 16 are designed to overshadow Constantius' faux-triumph.[29] Secondly, Julian's great victory has been seen as a counterbalance to the crushing defeat of the Roman field army under Valens at Hadrianople in 378, the culminating event and the conclusion to the final book of the *Res Gestae*. There are a number of similarities between these two large-scale set-piece battles.[30] Roman steadfastness is contrasted with barbarian rashness at Strasbourg, but vice versa at Hadrianople, for

[26] Ammianus' narratorial summation of Constantius' reputation (21.16.15; 22.1.2) had earlier been articulated by his troops (14.10.16) and Julian (20.1.2).

[27] Juneau 1999, 642.

[28] 16.10.1. In the late republican and early imperial periods, celebrating a triumph in civil war was considered taboo (Pliny *NH* 7.92; Val. Max. 2.8.7). According to Dio (43.42) and Plutarch (*Caes.* 56.4) Caesar did not go far enough to disguise the fact that his triumphs in 46 BC were over his fellow countrymen Cato, Scipio, and Petreius (Beagon 2005, 278). By the later empire, the situation had changed markedly. McCormick (1986, 81) suggests that celebrating a triumph in civil conflict was no longer regarded as improper by the late fourth century. Pacatus goes as far as praising Theodosius for doing just that 'you have seen, I say, a civil war (*civile bellum*) ended for which you can decree a triumph' (*Pan. Lat.* II(12).46.4). Only traditionalists such as Ammianus and Claudian (*VI Cons.* 393–406) preserved the old-fashioned view on the indecency of civil triumph. See now Humphries 2015, especially 156–61.

[29] Sabbah 1978, 330. The effect created by Ammianus text, that Julian's victory overshadows Constantius' triumph, reverses the likely experiences of Roman readers even in the 390s who may have witnessed the latter and only heard of the former.

[30] Kelly 2008, 313–16.

example.[31] A narrative that oscillates between action and stasis, and a 'face of battle' narrative style,[32] is common to both episodes. Even if Ammianus had composed an account of Hadrianople before its incorporation into the Latin *Res Gestae* (as Kulikowski has recently suggested[33]) Strasbourg is the conflict that sets up the comparison for Hadrianople rather than vice versa as the reader approaches it within the chronology of the Latin *Res Gestae*. Furthermore, since, as has been argued above,[34] Book 14 represents a major change of narrative gear away from the breviary nature of the lost books, then Strasbourg is likely to have been the first of all the conflicts, whether pitched battles or sieges, to be treated to such a lengthy description (as Hadrianople will be).

This section began with a note that critics have commonly viewed the battle of Strasbourg as a comparable episode to both the *adventus* earlier in Book 16 and the battle of Hadrianople, creating a sort of triangulation of events. It must be stressed that Strasbourg is the key in this relationship. Without Strasbourg as the linchpin, the comparison between unmilitary triumph ∼ military success ∼ military failure could not stand. It is a fundamentally important event to the structure of the *Res Gestae*.

4.2 MILITARY NARRATIVE IN PANEGYRIC AND HISTORIOGRAPHY

Strasbourg, by the sheer amount of detail and length of the episode, is meant to draw our attention to Julian's evolution from unskilled soldier to *Martius iuuenis* (17.1.1). Ammianus also openly refers to the other generic tradition which the description of military events

[31] Blockley 1977, 225–6.

[32] Cf. Kagan 2006. This will be discussed in more depth in section 4.2.

[33] Kulikowski 2012 (see n.24). There have been other arguments to account for Book 31's notably different structure and relationship to what precedes: Blockley (1975, 15) suggests that Books 26–31 are a later addition, 1–25 having been published by 392, prompted by the death of the last Pannonian emperor, Valentinian II in 392 and published no later than 395. Sabbah (2003, 49) argues that Book 31 is an 'overflow' book designed to take his total to one beyond Tacitus' total of thirty (the *Annals* and *Histories* combined).

[34] Chapter 2.1.

necessarily evokes, that of panegyric. In an introduction to his description of Julian's career, Ammianus famously declares 'now whatever I shall tell (and no wordy deceit adorns my tale, but untrammelled faithfulness to fact, based upon clear proofs, composes it) will almost belong to the material of panegyric (*ad laudatiuam paene materiam pertinebit*)' (16.1.3). Deeds in war were a standard element of panegyrical praise, just as the whole of this preface conforms to the ideal of rhetorical *amplificatio*.[35] It is worth dwelling on the point that Ammianus does not claim here to write panegyric itself, merely that the type of events he describes resembles the *materia* commonly associated with panegyric. He deftly suggests the way in which these deeds could be read, whilst distancing his account from that other genre. Indeed, the style of narrative that Ammianus uses in the description of Strasbourg does not resemble that of narrative commonly found within panegyric proper. In his version of the battle, Libanius attributes the majority of the decisive moments to Julian's personal interventions, rather than the army, and treats the army almost as an extension of its commander; 'when [the Alamanni] numbered 30,000, he marched down (κατέβαινε) to meet them . . . he did not prevent (εἶργε) their crossing, but by his attack he put a stop to any reinforcement for them (ἔστησε)' (18.55). The course of the battle is truncated, but Libanius describes a situation where the left wing of each side was hard pressed, saved only by Julian's intervention to spur on his troops (in a particularly Homeric fashion) 'the emperor shouted aloud copying the words of the son of Telamon' (18.58), and shaming them by suggesting they would be ostracized if they returned home in failure. Libanius' narrative, then, is dominated by the figure of Julian; its actions are synonymous with his personal actions, mostly expressed with third person singular verbs, and which leave little room for the participation of anyone else on the field. The army, in particular, is under his direct control throughout. Narrative of a military event within panegyric required the clear and direct attribution of the positive outcome of the conflict to the panegyric's addressee. Libanius achieves this by eliding reference to any other commanders on the Roman side (Julian does not need to consult anyone else about his plans) and the army responds positively to his orders. The army itself is anonymized, and, notably, suffers no

[35] As advised by Menander Rhetor, 373.9. Brodka 2009, 55.

injuries, whereas Libanius clearly records the number of the Alamanni dead (*Or.* 18.60).[36]

Ammianus' methods of describing conflict, by contrast, have recently come under criticism for privileging too much the experience of the combatants at the expense of command-centred explanations, which could have provided a clearer articulation of the tactical development of the battle. Certainly Ammianus' more detailed narrative of Strasbourg, which runs to a dozen pages in the Teubner edition, provides more opportunity to describe events in detail and from a range of perspectives. However, Kagan argues that Ammianus narrates in a style that actively downplays the role of Julian; that narrative style she terms 'face of battle'.[37] This term has been developed by a historian of late medieval and modern conflicts, John Keegan, who argues that a more effective method of assessing the progression and outcome of a conflict is to examine the experience of front-line soldiers rather than to focus solely upon the point of view of the commander.[38] His approach, therefore, examines psychology, motivation, and human experience on the micro-level, rather than more traditional attempts to evaluate overall strategy and tactics at the macro-level of the commander. In *The Face of Battle*, Keegan applies this methodology to the battles of Agincourt, Waterloo, and the Somme. Keegan wherever possible uses first-hand accounts of 'ordinary' soldiers on the front line—such as the letters and diaries of soldiers at the Somme—to construct his 'face of battle' histories of these modern conflicts. His source material, then, favours the testimony of eyewitness participants whose perspective he wishes to capture in his account of each battle.[39]

Kagan argues that Ammianus' descriptions of combat strongly anticipate Keegan's definition of the 'face of battle' method of historical writing. Julian appears rarely in the narrative of the actual battle.

[36] The technique is not unlike that used to portray the relationship between armies and their leaders in 'propagandistic' narratives of civil war, especially in Caesar's *BC.* See Ash 1999, 1–10.

[37] Kagan 2006, 3. [38] Keegan 1976.

[39] Despite the limitations of the source material available to the historian of antiquity in comparison to those who work on more modern periods, this approach has been attempted by Hanson using Greek historical texts (1989) and with Roman history by Goldsworthy (1996) and Sabin (2000), though Lenski (2007, 219) correctly criticizes their tendencies 'to reduce investigations of battlefield experience to overviews of battlefield operations and to substitute analogies with modern *comparanda* for eyewitness accounts by the soldiers themselves'.

Instead we find descriptions of the sights and sounds of battle and the psychological reaction of the participants used as an explanatory tool for the progress of the conflict. Ammianus' description of the major turning point in the battle is indicative of his wider narrative strategy in this scene (16.12.49–51):

> 49. And so there suddenly leaped forth a fiery (*ardens*) band of nobles, among whom even the kings fought, and with the common soldiers following they burst in upon our lines before the rest; and opening up a path for themselves they got as far as the legion of the Primani, which was stationed in the centre—a formation known as the 'praetorian camp'; there our soldiers, closely packed and in fully-manned lines, stood their ground fast and firm, like towers, and renewed the battle with greater vigour; and being intent upon avoiding wounds, they protected themselves like murmillos, and with drawn swords pierced the enemy's sides, left bare by their frenzied rage (*ira flagrantior*). 50. But the enemy strove to lavish their lives for victory and kept trying to break the fabric of our line. But as they fell in uninterrupted succession, and the Romans now laid them low with greater confidence (*fidentior*), fresh savages took the places of the slain; but when they heard the frequent groans of the dying, they were overcome with panic (*pauore perfusi*) and lost their courage. 51. Worn out at last by so many calamities, and now being eager (*strenui*) for flight alone, over various paths they made haste with all speed to get away, just as sailors and passengers hurry to be cast up on land out of the midst of the billows of a raging sea, no matter where the wind has carried them; and anyone then present (*tunc praesens*) will admit that it was a means of escape more prayed for than expected.

Simply put, we can determine that the end of the battle was brought about by a strong attack by the Alamanni upon the Roman centre, which was resisted and dispersed by the Roman troops. The Alamannic flight marks the end of the battle and the Roman triumph. In terms of precise causation of these events, however, Ammianus bases his explanation upon the psychology of the combatants. The Alamanni begin fervently, though Ammianus notes this 'frenzied rage' also creates a tactical shortcoming in that they do not protect themselves sufficiently and leave themselves open to attack, unlike the calm and collected Romans, who take care to avoid being wounded. The aural perception of the losses on the enemy side ('the frequent groans of the dying') finally undermines the Germans' initial enthusiasm and

turns them to panic, just as the Romans' emotions develop in the opposite direction, as they gain confidence (*fidentior*). The balance is tipped, causing the German flight. There is no direct intervention at this critical moment in the battle by commanders on either side (certain groups are distinguished, the 'nobles' among the Germans and the Roman *Primani,* but they merge into the general mass during the engagement).

Kagan is right to define Ammianus as a kind of 'proto-face-of-battle' narrator, though she does not view this as a positive trait in an historian:

> [Ammianus' military narratives] convey the experience of battle from the perspective of the participants, they explain the outcome of events on the basis of generic causal explanations, and they convey the impression of the reality of combat. Like Keegan, Ammianus accentuates some of the more mundane, although not necessarily less heroic, aspects of combat. He seems fascinated by psychological reactions to casualties. Ironically, his determination to convey the 'atmosphere of battle' . . . undermines the military historian's ability to explain the outcome of these battles accurately.[40]

Such a judgement assumes that the prime objective of the military historian should be to offer an accurate explanation of tactics and strategy. Ammianus' commitment to this style of military narrative, which recurs in the siege of Amida in Book 19 and the battle of Hadrianople in Book 31,[41] suggests that, despite its shortcomings in the eyes of modern military historians, he nevertheless valued this narrative strategy in large, set-piece military narratives. Kagan resorts to a biographical explanation of Ammianus' fixation with the face-of-battle style; as a participant at the siege of Amida in 359 (one of the three episodes that clearly exhibits this style of narrative), Ammianus was more sympathetic to the experiences of combatants and therefore sought to retain the participant's perspective when he came to write up his account over twenty-five years later.[42] Kagan

[40] Kagan 2006, 28.

[41] For Amida, see Kagan 2006, 23–51, and for Hadrianople, see Blockley 1977, who rightly argues the disastrous outcome for the Romans is explained via a reversal in the characteristics attributed to the armies at Strasbourg.

[42] 'Ammianus faces his biggest narrative challenge when he chooses to narrate the set-piece infantry and cavalry combat at Strasbourg, a battle that he has not witnessed... Had he not experienced siege warfare at Amida, he might well have chosen to narrate Strasbourg using different structures and images. The resulting description of

must admit that Ammianus' absence from Strasbourg necessitates a more complex process of composition for this earlier episode.[43] She suggests that even though Ammianus was not a participant at Strasbourg, his experiences of conflict during the siege of Amida in 359 allowed him to deploy the same narrative style for this pitched battle, although the tactical details, such as they are described, derive from Ammianus' research, which includes Julian's *biblidion*, official dispatches, and his personal conversations with other *protectores domestici* after the event.[44] Ammianus' sources for the details of Strasbourg are ultimately irrecoverable, although it is worth dwelling on the fact that, if the *biblidion* was among them, Ammianus must have heavily reworked its focus away from a text that had favoured Julian's actions perhaps in a way not unlike Libanius' panegyrical account.

I have argued elsewhere that Amida, which also undoubtedly displays the 'face-of-battle' style, is not a simple record of Ammianus' experiences.[45] The appearance of 'face of battle' siege narrative in the works of other 'non-participant' historians such as Herodian and Dexippus, and even in Heliodorus' novel the *Aethiopica* (which, nonetheless, has long been noted for the historiographical style of its narrative[46]) demonstrates that this style is not a necessary corollary of participation. Instead, it was likely a standard topos of late antique (particularly Greek) historiography.[47] Ammianus' choice to write up Amida as a narrative set piece that forms a triad with Strasbourg and Hadrianople also establishes Amida as a key element of emperor criticism: just as Strasbourg is connected to Julian's military success and Hadrianople to Valens' failure, Amida too strives to emphasize Constantius' reputation for failure in external war. Even though Constantius was not present, Ammianus indicates that Amida was Constantius' responsibility and that the Roman defenders knew that they were fighting, unsuccessfully, in his name and for his

what the battle of Strasbourg might have been like for the combatants is the product of Ammianus' historical inquiry and of his imaginative reinterpretation of a formative combat experience, the siege of Amida.' Kagan 2006, 51.

[43] The narrator makes the protagonist's absence clear, by explicitly mentioning his departure for the east, just before he begins the narration of Strasbourg, 16.10.21.

[44] Kagan 2006, 63–5. De Jonge also believes Ammianus consulted the *biblidion* 1972, 165.

[45] Ross 2015c. [46] Morgan 1982. [47] Ross 2015c, 16–22.

reputation.[48] Face-of-battle style at Amida seems to fill a vacuum created by the absence of Constantius (and draws our attention to the leaderless Romans who nevertheless fight heroically without him). Strasbourg, of course, comes chronologically before Amida, but what does Ammianus gain, then, from using a style of narrative that seems to diminish the opportunity for a commander to be portrayed as directly responsible for the outcome of a battle? This question is particularly potent given that the positioning of Strasbourg within the *Res Gestae*, and authorial comments elsewhere, suggest the battle should be viewed as an endorsement of Julian's (newly found) military credentials.

One thing is clear, face-of-battle style, particularly when compared to Libanius' panegyrical battle narrative, allows a far greater role for the army. To tackle this question, once again we must interrogate the interplay between the army, Julian, and the narrator.

4.3 PREPARATIONS FOR BATTLE—COMPETING INTERPRETATIONS

Julian does not enter the battle entirely unprepared. The narrator in the earlier part of Book 16 records the influences that shape Julian's military character, though underlining that Julian is still out of place in his new role. He is still a *philosophus*, reflecting his presentation at his elevation, though he is now compelled to undertake military exercises (*proludia disciplinae castrensis*, 16.5.10). However in doing so, Julian reveals the depth of his philosophical character, to which this training now tries to add military expertise. In undertaking this

[48] The defenders, for example, exhort the absent Constantius at 19.2.11, acclaiming him (ironically considering the imminent loss of the city) 'lord of the world and the universe'. I suggest that by narrating the siege of Amida at such great length (especially since other contemporary accounts pay relatively little attention to it during wider Persian campaigns in 359–60) Ammianus consciously attempts to supplant Constantius' successful defence of Nisibis during the siege by Sapor in 350 with his loss of another Mesopotamian stronghold, Amida, to the same Persian king. This was of particular importance for Ammianus because Julian had been primarily responsible for aggrandizing Constantius' achievements at Nisibis when he included narrative of the siege in both of his panegyrics to Constantius in the 350s. Ross 2014, 144–9. Constantius is also blamed for preventing Ursicinus from coming to the aid of Amida (19.3.2).

training, Julian calls upon Plato (*Platonem crebro nominans*), and quotes a proverb 'a pack-saddle is put on an ox; that is surely no burden for me' (*clitellae boui sunt impostae*; *plane non est nostrum onus*, 16.5.10).[49] The quotation is designed to suggest the ease with which Julian adapts to his new role, but it also reveals a new stage in his evolution from Greek student to Roman commander. This is the second time that Julian offers a quotation, the first being his recitation of a line of Homer at his elevation. Here the situation, however, has changed. Julian still quotes rather than speaking in his own voice, and his mind is still dwelling on Greek authors (Plato), but unlike the line of Homer the proverb is in Latin. Ammianus' choice of proverb too is significant. It appears in Cicero (*Att.* 5.15.3) but is itself a translation of a Greek phrase.[50] Julian has not yet fully emerged as a Roman hero-general.

Julian has, however, learned from more recent examples of military prowess. When first setting out against the Alamanni, he is advised of a short but difficult route taken by Silvanus the previous year. Julian decides to follow Silvanus' itinerary and therefore Silvanus' example, 'the Caesar with the greater confidence (*fidentius*) made a strong resolve to emulate the daring (*audaciam*) of that hardy man (*uiri fortis*)' (16.2.4). Despite the presentation in the earlier book of Silvanus as a rebel and enemy of Constantius, the former *magister peditum* is clearly a positive example for Julian, and perhaps proleptically suggests his future rebellion against Constantius from a Gallic base. Through *exempla* and intratexts, then, Julian's activities at Strasbourg are set up as an integral part of his development as a character, particularly as legitimate contender for the role of Augustus.

Julian's first military activities in Book 16 before the battle of Strasbourg also play a role in explaining how he acts in that later conflict. Julian's actions in the lead-up to Strasbourg are characterized by his understanding of the situation and his quickness to respond to the enemy. He reacts to the destruction of Lyons by another of the German tribes, the Laeti, 'with quick decision' (*agili studio*, 16.11.5), and refortifies Tres Tabernae 'sooner than expected' (*spe celerius*, 16.11.11). But this is not enough to convince the troops of his capabilities as a commander (16.11.13):

[49] Galletier and Fontaine 1968, 270 n.297.
[50] It had appeared in Diogenes Laertius 7.9. Otto 1890, 57.

> However, it was current rumour everywhere, that Julian was not chosen to relieve the distress of Gaul, but that he might meet his death in the cruellest of wars, being even then, as it was thought (*ut existimabatur*), inexperienced (*rudis*) and one who could not stand even the clash of arms (*ne sonitum quidem duraturus armorum*).

The sentiment that Julian was sent to Gaul to die rather than succeed is a standard part of pro-Julianic (and anti-Constantian) propaganda,[51] but by placing this interpretation in the thoughts of an anonymous group of Romans (presumably Julian's troops) Ammianus sets up Julian's apparent shortcoming as a problem not just for the narrator but the other characters within the narrative. By raising this issue now and in this way, Ammianus also establishes Strasbourg as the great trial for Julian, which will either prove or disprove Constantius' plans.

Nevertheless, Julian compares favourably with his enemy, and thus Ammianus draws structural comparisons between Julian and the Alamanni that undermine the negative assessment of Julian's military skills put forward at 16.11.13 by the anonymous group of troops. Whereas Julian at the outset is well-informed about the situation and quick to respond, Ammianus presents the Alamanni as acting on misinterpretations of Julian. They initially came to Strasbourg 'thinking that Caesar had retired through fear of the worst' (16.12.1), a position that the narrator blatantly shows to be false as Julian earlier had been described building up his fortifications and restocking his supplies (16.11.11–12). Like Julian, however, they think of other recent encounters between the Romans and the Germanic tribes in order to gain confidence, though in their case not of Silvanus but another Caesar, Decentius, the brother (or cousin) of the usurper Magnentius, whom Chnodomarius 'met on equal terms and defeated' (16.12.5).[52] Although Julian had understood Silvanus as a positive *exemplum* (bringing his interpretation into line with that of the primary narrator), the addition of the example of Decentius not only serves to highlight the opposing mindsets of Julian and the Alamanni but also magnifies the challenge faced by Julian.[53] He is

[51] Libanius *Or.* 18.37, though Julian himself does not mention this interpretation (*Ep. ad Ath.* 278a).

[52] Only Ammianus mentions Decentius' defeat by Chnodomarius.

[53] Decentius was Caesar from 350 to 353, when he killed himself after receiving news of his brother's death. Aur. Vict. 42.10; Eutropius 10.12.2.

compared not just to a general who failed against the Alamanni but a failed Caesar and an enemy (even a victim) of Constantius.[54]

This theme of historical consideration extends also to the Roman troops, who recall that in the previous year, the tribes put up little resistance to Roman incursions beyond the Rhine, which in turn gives them confidence (16.12.15). Once again, however, the narrator offers a correction, 'but no one noticed that now the state of the case was changed' (*sed nullus mutatam rationem temporis aduertebat*, 16.12.16); the tribes had now unified and become emboldened by Constantius' withdrawal from the front.[55] All three actors—Julian, the Roman troops, and the Alamanni—are shown to draw upon interpretation of recent events to encourage them towards action. Curiously, it is the Roman troops who misunderstand the situation, a misunderstanding which is clearly demonstrated by the corrective intervention of the primary narrator.

Standing central among these competing interpretations of the intentions of each of the major players at Strasbourg is a speech given by Julian to his troops. The event itself is of significance because it is the first occasion in the text that Julian has delivered a lengthy speech in *oratio recta,* and it thus provides an opportunity for Ammianus to present the direct interaction between the troops and their new (and, according to some, inexperienced) general, and therefore also to establish the dynamics of that relationship before the battle gets underway. It thus also picks up on some of the themes established in the speech scene at 15.8, in terms of the interaction between speaker, audience, and wider setting within the narrative. The most notable aspect of the speech, however, is its rhetorical failure. Julian advocates delay (it is already midday) especially since the Romans are tired from a long march and have not had the chance to eat or drink water, for, as Julian puts it 'what strength can we have, when our limbs are enfeebled with hunger, thirst and toil, to offer resistance?'

[54] Ammianus had certainly narrated Decentius' reign in a lost book (15.6.4), and it is not impossible that he exploited his fall to criticize Constantius' victory in civil wars and the underhand methods he used to achieve them. Other pro-Julianic authors suggest that Constantius encouraged the German tribes to fight against Magnentius and Decentius (Lib. *Or.* 18.33; Zos. 2.53). According to Ammianus, Constantius certainly distrusted the usurpers' troops long after their deaths (18.9.3).

[55] Ammianus, as has been noted above, does not make Constantius' movements clear. The reference to his absence here must refer to his *adventus* in Rome, narrated in 16.10. Cf. Barnes 1993, 222.

(16.12.11). The troops, however, reject Julian's advice and demand to engage immediately (16.12.13). They get what they demand. Against a prevailing tradition that treated Strasbourg as the underpinning of Julian's martial credentials, the obvious inability of Ammianus' Julian to control his troops and impress his will upon them is a major departure from earlier accounts. Although Libanius, as we discussed earlier, cannot embed Julian's speech within his own speech, there is no doubt that it was one of exhortation, designed to encourage not dissuade the troops from battle.[56] Furthermore, Ammianus surrounds this speech with the formulaic elements of the speech scene, such as we had seen at the elevation speech at 15.8; the narrator describes the setting, notes the time of day and the tone of speaker's voice, and records the reaction of the audience.[57] The speech is, therefore, heavily marked as an important event within the narration of the battle. Despite Julian's failure to dissuade the troops, his speech advances several ideas which help characterize his attitude to battle (16.12.9–12):

> 9. 'Regard for maintaining our common safety (to speak most sparingly) urges me, a Caesar far from pusillanimous, to urge and entreat you, fellow soldiers, to have confidence in our mature and sturdy courage, and to choose for all of us rather the path of caution, not the over-hasty and doubtful one, if we are to withstand or to repulse what we have to expect. 10 For in the midst of peril, while it is proper that young men should be energetic and daring, they should also (when occasion requires) be docile and circumspect. Let me therefore in few words detail what my opinion is and see if you will give me leave, and your just anger upholds it. 11 The

[56] Libanius' Julian is 'well aware that such an address at the start of action sends the men cheerfully into battle' (*Or.* 18.53). Pighi suggests that Ammianus accurately presents a situation where Julian avoids giving a full-blown *exhortatio* in order that Julian may maintain a position of deference to Constantius. Blockley is surely right to point out that any speech, *exhortatio* or otherwise, would have been forbidden (1977, 227); and in any case, if Ammianus had wanted to downplay a speech which fails in its rhetorical objectives, he need not have set it within a formulaic (and therefore conspicuous) speech scene. Ammianus' later note that Julian avoided giving an *exhortatio* in order to avoid a 'burden of jealousy' (16.12.29) is designed rather to illustrate Julian's awareness of Constantius' paranoia in a way reminiscent of Silvanus and unlike Gallus.

[57] O'Brien 2013a offers a detailed sentence-by-sentence survey of Ammianus' deployment of the speech-scene elements in 16.12.8–18. He provides an excellent analysis of the variation in the formulaic elements found elsewhere, but does not fully draw attention to the role of the speech within the battle itself or the development of Julian's character (and its interpretation by both external narrator and internal characters).

> day is already nearing noon; we are exhausted by the fatigue of the march; steep and blind paths will receive us; with the moon waning the night will be relieved by no stars; the country is fairly ablaze with heat and relieved by no supply of water. If anyone should grant us the ability to pass through all this comfortably, what are we to do when the enemy's swarms rush upon us, refreshed as they will be with rest and food and drink? What strength can we have, when our limbs are enfeebled with hunger, thirst and toil, to offer resistance? 12 Therefore, since even the most difficult situations have often been met by timely arrangement, and when suitable advice has been taken in good part, heaven-sent remedies have frequently restored the condition of affairs which threatened ruin, here, I ask of you, protected by a rampart and a trench and with our sentinels picketed, let us rest and for the present enjoy sleep and food suitable to the occasion; and then (with God's leave be it spoken) let us advance our triumphant eagles and victorious standards at the first break of day.'

Julian's arguments are grounded in practical considerations, and reflect his earlier interpretation of the comparatively small number of his troops and difficulty of the situation. The thrust of Julian's argument is supported later by the primary narrator, who in response to the troops' rejection of Julian's argument, notes, as we have seen, that they did not understand the situation properly; that the Alamanni were now more closely united against the Romans than in earlier campaigning seasons (16.12.16) and that Vadomarius' willingness to break the treaties concluded earlier with Constantius dramatically changes the strategic situation (16.12.17). In both these cases the primary narrator's summaries of the strategic situation act as a subtle endorsement for Julian's arguments for caution and far more openly undermine the troops' reasons for demanding to engage immediately. Indeed, the primary narrator offers a stark corrective to the troops' interpretation in a way that displays the narrator's omniscience in contrast to the limited understanding of the army: 'but no one noticed that now the state of the case was changed' (16.12.16), 'in another way also the Roman situation was made worse . . . ' (16.12.17).

In light of the narrator's intervention Julian's position appears the more sensible. Indeed, the crux of Julian's argument contains an air of appropriateness beyond the immediate context of the preparations at Strasbourg. As Blockley noted, Julian's line of argumentation bears a striking resemblance to the actions recommended by military

tactician Vegetius, who in his *Epitoma rei militaris* and under the heading of 'precautions to be taken on the day of engaging in a general action' advises that 'in ancient times it was customary to lead soldiers into battle after they had been treated to a light meal' (3.11.3) so that they 'might not grow tired from hunger (*fatigarentur inedia*)' (3.11.3).[58] Furthermore Vegetius warns that 'men who are going to battle lose much of their strength from marching-fatigue' (3.11.7). It seems that Julian, despite his lack of experience, is behaving in a way that Vegetius would approve of. The relationship between these two authors is difficult to establish for certain, especially since Vegetius' date is still a matter of debate, though there is at least a majority opinion that he wrote in the West during Theodosius' stay in 388–91, almost exactly concurrent with Ammianus' period of composition.[59] The similarities between the two, however, point to the expected and even formulaic role that Ammianus' Julian plays, not just as a general, but a general within a particularly literary context. Despite the veneer of didacticism of a work designed as practical advice to an emperor, the *Epitoma rei militaris* is as much aimed at an urban audience who knew as little of the realities of war as the author of the work itself.[60] Vegetius, after all, was not a military specialist. His views were antiquarian and he reassembled the works of earlier tacticians in a way that made entertaining reading as much as a practical guide to warfare.[61] Vegetius even actively presents some of the advice to feed the troops as an action done in 'ancient times'

[58] Blockley 1977, 229 focuses on Julian's attempt to refresh the troops here in the speech and check their eagerness later in the battle, comparing 16.12.33 to Veg. *Mil.* 3.12 and 26. Translations of Vegetius are taken from Milner 1993.

[59] Two secure termini place the date of Vegetius between 383 (there is a reference to Gratian as *divus Gratianus*) and 450. The work refers to a recent Roman military calamity; those who wish to place Vegetius in the fifth century argue it refers to Alaric's sack of Rome, though this overlooks four references to Rome as an 'inviolate city', an impossible epithet after 410. The event that is more likely referred to is the Battle of Hadrianople in 378, and thus the addressee (who is presented as an active general himself) is Theodosius. The *Epitoma rei militaris* must have been written between 383 and 395, and perhaps even during Theodosius' stay in Italy between 388 and 391 (the reference to Gratian may suggest a western audience, even if the use of Latin alone is not enough to establish this). Milner 1993, xxv–xxix; Barnes 1979. For a recent re-statement of the case for a fifth-century date under Valentinian III however, see Charles 2007.

[60] Whately 2015, 244–5.

[61] Allmand 2011, 2. Although it was used as a practical guide in the middle ages, as Allmand goes on to demonstrate.

(*ueteribus saeculis*). Vegetius' recommendations likely draw on the same sort of sources as did Ammianus for examples of good generalship in earlier works of histories and military treatises.[62] For example, ensuring that one's troops were refreshed with water had become a topos within historiography by Tacitus' day. Tacitus can manipulate the topos to damn Otho's incompetence, for example, at *Hist.* 2.39.2, by criticizing him for failing to supply fresh water to his army.[63]

Blockley argues that the parallels with Vegetius suggest Ammianus is presenting Julian here as an ideal, even exemplary, emperor.[64] However, this comment cannot stand within the immediate context of the speech scene: Julian loses the argument and cannot implement the 'textbook' response of the cautious general. In any case, the battle goes on to become a resounding success, despite the change of plan. Of course, the speech allows Ammianus to corroborate the earlier point that Julian had taken his military training seriously; Julian had learned the theory and makes an attempt to apply it. This contrast between theory and practice, however, allows for a more complex picture of the developing Julian.

Thus far it may seem that Ammianus sets up a Roman failure. Julian articulates a policy of caution that the narrator endorses by drawing the narratee's attention to a crucial misunderstanding of the enemy by the Roman troops. Yet the battle that follows is an outstanding success. If strategic planning, such as that advocated by Vegetius, is not the root of victory, then what is? The way in which the troops reject Julian's advice introduces another kind of explanation (16.12.13):

> The soldiers did not allow him to finish what he was saying, but gnashed and ground their teeth and showed their eagerness for battle by striking their spears and shields together, and besought him that they might be led against an enemy who was already in sight, trusting in the favour of god in heaven (*caelitis dei fauore*), in their own self-confidence, and in the tried valour of their fortunate general; and as the event showed (*ut exitus docuit*) a sort of helpful guardian spirit (*salutaris quidam genius praesens*) was urging them to the fray, so long as he could be at hand.

The army's eagerness for battle is not presented as an irrational choice. They introduce a quite different form of reasoning to Julian's

[62] A conclusion also reached from an assessment of different passages by de Jonge, 1955.

[63] Ash 2007, 185, who identifies Polybius 6.27.3 and Ps.-Caes. *Alex.* 8.1 as other examples of the topos.

[64] Blockley 1977, 228.

strategic considerations, in which they elevate their interpretations to a divine level and include a personal judgement of Julian's and their own qualities.[65] Julian had indeed made passing references to 'heaven-sent remedies' (*diuina remedia*) in his speech, but these were not the primary basis of his argument, and exactly what those powers are or whether indeed they might help here is not made clear.[66] By contrast, the divine element is given a prominent position as the first in the list of three reasons by the soldiers, and is further reinforced via narratorial corroboration in the form of a prolepsis: not only did they trust in the 'favour of god in heaven', but the narrator confirms more specifically that this was 'a sort of helpful guardian spirit', whose favour towards the army was guaranteed not by Julian's actions as much as his presence.[67] Before the battle has begun, the narrator alludes to its successful conclusion in the prolepsis (*ut exitus docuit*), a phrase that establishes his certainty about an event or interpretation.[68] Ammianus does not promise to show how the battle demonstrates the presence of a guardian spirit later in his narrative, instead he proleptically anticipates the successful outcome of the battle to corroborate the soldiers' actions.

The divine element is repeated during the conclusion of the speech scene, in which, astonishingly, Julian is ordered forward by one of his standard bearers (16.12.18):

> 'Forward, Caesar, most fortunate of all men (*felicissime omnium Caesar*), to where your good fortune (*fortuna*) guides you; in you at last we feel that both valour and good counsel are in the field. Leading the way for us like a lucky and valiant commander (*ut faustus antesignanus et*

[65] O'Brien 2013a suggests that between Julian's speech and the response of the soldiers Ammianus has created a sense of legitimizing *consensus omnium*: 'a leader fortunate . . . brave and experienced, an army in full support of him, and the pious idea that god's favour is necessary for victory'. This analysis overlooks the fact that we have the very opposite of *consensus* between the army and Julian: the former oppose the latter.

[66] Brodka 2009, 54–65 argues that Strasbourg illustrates the possibility for Roman success under Julian through a combination of Julian's *consilium* and the army's *virtus*, both endorsed by divine favour. As discussed earlier, Julian's planning is compromised by the troops' refusal to obey him, and as outlined below, he is largely unaware of the divine support during the battle. Brodka does not take into account narratological questions of who is aware of and articulates the concepts of *virtus* and divine endorsement.

[67] Brodka 2009, 60.

[68] For the use of prolepses in relation to omens, see Chapter 5.4.

> *fortis*), you will find what the soldier will accomplish when his strength is called out to the full, under the eyes of a warlike general (*bellicosi ducis*), the immediate witness of his achievements, if only the supreme deity be present (*modo adsit superum numen*).'

The event is an inversion of the general's usual role in encouraging his troops to battle; here the troops command Julian to advance. The reference to *fortuna* echoes the troops' (and the narrator's) earlier identification of the divine favour shown to Julian. It is important to note that the army again (as we saw in the elevation scene) is the character within the text that can interpret the situation correctly. Julian at this stage shows no awareness that *fortuna,* the *caelitis dei favor,* a *salutaris genius*, or the *superum numen* are at hand and ensure his victory, even after the army has articulated their interpretation to him. Ammianus does not allow the narratee to perceive Julian's response to the army's revelation; the subsequent notice of the decision to engage in battle is presented with a set of passives that keep the motivating agent obscure: 'when these things had been heard [the *signifer*'s speech] no delay was permitted but the army moved forward and approached a hill of gentle slope (*his auditis cum nullae laxarentur indutiae, / promotus exercitus prope collem aduenit molliter editum*)' (16.12.19). If this is Julian's order we do not know at this stage whether he believes his troops or merely has no other option but to concede to their demands.

4.4 BATTLE NARRATIVE

This characterization of Julian as a commander who is focused on the practical aspects of the battle and oblivious to the divine apparatus at work around him continues throughout the depiction of the conflict itself. Julian plays a minimal role in the narrative that follows, indeed he intervenes on only three more occasions before the conclusion of the scene, but these interventions are important for Ammianus' characterization of Julian both via his speech and actions, and via further structural parallels drawn with the actions and presentation of his enemies. Julian delivers a series of brief interjections to encourage his troops at moments when they show some hesitation. This is not a formal *adlocutio* set within an extensive speech scene such as Julian will later deliver before his troops during the Persian expedition (23.5

and 24.3). Instead Ammianus presents us with a series of individual sentences of encouragement to separate groups. Ammianus usefully explains away the odd setting by referring to Julian's wish to avoid arousing Constantius' jealousy by delivering a full-blown speech, a role Ammianus implies is reserved only for an emperor (16.12.29). As I noted above, this brief explanation of Julian's motivations allows the reader to know that Julian is rightly aware of Constantius' suspicions. However, Julian does not let this private awareness come to the fore in these brief exhortations to the troops. Instead Julian articulates his mission in a way that acts as a (delayed) response to his elevation to the position of Caesar, on which he had been almost mute in the elevation scene itself in the previous book. Now Julian defines his mission to 'wash away the old-time stains and restore its due honour to the majesty of Rome' (16.12.31), more explicitly limiting the scope of his mission in Gaul: to 'do away with the reproaches inflicted upon our cause, in consideration of which I have hesitatingly (*cunctando*) accepted the title of Caesar' (16.12.32). Although he willingly engages in battle, he still suggests that the troops were too eager: 'there has come now, comrades, the real time for fighting, which you and I have long since desired, and which you were just now demanding, when you were tumultuously calling for your weapons' (16.12.30). Later he still promotes 'moderate and cautious thought' (16.12.33). There is no mention of any divine support in these four brief exhortations. Instead they define his interpretation of his role, publicly towing the line under Constantius (of whom Julian is justifiably wary) and promoting the good of the state rather than any personal agenda.

Not just Julian's speech but even his mere appearance can be enough to alter the actions of his troops: 'when Caesar had seen from a distance that the cavalry were looking for nothing except safety in flight, he spurred on his horse and held them back like a kind of barrier. On recognising him (*quo agnito*) by the purple ensign of a dragon the tribune of one of the squadrons stopped, and pale and struck with fear rode back to renew the battle' (16.12.39). Certain recurring motifs of Julian's keen oversight of the battle and his swiftness to respond are apparent. The troops now are in such a position that it is not anything that Julian says or does that checks this retreat, but merely the fear engendered by his appearance.[69]

[69] Julian is recognized primarily by his purple dragon standard rather than for himself. The note dovetails nicely with an episode earlier in Book 16, where

Julian's positive relationship with his army, by which they implicitly trust him, and his presence, which acts as an incentive for their actions, contrasts directly with the distrust shown by the Alamanni for their commanders. Like the Romans who order Julian forward at the outset of the battle, the Alamanni also instruct Chnodomarius what to do, commanding him to get down off his horse, lest he tries to abandon them should the battle turn against them (16.12.34). In a comparable inversion of a similar scene, Chnodomarius actively tries to avoid being identified on the field, 'covering his face, so he would not be recognised' (*uultum, ne agnosceretur, operiens*). His attempt to hide fails, and recognized (*quem agnitum*) he is apprehended by a Roman cohort (16.12.59);[70] whereas Julian, as we have just seen, uses his appearance as a positive motivation for his troops.[71]

Julian's final major act, like his first, is to restrain his troops. Once again his ability to understand and anticipate the situation ('with swift intelligence foreseeing what might happen') halted the troops from driving the fleeing Alamanni into the Rhine and thereby also 'entrust themselves to the eddying flood' (16.12.55).[72]

Throughout these three interventions, Julian largely retains his original role of the textbook general, encouraging or restraining his troops in a cautious method that seeks to promote their safety and the security of the state. He does not attempt any individual acts of heroism or recklessness, yet he does also direct the army personally

Constantius makes use of the dragon standard not as a useful visual tool in battle but as an adornment to his procession during the *adventus* in Rome (*purpureis subtegminibus texti circumdedere dracones/ . . . et ideo velut ira perciti sibilantes,/caudarumque uolumina relinquentes in uentum*, 16.10.7). Ash notes that the appearance of the commander to inspire his troops is a historiographical topos found in Tac. *Hist.* 2.39.2, Livy 6.8.6, 9.27.13, 21.43.17, Dio 43.36, and Pliny *Pan.* 15.5 (Ash 2007, 185). The episode at Livy 9.27.13 is most analogous to the situation in Ammianus, where the flagging Roman troops are bolstered by the appearance of their general in their battle against the Samnites.

[70] There are a number of parallels that suggest Julian and Chnodomarius are designed to be contrasted directly here. Julian moves towards the battle, whereas Chnodomarius hurries away; Julian urges his horse on, whereas Chnodomarius falls off his; both leaders are described with a combination of the relative pronoun and *agnitus* (16.12.34 and. 59).

[71] Ammianus has created a Chnodomarius physically distinct ('fat and heavy', 16.12.59) from that of Libanius' ('a tall, fine figure of a man', *Or.* 18.60). Libanius depicts Julian's enemy as the noble savage, whereas Ammianus tries to make him as unlike Julian as possible.

[72] A procedure that is recommended by another tactician, Onasander, 11.

at the critical moments of the battle. Punctuating the description of the battle, which, as we saw earlier receives an explanation of causation in terms of the troops' collective ability to withstand the frenzied attacks of the Alamanni, are two further authorial indications of the role of divine forces that develop the points made by the troops and the narrator in response to Julian's speech before the start of the battle.

The narrator retrospectively introduces a further assessment of the causes of the turning point in the battle, creating an additional causative layer above the steadfastness of the Roman troops. In the course of the narrative, as we saw above, superior mental preparedness among the Romans at first seems to provide the explanation for Roman success. However, immediately afterwards, in the words of the primary narrator addressed to the primary narratee, 'the gracious will of an appeased deity was present' (*aderatque propitiati numinis arbitrium clemens*, 16.12.52) allowing the Romans to press home their advantage. The scene as a whole is brought to a conclusion with the statement 'so the battle was thus finished by the favour of the supreme deity (*quibus ita fauore superni numinis terminatis*)' (16.12.62). Both statements represent the narrator's summation of the events just narrated. Sequentially, human causation (the psychology of the troops and Julian's inspiration of their confidence) is given primary consideration, but one cannot ignore the retrospective addition of divine causation, especially since the narrator draws attention to it in regular positions at the opening of the battle, its turning point, and its conclusion.

4.5 CONCLUSIONS: LEGITIMIZING JULIAN AND PREPARING FOR THE ACCLAMATION

The initial reference to the *numen* had been introduced by the *signifer* who had first ordered Julian into battle. There the soldier's reference had set up a forward-looking condition: if the *numen* should be present, Julian, a *bellicosus dux*, will see what the troops can achieve when their strength has been roused (*uiribus . . . excitatis*) (16.12.18). The precise description of the *numen* at the turning point and conclusion of the battle suggests the condition has been fulfilled. It is not just the presence of the *numen* that has been at work, but more importantly, its *arbitrium* and its *favor*, suggesting that the outcome

of the battle was in some way its decision. Furthermore, the adjective *propitiatum*, implies that the *numen* has granted this victory in response to an act of propitiation from the Romans. The one other occasion in which the *numen* seems to respond to an act of propitiation occurs in Book 19. The prefect of the city of Rome sacrifices to Castor and Pollux in order to calm a storm that is preventing grain ships from entering Ostia. His prayers are answered *divini arbitrio numinis*.[73] The connection between the request being made and granted is very clear in this episode. What we lack at Strasbourg is any direct request by Julian for divine assistance; and he even seems to be unaware that he receives it. Are we to conclude that Julian's presence alone is enough to guarantee the favour of the *numen*? If so Ammianus certainly shows no wish at this stage to articulate the connection directly. He has, however, throughout the scene promoted the army both in their military skills and their abilities to interpret Julian on behalf of the primary narratee. It is the army, not Julian, who recognize the divine powers that support the new Caesar. And in this interpretation they are supported by the confirmation of the primary narrator. Indeed, the whole style of Ammianus' battle narrative seems to be orientated towards the creation of a positive depiction of the Roman army under Julian's command. Ammianus' adoption of a 'face-of-battle' style allows him to devote more narrative space to their actions and psychology than the parallel account embedded within panegyric (and we may perhaps surmise, in Julian's own self-promoting *biblidion*). The anonymous and collective army carry out one more, culminating action in the aftermath of the battle, which may explain Ammianus' choice to treat both the army and Julian in this way. In an event otherwise unattested by the other sources, the troops unanimously proclaim Julian Augustus at the successful conclusion of the battle (16.12.64)[74]:

[73] 19.10.4. Davies 2004, 268, presumes that Ammianus' use of *numen* here is a way to avoid suggesting that named gods (in this instance Castor and Pollux) become directly involved in the narrative: 'if Ammianus had specified the active gods, he would have been writing epic not history'; cf. Rike 1987, 40. However, it is also evidence of Ammianus' imprecision with theological terminology, particularly of the impersonal powers such as *numen, fatum*, and *fortuna.*

[74] This event usually omitted by modern biographers of Julian, e.g. Browning 1975, 87–8; Bowersock 1978, 42 (both Browning and Bowersock otherwise draw heavily on Ammianus account of Strasbourg); Hunt 1998, 51. Athanassiadi 1992, 58 and Rosen 2006, 151 provide an exception.

> tunc Iulianus, ut erat fortuna sui spectatior meritisque magis quam imperio potens, / Augustus acclamatione concordi totius exercitus appellatus / ut agentes petulantius milites increpabat / id se nec adipisci uelle iurando confirmans.
>
> Thereupon, since Julian was a man of greater mark than his position, and more powerful in his deserts than in his command, he was hailed as Augustus by the unanimous acclamation of the entire army; but he rebuked the soldiers for their thoughtless action, and declared with an oath that he neither expected nor desired to attain that honour.

The army's justification is couched in the same terminology as earlier, focusing particularly on his *fortuna* now reinforced by the example of his victory. It is a clear expression of the point that the military victory at Strasbourg is justification of Julian's right to become Augustus. That it is made by the army carries extra significance. Firstly, looking back over the preceding narrative, the army have been established as a group of skilled interpreters, who are aware of the *numen*'s support of Julian, and even, in the words of the *signifer,* of the personal attachment of a *genius* to him. Julian, by contrast, has been entirely unaware of the divine favour, which the primary narrator nonetheless corroborates.[75] The army acts throughout this scene as an arbiter of Julian's readiness for sole rule, uniting the figure of Julian with the structural prominence of the Strasbourg scene within the wider narrative. They are in fact *better* arbiters than Julian himself: by the conclusion of Strasbourg, Julian possesses all the qualities that enable him to become sole Augustus, except that he does not realize this himself. He has learned all the practical aspects of warfare, but as yet is not aware (or at least the narrator has not allowed him to demonstrate his awareness) of divine support.

As already noted, the description of the troops' unilateral acclamation of Julian at the end of Strasbourg, as far as we can tell, is unique to Ammianus. If Eunapius mentioned it, Zosimus elided it (3.3.3–4). Buck surmises why Zosimus took this decision, if indeed he did:[76] 'this incident must have proved to Julian and to his contemporaries

[75] This is quite contrary to Libanius, who maintains Julian confidently embarked upon his Gallic mission because 'he had confidence that the gods fought on his side. He knew that Heracles too had escaped the Styx because Athena tipped the scale in his favour' (*Or.* 18.39).

[76] Presuming Eunapius recorded this episode at all, and, indeed, that 16.12.64 is not simply Ammianus' invention. See Weisweiler 2015 for such an 'inventive' Ammianus.

that he could be a candidate for Empire. Omitting it [in Zosimus' version] removes from the reader's own mind and from the reader's perception of Julian's motivation the possibility that the Caesar could aspire to be the Augustus. Hence the plausibility of a spontaneous mutiny at Paris is reinforced.'[77] Very much the inverse should hold, then, for Ammianus. The subsequent acclamation at Paris in Book 20 loses its sense of spontaneity, as it had already been made clear that Ammianus' Julian could be elevated on the strength of the victory at Strasbourg alone. Spontaneity may not be as much a hallmark of Ammianus' version of events in Book 20, but he takes care to suggest the acclamation was at least not fully premeditated, and Julian is depicted as taking steps to avoid it happening (20.4.11 and 15).[78] To have included the earlier acclamation in Book 16 compromises this situation, and it is therefore worth considering what Ammianus gains by including the episode at 16.12.64 at all.

The value appears to lie in the repetition itself. In Book 20, the context makes clear that it is the same group of troops that had been with Julian at Strasbourg who acclaim him in Paris—their Gallic roots and their loyalty to Julian based upon their shared campaigns prompt them to refuse Constantius' order summoning them to the eastern front. Julian echoes their sentiments, referring to their shared victory at Strasbourg as 'that most happy day' (20.5.5). As in 357 Julian refuses their acclamation (20.4.15), though on a second occasion he reluctantly acquiesces. The major difference in Book 20 is that Julian is now conscious of divine sanction (20.5.10):

> But in the night before he was proclaimed Augustus, as the emperor told his nearer and more intimate friends (*iunctioribus proximis*), a vision appeared to him in his sleep, taking the form in which the guardian spirit of the state (*Genius Publicus*) is usually portrayed, and in a tone of reproach spoke as follows: 'Long since, Julian, have I been secretly watching the vestibule of your house, desiring to increase your rank, and I have often gone away as though rebuffed. If I am not to be received even now, when the judgements of many men are in agreement, I shall depart downcast and forlorn. But keep this thought in the depths of your heart, that I shall no longer abide with you.'

[77] Buck 1993, 77.

[78] See Matthews' careful endorsement of Julian's innocence (1989, 98–9). Ammianus, if he believed that Julian was guilty of premeditation, has done a good job of making it ambiguous.

The scene is not quite as straight-forward as it may at first seem. Julian's revelation that he has seen the *Genius Publicus* is chronologically out of place—the primary narratee, like Julian's 'nearer and intimate friends', finds out about Julian's vision only after he has been acclaimed by the troops and has accepted the elevation. The result is certainly to promote the 'description of the events on a purely human level',[79] but the appearance of the *Genius* nevertheless reflects a substantial change from the previous attempted elevation scene in Book 16. Furthermore, Ammianus' version differs from Julian's own, in which he actively seeks out a confirmatory sign from Zeus (*Ep. ad Ath.* 284C); such an action would have been impossible for Ammianus' Julian, who till this point has been oblivious to signs of divine endorsement. He can passively receive a sign in Book 20, but it would have been incongruous for him to actively seek one.

Many of the factors which motivated the army in the aftermath of Strasbourg are again at play in Book 20, though now with the additional sense of urgency created by Constantius' threatened removal of the Gallic troops to Persia. Julian only achieves final maturity and reaches a position of being able to accept such an acclamation once he recognizes that divine powers favour him. On a more pragmatic note, Ammianus could not avoid the problem that the later acclamation in Paris in Book 20 was as much the result of the soldiers' sense of self-preservation. However, by prefiguring the successful acclamation in Book 20 with the earlier albeit unsuccessful one in Book 16 was to attribute more noble causes to it.

Indeed, the important role that Ammianus allots to Julian's troops in Books 16 onwards reflects a potential difficulty in engaging with a pro-Julianic tradition that sought to exculpate Julian by presenting him as a victim of the thuggish soldiers' sense of self-preservation. Zosimus has Julian forcefully carried out of his quarters by the troops (3.9.2), and Zonaras suggests the troops threatened to kill him if he did not comply (13.10.51). Even Julian himself depicts a menacing army, who surround his palace shouting (*Ep. ad Ath.* 284B–C). In Ammianus' version the troops are notably less heavy-handed; the most prominent example of this amelioration lies in Ammianus' recasting of the story of a plot against Julian immediately after his acclamation. Both Julian and Libanius mention a plan by those who

[79] Den Boeft et al. 1987, 130.

are still loyal to Constantius to use the confusion immediately after the acclamation to kill Julian (Jul. *Ep. ad Ath.* 285A–B, Lib. *Or.* 18.102), which Ammianus mollifies into a mere rumour of a plot. Nonetheless this rumour galvanizes the troops loyal to Julian, who rush the palace to protect their new *Augustus.* They stand down only when Julian appears unharmed within a tableau, 'resplendent in the imperial garb' (20.4.20–22).[80] In the *Res Gestae*, the troops remain unquestionably loyal, and thus their qualification as Julian's anointers is preserved.

Julian's developing relationship with the metaphysical forces of the *Res Gestae*, particularly his gradual awareness of divine approval for his reign, also conditions Ammianus' presentation of one of the most famous episodes in Julian's career (and one which nonetheless manifests as an under-stated episode in the narrative), namely Julian's public 'apostasy' in 362. Despite an earlier note at 21.2.4 that Julian had attended an Epiphany service at the beginning of 360, and had thus participated in a ceremony of the Christian religion 'from which he had long since secretly revolted (*desciuerat*)', Ammianus places the moment of Julian's public declaration of his abandonment of Christianity only safely after Constantius' death and Julian's undisputed assumption of the role of sole emperor (22.5).[81] The chapter is brief, and in the words of the Dutch commentators is 'unsatisfactory' because 'the information which it provides is inadequate in some important respects. Its coherence leaves much to be desired'.[82] This is perhaps not surprising, for Julian's relationship with Christianity was necessarily a difficult issue for Ammianus. Certainly, Christianity itself was a subject to be marginalized within the genre classicizing historiography generally,[83] but in the case of Julian particularly, any prolonged discussion of his attitude to Christianity or indeed his adoption of traditional religious practices in reaction to it, would have interfered with Ammianus' use of the metaphysical apparatus of the *Res Gestae* in promoting Julian's growing legitimacy. To describe Julian engaging in cultic activities (which Julian promotes in 22.5) prior to his assumption of sole rule would have at best

[80] The accidental appearance of Julian now resplendently decked-out in his imperial robe allows Ammianus both to present a visual image of Julian's new state, whilst also preserving a sense of his unwillingness—he did not actively show himself to the troops in such a way.

[81] Rike 1987, 46. [82] Den Boeft et al. 1995, 51.

[83] Cameron and Cameron 1964.

undermined or at worst contradicted his initial presentation as ignorant of his divine backing both at the elevation scene and then Strasbourg. Instead Ammianus provides the narratee with retrospective statements that Julian 'was from the earliest days of his youth more inclined towards the worship of the gods (*numinum*)' (22.5.1) only at the moment of his 'apostasy' without any further details of the sort that might have appeased his modern commentators. Julian himself suggests that he had worshipped openly and had encouraged his troops to do likewise as early as his stay in Naïssus in late 361 when he had heard news of Constantius' death (*Ep.* 26, 415C–D).[84] Ammianus, then, must be suspected of 'repositioning' this event for the sake of the objectives of his narrative.

4.5.1 Narrative, Metaphysics, and Preparing for Persia

Ammianus responds to the pro-Julianic tradition by using Strasbourg, as Julian himself and Libanius had done, to promote Julian's legitimacy as a successful commander and therefore as a potentially legitimate emperor. By lavishing a large-scale battle description on Strasbourg, he not only conforms to a historiographic tradition by narrating a set-piece battle, but reserves the first example of this historiographic motif for Julian. This style of narrative, distinct from narrative within panegyric, allows Ammianus to be more subtle in his presentation and circumspect in the extent of his positive assessment of Julian. Although the length and detail of Strasbourg force a (positive) structural comparison with Constantius' *adventus* in the previous chapter, and with the later conflicts at Amida and Hadrianople in Books 19 and 31 respectively, using Strasbourg to promote Julian at this stage in the narrative was a delicate task for Ammianus, if only because it will be a further three years and four books before Julian becomes Augustus. The scale of Ammianus' narrative of Julian allows the opportunity for the historian to trace a development in his character from his first appearance as the unwilling adoptee. Ammianus thus presents Julian as an increasingly capable figure, but he is not yet fully ready to become Augustus. In

[84] Cf. Bowersock 1978, 62–3, though he is surely wrong to state that 'Ammianus was unaware' of this (79). As argued above, it was easier for Ammianus to delay the incident until Julian was indisputably sole ruler. Barnes, for once, is too cautious in expressing his ambivalence about the significance of this delay (1998, 156).

terms of military theory, Julian is well-prepared (or should we say, well-read?), but still acts at the bidding of his army, rather than vice-versa. This was a risky strategy for Ammianus, as to present Julian in this passive way risked decoupling the figure of Julian from the structural objective of Strasbourg: to demonstrate the development of Julian's legitimacy. Ammianus' solution is to have it both ways. Instead of undermining Julian, the army act as interpreters of Julian's capabilities not just on the human level but on the divine. They recognize the divine favour shown to him, and therefore are mentally more prepared for battle, a state which subsequently ensures the battle is a success. Face-of-battle style, together with the exchange between Julian and the army at the beginning of the battle, allows the narrator to depict the Romans' superior psychological state in action against the Alamanni. The last stage in Julian's progress towards full legitimacy is to recognize divine favour for himself at his acclamation in Book 20.

Thus far I have avoided the vexed topic of Ammianus' attitude to religion, particularly whether he presents a coherent metaphysical system, and if so whether one can equate this system with the author's personal beliefs. As far as the lattermost point is concerned, narratological theory has exposed the danger of equating author and narrator, even in 'applied' narrative texts such as historiography.[85] This should especially be the case in a text such as ours in which the narrator is so careful in his control and representation of his own action during moments of internal narration of his own participation in events.[86] From the discussion above, it should already be clear that the *numen,* the *genius*, and *fortuna* all have an important narratological role to play, especially in terms of which characters recognize their operation and effect on human action, and that the primary narrator corroborates or undermines those characters' interpretations via direct narratorial comment. Recent attempts to (re)construct a logical system of Ammianus' theology by Rike, Davies, and Brodka have largely been unable to reconcile the various inconsistences they have revealed in Ammianus' system. To give one example that we have already encountered, Ammianus happily shifts terminology during his description of religious events, such as the prefect

[85] For a succinct recent overview of the topic, see de Jong 2014, 17–19.

[86] Kelly 2008, 104–58 for Ammianus' controlled self-revelation; and Ross 2014 and 2015c for the use of the first person at Amida.

Tertullus' sacrifice to Castor and Pollux, not these gods but the *arbitrium* of the *diuinum numen* calms the seas and directs a favourable wind, allowing grain ships to enter Ostia and replenish the dwindling stocks (19.10.4).[87] Certainly it is clear that *numen* is the most important and fundamental of the 'impersonal' powers within the *Res Gestae*.[88] Brodka is correct in noting that *numen* is particularly heavily associated with the support and maintenance of Rome, both as city and imperial ideal. In 19.10 it ensures the food supply of the city, but elsewhere it is invoked as the reason for Rome's greatness and eternity (14.6.3; 27.6.6). Again we may detect a narratological as much as a theological point in Ammianus' attribution of *numen*'s support: Julian is equated with the security and eternity of Rome itself.

There is not scope in this book to address a topic which itself could require book-length investigation, but the final chapter will investigate how such divine or metaphysical issues are used by the narrator to explain events and characterize the actors within the narrative in the culminating episode in the narrative of Julian, the invasion of Persia in 363. It is in Persia that many of the strands that we have traced thus far combine, the development of Julian as a military leader, his awareness of divine approval or disapproval, and the interpretative presence of the narrator as a character.

[87] Davies also notes that *numen* can indicate '"a particular god" (e.g. Aesculapius 22.14.7), or can, in the plural, replace the traditional *di* (e.g. *cultus numinum* 22.5.1 and 25.4.20 or the *pax numinum* at 23.5.4), more often it is used in a sense that has led to discussions of "neutral monotheism"'. 2004, 265. The god of the Christians is also referred to as a *numen* 21.2.5. Brodka identifies at least two possible meanings of *fortuna*, one of which he seems to have taken over wholesale from Florus (and may therefore say more about Ammianus' place in a historiographical tradition than his attachment to stoic philosophy) (2009, 34).

[88] Rike 1987, 31.

5

Narrating Failure

Julian and Ammianus in Persia

This chapter aims to provide an analysis of certain aspects of Ammianus' presentation of the Roman invasion of Persia in 363, the culminating event of Julian's reign. It seeks to examine how several features of Ammianus' narrative technique that have been discussed in the previous chapters of this book come together to offer an explanation of Julian's downfall to a Roman, Latin-speaking audience. The Persian campaign is the single occasion in the *Res Gestae* where Ammianus the participant and Julian appear in close proximity, and more than any other event in the *Res Gestae* it had received significant literary attention before Ammianus. Why does Ammianus use first-person narration here, how does he combine it with his wider narratorial persona to explain what was an undoubtedly calamitous, but also geographically distant event on the other side of the empire, within the bounds of a noticeably Latin historiographical tradition?

5.1 PERSIA AND THE TRADITION OF PARTICIPATION

Ammianus' appearances as a first-person participant (whereby the primary narrator, who is usually external, becomes, temporarily at least, internal to his narrative) place him in dubious company within the genre of Latin historiography. Among the Latin historians of the empire we know of only Velleius and Eutropius who also adopted this

practice.[1] In Velleius' case, the use of the first person has earned him censure from modern critics:

> Velleius uses the first person singular for himself, the first person plural for the Roman soldiers. No attempt is made at formal objectivity, and Velleius shows no hesitancy in presenting himself as allied and indebted to the Emperor.[2]

First-person narration causes a potential dilemma for an historian. On the one hand, eyewitness testimony was among the strongest claims to authority available,[3] yet to present the narrative from the point of view of an internal narrator (in place of the more common external, 'omniscient' narrator) brought with it the danger of limiting the scope of the history and therefore undermining claims to impartiality. Velleius seems not to have been so concerned about opening himself to charges of bias, though the majority of his first-person appearances serve as statements of his presence during or observation of events rather than detailing his personal actions.[4] A skilful way to get round this problem is offered by Caesar: to separate the character and the narrator by the latter's use of the third person to refer to the former. The paratext (the intimation that the author was also 'Caesar') ensured the narratee was aware of the connection between narrator and character, and permitted some importation of authority.[5] This was not the procedure favoured by Ammianus, but neither did he allow the moments of his participation in the early parts of the *Res Gestae* to coincide directly with Julian, the one character who could have been treated as panegyrically as Velleius' Tiberius. The episodes involving first-person narration that we have discussed elsewhere have seen Ammianus in the company of Ursicinus (14.7 and 15.5). The major example of first-person narration that uses the singular occurs when Ammianus is conspicuously on his own, during his scouting operations in 359 and his flight to Amida

[1] Marincola 1997, 79 and 179. Cf. Chapter 2.1.
[2] Marincola 1997, 198.
[3] Marincola 1997, 66–86.
[4] E.g. 2.101.2; 2.111.3; 2.113.3; 2.114.2; 2.115.5; 2.121.3.
[5] Xenophon removed even the paratextual reference, pseudonymously referring to the author as 'Themistogenes'. Plutarch *de Glor. Ath.* 345E. Marincola has noted, however, that this is perhaps a literary game, and that there would have been few who failed to recognize that 'Themistogenes' and Xenophon were one and the same. There was a rhetorical need, however, to separate the identity of the participant and that of the author, particularly if the protagonist undertook so many praiseworthy actions. Marincola 1997, 186; cf. Pelling 2013, 45.

(18.6.5–8.13). In the company of the other defenders of Amida, the participant retreats into the more anonymous plural (19.1–8.4) only to appear in the singular again once he is on his own, having escaped the fall of the city and fleeing back to Antioch (19.8.5–12). All these events during which the first-person appears share a common feature—they had likely not received detailed attention in other authors before Ammianus (see Chapter 1 for Gallus and Silvanus). Equally Amida was not of such importance as Ammianus' extensive narrative may suggest, especially when compared to the far shorter descriptions of successful Persian sieges in 360.[6] In contrast, the participant-narration of the Persian campaign is distinct from these earlier episodes in two respects: Ammianus is now in the company of the emperor, and during an event which had received considerable literary attention before Ammianus wrote his account.

Since first-person narration is such a rare occurrence within extant Latin historiography (limited to Velleius, Eutropius, and Ammianus), it is also a phenomenon that may admit of intertextuality between the few occasions where it does occur. I argue below that this is particularly the case between Ammianus and his near contemporary Eutropius. At first inspection, nonetheless, Eutropius' reference to himself as a character in the first person is brief but appears in a similar situation to that of Velleius. Eutropius was also a member of a military expedition under an emperor (10.16.1):

> Hinc Iulianus rerum potitus est ingentique apparatu Parthis intulit bellum, cui expeditioni ego quoque interfui.
>
> Accordingly Julian took possession of the state and after vast preparations waged war against the Parthians, on which expedition I was also present.

This is the only direct reference to Eutropius' involvement in the campaign and certainly the only use of the first person to refer to

[6] Eutropius does not single out Amida amongst the generalizing list of 'captured towns, besieged cities and slaughtered armies' during Constantius' reign (10.1). Cf. similar treatment by Festus (*Brev*. 27) and Jerome (*Chron*. 236.l). Even Libanius, when condemning Constantius in his funeral oration for Julian, does not make a special case for Amida as a particularly awful disaster (*Or.* 18.208). I have argued elsewhere that Ammianus magnifies the importance of Amida by narrating the siege at length and in an epicizing way in order to overshadow Constantius' only major success in Mesopotamia, the successful defence of Nisibis in a similar siege nine years previously in 350. First-person narration imbues the episode with authority in what is the narrative of an otherwise under-reported event. Ross 2015c.

himself as a character in the *Breviarium*.[7] As for Velleius, the combination of being both a man of letters and a man of action was an important dual qualification for the historian. The campaign in which Eutropius participated is of course Julian's Persian invasion of 363, and thus it invites comparison with Ammianus' use of the first-person and his narrative of the same campaign. Before doing so, it is worth noting the uniqueness of Eutropius' brief appearance at this point within his narrative and how it may relate to the ways in which the Persian campaign had been treated by other authors in those half dozen years before Eutropius composed his *Breviarium* in 369.

Eutropius had an active career both before and after the Persian campaign. To have been a high-ranking member of Valens' court and a *vir clarissimus* when he composed the *Breviarium,* he must have continued in imperial service under Jovian, and possibly also held an important position under Constantius.[8] However, none of the events of the latter part of Constantius' reign onwards received any notification of Eutropius' participation (*Brev.* 10.11–18).[9] The intimation of personal involvement of an imperial official (even though he is to be equated with the author) may be seen as an odd choice in a work which otherwise admits little extraneous detail, and which can cover the entire reign of an emperor within the space of a single sentence. Why did Eutropius allow that *interfui* to intrude into his text? Writing at the end of the 360s, Eutropius was likely aware of the tradition that had grown up around the narrative of the Persian expedition. As already discussed in Chapter 1, the campaign of 363, more than any other recent event, inspired literary descriptions by those who had participated in it.[10] A more detailed survey of these authors, or at least of their *testimonia*, reveals quite how closely autopsy and authority (a combination explicitly evident in Eutropius) had been united in the earliest accounts of the Persian campaign.

As early as the end of 363, Libanius requests a copy of a diary of events that Philagrius, Julian's *notarius,* had prepared. Philagrius was

[7] He refers to himself as an historian in the preface addressed to Valens *res Romanas . . . brevi narratione collegi.*

[8] Bird suggests he was Constantius' *magister epistularum* (1993, vii, ix), based on *Scr. Orig. Cpl.* II.144.

[9] The role of *magister epistularum* required constant attendance on the emperor. Jones 1964, 504–5. Bird suggests that Eutropius may have been at Singara in 348 (1993, x). He certainly must have been with Constantius when he died in 361.

[10] See Chapter 1.1 for further details of several of the authors discussed here.

no minor figure. He had previously been entrusted by Julian with capturing Vadomarius, an Alamannic king, in a covert operation detailed by Ammianus in 21.4, in which Ammianus also recalls his later position as *comes Orientis*. It is not unlikely that Ammianus also knew of Philagrius' account of the Persian war, even in the same vague terms as Libanius describes it (*τὸν πόλεμον ἐν γράμμασιν*).[11] The pattern of well-connected participants writing up their accounts soon after their return continues in the other *testimonia* of lost works.

Libanius' exhortation to his recently banished correspondent Seleucus to write a history of the war concludes with the flattering statement: 'you may be quite sure that by writing it you will oblige all mankind. You, and many more saw the events; you alone of the eye-witnesses (*τῶν ἑωρακότων*) have an eloquence equal to the events' (*Ep.* 1508.6). Libanius draws attention to the number of people who could have done what he urges Seleucus to do and commit their eyewitness memories to text. The letter is dated by Norman to spring 365.[12] Whether Seleucus acted on Libanius' suggestion is not known for certain,[13] but the terms in which Libanius addresses him is indicative of the pool of figures closely associated with Julian who were in a position to offer accounts of the Persian campaign based upon their personal experiences. If Libanius' Seleucus did produce his work, it would have been that of an avid pagan and high priest (perhaps of Cilicia) under Julian who could claim a long and intimate acquaintance with both Julian and Libanius.[14]

[11] *Ep.* 115.2. Norman dates this letter to October 363.

[12] Norman 1992, 288.

[13] Libanius' correspondent could be Seleucus of Emesa (*BNJ* 780), who is described by the Suda as the author of a work in four books of hexameter on angling, a commentary on lyric poets, and a two-book *Parthica* (which some have identified as Libanius' Seleucus' work on Julian). No other information is provided, and caution should be exercised in connecting the two given the prevalence of the name in Syria.

[14] Lib. *Ep.* 13.1 (Foerster) to Julian dated to 353 records a visit of Seleucus to Julian in Bithynia. Bradbury 2004, 52. He was in Constantinople with Julian in 362, Lib. *Ep.* 697. His actions as high priest are alluded to in Lib. *Ep.* 770 from 362. Julian describes him as an 'old friend' (*Ep.* 32). See *PLRE* s.v. 'Seleucus I'; Janiszewski 2006, 136–44; and Banchich's essay in *BNJ* 226A. Libanius is not the only author to provide *testimonia* of lost works on the Persian campaign. Malalas mentions both Magnus of Carrhae and Eutychianus of Cappadocia as his sources for Julian's campaign (13.23). Malalas tells us little about Magnus of Carrhae other than that he was also a participant. Whether the historian Magnus was the same Magnus who is mentioned as one of the three soldiers who first burst out a tunnel at Maozamalcha (Amm. 24.4.23; Zos. 3.22.4) is an issue that appears to admit little chance of resolution. Those who argue for the identification include Seeck 1906, 531; Jacoby in *FGrH* 225; and,

Best attested of the lost accounts of the Persian invasion is that of Oribasius.[15] Eunapius states 'he composed a very accurate memoir of [Julian's] deeds for use in writing; he knew about all those deeds since he was present (παρών) when they were done' (fr. 15). Oribasius too had enjoyed a long friendship with Julian, from Julian's time in Gaul through to the moment of the emperor's death.[16] There is no clear evidence for when Oribasius wrote his ὑπόμνημα, but the situation sketched by Libanius for Seleucus could equally apply to him: an enforced exile under Julian's successors provided a good opportunity for writing up an historical account.[17] Although all the authors mentioned here are now fragmentary or exist only in *testimonia*, it is important to note that the later historians who used their works flaunted their sources' eyewitness credentials.[18]

Eutropius thus reflected the historiographical tradition that had developed around the Persian campaign by drawing attention to his participation. Of course we do not know how the earlier Greek authors may have brought their eyewitness credentials to the

tentatively, Janiszewski 2006, 128–9; and against: Laqueur 1928, col. 491–3; Thompson, 1947, 31; Paschoud 1979, xlix–l; Ridley 1982, 180; Matthews 1989, 163. Penella as editor of Magnus in *BNJ* 225 refrains from passing judgement. Malalas sees fit to include some additional biographical information for Eutychianus, presumably to add weight to Eutychianus' authority as a source, naming him 'as a soldier and *vicarius* of his own *numerus* of the Primoarmeniakoi, and was himself present in the war'. (Malalas 13.23; trans. Jeffreys, Jeffreys, and Scott 1986). There is no indication of when these authors wrote their accounts, but it is likely in the immediate aftermath of the campaign, as Philagrius had done.

[15] See also Chapter 4.1.

[16] Julian *Ep.* 14; *Ep. ad Ath.* 277C. Philostorgius places Oribasius at Julian's side at the latter's death, 7.15.

[17] Eunapius tells us Oribasius was exiled to the 'barbarians' though later recalled by Julian's successors. *Vit. Soph.* 21.8–11.

[18] To this list can also be added an epic poem on the campaign by one Callistion or Callistus, who once again is mentioned by a later historian, Socrates of Constantinople, in terms of his participation and proximity to Julian: 'but Callistus, one of his body-guards (ἐν τοῖς οἰκείοις τοῦ βασιλέως), who celebrated this emperor's deeds in heroic verse, says in narrating the particulars of this war, that the wound of which he died was inflicted by a demon' (Soc. *HE* 3.21). There is no indication how much of Julian's career Callistus covered, but he certainly concluded with the Persian campaign. Janiszewski 2006, 390–3; *BNJ* 223. If he is the same figure as Callistion who composed 'epic verses' and was the recipient of a letter from Libanius, then he had completed his poem by mid-364. Lib. *Ep.* 1233 (Foerster). Kaldellis in *BNJ* 223 believes they are one and the same; Janiszewski 2006, 392 is more cautious but entertains the possibility. The change in spelling is likely just to be a copyist's error. Callistion was serving as an *assessor* in 364, probably to the Prefect of the East, Salutius (Bradbury 2004, 204).

attention of their readers; they need not have used first-person, internal narration (certainly the idea of a first-person-participant narrator in an epic poem is unprecedented). For later historians such as Eunapius and Socrates, it became *de rigueur* to mention the eyewitness experience of their sources, however. By stating his presence, Eutropius places his work within that first eyewitness generation of the accounts of the campaign, although Eutropius wrote some years after that first wave of participants' narratives.

If Eutropius was aware of the tradition of eyewitness narration of the Persian campaign, then so was Ammianus; and more specifically, Ammianus was keenly aware of Eutropius' claims to participation and his method of using the first-person singular to record it. Ammianus alludes to Eutropius' single appearance when he notes his participation on Ursicinus' mission to depose Silvanus:[19]

> cui expeditioni ego quoque interfui (Eutrop. 10.16.1)
> inter quos ego quoque eram (15.5.22)

Both authors set the indication of their presence on military expeditions within relative clauses; both combine the emphatic *ego* with *quoque*; although Ammianus uses the first singular imperfect of *esse* uncompounded with *inter*, he uses *inter* as a preposition to the relative.[20] In Eutropius this clause contains the only use of the first-person by the narrator, in Ammianus it is the first use of the first-person singular in the extant portion of his work.[21]

This allusion to Eutropius is not a marker of Ammianus' *adulatio* for his recent contemporary but of polemic *aemulatio*. Ammianus presents his large-scale work of classicizing historiography in opposition

[19] I have discussed the historiographic implications of this allusion more fully in Ross 2015b.

[20] It seems be a feature of Ammianus' style to split *inter* from *esse*, especially in relative clauses, e.g. 14.11.2, 14.11.14, 15.5.4, 16.12.7, 21.14.4, 23.6.69, 25.4.20, 30.1.2. He only once uses *interesse* in the sense of 'to be among', and this does not occur in a relative clause: *ne feruentibus proeliis interesset* (31.7.5). It may be the case that **intereram* was not an available option on stylistic grounds, even though it would have further aided the identification of the allusion.

[21] Although, as we have seen, Ammianus used the first person to refer to his presence with Ursicinus in Antioch in Book 14, there he only uses the first-person plural (14.11.5). Ammianus was a junior *protector domesticus* (a mid-ranking staff officer) in 357 (16.10.21). It seems unlikely he played a major part in any event in the lattermost of the lost books, which narrated the years leading up to 353. Ammianus had already avoided the first-person singular in Book 14, and so it seems likely that 15.5.22 is the first use of the first-person singular in the whole work.

to the contemporary genre of *breviarium*. Book 15, which contains the Silvanus episode at Chapter 5, begins with a preface in which Ammianus outlines his programme: 'for brevity (*breuitas*) is only then to be praised, when breaking untimely delays, it subtracts nothing from the understanding of events'. It is widely understood that Ammianus here disparages the current trend of breviary history proffered by Eutropius, Aurelius Victor, and Festus in the 360s.[22] Kelly has recently demonstrated that by deploying close lexical allusions to Eutropius in, for example, his narration of the final days of Jovian's short reign, Ammianus strives 'to use the language of breviary to make Jovian's death seem a triviality'.[23] Alluding to Eutropius thus also brings to mind the genre of breviary history: Eutropius provides not just a source of information for Ammianus, but a genre and historiographical practice with which to engage in *aemulatio*.[24]

The allusion to Eutropius 10.16.1 demonstrates Ammianus' awareness of Eutropius' practice of noting his participation in an attempt to gain authority,[25] and by extension the tradition of participant-narrators of the Persian campaign specifically.[26] By deploying the allusion to Eutropius at a different point in his narrative, (that is, elsewhere than at the beginning of the Persian campaign), and indeed at a far less historically significant event (the Silvanus episode), Ammianus also offers a detraction of Eutropius' first-person credentials.[27] Ammianus also avoids drawing too much attention to the fact that, by using the first-person in the Persian campaign, he sets himself within a tradition of participant-historians of this event.

[22] Sabbah 2003, 62 and Kelly 2008, 240.

[23] Kelly 2008, 252.

[24] Most of the passages of Eutropius that Kelly identifies as sources for allusion in Ammianus also appear in the final chapters of the *Breviarium,* e.g. 25.10.12∼Eutr.10.17.3, 25.9.9∼Eutr.10.17.1, 27.6.16∼Eutr. 8.9.2, Kelly 2008, 240–50. The allusion at 15.5.22 also follows and corroborates the pattern.

[25] Marincola 1997, 79 (though Marincola does not seem to be aware of the tradition of participants writing accounts in Greek shortly after 363).

[26] 'Among this crowd of writers, and the swarms of high-ranking soldiers and officials who had accompanied Julian, Ammianus allows his presence to be felt, but he could not claim his uniqueness. It seems likely that, being bilingual and a voracious reader, he had read but not depended on such sources as were available.' Kelly 2008, 78.

[27] Ammianus may also offer a further detraction by using the allusion at 15.5.22 to introduce a series of further first-person verbs (albeit in the plural) whereas Eutropius has only the one. The allusion further exemplifies Ammianus' objections to breviary history: Ammianus will not refer to his presence in a breviary fashion as a single event, but as an on-going feature of his narrative.

Indeed, the way in which the participant enters the narrative in Book 23 is so understated as to seem incidental. Part of the way through the campaign and without any suggestion of why Ammianus is now present, 'having set out from there, we came (*uenimus*) to Zaitha' (23.5.7).

5.2 AMMIANUS' FIRST-PERSON IN PERSIA

The first-person is not a pervasive presence during Ammianus' account of the Persian campaign. There is not even an explicit statement of why he is there or why he suddenly appears as a participant at 23.5.7, unlike during the Gallus and Silvanus episodes.[28] From then on, the 'we' narrator is a frequent but not constant presence within the narrative. As other commentators have noted, the actions that 'we' carry out are predominantly those of movement, principally *uenimus* and its cognates, and refer to the collective actions of the army as a whole.[29] Movement is perhaps the most neutral action that Ammianus could have chosen to denote his own actions with the army, and it cannot be coincidence that *uenimus* is the verb chosen for the participant's last action, just as it had for the first, as 'we came to Antioch (*Antiochiam uenimus*)' (25.10.1). The narratee is frequently reminded of Ammianus' presence, rather than his autopsy specifically, although the former may imply the latter. Indeed, the use of the first-person is a strong method of creating focalization via the participant, but it does not require every verb have

[28] Cf. 15.5.22 mentioned above, and 'amid this variety of disasters Ursicinus, to whose attendance the imperial command had attached me (*cui nos obsecuturos iunxerat imperiale praeceptum*), was summoned from Nisibis' (14.9.1). Matthews, for whom first-person appearances primarily illuminate biographical details, has suggested that Ammianus joined the campaign only at Circesium where the first-person first appears (1989, 140). For a more nuanced interpretation see Smith (1999, 97) who endorses Matthews' suggestion but notes 'an author's decision to narrate in the first-person is also a literary choice and it generates literary effects and questions'.

[29] Kelly 2008, 39–40. There are eleven examples of (*per*)*uenimus* (23.5.7; 24.1.5, .2.1, .2.2, .4.31, .5.1, .8.2; 25.1.4, .8.5, .8.16, .10.1), one of *aduentaremus* (25.9.6) and one of its opposite *discessimus* (24.2.2). *uidimus* appears twice at 23.5.7 and 24.2.3. There are a further fifteen first-person plural verbs used to describe the actions of the participant (24.2.3, .5.5, .7.7, .7.8, .8.7; 25.1.1, .6.4, .6.4, .6.8, .6.10, .6.11, .7.14, .8.3, .8.15).

its subject as 'we'. It is a way to align the narratee with the primary narrator within the framework of the narrative and see the action through his eyes. Take, for example, Smith's analysis of the interaction of verbal forms at the end of Book 24 into Book 25, the famous moment when a dust cloud on the horizon heralds the arrival of the Persian army under Sapor (24.8.6–25.1.2):

> 'Some insisted' (*firmabant*) that the Persians had intercepted 'us' (*nobis*); 'the soldiers having been halted' (an ablative absolute), 'we' rested (*quievimus*) in camp; not until evening could 'that which was so dimly seen' (*quod squalidius videbatur)* be made out for what it was; 'we' passed (*exegimus*) a dark and utterly starless night in doubt and fear, 'no one daring to sit down and close his eyes'; when morning came, gleaming weapons 'seen from afar' (*longe prospecti*) 'showed' (*indicabant*) the arrival of the enemy; 'the troops, set alight by the sight, wished to attack' (*visu accensum, properantem congredi militem*), but 'the emperor forbade them'; there was some fighting, nevertheless, between the Persians and 'our' skirmishers.[30]

Focalization from the Roman (our) perspective clearly heightens the dramatic tension.[31] Though he does not articulate it in such a way, Smith's analysis implies that the proximity of one first-person plural verb transfuses its focalization into other verbs, particularly passives where no agent is specified. Thus it is 'we' who actually saw something dimly (*quod squalidius uidebatur*).[32] Smith rightly notes how this important turning in the fortunes of the Romans is elevated by 'visual perceptions being played upon to express a state of mind or convey a stimulus to action'.[33] But the distribution of the verbal forms also reveals something about the participant's reticence in developing his own role: it is not 'we' who then desire to fight immediately and who have to be restrained by Julian, but *miles*. The group that interacts with Julian never includes the participant, instead he keeps

[30] Smith 1999, 99. For 'participant focalization' without any recourse to the first-person verb, see Pelling 2013's analysis of Caesar's narrator's presentation of the story through the character Caesar's eyes.

[31] Though equally the structural arrangement here, in which the resolution to the question of what causes the dust storm is held over till the beginning of the next book, is as critical in establishing tension.

[32] It is telling that translators of this passage often assign the passive to 'we', so Rolfe's 'For not until evening . . . would we make out what it was that we saw so dimly' and Hamilton's '. . . what it was that we saw through the gloom'.

[33] Smith 1999, 99.

his distance. For example, it is *miles* that respond positively to Julian's speech at 23.5, not 'we'.[34] Moreover, there are long expanses of narrative where the participant recedes from view entirely. There are two particular stretches that are devoid of any first-person verbs, the operations to capture Pirisabora (24.2.9–22) and Maozamalcha (24.4.1–27). Among the numerous Persian strongholds taken, these two are selected for particularly lengthy descriptions, in which Ammianus resumes a purely external narratorial pose common to earlier descriptions of battle.[35] Even the note of arrival, so commonly recorded elsewhere with *uenimus*, at Pirisabora is replaced with *uentum est* (24.2.9). The narrator does talk about 'our cohorts' and 'our soldiers',[36] but with the absence of the participant in these often self-contained sections, the reader is left wondering who the possessing 'we' are. This is especially the case given the tradition within Roman historiography of using *nos* and *nostri* to refer to Roman troops even when there is no suggestion that the narrator was a participant among them.[37] It is certainly a convention that Ammianus' narrator follows elsewhere, where 'our troops' battle the Alamanni and Goths at Strasbourg and Hadrianople respectively,[38] where there is no suggestion that he was present.[39] The effect hinders any attempt by the reader to identify the role of participant—the referent could include the (Roman) narratee as much as the army on the march in Persia. Indeed, if one part of the army is designated as 'our', as, for example, the ships (*naues nostras*, 24.2.2), cohorts (*cohortibus nostris*, 24.4.7), cavalry (*equites nostri*, 24.5.2), or skirmishers (*excursatores nostros*, 25.1.2), could the use of *nostri* rather imply the absence of the participant from this particular group—the partitive use aligning the participant with the larger whole from which 'our' group is a

[34] *miles exultans,* 25.5.25.

[35] Cf. den Boeft et al. 2002, 99, on Maozamalcha: 'his description contains extended passages which are entirely conventional and interchangeable with accounts of other sieges'.

[36] 24.2.13; 24.4.7; 24.4.8; 24.4.12.

[37] The earliest example is found in Cato (*FRHist.* F 82). It was usually reserved, as here in Ammianus, for narrative of Roman conflicts with foreign enemies, though Caesar refers to his side as *nos* in the *BC*, which 'must have been a bold step, and, if not pure arrogance, may perhaps be taken as another indication that the work lacked his *ultima manus*' (Marincola 1997, 287–8).

[38] For example 16.12.15, .17, .19, .20, and .22 (Strasbourg) and 31.13.1, .3, .7, .10 and .16 (Hadrianople).

[39] Ammianus takes himself 'off stage' just before Strasbourg, 16.10.21.

smaller and distinct unit? Such considerations provide good evidence that the prime motivation for the use of first-person forms is not to enable biographical reconstruction.[40] As Ivić has put it, 'the protocol governing the appearance of the first-person plural is not to be looked for exclusively as evidence that he is a witness.'[41]

So if not purely to record participation or to create focalization (which can happen just as well by use of the third person), then why does Ammianus repeatedly draw attention to his presence upon the campaign by using this linguistic feature? One use seems to reinforce the structure of the episode as a whole. At first the participant appears mostly with those ubiquitous verbs of motion, indeed at an early stage of the campaign within Persian territory there is a swift series of five alone in 24.2 as successively we arrive at Thilutha (24.2.1), come to and leave Achaiachala (*uenissimus . . . discessimus*, 24.2.2), see a temple in Diacira and occupy Ozogardana (*uidimus . . . occupauimus*, 24.2.3). But once the situation worsens as they approach Ctesiphon, firstly 'we were shocked by a sad misfortune' (*tristi percellimur facto*, 24.5.5: a successful Persian raid that killed several pack animals and their attendants); then, more seriously, the Persians' plans (unveiled by the external narrator) are to torture us with hunger (*ut inedia nos cruciarent*, 24.7.7).[42] As a result of their scorched earth policy 'we were forced to stay (*tenebamur*) in a permanent camp' (24.7.7). The participant slowly falls victim to the Persians; active verbs become passive, and the pronoun *nos* frequently becomes the object of the enemy's action, who 'secretly attend us as we departed this place' (*hinc nos egressos, Persae . . . occulte comitabantur*) (25.3.1). This pattern intensifies after the death of Julian. Although 'we' still occupy Charcha (25.6.8) and arrive at Dura (25.6.9), 'we' endure hostile Saracens (*patiebamur,* 25.6.10), are hard pressed by lack of food and water (*premebamur*, 25.7.14). The Persians attack us as we camp in the valley, *nos hostes . . . incessebant* (25.6.6); fear grips us (*nos . . . opprimit timor*, 25.8.4), in a marked narrative change from the purely external narration of earlier successful conflicts with the Persians, the sieges of Pirisabora and Maozamalcha.

[40] For such biographical reconstructions, see Dillemann 1961, 96–7.

[41] Ivić 2004, 326.

[42] The participant later proves the interpretation correct, 'since we were without supplies we were tormented by hunger (*commeatibus nos destitutos inedia cruciabat*) that was already unendurable', 25.2.1.

Ammianus' inclusion of himself as a character in the narrative of the Persian campaign should be read as a response to the tradition of participant-narration that had grown up around the event. Going beyond a simple statement of his presence, he uses the actions of the first-person protagonists to create an autoptic frame for the entire narrative of the campaign and indeed to track the fortunes of the Roman army itself. It is a far more extensive use of the 'interpretative' participant that we had already witnessed in Books 14 and 15, yet it fulfils a similar purpose: to guide the change in interpretation of the episode, here from triumph and optimism to defeat and despair.

5.3 BETWEEN PRAISE AND BLAME—THE EPIDEICTIC TRADITION

Participant credentials are not the only aspect of the tradition of the Persian campaign that had developed in the more than twenty years between the event and Ammianus' likely time of composition. Indeed, despite Eutropius' vaunted participation in Persia, his actual narrative of the campaign, which comprises two sentences, provided little competition for Ammianus' grandiose version. Rather, the main narrative accounts prior to that of Ammianus came from the eastern Greek tradition. Despite the industrious activity of veterans to write up their versions in the mid-360s, discussed above, two Greek narratives, well before Eunapius could have written his history, came to dominate the debate over the role of the Persian campaign and its impact upon Julian's legacy, even though their authors had not participated themselves. Libanius' *Oration* 18 is familiar from discussions in earlier chapters. Its composition in 365 was his second response to Julian's death. In the immediate aftermath, he had composed *Oration* 17, a Monody on Julian, full of outpouring of emotion, as the rules of the genre demanded,[43] but lacking in many details of Julian's final campaign.[44] *Oration* 18, or *Epitaphius*, was most likely composed in

[43] 'What then is the purpose of the monody? To lament and express pity.' Men. Rh. 2.16.

[44] Dated to spring 364. Wiemer 1995, 251–5.

mid-365.[45] In comparison with the Monody, it bears witness to Libanius' efforts to uncover details of the campaign, attested also from the letters to Philagrius and Seleucus, and devotes nearly a quarter of its length to a narrative of Julian's expedition in Persia.[46]

Within a matter of months Gregory Nazianzen responded with a text (*Oration* 5) that likewise addressed 'questions of Julian's afterlife and the manner in which he ought to be memorialized'.[47] This was Gregory's second oration 'Against Julian', but unlike its predecessor *Oration* 4, it dwells at length upon Julian's activities in Persia.[48] For both Libanius and Gregory, the Persian campaign posed a problem: for Julian's supporters, such as Libanius, what should have been the military climax of Julian's career instead had to be explained or excused as a defeat. For Christian opponents, like Gregory, Julian's death was no simple triumph over the Apostate. It had been brought about by external opponents, the Persians, not by the hands of Christians within the empire. Furthermore, the defeat of a Roman army was not a topic for outright exultation, particularly since the shameful treaty that had saved the remnants of the army at the expense of important Roman territory in Mesopotamia was concluded by the new Christian emperor, Jovian.[49]

As Elm has recently argued, Libanius and Gregory were engaged in a very public debate over the interpretation of Julian's reign. Gregory was largely responsible for the creation of the 'Apostate', a view of Julian that endured in Christian circles in the East.[50] His material and

[45] At the latest before the earthquake on 21 July 365 (*pace* Van Nuffelen 2006). Elm (2012a, 439) suggests it was composed for the anniversary of Julian's birthday in late May or early June 365.

[46] *Or.* 18.204–80, i.e. seventy-six of the 308 sections in modern editions.

[47] Elm 2012a, 342–3. Elm places Gregory's text in late 365 or early 366, thus in the midst of Procopius' revolt, 'at a time when these issues were particularly pressing for pagans and Christians'. Lugaresi 1997, 14–23 lists a set of correspondences which suggests Gregory responded to Libanius.

[48] Gregory devotes over a third of his text to a narrative account of Julian's demise in Persia. He uses a narrative format in three places elsewhere in his two invectives against Julian, 4.85, 4.88, and 5.38, none of which involve Julian directly (Kennedy 1983, 222). Only 5.3–19 provides a sustained narrative of Julian's deeds.

[49] Elm 2012a, 340.

[50] Sabbah 1978, 367; Elm 2012a, 337. Gregory's second oration against Julian also addressed the contemporary political context of Procopius' rebellion: 'Whom should the true Christian public official support as emperor? The Arian Pannonian Valens, or the Christian scion of Constantine and Constantius's dynasty who, like Julian, presented himself with a beard and was Julian's cousin?' Elm 2012a, 434.

inspiration for doing so was the sympathetic portrayal of Julian found in Libanius, yet Libanius went on defending the memory of Julian for the next thirty years, though he did not offer a narrative of the Persian invasion in any of his subsequent orations.[51]

Both authors chose to embed a narrative of the Persian campaign within their epideictic works. The phenomenon is not uncommon in Late Antiquity: Julian, for example, had included extensive narrative of the siege of Nisibis in his two panegyrics to Constantius in the late 350s.[52] Epideictic's use of narrative brought it into generic proximity of historiography, as Roger Rees has recently observed.[53] Rees goes on, however, to note that although the form of narrative in epideictic and historiography may be very similar, its function was quite different. In panegyric's usual performative context, before the honorand and an audience, who would likely already know the details of the event narrated (particularly if that event was, for example, a recent war, during which the honorand was in command, and the audience had been participants), narrative is deprived of the main purpose it serves in historiography, namely a cognitive function of providing *cognitio rerum.* It is a point we find in Pliny, Trajan's panegyrist, who agonizes in a letter that: 'in [panegyric] everything is already known, common knowledge, discussed' (*Ep.* 3.13.2).[54] Narrative in epideictic, according to Rees, instead performs 'celebratory' or 'evidential' functions, to glorify the deeds of the honorand or to offer proof of certain of his virtues respectively.

Rees based his study on the *Panegyrici Latini*, a group of speeches that were all composed for (and mostly delivered before) living emperors. Neither Libanius or Gregory claim to be writing *basilikos logos* or *psogos* directly, but their works are clearly identifiable as epideictic. However, they are both generically curious for being targeted at a dead subject, Julian. Their audience, then, was not like that of the *Panegyrici Latini* (those who already knew of or had actually participated in the events narrated) and so the cognitive

[51] *Or.* 24 'On avenging Julian' was addressed to Theodosius and delivered in 379. In an oration of the mid- to late-380s, Libanius alludes to Julian as one 'who would have broken the power of Persia, had not treason prevented his design' (*Or.* 30.40). Swain 2004, 399–400.

[52] *Or.* 1.27A–29A and *Or.* 3.62A–67A. I discuss Julian's use of narrative in Ross 2014.

[53] Rees 2010, 107. I take Rees' points to apply equally to invective, since it largely follows the same rules as panegyric though inverted (Flower 2013, 55).

[54] Rees 2010, 110.

function must be more important, especially in the case of Libanius, who has left us evidence of attempts to gather information the likes of Philagrius in order to present it in his own terms. Libanius turned to a narrative format in order to present a quasi-historical account of Julian that best suited his needs in presenting his interpretation of Julian's reign, especially since there was a burgeoning eastern tradition of narrative accounts by participants. Libanius' choice to use narrative was also an attempt to provide what he considered a definitive version of events. One could say the same for Gregory, who chooses to respond to Libanius' presentation of the Persian campaign with a narrative account of his own. Libanius' and Gregory's success is attested by the loss of all the other eastern, participant-versions discussed above.

Ammianus knew of both Libanius and Gregory's works. Ammianus does not name any contemporary texts (or their authors) other than Julian's,[55] and even then, as we have seen above, he is selective: the *Misopogon* can be mentioned, but not the *Panegyrics* to Constantius and Eusebia. There are clear allusions, however, to Libanius elsewhere in the *Res Gestae,*[56] and given the 'para-historical' nature of *Oration* 18 particularly, together with Ammianus' connections to Antioch, it is inescapable that Ammianus was highly familiar with this text.[57] Sabbah has also argued for Ammianus' familiarity with Gregory's orations: for example Ammianus transposes Gregory's attacks on Julian, especially relating to Julian's supposed lack of gratitude to Constantius, into the mouth of Constantius in his speech at 21.13 denouncing Julian's rebellion against him.[58] While Ammianus' choice to write in Latin and in the West may have been an attempt to distance himself from the Greek debate that took place a generation earlier in the Antioch and Cappadocia, Libanius' and Gregory's

[55] See Chapter 4.1.

[56] E.g. an allusion to *Or.* 24.4 in the description of the aftermath of Ad Salices (Kelly 2008, 19). Ammianus also appears to 'correct' Libanius' suggestion that Julian should be buried in Athens rather than Tarsus (*Or.* 18.306). Ammianus instead suggests Rome for his final resting place, 25.10.5. See Epilogue. Kelly 2008, 296. For a further two examples, see Sabbah 1978, 267–8.

[57] Sabbah 1978, 258–9. Cf. Kelly 2008, 255.

[58] Sabbah 1978, 369. Elm (2012a, 441 n.32) cautiously endorses the argument that Ammianus knew Gregory, citing Barnes' contention that he was familiar with Christian literature generally, 1998, 156–8 and 254–5.

epideictic narratives represented the dominant tradition that he inevitably had to react against.[59]

Nevertheless, Libanius and Gregory had introduced two important (non-military) methods of judging Julian's failure into the discourse on Persia.[60] Libanius' Julian is 'firmly incorporated within Greek myth and Greek thought' in *Oration* 18, and compared positively to a range of Greek *exempla*, Achilles (66), Nicias (127), Socrates (155), Agamemnon (173), Proteus (176), Calchas and Tiresias (245), Themistocles and Brasidas (281), Leonidas, Epaminondas, Sarpedon, Memnon, Alexander 'son of Zeus' (297), and Plato (306).[61] Exemplarity allows Libanius to cast Julian not only in a positive and heroic light, but as the continuator of a particularly Hellenic tradition of figures. Gregory too turns to *exempla* in his narrative of the Persian campaign (*Or.* 5.8):

> He [Julian] had his eyes fixed on the Trajans and the Hadrians, persons whose prudence was no less admirable than their courage. He did not think of that Carus, or that Valerian, who paid the penalty of an inconsiderate attack, (because one must not blame it on chance, as the tragedian says) and who perished on the frontiers of the Persians, when they were at the zenith of their prosperity.

Gregory's *exempla* are less idealistic; recent Roman emperors are perhaps inherently less heroic than ancient warriors. And Gregory exploits the opportunity afforded by the use of narrative to contrast the thoughts of the character (known and reported by the privileged narrator) with the judgements of the primary narrator himself. He overlays Julian's choice of *exempla* with those of his own (negative) ones: Carus died in the process of invading Persia, and Valerian was captured.[62]

[59] Matthews sketches a situation in which 'the campaign must for a time have been the dominating subject of conversation in the streets, bars and dining-rooms of Antioch and every other eastern city'. He goes on to imagine Ammianus correcting extravagant accounts that were being bandied about by other veterans (1989, 163). This depiction rather overlooks the most startling aspect of Ammianus' history—its composition in Latin, which immediately sets it apart from the eastern tradition, and at a date far after such a debate had died down on the streets of Antioch.

[60] Indeed, Libanius presents the campaign up to the moment of Julian's death as a complete success. Even the decision to burn the ships and abandon Ctesiphon is presented positively (*Or.* 18.267, 283). There is no reason, then, for Libanius to explain Julian's strategic shortcomings. Cf. Seager 1998, 291.

[61] Swain 2004, 297.

[62] Carus died after taking Ctesiphon in 282 on the Tigris, either from illness or after being struck by lightning (Aur. Vict. 38.4–6). Valerian was captured by the Persians at Edessa in 260 (Eutrop. 9.7). Lugaresi notes that Julian had not treated

Similarly, both authors dwell on the problematic topic of divination. If Julian was favoured by the gods, why then did they let him die? It is a theme to which Libanius turns only after concluding the narrative of the Persian campaign, 'why then, you gods and immortal powers, did you not bring [Roman victory] to pass?' (*Or.* 18.281). Libanius reserves his comment for the periphery of the narrative of the Persian campaign. Julian as a character is not presented with any divine signs; thus he could not be accused of failing to interpret them correctly, especially since he had successfully done so to predict the death of Constantius earlier (*Or.* 18.180). Instead Julian is the unknowing victim of the 'unalterable degrees of fate' (*Or.* 18.298).[63] Gregory takes up the same theme with alacrity:

> He received a wound truly seasonable (or mortal) and salutary for the whole world, and by a single cut from his executioner he pays the penalty for the many entrails of victims to which he has trusted (to his own destruction); but what surprises me, is how the vain man, that fancied he learned the future from that means, knew nothing of the wound about to be inflicted on his own entrails! The concluding reflection is for once very appropriate: the liver of the victim was the approved means for reading the future, and it was precisely in that organ that the arch-diviner received the fatal thrust. (*Or.* 5.13).[64]

Gregory ironically portrays 'the great haruspex [who] could not read even his own exposed entrails'.[65] Gregory also reserves his comments on divination and divine will until after the conclusion of his narrative. It is not difficult to see why both authors adopt this approach. To have included omens or sacrifices within the course of the narrative would have forced Libanius to explain why Julian did not interpret them correctly, and Gregory to acknowledge the possibility of efficacy of pagan divination.

In Ammianus' version, both phenomena, *exempla* and omens, play an important and prominent role in the narrative. It is difficult to know whether Eunapius incorporated these two phenomena into his

Hadrian and Trajan wholly positively in his *Caesars*, which may have been Gregory's motivation for including them here ironically as Julian's chosen *exempla*. Lugaresi 1997, 188.

[63] Bouffartigue 2002, 186.

[64] Translations of Gregory are taken from King 1888, often adapted.

[65] Elm 2012a, 455. Lugaresi 1997, 200 sees this as a response to Libanius' claim that Julian correctly used omens to predict his victory against Constantius (*Or.* 18.180).

version; Zosimus has left us a largely 'factual' account of Julian's itinerary, which elides this sort of material, if it had existed in Eunapius at all.[66] Below we will consider how Ammianus follows Libanius' and Gregory's focus on divination and the ways in which he deals with the problem that the epideictic texts so obviously dodged: how the primary narrator mediates the interpretation of these events, particularly relating to Julian's perception and understanding of them.

5.4 OMENS

Unlike Libanius and Gregory, Ammianus weaves several ominous events into the course of his narrative of the Persian campaign. His decision to do so stands in contrast not just to these two authors of epideictic—Zosimus also includes no mention of any divinatory or religious activity during the campaign. Indeed, he conspicuously draws his reader's attention to his unwillingness to discuss the topic, noting only 'unfavourable sacrifices' at the outset of the campaign in Antioch, and claiming: 'I know why this was, but I will pass over it in silence' (3.12.1).[67] Eunapius' Julian foresees disturbances that will occur after his death but, from the fragments we have, shows no awareness of his own death via divination.[68]

[66] See nn.67 and 68. Eunapius' fragments themselves shed little light on the issue. The debate about the relationship between Eunapius', Zosimus', and Ammianus' accounts of the Persian campaign have largely dealt with 'factual' details (as dictated by the evidence of Zosimus) such as place names and the order of events (see Fornara 1991 for a sensible discussion of the issue, though his ultimate conclusion that Ammianus paid little heed to existing accounts, I cannot fully support). If Zosimus' note that 'at the time of his death, Julian had almost entirely destroyed the Persian empire' reflects Eunapius' summation of the campaign, then Eunapius himself appears to have adopted Libanius' presentation that it was successful up to the moment of Julian's death with no major shortcomings on the part of Julian. Ultimately, it was Gregory and Libanius who conditioned the terms of the subsequent debate of Julian's record in Persia.

[67] Paschoud suggests Zosimus wants to 'disguise the incoherent and inexplicable conduct of the pagan hero' (1979, 104).

[68] 'Julian, either as a result of asking the gods or by using his own reasoning, foresaw from afar the Scythian disturbances, which were still concealed, as it were in murky water' (fr. 27 (Blockley)). Theodoret (*HE* 3.16) mentions Julian's consultation of the oracles of Dodona, Delphi, and Delos, but does so in order to prove the inherent falseness of pagan divinatory practices, rather than Julian's misinterpretation of them.

By incorporating ominous events, which had been actively ignored, downplayed, or displaced by earlier authors, into his narrative of the campaign, Ammianus brought the *Res Gestae* more closely into line with the Roman historiographical tradition.[69] Omens and prodigies had long formed a part of the traditional material for Roman historiography.[70] Livy posts lists of prodigies at the opening and closing of the consular years,[71] and records their expiation or lack thereof by the Roman state.[72] Rather different from the omens of imperial historians, Livy's prodigies 'did not foretell anything in particular, but merely put forward a general warning of disaster unless precautions were taken'.[73] The recurring and formulaic nature of these prodigy lists allows Livy to manipulate this feature of his narrative in order to pass wider comment on the Roman state.[74]

Unlike Livy, Tacitus shows a greater tendency to weave the notification of prodigies and omens into the course of the narrative.[75] In doing so, he opens up the possibility of using the interpretation of signs by a character (particularly the emperor) as a method of character portrayal, especially by contrasting differing interpretations of an omen by varying groups within the narrative.[76] Tacitus responded

[69] The report of ominous events was often connected to the execution (or alteration) of military manoeuvres under the Republic. See Driediger-Murphy 2011, 71–83, who argues that such omens were not as open to manipulation as some have thought.

[70] Rosen 1968, 156. [71] Levene 1993, 35–6.

[72] Morgan's description of the Livian manner of noting omens and prodigies as 'serving up prodigy reports . . . in slabs of material at the start and end of year' captures nicely the lack of integration of ominous material within Livy's narrative (2000, 29).

[73] Levene 1993, 4. [74] Levene 1993, 38–77. [75] Morgan 2000, 29.

[76] Morgan 2000 surveys Tacitus' use of omens in *Histories* 1–3. For example, Galba fails to interpret omens correctly (a sign that he is out of touch with the situation around him), whereas the prodigy report at the end of *Histories* 1 acts as a clear prolepsis of Otho's failure for primary narratee and internal audience alike. Tacitus, then, is predominately interested in the ways in which omens are interpreted by characters within his narrative. Cf. Damon 2003, 273–5, for the traditions surrounding the place of omens and prodigies in the work of earlier Roman historians. The difference between prodigies and omens in republican times in particular should be noted: prodigies were 'events which the senate declared significant of divine feeling towards the Roman state' whereas omens 'were believed to foretell success or disaster for a particular undertaking or individual'. Strictly speaking what we find in the *Res Gestae* are exclusively omens. (Ammianus seems to use the terms *omen* and *portentum* interchangeably: cf. 23.2.7 *illaetabile portentum* and 23.5.6 *omen illaetabile).* There was no scope for state recognition of prodigies let alone expiation, as Ammianus himself explains at 19.12.20.

to a wider development during the imperial period that publicly observed omens or portents when reported by historians no longer referred to the general well-being of the state, but were now indications of an upcoming change of emperor.[77]

Throughout the *Res Gestae,* ominous activity is connected to the fate of emperors,[78] but the greatest number of omens clusters around Julian's Persian campaign. Those who have studied Ammianus' attitude to religion have, by and large, reached a consensus on his presentation of Julian's relationship to divination. Julian was confronted with a number of divine signs that indicated his failure. He either ignored them or sided with those who were willing to provide a positive interpretation, even when an opposing interpretation was offered by other groups within the narrative.[79] The most obvious example of this comes in 23.5.10–11, where the Etruscan haruspices interpret the slaying of a lion by some of Julian's troops as a strong indication that Julian must not continue his campaign, whereas the *Philosophi* counsel the opposite. The campaign continues, so Julian must have sided with the philosophers and thus must also have made the wrong choice. Generally, modern critics have interpreted Ammianus' stance as an attempt to defend the efficacy of traditional divination—omens still correctly predicted future events; it was Julian who was at fault for being unable, or unwilling, to understand and follow them.

According to this view, Ammianus wished to defend the practice of divination against those Christians, such as Gregory, who, as we have seen, jeeringly mocked Julian for not being able to foresee his own failure because the science of divination was flawed (thus Rike and

[77] Early imperial authors such as Velleius and Valerius Maximus even seem to have added extra omens to their account of the death of Caesar retrospectively in order to make Caesar's death conform to the contemporary expectations of the imperial period. Ripat 2006, 169–70.

[78] Julian perceives omens of Constantius' death at 21.1.6; ominous activity accompanies Valentinian's elevation to Augustus, 26.1.7, and omens forewarn him of his own death, 30.5.16–19; Valens is unaware of the omens of his demise, 31.1.1–5, 31.14.8–9. Various plots against imperial figures are galvanized by ominous activity, 14.7.7, 15.3.7, 29.1.7. Scardigli 2011, 245.

[79] For Rike the Persian campaign 'depicts the triumph of divination and Julian's final separation from this invaluable art' (1987, 63). Davies sees Julian as willing only to take on board positive interpretations (2004, 252), whereas Brodka suggests Julian was fated to adopt the incorrect interpretation (2009, 84–5).

Davies);[80] or else Ammianus defends traditional divinatory practices because they were part of contemporary debate in Rome of the 380s (Liebeschuetz);[81] Ambrose had referred to Julian's defeat and the negative role of the *haruspices* in his second letter on the Altar of Victory in 384[82] in evident support of Gratian's confiscation of the *haruspices*' endowments.[83] For Brodka the effectiveness of omens is a necessary aspect of Julian's self-sacrifice in order to maintain the glory of the Roman state—Julian knew the campaign would result in his death, but he carried on regardless.[84] In the interpretations of Liebeschuetz, Rike, and Davies, at least, Ammianus protects the status of divination at the expense of Julian's reputation as a religious innovator.

Other scholars are right to point to Ammianus' endorsement of divination, but given the careful placement of omens within the narrative, it is worth considering how this endorsement works from a narratological perspective. Omens are a recurrent part of the campaign, but not constant phenomena. They tend to appear in dense pockets, and mark important turning points in the narrative; the departure from Antioch (23.1.5–7); the end of the feinting manoeuvre that took the army to Carrhae, from which they might have advanced into Persia via either the Tigris or the Euphrates (they turn south towards the Euphrates) 23.3.3 and .6–.7; then the entry into Persian territory at the crossing of the Abora, 23.5. From then on there is a long hiatus in ominous activity, during which Julian's successful military operations along the Euphrates take centre stage. It is broken by a faulty sacrifice to Mars at Ctesiphon, during which the offered bull 'showed ominous signs' (*ominosa signa monstrauit*, 24.6.17) and Julian swears never to sacrifice to Mars again. This episode heralds the decision to abandon the siege of Ctesiphon and to burn the fleet (24.7.1–4). Julian's death itself is similarly marked by ominous activity; Julian sees the image of the *Genius Publicus* on the night before he is fatally injured, just as he

[80] 'Julian was a *dabbler* in divination: he overrode legitimate authorities and had too much faith in his own judgement and plans.' Davies 2004, 252.

[81] Liebeschuetz 1988.

[82] 'As for Julian, what need I say? He destroyed his own means of retreat, because he had unwisely trusted the responses of soothsayers' (*Ep.* 73.38).

[83] Liebeschuetz 1988, 204, citing Ambrose *Ep.* 73.16. See also Cameron 2011, 43.

[84] Brodka 2009, 76–105, especially 81 and 92.

had before his acclamation in Gaul,[85] though now she is veiled and sorrowful (25.2.3). On the same night he sees a comet, and 'filled with fear' (*horroreque perfusus est*, 25.2.4), summons the *haruspices*, who warn him not to enter battle.

By clustering omens together, Ammianus can give prominence to moments in the narrative he considers significant, and thus the placement of these omens is deliberate rather than random. More than that, his discussion of omens can establish a framework for the narratee to judge how characters in the text respond to proleptic warnings of future events. The narrator on a number of occasions discusses the efficacy of divinatory practices, none more explicitly than in a digression at 21.1.7–14 where the mechanism for auguries, auspices, haruspicy, oracles, and dreams is attributed to the control of Themis, 'so named because she reveals in advance decrees determined for the future by the law of the fates' (21.1.8). Omens or ominous signs (*omina* or *praesagia*) may not be mentioned here, but the digression nonetheless establishes the potential for divine signs to foretell the future; if they are misinterpreted, the fault lies with the interpreter, not the sign. It is a point memorably reinforced by the narrator's analogy that even professional interpreters can be wrong, just as a grammarian can be ungrammatical, a musician sing out of tune, or a doctor fail to find a remedy (21.1.13).[86] The placement of this information here is not without importance. Digressions necessarily are apostrophes by the primary narrator to the primary narratee. They stand outside the action of the narrative and their contents are unknowable to the characters within the text, and, unless we detect the pose of an 'unreliable narrator' (which is not the case in Ammianus or any other ancient historian, even the narrator of the *Historia Augusta*),[87] the narratee must presume the presentation is correct: omens must always correctly foretell the future.

Although omens are not explicitly mentioned in the digression in Book 21, the narrator frequently endorses their efficacy when they occur within the narrative. Take, for example, the first omen in

[85] Thus Ammianus uses this divine appearance to mark the beginning of Julian's reign as his acclamation (20.5.10) rather than the (legally more defensible) death of Constantius.

[86] Davies 2004, 253–4.

[87] For the classic discussion of the unreliability in fiction, see Booth 1961. The historian's narrator constantly works hard to impart the impression of reliability, particularly by all those topoi outlined in Marincola 1997.

Book 23 before Julian sets out from Antioch on the campaign. Felix, the *comes largitionum*, and Julian, the *comes Orientis* (the emperor's uncle), die in quick succession. The people of Antioch, after reading Julian's full title on inscriptions, recognize who will be next: *Julianus Felix Augustus* (23.1.5). Ammianus records Julian's reaction, *terrebatur omine*. The narratee is alerted to the fact that Julian understands that this is a negative prediction—fear is traditionally the correct action for one exposed to the correct interpretation of a negative omen.[88] However, to confirm the negative aspect of this omen, Ammianus states that this is indeed a correct prediction of the future: Julian 'was alarmed by an omen which, as the result showed (*ut docuit exitus*), was most trustworthy (*praesentissimo*)'. The primary narrator offers a prolepsis. The indicative *docuit* suggests that what Ammianus now predicts about the teleology of this omen is in fact correct even if it is brief and does not contain any detail; Ammianus does not tell us specifically that Julian will die, let alone when or how. The pattern is repeated in further omens at the end of this paragraph, where each omen is accompanied by the narrator's prolepsis: 'other lesser signs (*minora signa*) also indicated from time to time what came to pass (*quod acciderat, ostendebant*)' (23.1.7), though Ammianus does not record the reaction of Julian directly.

Ammianus provides a degree of authorial validation of omens that was unheard of in either Livy or Tacitus.[89] This validation is provided, however, only for the primary narratee. Indeed, then, if omens always correctly foretell events and are inherently proleptic, then one of their chief uses within the narrative is to allow the primary narratee to witness their interpretation by the characters within the narrative.[90] One might have expected that Julian's reactions to omens would provide the prime point of comparison between the narratee's awareness of their proleptic nature, but this is rarely the case. Certainly Julian's reaction to the *Felix Iulianus Augustus* omen, the first in Book 23, is openly recorded; but this is the exception rather

[88] E.g. Tacitus *Hist.* 1.86.1: *prodigia insuper terrebant.*

[89] Davies 2004, 267. For the 'number of occasions on which [Tacitus] expressed doubts—sarcastically, it goes without saying—not only about the interpretation of particular omens but even about their validity', see Morgan 2000; Damon 2003, 275.

[90] Davies notes that omens and prodigies in Ammianus no longer provoke the traditional response of expiation on behalf of the state (2004, 238; cf. Liebeschuetz 1988, 201). The purpose of omens, then, lies exclusively in their power to foretell future events, and thus they are also narratologically more potent.

than the rule throughout the Persian campaign. We do not know how Julian reacted to the other omens in 23.1, the ominous death of a priest (*aliud saeuum*, 23.1.6), or an earthquake in Constantinople (23.1.7). Equally, at 23.3.6, Julian orders sacrifices to confirm the interpretation of the omen but the narratee receives no information on the outcome of this procedure (23.3.7). As we will examine in more depth below, the rival interpretations provided by *haruspices* and *philosophi* (23.5.11 and .13–.14) go without a description of Julian's reaction to them directly. The narrator's unwillingness to clarify the character's reaction to these clearly proleptic omens leaves certain questions unanswerable; did Julian accept but ignore the correct interpretation provided by the likes of the *haruspices*, or had he ceased to believe in the power of omens?[91] The latter explanation would have set him at odds with the narrator's interpretation of the efficacy of omens, yet that long hiatus, mentioned above, between the dense cluster of omens at 23.5 and the decision to give up on Ctesiphon at 24.6.17 was a period of continuous martial success, where the narrative of cities captured and lands ravaged appeared at odds with the doom-laden predictions of the interpreter (and the narrator).

Only at 25.2 is the question of Julian's reaction to interpretation resolved. The narrator is explicit that Julian spurned the advice (*spernente*) of the *haruspices* and states that 'the emperor was opposed to the whole science of divination' (*imperatore omni uaticandi scientia reluctante*, 25.2.8). Again, there is a narratological reason for resolving this question only now: the next event in the narrative is Julian's fatal wounding. Julian's blatant rift with divinatory practice is short-lived, however. Once carried back to his tent, he acquiesces to his imminent death because he learns the place he was wounded is called Phrygia, 'for he had heard that it was fate's decree (*praescripta . . . sorte*) that he should die there' (25.3.9), and later confirms in his deathbed speech that 'I learned long ago through the words of a trustworthy prophecy (*fide fatidica praecinente*), that

[91] The narrator's unwillingness to draw a definitive conclusion in other episodes and on other matters has recently been explored by Weisweiler 2015, who suggests Ammianus constructs an 'image of fourth-century history which is always provisional, a work in progress' reflecting the political uncertainty of the times. The period of Ammianus' history was no less unstable than that of Tacitus or Herodian's, however, I would suggest that the moments of narratorial inconclusiveness are localized and serve particular purposes (see Chapter 2.5 on Silvanus).

I should perish by the sword' (25.2.19). The narrator does not intervene on either of these occasions in order to provide a clarification, which perhaps could have taken the form of an analepsis of when or where this mysterious prediction was made.[92] It certainly does not match up closely to any of the omens in Books 23 or 24.

The deathbed scene, nevertheless, reconciles Julian with the science of divination, which he now treats seriously, though too late to save himself. Whatever Julian's interpretation of omens earlier in the campaign, at its end he assumes the same attitude to their efficaciousness as the narrator had. It is striking, however, that the narrator had not prepared the narratee for this, the most important omen of all. Zonaras says Julian was presented with the prediction in a vision by a blond-haired youth while at Antioch (13.13.29), whereas Eunapius places a prophecy to Julian while he is on his deathbed.[93] Both authors are far more explicit about the details and delivery of this ominous event than Ammianus. Nevertheless Ammianus' withholding of the details of this omen provides a further instance of a narratorial phenomenon that links the moment of Julian's death to that of his acclamation in Book 20 in which Julian's vision of the *Genius Publicus* is revealed only after he has accepted the troops' acclamation. On both occasions a key, divine phenomenon that has been experienced by Julian is denied a proleptic use for the narratee, who learns of it only when Julian reveals it to an internal audience. Despite the frequent assumption of narratorial privilege assumed by Ammianus, Julian maintains a curious aloofness at these two critical moments.

Ammianus deliberately obscures Julian's response to omens until the last moment, and even then, he allows Julian to be reconciled to the process of divination. The charges laid against Julian by those who have studied Ammianus' attitude to religion that the emperor was a 'dabbler' have a degree of application. The way in which Ammianus' narrator controls the text's discourse on divination, however, deliberately obscures the opportunity to reach this conclusion definitively

[92] Den Boeft et al. 2005, 98, note the way Ammianus makes Julian introduce his revelation about the prediction, *nec fateri pudebit*, 'implies that Julian is going to reveal something which one might have expected him to keep to himself'.

[93] Eunapius fr. 28.6 quotes a verse-prophecy that predicts Julian's soul will journey to Olympus while his body is taken back to Seleucia. Julian's reaction is to be 'elated (ἀρθέντα)'. Ammianus' version, by contrast, makes no mention of his deification, nor does he for any other emperor.

before the moment of Julian's death. We as readers know that Julian is fated to die, but we are left unsure as to whether Julian was fully aware of this also.

The technique allows Ammianus to weave omens into his narrative, which are useful for heightening the dramatic tension at key turning points, whilst saving Julian from the outright charge that he was entirely oblivious to his fate. Indeed, as already intimated, omens do not go uninterpreted within the narrative—if the primary narratee is rarely allowed to view Julian's reaction, the interpretation of other groups fills the void, particularly the *haruspices* and philosophers who twice offer competing advice and on both occasions the narrator supports the former over the latter (23.5.10; 25.2.7–8). The correct form of interpretation then is particularly associated with Italy and the West. These *haruspices* were specifically Etruscan, and the negative omens that they interpret correctly in Persia have resonances back in Italy and Rome specifically. The *haruspices* use the Tarquitian books to interpret the appearance of a shooting star (25.2.7).[94] The list of *minora signa* at 23.1.7 is concluded by the report to Julian that the Sibylline oracles at Rome forbade the emperor to leave the borders of the empire that year. The same night that Julian had a dream that seemed to predict a bad outcome to the campaign, the temple of Apollo burned in Rome (23.3.4). Ammianus continues to synchronize events between Persia and the eternal city: at his arrival at Callinicum Julian observed the rites of the Magna Mater because this was the day of her festival in Rome (23.3.7). The narrative of this particularly eastern event, which had received so much attention by eastern authors before Ammianus, is brought in this work of Latin historiography within a more Roman frame: the very fabric of Rome (in the form of the temple of Apollo) responds to the fate of its emperor on the other side of the empire.[95] The culmination of this process is perhaps Ammianus' statement that Julian should have been buried at Rome rather than Tarsus (25.10.5).[96]

[94] Etruscan texts translated into Latin in the late Republic. Den Boeft et al. 1998, 17.

[95] It was fortuitous for Ammianus to be able to connect the destruction of a temple of the god of prophecy in Rome to the catalogue of ominous activity in Persia. Rike 1987, 27, rightly notes the balance between the destruction of the temples of Apollo in Rome and Antioch (for the latter, see 22.13.1–3).

[96] Den Hengst (2010, 228–9) also notes that the Roman cardinal virtues attributed to Julian in his death notice and Ammianus' suggestion that Julian should have been buried at Rome not Tarsus are part of the author's 'Romanization' of Julian.

Omens, then, establish a method of judging and explaining Julian's failure. It is significant that this framework is noticeably Roman in character. It is not the only way that Julian's last campaign is 'Romanized' by the narrator.

5.5 JULIAN AS HISTORIAN—THE INTERPRETATION OF *EXEMPLA*

To turn to the other aspect of Libanius and Gregory's discourse on the Persian campaign, Ammianus also treats *exempla* within his narrative, and gives them far more valency as a method of judging Julian's failure than he did omens. Ammianus has Julian deliver a speech in *oratio recta* at the moment of the army's entry into Persian territory, at the crossing of the Abora river (23.5.16–23). In this speech he draws explicitly on his knowledge of earlier, exemplary leaders who had invaded Persian territory before him, in a way that allows the reader to pass comment on his motivations through a process of subtle intertextuality. As noted above, the speech scene is also marked by a cluster of omens (23.5.6–14) and by the first appearance of the participant (23.5.7). Ammianus uses multiple phenomena to mark the importance of this moment in the narrative—omens, the appearance of the participant, the speech itself, and the lengthy digression on the geography and peoples of Persia in the subsequent Chapter 23.6, which concludes the book. The narrative of the campaign within enemy territory begins only in Book 24. The order in which these markers appear was chosen carefully, not least since the positioning of the speech after the omens, yet also at the very moment of the crossing of the Abora, required some chronological slipperiness that has provoked several modern attempts to exculpate or condemn Ammianus for at best inelegance or at worse a flaw.[97] Most commentators note how Julian's speech (23.5.16–23) appears to ignore the

[97] The speech is introduced with a statement of the breaking up of the bridge, via which Julian and the army had just crossed the Abora (*fracto igitur, ut ante dictum est, ponte,* 23.5.15), whereas the dismantling had already been noted at 23.5.5 (*pontem auelli praecepit*). Thompson 1947, 29, blames Ammianus' careless editing; however, that Ammianus was aware that he was repeating something he had dealt with previously is surely implied by his statement *ut ante dictum*. Chalmers 1958 resorts to inventing biographical details about Ammianus' personal actions which are not

most glaringly obvious issue as defined by the immediately preceding narrative, namely the series of omens that seem to predict Julian's failure. In light of our discussion above, this may not be such a surprise, since, as we have noted, the narrator avoids presenting the narratee with a depiction of Julian's reaction to the omens at this stage in the campaign.

The speech nevertheless also provides a commentary on the relationship between the character and the primary narrator. Rather than a response to the omens, the speech contains a set of *exempla* of previous Roman invasions of Persia to counter, as Julian puts it, the muttering of some evil men (*maledici*), who have apparently suggested that this is the first occasion that the Romans have invaded Persia. After this set of examples (16–17) Julian highlights the differences between his motivations and those of the earlier commanders who invaded Persia—earlier generals and emperors sought personal glory, whereas Julian intends to avenge recent Roman losses and stabilize the Eastern empire (18); there is a brief reference to the vicissitudes of fortune that could bring Julian success or failure (19), then a further set of *exempla* of Romans who 'spent many ages in eradicating whatever caused them trouble', namely Numantia, Fidenae, and Veii (20). He concludes with an exhortation to the soldiers not to be tempted by plunder, and a promise to offer an account of what has been rightly or wrongly undertaken once they are safely home (21–2).[98]

Although sharing several similarities with other speeches in the *Res Gestae*, it is also unique in terms of the function it fulfils within this section of the narrative. It draws Julian into a close, parallel position with the primary narrator in several distinct ways. The Dutch commentators noted that the content of the first part of the speech, which is devoted to an overview of previous campaigns against the Persians, provides the information that we might otherwise have expected to

clearly supported by the text. Fornara 1985 argues for Ammianus' veracity here, but, in a rare moment in which he entertains Ammianus' manipulation of the representation of historical reality for literary purposes, Matthews is right to suggest that Ammianus has wanted to include the omens and the sighting of Gordian's tomb before the speech so 'with its air of hesitant optimism, [the speech] acquires an edge of dramatic irony'. 1989, 178.

[98] The speech follows a recognizable rhetorical pattern of *exordium* (16); *tractatio* (16–21) made up of a *confirmatio* comprising the set of ancient and more recent *exempla* (16) and *confutatio* (18–22); and *peroratio* (23). O'Brien 2002, 214.

find in a digression. They suggest this apparently odd procedure is Ammianus' attempt to avoid providing yet another lengthy formal digression—there had already been one on siege equipment at 23.4 and subsequently there will be a description of the Persian empire at 23.6.[99] The choice to place this historical material in the mouth of Julian rather than the geographical or technical information of the other two digressions brings the persona of Julian closely in line with that of the historian himself. Julian's aim is to inform (*docturus*) his troops about these earlier campaigns (23.5.16). The verb *doceo* is regularly favoured by the primary narrator in his frequent interventions in the narrative, especially when introducing new sections of text,[100] sources of information, [101] or analepses and prolepses.[102] In essence, these narratorial intrusions define a major aim of the narrator and his *textus* as to *docere* events and their causes. Julian will do the same for his audience as the primary narrator does for his primary narratee. This is not Julian's only appropriation of the narrator's pose. Among the list of *exempla* offered to provide evidence that this is not the first Roman invasion of Persia are Lucullus and Pompey, who marched as far as the Caspian sea, passing through the Albani and Massagetae 'whom we now call the Alani' (*quos Alanos nunc appellamus*). The phrase that introduces this detail of historical nomenclature is a typical narratorial intervention used, for example, in the digression on Egypt in the previous book to provide the contemporary term for the Scenitic Arabs (*quos Saracenos nunc appellamus*, 22.15.2).[103] Ammianus later repeats the distinction between Massagetae and Alani in these historical terms in a digression on the Huns (31.2.12).[104] Julian's speech resembles not just the subject matter of

[99] Den Boeft et al. 1998, 81.

[100] *docebit orationis progrediens textus* 18.4.7.

[101] E.g. introducing information derived from Timagenes (15.9.2) and Sallust (15.12.6).

[102] Examples are too numerous to catalogue fully, but are often of the form *ut supra docuimus* (17.14.1, 24.2.18); or *ut docebitur postea* (17.3.3); *ut congruo docebimus loco* (28.6.30, 30.7.4).

[103] Cf. also the death of Valentinian, during which the emperor suffers from constriction of blood vessels, 'which we now call haemorrhoidae' (30.6.5). The 'we' here appears to be not just 'contemporary' people but also Greeks.

[104] Though he also neglects to at 22.8.38 during the digression on the Black Sea: 'near them [the Aremphaei] are the Massagetae, Halani, and Sargetae (*iuxtaque Massagetae Halani et Sargetae*). Feraco's recent suggestion (2011, 231) that Ammianus merely juxtaposes the ancient and modern names without making the distinction

a digression, but the narrator's pose with which he overtly shows off his awareness of historical developments.

A third aspect of this harmonization between character and narrator comes from Brok's observation that Julian's division of *exempla* into those from ancient history (*vetustate*)—Lucullus, Pompey, and Ventidius, a general of Antony—and more modern times (*recens memoria*)—Trajan, Verus, Severus, and Gordian—coheres with the starting point of the *Res Gestae*: the campaigns of the latter group would have been narrated in the earlier part of the history, the former not.[105] Julian appears to be aware of the difference between *exempla* that are internal to the *Res Gestae* and those that are external, a position that should be the sole privilege of the external narrator. Finally, Julian concludes his survey of *exempla* with the self-defining phrase 'I have set forward these things as one knowledgeable in ancient texts' (*ut antiquitatum peritus exposui,* 23.5.21). Being *peritus antiquitatum* is also a pose that is promoted by the narrator elsewhere: in a rare overt narratorial reference to his historical method in searching out *exempla* elsewhere, the external narrator states: 'leafing through the copious records of the past, I have not found any eunuch with whom I could compare [Eutherius]' (*antiquitates replicando complures / inuenire non potui*, 16.7.8).[106] The narrator also criticizes those who are *antiquitatum ignari* for mistakenly defining the defeat at Hadrianople as the worst ever barbarian incursion into Roman territory. He corrects them with a set of counter-examples in a procedure not unlike that used by Julian in his speech to correct the *maledici* (31.5.11–17). The Dutch commentators note that by *antiquitates* Ammianus 'means historical works'.[107] More specifically, *antiquitates* are historical works that can provide *exempla.*

clear neatly rescues Ammianus from the charge of inconsistency. It could just be an oversight.

[105] Brok expresses his observation with caution 'one might be tempted to think that for Ammianus *vetustas* is the time before Trajan, thus the period that he does not discuss in his work'. (1959, 84). Given the context of the speech, which so clearly brings the character of Julian into line with the external narratorial voice in other ways, such caution is not necessary.

[106] In a show of his greater learning, the narrator goes on to correct 'a careful reader of ancient texts' (*scrupulosus quidam lector antiquitatum*) who may offer the counter example (16.7.9). See den Boeft 2007, 301–2 for the positive attribute of being 'well-read' in history for Ammianus' characters.

[107] Den Boeft et al. 1991, 209.

If Julian is being set up in the guise of an historian, how successfully does he interpret the past? A major aspect of Julian's interpretation is that it is staunchly Roman.[108] He excises any reference to successful Greek campaigns against the Persians. But the list is not a haphazard collection of *exempla* from Roman history. Julian's motivation in giving his speech, the need to inform an audience about previous Roman campaigns against the Persians on the eve of a new one, bears a strong resemblance to the authorial preface to the second half of Festus' *Breviarium*. After a survey of the provinces of the empire (1–14), Festus addresses Valens (*Brev.* 15.1):

> Scio nunc, inclyte princeps, quo tua pergat intentio. requiris profecto, quotiens Babyloniae ac Romanorum arma conlata sint et quibus uicibus sagittis pila contenderint. breviter euentus enumerabo bellorum. furto hostes in paucis inuenies esse laetatos, uera autem uirtute semper Romanos probabis exstitisse uictores.
>
> I know now, famous prince, where your attention is heading. You are asking, of course, how often the arms of Babylonia and the Romans have clashed, and with what changes of fortune the *pilum* and the arrow have been matched. I'll briefly count out the results of the wars. You will find that, from their trickery, the enemy have rejoiced in a few cases, but you will approve the fact that by their virtue the Romans have always ended up the winners.[109]

In the chapters that follow, Festus outlines all the encounters between the Romans and Persians from the late Republic to Julian's own in 363. This apostrophe, together with a further two to the emperor who was the text's addressee, reveals that Festus' aim is to provide Valens with an overview of previous Roman encounters with Persia as Valens prepared to do so himself in 370.[110] The great war that Festus' text anticipates, however, never occurred. Instead Valens' policy in the East was characterized by tricky negotiations mostly focused on establishing Roman influence over Armenia.[111] Nevertheless, Festus' work, particularly its second half, provided a concise overview of Romano–Persian conflict from the late Republic to 363. Its material was derived mostly from Florus, the *Kaisergeschichte*, and Eutropius, but its selection and arrangement, focusing solely on the East, was novel. As Kelly remarks, 'there is perhaps a surprising degree

[108] Den Boeft et al. 1998, 112. [109] Trans. Kelly 2010, 81.

[110] Festus hopes that Valens will be victorious in Persia as he had been against the Goths, *Brev.* 30.

[111] Curran 1998, 93–4; Lenski 2002, 167–85.

of originality in how these conventional contents are selected and arranged according to a geographic principle.'[112] Festus' work provides a useful, near-contemporary catalogue of the sort of figures that Julian could have drawn upon for his speech. A comparison of Julian's *exempla* with Festus' would be instructive in this light alone. There appears to be a closer link between the two, however. The political message of Festus' work, of the recurring Roman victory even after setbacks, neatly fits Julian's rhetorical aim (23.5.16):

> contemplans maximis uiribus et alacritate uos uigere, fortissimi milites, / contionari disposui / docturus ratione multiplici / non nunc primitus, ut maledici mussitant, / Romanos penetrasse regna Persidis
>
> Seeing the great vigour and eagerness that animate you, my valiant soldiers, I have resolved to address you, in order to explain in full detail that this is not the first time—as some evil-minded men mutter—that the Romans have invaded the Persian kingdom.

Festus' introduction to his catalogue of Romano–Persian wars has a strong thematic similarity to the introduction to Julian's speech, even though there are no lexical allusions. Both address an audience that the narrator/character deems to require instruction about such conflicts. Julian even appears to manipulate some aspects of Festus' version. Festus assumes his interlocutor is aware that there have been at least some earlier conflicts between Rome and Persia, he only needs to know how many (*quotiens*). Julian faces a taller order, to dispel his audience's ignorance that there have been none at all, that this is the first occasion (*nunc primitus*). Festus will fulfil his task in keeping with his genre, *breviter*; Julian, although his speech is much shorter than Festus' fifteen chapters, promises to develop his point as fully as possible, *ratione multiplici*.[113]

There is no lexical allusion to this passage of Festus in Julian's speech. However, Ammianus frequently alludes to Festus in digressions-proper (and as we have already seen, the speech is presented as quasi-digression); notably, as Mommsen originally argued and Kelly has more recently elaborated, Ammianus often takes factual details for his digressions from Festus, [114] though frequently supplementing them with

[112] Kelly 2010, 78.

[113] This may be another subtle attack on the genre of breviary, since in comparison Festus' concise version seems very wordy; equally, it may comment that Julian is not a very good historian, for which see below.

[114] Mommsen 1881, 605–9; Kelly 2010, 85–8. The list is provided in Chapter 1.1.

information from elsewhere or inserting information altering them to better fit his own purposes.[115] During the digression on Thrace, for example, Ammianus marks the source of his information regarding the Scordisci's practice of sacrificing captives to their gods:[116]

> saeui quondam et truces / et (ut antiquitas docet) / **hostiis captiuorum** Bellonae **litantes** et Marti (27.4.4)
>
> a people formally cruel and savage and, as antiquity teaches us, **they appease** Bellona and Mars **with sacrifices of captives**
>
> **hostiis captiuorum** diis suis aliquando **litauerint** (Festus 9.1)
>
> They sometimes **appeased** their gods **with sacrifices of captives.**

Once again we find *antiquitas* used to refer to an exemplary text. Here it marks the allusion to Festus, and it also provides an intratext with Julian's speech. Julian's pose as *antiquitatum peritus* and his intention *docturus* both suggest he is not just assuming the pose of the narrator in a digression, but also adopting his practice of drawing on earlier texts, and, given the context here of the need to justify an invasion of Persian territory based upon an historical survey of previous such invasions (as Festus had provided for Valens), that intertextual source is surely Festus' *Breviarium.*

So how does Julian draw upon Festus? A comparison of their two lists of Romano–Persian conflict reveals how selective Julian has been. Julian picks six figures with which to exemplify previous encounters between Rome and Persia: Lucullus, Pompey, and Ventidius from 'ancient history', and Trajan, Hadrian, and Gordian to represent more recent conflicts. All, according to Festus, were unremittingly successful. Lucullus defeated Tigranes, King of Armenia and captured Nisibis (15.2–3). Pompey waged successful wars in Armenia and defeated various tribes including the Albani, whom Julian mentions. Ventidius defeated a Persian army in Syria and is described as the

[115] Kelly cites the example of the information about the Thracian tribe, the Scordisci, at 27.4.4. Festus notes 'often through them the Roman army was cut down' (*saepe per eos Romanus est caesus exercitus*). Ammianus also mentions the leader of the army 'through their harshness after manifold military disasters the Roman state was often troubled and finally lost a whole army with its leader' (*quorum asperitate post multiplices pugnarum aerumnas saepe res Romana postremoque omnem amisit exercitum cum rectore*). Factually this is incorrect. The leader, Cato, was not killed (he survives according to Livy and Florus, the likely sources for Festus): instead the *exemplum* has been manipulated to act as a portent of Valens' death. Marié 1984, 28–9; Kelly 2010, 87.

[116] For the 'marking' of intertextualities, see Kelly 2008, 286.

first to triumph over the Persians (18.1). Trajan captured Seleucia, Ctesiphon, and Babylonia, and turned Armenia, Mesopotamia, and Assyria into Roman provinces (20.2). Verus likewise captured Seleucia, and thus 'triumphed over the Persians' (21.1). Julian is thus highly selective in his choice of *exempla*—he excises any reference to figures from the imperial era who were not emperors, even if they may have been successful. Thus Festus' Odaenathus (23.2) may have provided an ideal *exemplum*—he invaded Persia, got as far as Ctesiphon, and is described by Festus as *Romani ultor imperii*—but as a mere decurion of Palmyra, he does not appear in Julian's list.[117] Equally, Roman figures who do not fare so well, or those who are associated with failure, have also been elided. Crassus may have reached the upper Euphrates at Zeugma, but he was led into a trap by a Persian *perfuga,* defeated, and killed in battle (17.1–2). Cassius fought against the Persians three times, 'throwing them back over the Euphrates', but he is just as well known for rescuing the remains of Crassus' defeated army (17.2).[118] Julian mentions Marc Antony only in relation to Ventidius, but Antony could have merited inclusion in his own right: he had some initial victories against the Persians, but soon was driven back by 'hunger, disease, and storms' (18.2). The first of these three will come to affect Julian's troops, and the participant particularly (*nos . . . inedia cruciabat* 25.2.1; cf. 25.8.15). Augustus' grandson Gaius was militarily successful but was assassinated by a Persian messenger (19.1–2). Valerian was captured when fighting Sapor (23.1). Carus successfully captured Coche and Ctesiphon, but was struck dead by a bolt of lightning on the Tigris (24.2).[119] Galerius might have been victorious over the Persian king Narseus, but only after being beaten in his first encounter and humiliated by Diocletian as punishment (25.1).[120] Some of these Roman

[117] Odaenathus appears to have been of more noble birth than Festus gives him credit, Zos. 1.39.2.

[118] Eutropius (7.5.2) and Festus (18.1), both likely relying on the *Kaisergeschichte*, record the detail that Ventidius killed the son of the Persian king on the anniversary of Crassus' death (taken up also by Orosius 2.6.18). This detail is not found in earlier sources (Cf. Livy *Epit.* 128, Velleius 2.78.1, and Dio 99.19–20). Ammianus, if he thought it important, also elided it, presumably for the same reason as the absence of Cassius—Julian does not want to recall Crassus.

[119] Carus' usefulness for Julian's critics has already been illustrated by Gregory (see section 5.3 above).

[120] Ammianus recounts the story elsewhere at a more appropriate point: Constantius reminds Gallus of Domitian's punishment of Galerius (though not Galerius' crime) in order to threaten Gallus into returning to the West. The narrator describes it

commanders from the imperial period would fit Julian better. Marc Antony, like Julian, enjoyed success but succumbed to a lack of supplies; Carus, whose route Julian follows, died mysteriously and suddenly, marking the Roman defeat, in much the same way as Julian's death on the Tigris ends Roman hope of success.

The one exception to this series of successful emperors is Gordian, whose inclusion by Julian has been necessitated by the action of the participant:

> hic Gordiani imperatoris longe conspicuum uidimus tumulum, / cuius actus a pueritia prima / exercituumque felicissimos ductus / et insidiosum interitum / digessimus tempore competenti. (23.5.7)
>
> Here we saw, conspicuous from afar, the tomb of the emperor Gordian, of whose deeds from early childhood, his successful campaigns, and his treacherous murder we have spoken at the appropriate time.
>
> 'redissetque pari splendore iunior Gordianus, / cuius monumentum nunc uidimus honorate, / apud Resainan superato fugatoque rege Persarum, / ni factione Philippi praefecti praetorio / sceleste iuuantibus paucis / in hoc, ubi sepultus est, loco uulnere impio cecidisset. / nec errauere diu manes eius inulti, / quod ueluti librante iustitia omnes, / qui in eius conspirauere <perniciem>,[121] / cruciabilibus interiere suppliciis.' (23.5.17)
>
> 'and the younger Gordian, whose monument we just now saw with reverence, would have come back with equal glory, after vanquishing the Persian king and putting him to flight at Resaina, had he not been struck by an impious wound inflicted by the faction of Philip, the praetorian prefect, and a few wicked accomplices, in the very place where he now lies buried. But his shade did not long wander unavenged, for as if their deeds were weighed in the scales of Justice, all who conspired for his destruction perished by agonising deaths.'

The action of the participant, *uidimus*, provokes the intervention of the narrator to supply a 'cross reference' to an earlier part of his text, *digessimus*. Moreover, that reference also provides a succinct summary of Gordian's career as it was narrated, presumably, at greater length in one of the lost books—his victories (though it is not clear from the narrator's analepsis in which wars Gordian was successful)

as a 'not so very old example' (*non adeo uetus exemplum*, 14.11.9–10, probably taking the story from Eutropius 9.24 and, as here, embedding the genre of breviary within his narrative for a specific purpose; in Book 14 'the intellectually limited Constantius is shown closely echoing a simple abbreviated history', Kelly 2008, 285.

[121] Novák's addition (1911, 319).

and his death. Of the emperors from the 'recent past' Julian gives detailed description only for Gordian, and thus on only this occasion could Julian's interpretation be judged against the main narrative in a lost book. Of course, having that lost book would greatly help us understand the nature of Julian's historical interpretation when compared to the narrative of Gordian's reign at the *tempore competenti*. But the summary at 23.5.7 is surely designed to act as a more immediate point of comparison, not least because there is a parallel between the action of viewing the tomb and the recollection of the historical note: for the primary narrator, the participants' viewing (*uidimus*) prompts the analepsis and historical note (*cuius actus . . . digessimus*), whereas for Julian, his historical note on Gordian prompts a recollection of the viewing of the tomb (*cuius monumentum . . . uidimus*).

When placed side-by-side Julian puts a far more positive gloss on Gordian and his career—the vague *felicissimos ductus* become specifically the defeat of the Persians which had the potential to result in outright success ('he would have come back with equal glory [to that of Trajan, Verus, and Severus]'), but at least, says Julian, his killers were punished.[122]

So we may conclude from the comparison with Festus that Julian is a selective interpreter of history, and his argument based on *exempla* does more than merely answer the charge that his is an unprecedented invasion of Persia (which has itself not been mentioned by the narrator or any character within the narrative). Instead the *exempla* create a history where every Roman conflict with Persia results in Roman success. Moreover, Roman victory is dependent upon the Roman leader—each conflict is, after all, referred to metonymically only with the name of the Roman commander.

Exempla have a strong intertextual application: the invocation of Festus' catalogue of *exempla* reveals the selective nature of Julian's conception of Roman history. The specific example of Gordian, however, also reveals their narratological importance for understanding characters within the text. Julian's interpretation of Gordian is conditioned by the discussion of the same *exemplum* by the narrator a few sections earlier. The intersection of intertextuality

[122] As Ivić observes, the historical note introduced by the combination of the participant's autopsy and the narrator's analepsis 'seems to cast doubt on Julian's assurance of success based on his choice of historical precedents' (2004, 329).

and narratology continues throughout the Persian campaign. The narrator ensures that Julian is not wholly incorrect in his choice of *exempla*.[123] Julian later orders the Naarmalcha canal to be cleaned out and made useable just as, according to the narrator, Trajan and Severus had done before (24.6.1). He also improved morale by publicly swearing oaths that the Romans would be successful, just as Trajan had done (24.3.9). Julian is revealed by the narrator to follow quite literally in the footsteps of his chosen *exempla.*

However, the narrator also ensures that several of those Roman commanders whom Julian excludes from his list appear elsewhere within the narrative. Like Gordian and his tomb, Crassus' defeat forms part of the narrative of the Persian campaign, drawn in by a historical note. At 23.3.1 Julian and the army arrive at Carrhae. The town has appeared twice earlier in the *Res Gestae* (18.7.3, 20.11.11) but only on this occasion does the narrator describe it as 'notorious (*insigne*) for the disaster of the Crassi and the Roman army'.[124] Carus is connected to Julian's gruesome discovery of the bodies of some executed Persians.[125] An event from Galerius' campaign against Narseus is invoked by the philosophers just before Julian's speech in order to promote their interpretation of an omen (which is entirely incorrect, as the narrator makes clear) (23.5.11).[126] And the army

[123] Smith (1999, 95–6) catalogues the *exempla* that appear in the Persian campaign. Although he notes the occasional irony with which some are deployed, he does not systematically distinguish *whose* example each is, narrator's, participant's, Julian's, or another character's: 'the past weighs heavily on this narrator—and on his hero, too'. As this section shows, the pattern of *exempla,* especially who introduces each *exemplum* into the text, seems to open up a distinction in interpretation between the narrator and Julian.

[124] The same applies to Crassus, whose defeat and death are alluded to only here. Elsewhere he is invoked as a positive *exemplum* of Roman generalship (30.4.6).

[125] Julian sets out ahead of the army with a small detachment 'in order to visit a deserted city destroyed in former days by the emperor Carus' (24.5.3). The story is found in a more garbled form in Zosimus (3.23.3), but it is notable that Ammianus places the reference to Carus firmly in the narrator's voice, whereas Zosimus attributes it to information supplied by the inhabitants of the town (which in his version, is not deserted). For discussion of the problems in this passage of Zosimus, see Paschoud 1979, 156–62 and Ridley 1982, 114, and for Seyfarth's adoption of Lindenbrog's reading of *a Caro* in Ammianus (rather than Vs *sacro* or Valesius' *a Vero*), see den Boeft et al. 2002, 154.

[126] Galerius also provides a retrospective portent that reflects the disastrous outcome of the Persian campaign when a statue of him drops a ball which it had been holding in its hand. The event also marks the closure of the campaign and the last appearance of the narrator upon 'our' return to Antioch, 25.10.1–2.

discovers an aged veteran of the same campaign, who had been abandoned by Galerius' army and gone native amongst the Persians. He is overjoyed in knowing now, as he had always hoped, that he would die in Roman territory. Smith detects a note of irony since the leader of the present campaign will die early,[127] but it also brings Julian's campaign directly into contact with an earlier one that he had failed to mention in his speech.

The narrator succeeds in alluding to several of the less successful Roman campaigns in Persia in a way that undermines Julian's overly positive interpretation of the past and his deployment of *exempla*. Indeed, the rest of the speech shows Julian overlooking more appropriate *exempla* closer to home. He states '"if fickle fortune (*fortuna uersabilis*) should overthrow me in any battle, I shall be content with having sacrificed myself for the Roman world, after the example of the Curtii and Mucii of old and the noble family of the Decii."' (23.5.19). Julian appears to be unaware of Ammianus' assessment of his half-brother's demise: '[Gallus] raised to the highest rank in Fortune's gift (*in amplissimum fortunae fastigium*), he experienced her fickle changes (*uersabiles eius motus expertus*), which make sport of mortals.'[128]

Exempla, then, have far more valence as a means of understanding (and criticizing) Julian than omens. Whereas the latter provide an important means to create a doom-laden atmosphere within the narrative, the narratee is rarely allowed to know how Julian reacted to them directly. The continuation of the campaign (and the narrative) suggests he ignored or disbelieved them, but the precise details are not made clear until a point close to his death (25.2). Indeed, the speech at 23.5 (so programmatically important for the campaign that is to come) represents this narratorial choice. Julian discusses *exempla* not omens, and thus the former are promoted over the latter as a means of judging Julian. This point is made explicit by the narrator when he comments on the uncertainty surrounding the lion-omen in that important chapter, 23.5: 'And, in fact, we read of other ambiguous oracles (*nam et oracula dubia legimus*), the meaning of which

[127] Smith 1999, 96.

[128] Gallus' death notice at 14.11.29. The role of fortune is still more obvious in the next sentence, which introduces a series of historical *exempla*: 'it was this mutable and fickle Fortune (*haec* ***fortuna mutabilis*** *et inconstans*) that changed the Sicilian Agathocles from a potter to a king' (14.11.30).

only the final results (*casus . . . postremi*) determined.' He goes on to list three exemplary cases. The process of interpreting omens is best understood by recourse to *exempla*. The interpretative value of the past, then, could be said to trump that of the future.

5.6 COMPLETING THE ROMANIZATION OF JULIAN

The first words that Julian spoke when he entered the narrative of the *Res Gestae* were Greek, a quotation from Homer, appropriate for a student fresh from university days in Athens. Ammianus' presentation of Julian at the final event in his reign has transformed him into a figure wholly understandable from a Roman perspective—using direct speech he is set as a character to be judged exclusively within the framework of Roman imperial examples.[129] If he fails, it is because he does not think of the correct Roman precedents. Perhaps the best illustration of Julian's Romanization and the relationship that he has with the participant comes when Julian fully realizes that he does not always live up to the *exempla* he sets for himself. After being driven back from an attack he personally led against the walls of Pirisabora, some of his men being injured in the process, 'he bore a blush of shame upon his face. For he had read (*legerat*) that Scipio Aemilianus, accompanied by the historian Polybius of Megalopolis in Arcadia and thirty soldiers, had undermined a gate of Carthage in a like attack' (24.2.16). Julian had invoked Scipio in the second part of his speech as one of those Roman leaders of old who had entirely destroyed his enemy (23.5.20). Julian has failed to live up to his chosen *exemplum* and he knows it, but the comparison not only casts him in the guise of Roman Scipio, but, as Kelly puts it 'Ammianus is by implication cast as Julian's Polybius'.[130] It is possible to elaborate on this point further, however: the nationalities of these two *comparanda* are significant. Ammianus, the self-proclaimed *Graecus* of the sphragis, takes on the role of the Greek explicator of Roman history, and Julian the

[129] The process of 'Romanization' continues in the death notice, 25.4.1 (den Hengst 2010, 229).

[130] Kelly 2008, 66. Ammianus rarely mentions other historians by name, Sabbah 1978, 64.

role of the ultimate Roman conquering hero and defender of the Roman state.

Ammianus' narrative of the Persian campaign responds in important ways to the traditions that had sprung up swiftly in the 360s after Julian's death. His personal involvement as an internal narrator is a mark of the text's *aemulatio* of the tradition of participant-narration that existed in the East and had been deployed by Eutropius. Ammianus deftly weaves together internal and external narrative to provide a subtle criticism of Julian on two fronts that had characterized discussion of Julian in the epideictic tradition, and which, as far as we can tell, Eunapius avoided in his *History*, namely Julian's response to omens and his knowledge of the exemplary past. The juxtaposition of direct narratorial comment with the actions of Julian shows that Ammianus identified Julian's shortcomings in his ability to predict the future and to interpret the past as causes for his ultimate failure in Persia. Nonetheless, the critical frame in which Ammianus sets his Julian reflects his chosen genre and a wider programme to present and explain Julian to a Latin-speaking audience. His failure in Persia is at least a Roman failure.

Epilogue

One of the narrator's last direct comments on Julian relates to his place of burial in Tarsus (25.10.5):

> But his remains and ashes, if anyone then showed sound judgement, ought not to be looked on by the Cydnus, although it is a beautiful and clear stream, but to perpetuate the glory of his noble deeds they should be laved by the Tiber, which cuts through the eternal city and flows by (*praeterlambere*) the memorials of the deified emperors of old.

Ammianus' statement forcefully corrects Libanius' similar claim that Julian should have been buried not in Tarsus but at Athens 'in the Academy, next to Plato's tomb' (*Or.* 18.306).[1] Nonetheless, Ammianus' Latin phrase also alludes to Virgil's evocation of the burial place of the first Roman emperors: 'what funerals you will see, Tiberinus, as you flow past (*praeterlabere*) [2] the new tomb!' (*Aen.* 6.873–4).[3] Ammianus' dual allusive practice here neatly reflects his wider creation of a western, Latin Julian in opposition to the eastern Julian of the existing tradition.

By setting a portrayal of Julian within the revived genre of historiography in Latin, Ammianus was able to give attention to many aspects of Julian's reign that had not received detailed elaboration in the existing discourse on Julian up to the 380s, particularly Julian's elevation in 355 and the pre-emptive description of Silvanus. However, he also created a new narrative of several events that had already

[1] Tränkle 1962, 31.

[2] *Praeterlambere* in Ammianus is Valesius' correction of V, but den Boeft et al. (2005, 320–1)'s preference for Gelenius' *praeterlaberetur* strengthens further the identification of the allusion to Virgil.

[3] For the reflection of Ammianus' wider historiographical objectives in this allusion, see Kelly 2003, 590–4; den Hengst 2010, 229.

received extensive discussion in the quarter century after Julian's death (Strasbourg and Persia). In each case, Ammianus' revival of historiography, particularly Latin historiography, granted the opportunity to create a definitive, conclusive Julian-narrative which stood noticeably detached from the majority of the earlier accounts that had been written in the East for easterners and mostly in Greek. The identity of the historian as a Greek writing in Latin offers considerable authority for this enterprise, but the definitiveness of Ammianus' version gains additional authority by its shaping of contemporary history into large-scale, stock generic topoi that had previously been developed by the likes of Sallust and Tacitus (tyrannical representation, speech scenes, imperial adoptions, battle scenes, and the use of omens). The combination of composition in Latin and the promotion of Rome presupposes the ancient capital as the place of writing, and the city's inhabitants if not the sole audience, an important and unavoidable one. Ammianus' is a western Julian, recounted by an authoritative Greek no doubt, but presented in a very Roman context of Latin historiography.

Although the deployment of topoi is a recurring phenomenon throughout Ammianus' narrative of Julian, it does allow for the development of Julian as a character. Julian progresses through the stages of the unprepared but divinely endorsed student, the increasingly competent military leader, to a high point as an ideal emperor at his acclamation who is finally aware of his divine endorsement, and ultimately to a more complex figure encountering failure in Persia. This development is also marked by the primary narrator's control of his principal subject, especially the degree to which Julian's interpretation of events is allowed to cohere with the (authoritative) presentation by the primary, external narrator. In terms of recent discussions of religion within the *Res Gestae*, I adhere to the view that Ammianus not only denigrates Christianity but also creates a metaphysical system that owes more to paganism and traditional philosophy. To what degree this framework, as revealed by Rike, Davies, and Brodka, is fully consistent is still a matter of debate,[4] but I hope to have shown that forces such as *fatum, fortuna*, and the *numen* play an important narratological role, especially as regards which characters may perceive and interpret these forces correctly.

[4] Brodka 2009, 32–40 identifies some inconsistencies in the definition of *fortuna*.

More than just an external narrator, Ammianus is of course one of a select group of historians who is also a participant within the narrative world that he creates. As Kelly has shown, many of his exploits are described in such a way that the loneliness and independence of the participant is designed to reflect back onto the narratorial persona and thus act as a further corroboration of Ammianus' authority to write his history. In Persia, the appearance of participant and of first-person narrative also acts as a point of *aemulatio* with existing, eastern accounts of the Persian campaign. Earlier, in the accounts of Gallus and Silvanus, the participant's appearance fulfilled a structural function in precipitating a change in the narrator's presentation of each of these imperial characters. Just as Gallus and Silvanus act as preparatory studies for Julian, so too can the role of the participant in each of the Gallus and Silvanus episodes be seen as preparation for the appearance of the first-person during the Persian campaign. Ammianus had been careful to remain distant from the figure of Julian. Julian is kept away from the Silvanus episode (Chapter 2) whereas Ammianus keeps himself away from Julian in Gaul. It cannot be coincidence that the most extensive and the most 'personal' of Ammianus' appearances (at Amida) occurs on the other side of the empire from Julian, who was at that point in Gaul, and in a scene that is designed to provide criticism not of Julian but of Constantius.[5] So, in much broader terms, Ammianus' appearance at 23.5 at the crucial moment when Julian delivers a speech that reveals his flawed reading of the military situation and amidst a situation where the discourse on omens still remains unresolved, may suggest that this should be read as the ultimate moment of peripeteia in Julian's career.

I am aware that my reading of Ammianus raises several wider possibilities for investigation. In this book I have been mostly concerned with the military episodes in Julian's career (largely because they were the ones which had received most discussion by Latin authors prior to Julian, as outlined in the Introduction), but a comparison with Julian's 'civil' roles in both Constantinople and Antioch would also be instructive. We know that Ammianus avoided discussion of the New Rome wherever possible,[6] but the primary narrator is forced to use Constantinople as the setting for his narrative in the first

[5] Ross 2014. [6] Kelly 2003.

half of Book 22 during Julian's stay in 361. It would seem the ideal opportunity to exhibit pro-Roman bias and rivalry with the ancient capital's younger competitor. Looking beyond the narrative of Books 14–25, one could ask whether the interaction between Ammianus' narrator and the character Julian is distinct from that with other emperors in the *Res Gestae*.

In the conclusion to his book, Kelly posed a question: 'if [Ammianus'] autobiographical passages focus on the formation of a historiographical persona . . . is he comparable to those historians writing in Greek, such as Olympiodorus, Priscus and Procopius, who are equally prominent in their own works?'[7] The same question could be posed for Ammianus' structural use of the participant. The almost wholesale absence of narratological studies on works of Latin prose of all periods and of late antique texts both Latin and Greek makes it difficult to discern whether Ammianus' narratorial technique is similar to that of other historians (or indeed to writers in other genres, particularly the novel[8]); and whether in this respect, Ammianus should be considered more Classical or Late Antique in his aesthetic. Nonetheless, I hope some of the features of Ammianus' narrator that I have identified here will offer a comparison for future studies of Sallust as much as Procopius.

It is within the continuum of Roman historiography, as represented in its largely extant form by the termini of Sallust and Procopius, that we should be prepared to read Ammianus as a skilled literary practitioner, who is willing to create a thrilling and compelling narrative under the constant and pervasive control of a subtle narrator, and who engages with and adapts the models set by his predecessors to shape an authoritative view of his recent history.

[7] Kelly 2008, 320. Elsewhere I have addressed this question for Procopius, where the answer is certainly yes, Ross *forthcoming*.

[8] A genre that Ammianus seems to have been fully aware of (see Weisweiler 2015, 126–9, who points out that the story of Craugasius and his wife in Books 18 and 19 exhibits many of the topoi expected of the plot of an ancient novel. These observations may suggest that Ammianus also owes more directly to Heliodorus in the narrative of the siege of Amida, which is 'framed' by the Craugasius-narrative, than I allowed in Ross 2015c).

APPENDIX

The *Res Gestae*'s Discourse on Greek

Chapter 1 argued that there was a stark difference, even a tension, between Greek and Latin accounts of Julian, that Julian himself was an unsympathetic or at least misunderstood figure in Rome by the 380s, and that Ammianus openly points to a discordant effect of Julian's Greekness in the West. Yet Ammianus promotes his own Greekness as a prime credential of his history-writing in a western context, especially because of his specialized knowledge in an increasingly monolingual Rome of the language of Julian and the eastern authors who had written far more extensively about him than their Latin-speaking counterparts. The *Res Gestae* frequently reminds its reader of the Greek heritage of its narrator and the role Greek has to play in the world portrayed within it. This Appendix offers a wider analysis of Ammianus' discourse on Greek; particularly it addresses the related questions of how the narrator describes and discusses Greek, which characters within the narrative understand Greek, and how the primary narrator incorporates Greek text within a work of Latin prose. I do not offer such an evaluation in the belief that it can offer an easy answer to as simple a question as whether Ammianus expected his readership to know Greek themselves. As will be outlined in more depth below, to attempt to draw an equation between the complexity of the Greek text presented within the *Res Gestae* and the expected linguistic ability of his reader renders no single or simple result. Indeed, the disparities such an equation raises suggest that Ammianus' intention in the inclusion of Greek was not purely based on the expectation of his reader's familiarity with the language.

Ammianus' presentation of Greek is intimately connected to his bilingualism, specifically the effect of writing Latin as a *Graecus*. Den Boeft drew attention to the importance of this question more than twenty years ago and sketched out some avenues for assessing the nature and extent of Grecisms within Ammianus' Latin. His preparatory conclusions display the intricacy of the topic; some of the arguments made by others in favour of Ammianus' apparent 'Greekness', such as heavy use of participles, may in fact be part of a wider trend in late Latin prose.[1] Nevertheless, there are some examples of 'negative interference', in which Ammianus' native Greek prevented his use of certain syntactic structures, such as the absence of that verbal form so

[1] Den Boeft 1992, 16, citing Hofmann and Szantyr 1965, 384.

favoured by other Latin historians, the historic infinitive.[2] His conclusions, however preliminary, present an Ammianus who was hampered by his Greekness, and whose Latin was inadvertently affected by his inability to master some more complex Latin idioms. Scholarship is still awaiting a systematic, modern study of Ammianus' Latin,[3] though Kelly, building on the work of Harmon,[4] has recently demonstrated that the *Res Gestae*'s consistent accentual clausulation reveals Ammianus regularly retains the location of the Greek accent for Greek words within his text. Notably, for example, those words whose long penultimate syllable should attract an accent in Latin are nevertheless stressed on the antepenult according to standard Greek practice, for example *quas Graece sýringas appellámus* (17.7.11).[5] Kelly raises the possibility that the preservation of the Greek accent was a deliberate attempt to make his Latin 'sound' Greek.[6] Linguistic constructions and the use of accents reveal a peculiar, possibly intentional, 'Greekness' to the very fabric of Ammianus' text, but what of the active presentation of Greek language and culture within the *Res Gestae*?

When Julian sends a tribune to scout out the Alammani in 359, Ammianus cites the reason for his choice of a particular officer for the job, Hariobaudes, based upon the officer's linguistic skills: he was 'thoroughly acquainted with the language of the barbarians (*sermonis barbarici*, 18.2.2). Knowledge of other languages, evidently, was highly prized. Whatever this 'barbaric' language was, however, Ammianus shows little interest in its identification, focusing instead on the strategic usefulness of the Roman's skill in this foreign tongue. Equally in the excursus on Thrace in Book 27, Ammianus mentions the former occupants of the area, 'barbarians who

[2] 'Ammianus found this typically Latin idiom [the historic infinitive], which had no parallel in Greek, too tricky and that his rejection of it is a case of "negative interference"' (Den Boeft 1992, 17). Den Boeft concludes that, although some of the instances of the Greekness of Ammianus' Latin can be explained in terms other than his bilingualism, there are sufficient clues that Ammianus' native Greek had a significant impact on his style. He particularly calls for a study of 'recurring syntactic trends' in light of 'linguistic interference in his bilingual make-up' (Den Boeft 1992, 17–18).

[3] Called for by den Boeft at the end of his essay in 1992, 14 and 18. Ammianus is touched upon briefly in Adams' magisterial *Bilingualism and the Latin Language* (Adams 2003), the aim of which, however, is not to offer a systematic study of individual authors. Kroon and Rose's study of Ammianus' use of 'narrative tenses' is confined only to Books 22 and 23 (Kroon and Rose 1996).

[4] Harmon 1910, 214–18. [5] Kelly 2013[2015], 69–70.

[6] Célérier 2013, 126–30 also points out that several of the Greek terms in the *Res Gestae* are adopted as loan words for the first time in extant Latin literature. They, then, are not terms that the reader might have been familiar with from other Latin writers who incorporated Greek within their texts, and thus may create an extra degree of novelty and 'Greekness'.

differed from one another in customs and language' (27.4.9) but fails to identify their language specifically.[7] In these passages, the proliferation of unidentified languages is presented as a marker of the exoticism or the hostility of places on the borders of the empire, to be overcome, in the case of the first, by the skills of the bilingual Hariobaudes. Greek, by contrast, is held up as the premier other language of the empire, and the only one it is acceptable for the narrator to name.

This silence is all the more striking when one considers that Ammianus himself may have known one of these unnamed (and unnameable) other languages. Ammianus' use of Greek terms will be examined below, but Ammianus offers three glosses for words that derive from Syriac. Two refer to place names encountered during Julian's Persian expedition. Ammianus notes (in his first use of the first-person in this section of the narrative) that 'we came to a place called Zaitha, which is translated (*interpretatur*) as "olive tree"'. (23.5.7).[8] The part of the river Euphrates that flows past Ctesiphon is twice explained: 'another [part of the river Euphrates], Naarmalcha by name, which is translated (*interpretatur*) as "the kings' river", flows past Ctesiphon'. (24.2.7).[9] Both glosses are perfectly correct; *zaytā* is the Syriac for 'oil' or the 'olive tree' from which it comes.[10] Naarmalcha derives from Syriac *nar*, 'river', and *malkha* 'royal'.[11] The third gloss comes from another expedition on the Persian frontier. In 359, when the Persians first invaded Roman Mesopotamia, Ammianus was cut off from Ursicinus and scrambled towards the safety of Amida: 'we came to a place . . . called Meiacarire, for which the cool springs supply the name (*cui fontes dedere uocabulum gelidi*)' (18.6.16). Ammianus' etymology once again is correct.[12] The glossing of a Syriac name has been cited as evidence for Ammianus' knowledge of that language.[13] Certainly, Ammianus is the only author to provide the correct interpretation of Zaitha and Meiacarire, although other Latin and Greek writers knew about the etymology of Naarmalcha.[14] Given Ammianus' eastern origins and the

[7] *barbari . . . morum sermonumque uarietate dissimiles*. A similar case is found during the excursus on the lands bordering the Black Sea in Book 22. The area nourishes men *linguis et moribus dispares* (22.8.11).

[8] The place name is given as Zautha by Zosimus but without a gloss (3.14.2).

[9] The same explanation is given when the river is mentioned again at 24.6.1, *flumen Naarmalcha nomine, quod amnis regum interpretatur*.

[10] Musil fails to make this explicit in his otherwise thorough study of the history of this settlement (1927, 337–40).

[11] Den Boeft et al. 2002, 43.

[12] The name is a fairly direct transcription of *mayē* 'cold' and *qarīrē* 'waters'. The latter word (which exists only in the plural) could by extension refer to *fontes*, although the more precise term for 'spring' is *'aynō*.

[13] Kelly 2008, 117.

[14] Strabo had referred to the Naarmalcha as the river *basileus* (16.1.27) and Pliny the Elder offers both the Syriac name and the correct gloss in Latin: *ab Assyriis uero*

spying missions upon which he was sent in Persia, it is likely indeed that Ammianus was not just bilingual with Latin and Greek, but trilingual with some expertise in Syriac.[15] However, these three glosses suggest his wish to downplay this side of his linguistic heritage within his history. Each etymological explanation is distanced from the narrator, either through the passive *interpretatur* or the phrase *dedere uocabulum* (the subject of which is the 'cool springs' themselves not the Syriac language or those who speak it).[16] This stands in stark contrast to the usual phraseology for the far more numerous use and explanation of Greek terms, typically introduced 'as we Greeks call it (*Graeci appellamus*)'[17] in which the Greek language is openly displayed and often aligned with the expertise of the narrator.

Matthews has argued that this practice reflects a wider 'massive conspiracy of silence mounted by the urban upper classes of the Roman empire against the native hinterland of their cities', specifically, in this case, a conspiracy not to learn or mention the language of those rural hinterlands.[18] If this is so, it is all the more surprising that Ammianus should partake in this 'conspiracy' if he actually knew Syriac himself (unlike those urban élites, especially if he were writing in Rome). Furthermore, there was a precedent of naming the source language in the case of Naarmalcha; Pliny had already openly described it as an 'Assyrian' word.[19] Among contemporary Christian authors, knowledge of Syriac was crucial for exegetical issues, particularly relating to the untranslated Aramaic words of the Old Testament, and was not as easily side-lined as it is in Ammianus.[20]

universis appellatum Narmalchan, quod significant regium flumen. See den Boeft et al. 2002, 43.

[15] Cf. his description of another foreign term, the Sarmatian war cry (*marha marha, quod est apud eos signum bellicum*, 19.11.10) which focuses on the purpose of phrase, rather than its literal meaning or etymology, perhaps suggesting he did not have a command of the Sarmatians' language. Its actual meaning is 'death death', Seyfarth 1968 vol. 2, 73 n.112.

[16] Only on one occasion does he mention the *Assyria lingua*: Seleucus Nicator had embellished the cities of Mesopotamia, which subsequently received Greek names, although 'they have not lost the old appellations in the Assyrian tongue, which the original settlers gave them' (14.8.6). It is notable that Ammianus provides neither the Greek names nor the Syriac equivalents (for some suggestions, see Galletier and Fontaine 1968, 216 n.87). The absence of glosses or examples of actual Syriac names leaves the description of the language in the abstract.

[17] 22.8.44, 23.6.20. The use of the first-person to introduce Greek terms is also found at 17.7.11, 18.6.22, 22.15.2, 22.15.29, 23.4.10, 25.2.5, 26.1.1.

[18] Matthews 1989, 69.

[19] See n.662. Matthews (1989, 69) suggests Ammianus did not name Syriac in the glosses 'perhaps thinking that his readers would find it obvious (or not thinking about it at all)'. The context of composition in Rome makes this first option seem quite unlikely.

[20] Jerome openly flaunts his knowledge of Syriac (*Ep.* 17.3) and offers a series of glosses of Syriac words (e.g. *Quaest. Hebr.* 22, 50, 60, and 68; *Comm. in Isaiam* 9.29;

The marginalization of other languages allows a central role for Greek within the *Res Gestae*. Greece itself is regularly associated with the literary and intellectual figures it has produced: the sobriquet 'storied Greece' is used to mark an allusion to Herodotus and his account of Xerxes' review of his troops at Doriscus (18.6.23), albeit the *exemplum* is one that the narrator seeks to surpass.[21] Demosthenes, described as the 'eternal glory of Greece', is invoked to correct the erroneous interpretation by some of the legality of the assassination of King Pap by the Roman general Trajanus (30.1.23). The emperor Augustus followed a Greek precedent in his reform of the calendar (26.1.13). In more than a dozen cases, Greek is brought in as the language of precise technical terms for, among others, phantasies (14.11.18), nodes of the solar eclipse (20.3.4), the law of fates (21.1.8), hieroglyphics (22.15.30), a siege machine (23.4.10), and atoms (26.1.1). The distribution of these terms throughout the history is notable. They are confined mainly to excursus where Greek learning is conspicuously tied to displays of the narrator's erudition.[22] The narrator even combines eyewitness participation and reliance on Greek learning during his survey of the Persian empire, when he notes that the area 'Adiabena' had been so called because it is located between two un-crossable rivers 'for we Greeks for *transire* say *diabenin*' (23.6.20, i.e. διαβαίνειν).[23] He goes on to correct the interpretation from personal experience: 'But I myself say that there are two perpetually flowing rivers to be found in these lands, the Diabas and Adiabas, which I myself have crossed, and over which there are bridges of boats; and therefore it is to be assumed that Adiabena was named from them' (23.6.21). Both these occasions serve to remind the reader of Ammianus' inseparable expertise

Comm. in Proph. Min., *Abdiam* l.178) even if his knowledge of Syriac 'was somewhat shaky', King 2009, 223. Far from a 'conspiracy of silence', an over-exaggerated fluency in Syriac was an important authoritative claim for Jerome. For a similar phenomenon in Augustine see, e.g. *de Gen. ad lit.* 1.18 (36).

[21] Kelly 2008, 84–7; Weisweiler 2015, 119–21.

[22] Greek in digressions: *Galatae* the Greek term for *Galli*, 15.9.3; *syringae* the subterranean caverns where earthquakes begin, 17.7.11; *horizontae*, 18.6.22; three types of eclipse nodes, 20.3.4; *synodos, menoeides, dichomenis*, and *apocrousis,* four phases of the moon 20.3.9–11; *tethimena* the law of the fates, 21.1.8; *Euxeinos* and the etymology of the Black Sea 22.8.33; etymology of pyramid from *pyr*, 22.15.29; *hierographicae*, 22.15.30; the *helepolis*, 23.4.10; *diabenin* for Latin *transire* 23.6.20; *diasson* a shooting star, 25.2.5; *atomi*, 26.1.1; *zodiacus*, 26.1.8. In the majority of these cases, Ammianus associates himself with the Greek language by using a first person construction 'as we (Greeks) say'. There are five occasions when a gloss is more impersonal (*sermo Graecus appellat*, 15.9.3, 21.1.8, and 26.1.8, *Graece . . . dicitur*, 20.3.9, *appellarunt*, 22.15.30).

[23] He leaves the privative prefix in Adiabena unexplained, presumably because it is also a feature of Latin.

as *Graecus* and *quondam miles*. Indeed they work together to offer a dual form of authority for his history.

Of the three occasions outside digressions, one occurs in another non-narrative section of the history, the preface to Book 26. Like the excursus, a preface is a suspension of the narrative and a direct apostrophe to the primary narratee that may allow the narrator to make a claim to authority.[24] The remaining two that are embedded within the narrative proper occur in close association with two characters: Julian and Ammianus himself.

When on a spying mission in 359 to Corduene on the Roman–Persian border, Ammianus dramatically sketches out the scene when he first encounters the Persian army: 'there we stayed for two full days, and at dawn of the third day we saw below us the whole circuit of the lands (which we call *horizontae*) filled with innumerable troops with the king leading the way, glittering in splendid attire' (18.6.22). The depiction of the Persian king, his retinue, and the 'various leaders after them, elevated in their authority and power' owes as much to the literary tradition of ecphrasis than an accurate record of what Ammianus saw from that hilltop. As Kelly notes, 'it is characteristic of ecphrasis to blend what the internal viewer can see with details and information which may elude him.' [25] The placement of the Greek term for the horizon aids the suspension of narrative proper (since Greek terms tend to be associated with excursus and narratorial apostrophes) and promotes the transition from a statement of autopsy to the literary domain of ecphrasis.

The second example of a technical term outside a digression is connected to Julian. The night before his death, Julian saw a shooting star, which Ammianus explains and clarifies with a specific typology: 'that fiery brilliance was of the kind that we call *diaisson,* which never falls anywhere or touches the earth' (25.2.5). Thus at this critical moment in Julian's reign,[26] Ammianus breaks with convention by inserting a Greek term, which otherwise would be almost exclusively confined to the excursus. The association of a Greek term and the predicted death of an emperor is a recurring theme in the *Res Gestae*, which is examined in more depth below.

The technical terms discussed above are introduced as if they were unknown to the narratee. Most, also, are accompanied by a gloss in Latin that gives a reasonable definition (*atomi* are 'small individual bodies that fly through space', 26.1.1) or even an explicit explanation of the Greek

[24] Refusing to record *minutiae* in his history, Ammianus defends himself by likening the process to counting 'the small indivisible bodies which fly through space, and to which we give the name of 'atoms' (26.1.1).

[25] See Kelly 2008, 79–87 for an analysis of how Ammianus blends autopsy and the use of ecphrasis in this passage.

[26] For this section as the turning-point, or rather the revelation, of Julian's relationship with divinatory practices, see Chapter 5.4.

etymology (as in the case of Adiabena). The definition and etymology of individual technical terms construct a narratorial persona of a conspicuously learned bilingual who is willing to explain his 'other' language in the Latin that is shared by him and his narratee, but in turn they equally construct a narratee that does not know even some of the simplest items of Greek vocabulary, and needs to be informed that διαβαίνειν is the Greek for *transire* for example.

This view of the narratee may be challenged by the presence of extended quotations, however. Ammianus includes a number of Greek passages, mostly of verse, which to understand fully would require a far more developed knowledge of the vocabulary and syntax of literary Greek.[27] Once again, these quotations appear to share a similar purpose and fall into one of a small set of overlapping categories. Most in some way relate to prediction of future events. A mysterious inscription of eight hexameter lines found at Chalcedon clearly predicts (*futura plene pandentes*) the death of Valens (30.4.3). Those being tried for treason by Valens in Antioch recite three lines of Greek, 'those familiar verses' (*versus illos notissimos*), which predicted their punishment and also the retribution against Valens in the form of his death at Hadrianople (29.1.33; the last line is repeated again in Valens' death notice, 31.14.8). Two lines of Menander stating that 'a demon is assigned to every man | at birth, to be the leader of his life' (21.14.4) corroborates the report that Constantius had seen a vision of his guardian spirit leaving him, a few months before his death in 361. This episode corresponds to a similar one a few chapters earlier in the same book, in which Julian dreams of four hexameter lines that also predict Constantius' death (21.2.2). Julian himself had recited a line of Homer when he was appointed Caesar, 'by purple death I am seized and fate supreme', (15.8.17) which likewise is predictive, though the trajectory of the fatal outcome (Julian's death in Persia) is far more distant in relation to the moment of prediction than any of the other Greek quotations, coming eight years or ten books of Ammianus' narrative later.[28]

Other categories are apparent in this brief list. The predictive nature of these Greek verses largely refers to the fate (often the death) of emperors. They are also quotations either of contemporary oracular verses

[27] These longer passages were originally written in Greek letters, whereas the shorter glosses often appear transliterated into Latin in modern editions. It is difficult to know whether the use of Latin script for these Greek terms is original. Peltarri's study of the earliest manuscripts of Augustine, which come from Augustine's own scriptorium, show that it was standard practice to write Greek terms with Latin letters by the early fifth century. Transliterations back into Greek (a form of hyper correction) were the work of later editors. Peltarri 2011. Kelly (2013[2015], 69 n.6) has adduced some instances where Greek terms may have originally been in Greek.

[28] See Chapter 3.1.

or inscriptions,[29] or of ancient Greek authors (Homer or Menander exclusively).[30] Several of the former category are not unique to Ammianus. Zosimus and Zonaras record the same Greek verses in Julian's dream;[31] Socrates and Zonaras do so for the inscription found at Chalcedon.[32] These quotations evidently formed part of an existing Greek tradition that had grown up around the (fated) death of these emperors.[33] In the case of Valens, as noted above Ammianus alludes to the familiarity of the inscription, describing the verses as *illos notissimos* (29.1.33).[34] As such, these are unique occasions within the *Res Gestae* in which Ammianus alludes to a prevailing tradition in such a direct way, and it is notable that in doing so he retains the original Greek, rather than rendering a Latin translation or paraphrase. Finally, several of the Greek quotes cluster around Julian. He is the only character allowed to speak in Greek, quoting Homer at the moment of his elevation. Similarly he dreams of Greek verses and understands their meaning, unlike Valens who ignores 'being uneducated and rude (*inconsummatus et rudis*) disregarded [the prophetic verses] at first' (31.14.8). A quotation associated with Marcus Aurelius (albeit criticizing both emperors' predilection for sacrifice) appears in Julian's death notice (25.4.17).

But how crucial to the understanding of the narrative is the ability to understanding these passages of Greek? Ammianus does not offer a translation or even a précis of the contents of these quotations and one might conclude then that the narratee is expected to understand not just individual items of Greek vocabulary, but also Greek syntax. Nonetheless, the surrounding narrative often makes the significance of the Greek quotation clear. Take, for example, Hilarius' testimony before Valens' judges in Book 29 during Theodorus' treason trial (29.1.33):

> And when Hilarius had laid the knowledge of the whole matter so clearly before the eyes of the judges, he kindly added that Theodorus

[29] The longest such quotation related to an inscription is the Greek translation of the hieroglyphs on the obelisk which Constantius' erects in Rome (17.4.18–23). See below for a full description of its significance.

[30] A line of Homer is also quoted in the excursus on Persia to identify a tribe (23.6.62). Homer is presented here as a source for ethnography, and thus Ammianus' use of the Greek quotation serves a similar purpose to the use of Greek technical terms elsewhere in the digressions: to stress the authority of Greek sources and thereby his own authority based upon his knowledge of them.

[31] Zos. 3.9.6; Zon. 13.11 [55].

[32] Soc. *HE.* 4.8; Zon. 13.16 [78].

[33] Cameron 2011, 677.

[34] Though Ammianus does not make clear *to whom* these verses are well known, *pace* den Boeft et al. 2013, 54, who presume it must refer to his readers; in narratological terms, there is no clear distinction whether this should apply to the primary narratee or secondary (internal) narratees such as the inhabitants of the East.

> was completely ignorant of what was done. After this, being asked whether they had, from belief in the oracles which they practised, known beforehand what they were now suffering, they uttered those familiar verses which clearly announced that this work of inquiring into the superhuman would soon be fatal to them, but that nevertheless the Furies, breathing out death and fire, threatened also the emperor himself and his judges. Of these verses it will suffice to quote the last three:
>
> [in Greek] 'Avenged will be your blood. Against them too
> Tisiphone's deep wrath arms evil fate,
> While Ares ranges on the plain of Mimas.'
>
> [in Latin] When these verses had been read, both were terribly torn by the hooks of the torturers and taken away senseless.

The effect of the Greek verses is clearly summarized before they are quoted: they predicted not only that Hilarius' divinatory practices (the use of a method resembling a Ouija board to find out the name of the next emperor) would bring about his and his accomplices' death, but that Valens and his judges too were threatened with death. The quotation alludes to the specific location of Valens' death, but the information required to make sense of the enigmatic prediction is not revealed by the narrator here—the 'plain of Mimas', we learn only in Valens' death notice, was understood by Valens to be a part of Ionia named as such by Homer and Cicero (31.14.8). His interpretation was incorrect: after his death at Hadrianople, and near the place where he died, 'a monument made of a heap of stones was found, to which was fastened a tablet engraved with Greek characters, showing that a distinguished old man called Mimas was buried there' (31.14.9). Even if the reader could understand Greek, the quotation does not enhance the interpretation of the Latin narrative immediately surrounding it.[35] The one function for the reader who could understand it is to establish a narrative 'seed' that will be fulfilled by Valens' death notice,[36] but even then, the important information that justifies the power of divination is clearly given by the Latin narrative. The Greek, then, serves an almost ornamental function, increasing the mysteriousness surrounding the quotations, whose interpretation in any case requires far more than a simple understanding of the Greek text.

By far the longest passage of Greek within the *Res Gestae* is the Greek translation by one Hermapion of the hieroglyphics inscribed upon the obelisk that had been brought to Rome by Augustus in 10 BC and set up in the Circus Maximus (17.4.17–23). The oddity of the inclusion of this translation of an inscription has rarely been noted. The justification for its

[35] Davies describes it as 'rather vague', 2004, 279.
[36] For the concept of the narrative 'seed' see de Jong 2007, 8.

appearance comes from the long description of the erection of another obelisk by order of Constantius also in the Circus Maximus (17.4.1–16). Ammianus gives no clear reason for including the translation of the inscription, and the introduction merely states: 'now the text of the characters cut upon the ancient obelisk which we see in the Circus I add below in its Greek translation following the work of Hermapion' (17.4.17). The translation that follows is not complete, offering first the translation of the three lines of hieroglyphs on the south side, only the second and third lines of the west side and the first line of the east side, as Ammianus himself makes clear by concluding the transcription with *et reliqua* (17.4.23), after which the narrative leaves Rome, shifts focus to the East, and details an exchange of letters between Constantius and Sapor.[37] There is no narratorial comment made about the significance of the inscription, which describes the relationship of the Sun god, nor for the selection of specific lines.

Once again, we find a situation in which the translation of the Greek is in no way necessary for an understanding of the progress of the narrative, perhaps even less so than for any of the later verses and inscriptions because no subsequent event appears to depend upon it. Its inclusion has the air of an appendix to the story of Constantius' 'new' obelisk.[38] So why include it at all? One obvious purpose is the promotion of Greek learning—it is a Greek speaker, Hermapion,[39] who has been able to render the hieroglyphs into an intelligible language ('the infinite carvings of characters called hieroglyphics, which we see cut into it on every side, have been made known by an ancient authority of primeval wisdom' Ammianus remarks in his general description of obelisks, 17.4.8[40]). Furthermore, however, the Greek translation may also

[37] The loss is not the result of a lacuna in the manuscript tradition, Seyfarth 1968, 112. The presence of Greek characters proved a problem for Ammianus' ninth-century copyist, who in V attempted to reproduce a line-and-a-half of the Greek, then left a blank space for the rest of the inscription (Vat.Lat.1873.41v–41r). Our Greek text comes from the *Hersfeldensis* via Gelenius' edition. Cf. Lambrecht 2001, 56–7.

[38] Cf. Kelly's comment that it has 'all the appearance of a digression' (2003, 604).

[39] The identity of Hermapion is unknown. Benaissa suggests the emendation of the phrase *quem uidemus in Circo, Hermapionis librum secuti* (17.4.17) to *quem uidemus in Circo Maximo Apionis librum secuti*, thus identifying the translator as the first-century Alexandrian scholar and the target of Josephus' eponymous *Contra Apionem* (Benaissa 2013). As Kelly points out (pers. comm.) the suggested emendation would cause an exception to Ammianus' otherwise entirely regular clausulation. The suggested *quem uidemus in Círco Máximo* breaks the rule that there must be either two or four unstressed syllables between the final two syllables in a clause. (As it stands, *quem uidémus in círco | Hermapionis líbrum secúti* gives two examples of *cursus planus*). For a full explanation of Ammianus' clausulation, see Barnes 1998, 225–30.

[40] He then roughly sketches out the principles of the script: 'For not as nowadays, when a fixed and easy series of letters expresses whatever the mind of man may conceive, did the ancient Egyptians also write; but individual characters stood for

act as something of a smokescreen for Ammianus' engagement with another inscription related to these obelisks. Building on an observation by Sabbah and Fowden,[41] Kelly has demonstrated that Ammianus alludes, in his description of erection of Constantius' obelisk, to a Latin inscription that was on the base of that same obelisk.[42] This inscription is a verse text that praises Constantius for his gift to the city planned at the time when 'the hateful tyrant [Magnentius] laid Rome waste' (*ILS* 736.15). Ammianus appears to correct a number of the pro-Constantian elements of the inscription, undermining the poem's suggestion that Constantius redirected the obelisk away from Constantinople to Rome, and presenting Constantius' choice to erect the obelisk as the result of his recent visit to the capital, whereas the poem suggests the plan was longer in the making and was first considered during the reign of Magnentius in 350–3. A number of lexical allusions corroborate Ammianus' engagement with the Latin inscription.[43] Kelly suggests the multivalent effect of the allusion, 'to readers who observed the intertextuality with the inscription, Ammianus' correction was visible; but it was not made obtrusive to those who could not spot it. For some readers, therefore, it might be visible that Ammianus was denying the relevance of Constantinople; others might have no conception that anybody had ever suggested sending the obelisk there, or that anything was missing.'[44] At the very least, however, the presence of another inscription so obviously incorporated in this section of the *Res Gestae* cannot be coincidence. In a passage that already has betrayed complex intertextuality, could Ammianus be using Hermapion's translation of the hieroglyphic inscription to distract from his engagement with that other, Latin inscription; or indeed does he use the lengthy and obvious Greek translation as a 'marker' for the more subtle allusion to the Latin inscription?[45] The mysterious Hermapion could then be a cipher for Ammianus himself—both are bilinguals who have skill for 'translating' inscriptions on Roman monuments; in Ammianus' case, translating also means correcting the version he found. Whichever way we read the relationship between Ammianus' text in 17.4 and the two inscriptions, the presence of the Greek, once again, does not imply that its content has to immediately be intelligible to all readers.

Ammianus carefully controls the use of Greek within his history. His selection of Greek terms and quotations and their distribution throughout

individual nouns and verbs and sometimes they meant whole phrases.' 17.4.10. He goes on to give the examples of the vulture meaning 'nature' and bee for 'king'.

[41] Sabbah 1970, 169 n.32 and Fowden 1987, 54–5.

[42] Kelly 2003, 603–6 and Kelly 2008, 225–30. The inscription was transcribed by Michele Mercati in 1589 when the obelisk was moved to its present location outside the Lateran.

[43] See Kelly 2008, 228–9. [44] Kelly 2008, 230.

[45] See Kelly 2008, 286 for the concept of 'marking' an *exemplum* or allusion.

the text allows Ammianus to construct a specific discourse on the role of Greek. Greek is an authoritative language that provides the terminological apparatus to describe with precision the strange and unknown in excursus. Within the narrative, references to Greek texts, whether they are quotations of ancient authors or contemporary predictive verses, act proleptically as indicators of the fate of emperors. As such, Greek assumes an important interpretative role. Ammianus constructs more than a single identity for his narratee in terms of his linguistic abilities, but the *Res Gestae* constantly promotes the knowledge of Greek as a useful attribute in understanding the world created by his text (even if that interpretive skill is not available to the narratee). The narrator promotes himself as the main interpretative agent of Greek. Ultimately we should read the combination of the various representations of Greek within the *Res Gestae* as endorsement of Ammianus' authority to write Latin history as a Greek, and specifically to provide an authoritative interpretation of Julian, who alone of all the characters in the narrative speaks in Greek and is thus directly equated with Greek culture.[46]

[46] At his elevation, 15.8.17, Gallus is reported to speak excellent Greek, but his actual words are not given in direct speech as they are for Julian, 14.1.9.

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